

Ranjan Kumar Panda *Editor*

Samkhya-Yoga Philosophy of Consciousness

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Sciences

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*“Success is the last word life can
accommodate!”*

*Professor R. C. Pradhan
Most honest and committed scholar of
Philosophy,
My respected teacher who inspires me
to do philosophy all the time.
I humbly dedicate this anthology to him.*

Preface and Acknowledgement

Like everything related to our life has a beginning, this anthology also began with a curiosity to probe into the problem of dualism. Being a student of Philosophy of Mind, I am well acquainted with the problem of Cartesian dualism, but while reading Sāṃkhya's philosophy, I am intrigued by its theoretical position on Puruṣa and Prakṛti. To tell you the story of this endeavour, it all started in two phases. The first phase is about the discourse on the *metaphysics of consciousness*, and the second phase is about understanding and comparing the Cartesian mind-body dualism with the dualism in Sāṃkhya concerning the nature of Puruṣa and Prakṛti. So far as the first phase is concerned, it all commenced with a discussion of Professor R. C. Pradhan's work on the *Metaphysics of Consciousness: Indian Vedantic Perspective* (Springer 2020) at the Forum for Philosophy. Many of the contributors to this volume were part of the discussion. In the twenty-first century, this book seriously attempts to establish consciousness as a non-reductive and non-evolutionary phenomenon. It rejects the basic discourse in evolutionary biology that has been influential in naturalizing consciousness. It also shows that not all Western philosophical thinking undermines the ontology of consciousness and human subjectivity, rather it tries to show following Sri Aurobindo's notion of evolution that consciousness evolves differently concerning human knowledge and existence. While claiming to provide a Vedantic perspective, it proves that consciousness is most fundamental and could be theorized from the *first-person perspective*. A person is not merely a functional entity, but rather a metaphysical being that exists and is defined by consciousness. The metaphysics of the notion of self and self-consciousness provide ground for theorizing experience, subjectivity, freedom, and creativity.

During this discussion, I was teaching Sāṃkhya-Yoga to undergraduate students in my institute. Due to the COVID-19 pandemic, classes were online, and some students were genuinely taking an interest in reading Indian Philosophy, and used to have discussions after the class meeting as well. Since I am not an expert in Indian Philosophy, I was trying to provide some convincing responses to the students as well as to myself. While looking for some research papers, I came across Professor Ian Whicher's paper titled "From Radical to Co-operative Duality: Moving towards a Non-Dualistic Interpretation of Classical Yoga". This work, to a novice like me, was

interesting. I wrote to Professor Whicher with some questions concerning the nature of self, consciousness and the *Puruṣa-Prakṛti* relationship and got overwhelmed by his response. An online meeting was convenient and easy to fix. We had a one-to-one online discussion. Such online meetings were possibly the only positive development that happened during the pandemic. The virtual platform disclosed to us a new way of meeting people and carrying out academic and many other activities which were not thought of before the pandemic. I suggested that the members of the Forum have a lecture series on Sāṃkhya-Yoga Philosophy. The series started with Professor Pradhan's lecture, and many friends working in Indian Philosophy also joined. We continued the series with almost fifteen lectures. And, finally, we decided to have a conference on this theme. On 25th-26th September 2021, all the speakers who had given the lectures met and presented their revised papers along with some new invitees. This was the first international webinar/conference of the Forum for Philosophy. At the end of this conference, we decided to publish all the papers in an anthology. Thus, the anthology on the Sāṃkhya-Yoga Philosophy of Consciousness came into being.

This anthology delves into the nature of dualism, evolution, emergence, consciousness, self-consciousness, self-knowledge, *sādhana* and *samādhi* in the Sāṃkhya-Yoga Philosophy. Sāṃkhya's presupposition of *Puruṣa* and *Prakṛti* as two fundamental principles does not project dualism, but when it comes to Yoga, it directs us how to overcome this dualism by following *sādhana mārga*. Yoga is an allied system of Sāṃkhya *darśana* and it shows the paths following which one practises *sādhana* leading to the state of *samādhi*. In the state of *samādhi* the yogi transcends the realm of psychic consciousness where there is no duality, between *Puruṣa* and *Prakṛti*. The psychic consciousness *antaḥkaraṇa* is very much part of the *Prakṛti* as it is the constitution of the first three evolutes. The dynamism of the evolution shows that the proximity is due to the inherent nature of *rajas*, but the transformation of *guṇas* is also a condition for understanding the process of evolution and dissolution. However, the semantics of dualism in Sāṃkhya has many layers. It is not merely about the *Puruṣa* and *Prakṛti*, or the psychic consciousness and transcendental consciousness. To comprehend the meaning, we need to look at the causal relation and the intentionality involved in the consciousness. Deep inside these relations, one finds the subtle speculative metaphysical thinking that theorizes consciousness elaborately.

To explicate the sophisticated metaphysics of consciousness, this anthology has made an attempt to bring the contemporary readings of scholars who have analytically delved into various themes central to Sāṃkhya-Yoga philosophy. The focus of our study is on consciousness and not on the practice of yoga. It is well known that the twenty-first century is the century of *yoga*—the philosophy of union, non-duality and harmony. All these can be achieved provided one is prepared to transform oneself and understands the nature of *ahaṅkāra*—ego that is part of the individual's psychic consciousness. Moreover, yoga, while asserting preparedness, introduces *yama* as the normative condition of initiating a desirable transformation. The normative dimension of consciousness is not only to be conceptualized in the context of practising *yoga*, but it is also to be construed in connection with the notion of suffering. Sāṃkhya begins its discourses with reference to the nature of suffering—*duḥkha*.

The story of consciousness in Sāṃkhya-Yoga is not a story limited to the discourse from suffering to *samādhi*—for the realization of *kaivalya*. Rather, it asserts the primacy of the ontology of *Puruṣa* as pure consciousness that is different from the ontology of *Prakṛti*, that is, essentially dynamic. If yoga culminates in a union, then it must succeed in delivering *cittavṛttinirodha*—the complete cessation of *vṛtti* of the *citta*. This is something that unfolds the complex epistemic condition of normativity in which Yoga tries to align itself with the metaphysics of Sāṃkhya.

Many deserve special acknowledgement, and I would like to thank them here. Professor R. C. Pradhan, to whom this book is dedicated. He deserves special thanks for chairing all the sessions of the invited lecture series, organized by Forum for Philosophy, on the Sāṃkhya-Yoga Philosophy of Consciousness and initiating excellent discussions. Without his guidance and support, this volume would not have been possible. I also thank all the members of the Forum for their valuable support. When this Forum was formed by me along with some of my students, we used to meet every Friday to discuss something on a philosophical topic. It all started in July 2017 and continued with its weekly meeting. The Forum became more active with the opening of online platforms for meetings and discussions. My special thanks to the late Professor N. J. Vyas, for his wholehearted support for having the Forum for Philosophy. I will always miss his sense of humour and humility. I would like to thank Dr. Abhishek Yadav and Mr. Sumit Pandey for their sincere effort in organizing Forum's activities.

I thank all the contributors who have contributed their research work to this anthology. Many could not give their paper due to their busy schedule and paucity of time, but they have always encouraged us in some way or the other and participated in the conference. They are, Professor Sachchidanand Mishra, Member Secretary, Indian Council of Philosophical Research, New Delhi. Professor Shivani Sharma, Punjab University, Chandigarh, and Professor Godabarisha Mishra, Nalanda University, Nalanda.

My special thanks to Professor C. D. Sebastian, my colleague in the Department of Humanities and Social Sciences, IIT Bombay, for his valuable guidance in publishing this anthology and for recommending the manuscript to Springer. I thank all my colleagues in the Department for their cooperation and goodwill. Dr Abhishek Yadav and Ankita deserve to be mentioned here as they have extended their support in the last moments of editing the introduction. I must thank Mr Sumit Pandey for assisting me patiently by arranging the chapters, editing the references, and systematically presenting the manuscript to Springer. I sincerely thank Satvinder Kaur ji of Springer for extending their wholesome support throughout the publication. And, I, on behalf of all the contributors also thank the referees for kindly reviewing the manuscript and providing us valuable feedback. I also thank Professor Sacchidananda Mishra, the editor of *JICPR*, for giving a positive note on the permission to republish Professor Daniel Raveh's paper titled "Rethinking Pātañjala Yoga Through the Concepts of Abhyāsa and Vairāgya."

My little academic engagements have been fruitful and cherishing because of the kind and loving support I have received from my wife, Puspanjali and daughters Abhipsa and Abhishruti.

October 2024

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About the Editor

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Chapter 1

Introduction: A Note on Sāṃkhya-Yoga Philosophy of Consciousness



Ranjan Kumar Panda

Abstract Consciousness is one of the primitive philosophical concepts that all philosophers have aspired to understand and theorize about its ontology. Consciousness has been central to the philosophical discourse in all the classical Indian philosophical systems. Some have denied its ontology, and some have accepted and asserted in such a way that consciousness is considered real and all-pervasive. This assertion has not lost its value but rather unfolded in many ways in the contemporary academic discourses much beyond the theoretical realm of philosophy, it has been in discussion in science and society. Sāṃkhya-Yoga philosophy, being one of the primitive philosophical systems, has attracted the attention of many contemporary philosophers and scientists. In this chapter, I have tried to bring about some of the central themes concerning consciousness that are the focal point of study. The chapter is broadly divided into two sections. They are, my philosophical notes and reflections, and the other is about the chapter summaries. The first part has been classified into some subsections that include discussions on the metaphysics of consciousness, dualism, self-consciousness, creation, evolution, suffering, *samādhi*, and the normative aspects of yoga, whereas the second part systematically provides a brief outline of the chapters that are discussed here in this book. For a learner, taking *notes* is an important aspect of any systematic investigation. Thus, my title intends to cover two parts that are included here for a sympathetic reader—*sahrudaya*, who would always add to this introduction by bringing some critical reflections and positive suggestions to further unfold the discourse more systematically and suggestively.

Keywords Consciousness · Metaphysics of consciousness · Sāṃkhya-Yoga · Dualism · Self-Consciousness · Self-Knowledge · Evolution · Suffering · *Samādhi*

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1.1 A Prelude to the Discourse on Consciousness

The study of consciousness has drawn the attention of philosophers from ancient times. The Vedas and the Upaniṣads are very much relevant in the discourse on consciousness, which later on is reflected in the ancient philosophical systems of Indian Philosophy. But recently, psychologists, neuroscientists, linguists, information scientists, and technocrats have taken a lot of interest in investigating the root of its ontology as they are all engaged in the discourse of developing cognitive science in a much more sophisticated manner that would explain fully the nature of consciousness. Their primary aim is to discover either the biological locus of consciousness or to show that consciousness can be artificially produced in the form of artificial intelligence. Many have resolved that consciousness is nothing but brain processes, and thereby, it is causally explainable. The development of artificial intelligence has shown how machines can intelligently perform various reasonably acceptable activities as they fulfil certain pragmatic concerns of humanity today. Thus, the success of cognitive science and artificial intelligence seems to be phenomenally advancing day by day. Since the study has been predominately conducted to explain consciousness following scientific techniques and methodology, it provides an opportunity for philosophers to engage in the discourse of consciousness.

In this connection, most of the philosophical theories in recent times are either parallelly or subsequently developed to provide a complimentary account of the scientific findings or critique their theoretical perspectives. Nevertheless, the scientific theorization of consciousness has not successfully eliminated consciousness from the discourse of philosophy. Even for the so-called eliminative theory of consciousness, it has not been possible to offer a viable replacement for theorizing human subjectivity. The subjective first-person perspective of human conscious experience is still considered irreducible to any form of physical state and neural processes of the brain. In a similar line of thought, it is yet hard to accept humanoid robots replacing human beings. The exponents of subjectivism believe that consciousness is genuine and has a unique and ubiquitous ontological status. Consciousness remains a hard problem as it was emphatically brought out by Chalmers (1996). The ontology of consciousness is expressed in many forms, such as thinking/thoughts, experience, ego, and the self.

In Indian Philosophy, the ontology of consciousness is explicitly discussed right from its inception. There are two philosophical perspectives concerning consciousness, namely the empirical perspective and the transcendental perspective (Gupta, 2003: 10). The transcendental perspective maintains that consciousness is not causally explainable, rather it involves subjectivity. The subjective element in consciousness is undermined by the empirical perspective argued from the viewpoint of Cārvāka, Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika and Mīmāṃsā. Contrary to the empirical perspective, Sāṃkhya-Yoga and Vedānta hold that consciousness is transcendental and subjective. Consciousness is transcendental because it is the very possibility of knowledge. Consciousness *per se* is also defined as transcendent because it is beyond the limits of sense experience (Gupta, 2003: 11). The notion of *ātman* or the self is conceived as

real and independent of the world. The self could be engaged and disengaged with the world. And its mode of engagement and disengagement unfolds how the operation of consciousness is immanent as well as transcendent. The transcending characteristics of consciousness are always in the debate of many philosophical systems.

However, the empirical perspective admits that consciousness is intentional and articulated in connection with the object that it is *conscious of*. One can always be conscious of the object(s) in the world, but the intentionality of this consciousness does not entirely establish its ontology. Consciousness at the empirical level is not *bhāvamukta*—i.e., it is not free from emotion and feelings. It predominately possesses *ahambhāva*—the ego consciousness. As a result, one could intermittently get an impression about oneself which does not sustainably ensure its ontology (Mohanty, 1979: 10). To know consciousness in its entirety in the ontological sense needs to bring the notion of self-knowledge or self-awareness articulated through both the transcendental and the transcendent features of consciousness. The Sāṃkhya-Yoga and the Vedānta do talk about self-knowledge or self-awareness. That is about the (self) *ātman* and (self-knowledge) *ātmajñāna*. The self or *ātman* can be free from desire and attachment to the world. This freedom is achieved through (contemplation) *sādhana* that elevates a person to a higher level of *chetanā/caitanya* (consciousness), resulting in a transformation in the very mode of thinking. There is no craving for worldly pleasures and act with ego and pride. Thus, consciousness has been treated as a *spiritual substance*.

To understand the notion of the spiritual, we need to comprehend the intentionality of consciousness that operates at the psychological level and beyond the realm of the psychological. The psychological self epitomizes itself with ego and desire, thereby expressing ignorance as well as intelligence concerning its interaction with the world. The psychological self is confined by worldly concerns. It is not preoccupied with the questions concerning the self and self-knowledge. For instance, in *Katha Upaniṣad*, Nachiketa was deeply inclined to know from Yama about the true nature of the self. He was not concerned with the materiality of the world. In this sense, the knowledge of the world is different from the knowledge of the self. Though both involve intentionality in the epistemic or the semantic process of knowing reality, still the nature of knowledge is such that it presupposes consciousness. So far as the presupposition of consciousness is concerned it refers to pure consciousness as formless and self-intimating that contains no forms within itself and refers to no other. The self-intimating feature disclosed through self-knowledge describes consciousness as transcendental and indefinable, intangible, beginningless and endless. This description has significance as one gradually transcends the realm of the psychological through *sādhana* and reaches the highest state of consciousness, that is, *turīya*. This is an Upaniṣadic classification where the state of consciousness is conceptualized with four layers, they are, *jāgrata* (waking), *swapna* (dreaming), *suṣupti* (dreamless sleep), and *turīya* (transcendental consciousness). There is a need to understand both the empirical and transcendental aspects of consciousness that are very much a part of the discourse on consciousness in the philosophical system of Sāṃkhya-Yoga. This is so because by emphasizing the empirical scientific study of consciousness, one may not provide a comprehensive account of consciousness. Rather one would miss

the cosmic and its universal nature on which its ontology is grounded. Therefore, “there is a need to have a comprehensive metaphysics of consciousness.” (Pradhan, 2020: ix)

1.2 A Reflection of Sāṃkhya-Yoga Metaphysics of Consciousness

In this regard, to advance the dialogue on the theme of the “metaphysics of consciousness,” we intend to study the Sāṃkhya-Yoga Philosophy of Consciousness. Sāṃkhya-Yoga are allied philosophical systems customarily categorized under the orthodox classical Indian Philosophy. It is a non-Vedantic school of thought but developed on the grounds of Vedic philosophical tradition. When we discuss the ancient philosophical systems that developed in India, there is a common reference to orthodox and heterodox philosophical systems. The orthodox philosophical systems follow the authorities of the Vedas and Upaniṣads. Sāṃkhya-Yoga appears in the camp of orthodox systems because they adhere to the fundamental presuppositions of philosophizing. Cārvāka, the philosophy of Buddha and Mahavir belong to the heterodox system as they deny the authorities of Vedas and Upaniṣads. Apart from that, Sāṃkhya uniquely delves into experiences of life. The dialogue between Asuri and Kapila shows that there is a positive attitude towards life and that change or aspiration for the realization of higher values or attainment of spiritual perfection is part of the discourse of *Sāṃkhyakārikā* (Parrot, 1986). The change occurs with the reflective attitude towards life where reflection is construed as experience. It is not merely to be treated as an ascetic effort. The reflective mode of contemplation springs from life that takes a seeker towards liberation, which is something in the continuity of life. This positive attitude towards life experience is something unique so far as the classical philosophical systems in Indian Philosophy are concerned.

The Sāṃkhya-Yoga philosophizes the notion of consciousness with theoretical and practical concerns and has drawn the attention of many contemporary Western and Indian philosophers, such as Gerald J. Larson, Ian Whicher, Edwin Bryant, Sibajiban Bhattacharyya, Daya Krishna, Daniel Raveh, Paul Schweizer, David Bestow, Franklin Edgerton, T. S. Rukmini, Stephen Kent, and Tuvia Gelblum to name a few. They have been working on various central concepts of Sāṃkhya-Yoga philosophy *vis-à-vis* relating it to the Western philosophy of consciousness. Our interest lies in opening up some new conversations by delving into some of the interpretations and examining the significance of their theorization of Sāṃkhya-Yoga philosophy in the contemporary world.

Philosophical inquiries are inquiries concerning the love of knowledge, and philosophical knowledge grows in a climate of incessant *thinking* on various questions and problems in philosophy. Opening up the dialogue with reflective, meditative thinking is possible if we have some *new questions* (Raveh, 2012). Questioning is essential to envision the possibilities of renewing a philosophical text, whether it

is about Sāṃkhya-Yoga philosophy or it is about any other system of philosophy; “[a] close look into the philosophical questions and arguments does suggest that the general drive of a philosophical explanation or discussion is towards understanding” (Pradhan, 1992: 165). Understanding forms new meaning and develops a new perspective that may further reflect its relevance in everyday life. Philosophizing thereby aspires to have philosophical activities recurrently and systemically to carry out dialogues and these dialogues and conversations profoundly influence us and, to some extent, transform our *thinking* and way of life.

Moreover, in an intellectual tradition, it is always necessary to keep the dialogue on fostering a “fresh philosophical thinking” and not to engage in repeating the text but to conceptually analyse and make a critical intervention to create a *saved*—a “live dialogue” (Raveh, 2008: 434). Philosophical thinking as the dialogical inquiry unfolds, as Daya Krishna mentions referring to the reading of Īśvarakṛṣṇa’s *Sāṃkhyakārikā*, that there is something “vital and living, fertilizing the thought of the present and future” (2006: 354). “Thus new questions could be framed to have different answers and be more relevant to the times we live in.” Thus, to read the classical *Sāṃkhyakārikā* or *Yogasūtra* is not to visit the past but also to see their contemporary relevance in addressing some pertinent questions concerning metaphysics, epistemology, psychology, ethics and aesthetics.

1.3 Consciousness in Its Web of Other Concepts in Sāṃkhya-Yoga

Half a dozen concepts are central to the Sāṃkhya-Yoga Philosophy of Consciousness. These concepts are *Duḥkha* (Suffering), *Puruṣa* (Consciousness), *Citta* (self/ the mental) and *cittavṛtti* (mental modification), *Prakṛti* and *triguṇas* (Nature and its attributes), Causation, Evolution, *cittavṛtti nirodha*, (cessation of mental modification) *Samādhi* and *Kaivalya* (Aloneness/Liberation). We need to analyse these concepts and examine the ways they are interpreted and studied. Therefore, the focal point of this discussion is to engage ourselves in critical dialogical inquiry and try to bring out some pertinent viewpoints.

In recent times, Yoga, a metaphysical ally of Sāṃkhya philosophy, has attracted much attention from people due to its practical relevance to health. The practical dimension of *Yoga* is established through its teaching concerning the “psychosomatic technique of meditative practice”¹ (Bryant, 2009: xlv). Since it primarily deals with mental and physical fitness, one might be curious to know whether this popular dimension has undermined its philosophical perspective. Mentioning its philosophical content, Daya Krishna writes, “The text [*Yogasūtra*] seems to be, self-consciously a *prayoga-śāstra*, not interested in theoretical discussions or reflection of *pūrvapakṣa*, except incidentally. It is an *anūsāsanagrantha*, as it proclaims in the first *sūtra*” (2006: 204). Yoga and its *prayoga* (application) are not merely about

¹ Edwin Bryant, *The Yogasūtras of Patanjali*, Macmillan, New York, 2009.

a manual concerning implementing the righteous conditions for attaining *samādhi* and *kaivalya*; instead, it unfolds the very function of mind/consciousness that opens up a discourse on “psychology of mind and understanding of consciousness, rather than metaphysics of all manifest reality” (Bryant, 2009: xlvi). Patañjali’s *Yogasūtra* may theorize how reality has come into being, but it is not entirely devoid of seeking a metaphysical answer to some of the new questions concerning consciousness, freedom, and aloneness.

Raveh’s reading of *Yogasūtra* brings us an exciting episode of *yoga* as a *translation* between experience and language (2012: 4). According to him, *yoga* in its dialogical mode of translation offers an opportunity to represent the “inner selfhood” or “inner otherness,” which requires an intent theorization about human consciousness. In this connection, Raveh reiterating the voice of Daya Krishna finds that not much philosophical reflection on “yogic experimentation with human consciousness is carried out” (Raveh, 2012: 7). And, to measure its philosophical depth, new questions to be asked, not by overlooking its pragmatic concern, but by reflecting and engaging ourselves in a dialogue, we could locate the philosophical perspective of Ian Whicher’s notion of “practical metaphysics” (2010: 134). Highlighting the pragmatism of *Yogasūtras*, Whicher brings in *cittavṛtti-nirodha* as a case of “progressive unfoldment” of human consciousness that eventually reveals the true reality. Thus, *thinking* and *thinking together* is often necessary to unravel some of the elapsed philosophical deliberations by raising and reiterating some of the critical questions: Where does this *unfoldment* ultimately lead to? How does *Yoga* contribute to inner transformation? How does one recognize one’s identity? How does one re-establish the self-consciousness or *svatantratā* (freedom)? Furthermore, how does one transcend *pravṛtti* and return to *kaivalya* (aloneness)? (Daya 2006: 208).

While raising these questions, we need to reflect on the nature of *Puruṣa*. *Yoga* shares the metaphysics of Sāṃkhya philosophy, which maintains *rationalistic dualism* concerning the ontological existence of *Puruṣa* and *Prakṛti*, with a vital component of *atheistic realism*. Bryant believes that the “... *Citta-Puruṣa*-dualism of the text [*Yogasūtra*] much to offer modern discussion on the philosophy of mind and consciousness, and the *saṃskārakleśa* model has an enormous contribution to make contemporary approaches to therapy and psychoanalysis” (2009: 590). In a nutshell, *Yogasūtras*, for Bryant, presents a psychology of mind that need not be entirely treated for labelling pragmatic concern but indeed a venture towards theorizing the mind, not bypassing the problem of dualism.

The psychology of mind and psychoanalysis are deeply connected to the moral perfection of a person. While translating and commenting on Patañjali’s *Yogasūtra*, Shyam Ranganathan categorically points out the theoretical, and philosophical relevance of the *sūtras*. Among the classical philosophical systems, Patañjali had tried to systematically develop moral philosophy, which gave importance to practice that involved “external moral observances and internal purification of the psyche are not simply pragmatic means to some abstract spiritual end, but directly a function of his concern for the ethical” (2009: 22). According to Ranganathan, *Yogasūtras* is not merely a *prayoga śāstra*—a treatise concerning merely the practice of *yoga*, rather it “provides a formal, systematic and philosophical elaboration of the practice” (2009:

1). The practice is necessarily grounded on the ethical viewpoint of life, and he firmly upholds that the translators have failed to look at this treatise philosophically, particularly the translation of moral-philosophical context in which the notion of *dharma* is to be construed. This is evident in the preparatory stages of *aṣṭāṅga* yoga with the understanding of the significance of *Yama*. The normative demands of *yama* unfold the necessity of preparing oneself for a systematic approach towards moral perfection. In all its “variegated uses in Indian Philosophy, *dharma* is the correlate of ethical or moral” (2009: 21).

Ranganathan’s philosophical stance secures a space for the “practical metaphysics” of Whicher and shows the divergence in interpreting the *Yogasūtra* in juxtaposition to the viewpoint of Bryant and Raveh. Ranganathan maintains that the aspiration for moral perfection is reinforced if and only if there is moral knowledge. Unlike the Sāṃkhya, which maintains that self-knowledge is essential for *kaivalya*, Patañjali’s concern is not merely epistemological, but rather normatively epistemological. In other words, Sāṃkhya’s epistemic concern regarding self-knowledge is fundamentally confined to the discrimination of the function of *Puruṣa* and *Prakṛti*. In contrast, Patañjali’s effort has created a space for moral epistemology so far as self-knowledge is concerned. The essential attitude for moral perfection and its development to the realm of *dharmamegasamādhī*, (that is, “the rain clouds of morality liberating state of absorption that washes away all stains of evils”) indicates the conceptual predominance of the ethical within the epistemic conditions of *vyrttis*. For Ranganathan, Sāṃkhya’s reading of the *Yogasūtra* has failed to grasp the moral-philosophical context of Indian Philosophy.

1.4 Dualism in Sāṃkhya-Yoga

Yoga’s unifying worldview is undoubtedly drawn on the metaphysical ground of Sāṃkhya’s dualism of *Prakṛti* and *Puruṣa*. Some philosophers have critically reflected on the uncompromising *rationalistic dualism* proposed by Sāṃkhya philosophy. This dualism is construed as *fictitious* by Schweizer (1993) whereas Larson (2013) interprets it as exceptional and *unconventional*. *Puruṣa* and *Prakṛti* are two metaphysical principles held by Sāṃkhya-Yoga philosophy. *Puruṣa* represents consciousness. It is natural and one of the universal principles conceptualized along the side of the ontology of the *Prakṛti*. The *Prakṛti* being constituted of *triṅgaṇas* is the manifesting ground of the entire creation. The creative dynamism of *Prakṛti* unfolds the causal relationship that exists in nature and persists harmoniously in the continuum. Larson’s and Schewizer’s readings of dualism in classical Sāṃkhya philosophy *vis-à-vis* the dualism discussed in the classical and modern Western philosophy seem to be problematic or, in a sense, something incomparable. Hence, Larson calls it *unconventional* while juxtaposing it with the contemporary theories of mind and body.

Since Larson’s reading of classical *Sāṃkhya* as a *religious* thesis suggests that “consciousness of *Puruṣa* is not a cosmic consciousness, rather it is simply a fact

of in individual, impersonal consciousness, the consciousness which renders man's life and the manifest world possible" (1969: 47). One might ask if *Puruṣa* does not represent *cosmic consciousness* but only represents *individual consciousness*, then how it is to be understood? For Larson, this is a fact of individual *Puruṣa*—consciousness is “nothing or the presence of *nothingness* in the world” (1969: 48). The challenge here before us is how we analyse the notion of *nothingness*. Is Larson's Sartrean existential interpretation of *Puruṣa* viable? He also suggests that *Puruṣa*-consciousness is “transparent and translucent. It is a (*sākṣin*) witness” (1969: 46). In this regard, the challenge is how do we determine the epistemic nature of *Puruṣa* being a witness of the fact that “something is for the sake of it—*puruṣārtha*.” Suppose the epistemic *content* is what *Puruṣa* is not, then one might question: How does one construe the ontology of this epistemic involvement of *Puruṣa* being the sole witness of the changes occurring in *Prakṛti*? What if the *Puruṣa*—consciousness could be defined as cosmic consciousness?

Puruṣa in Sāṃkhya represents *pure consciousness*. According to Sibajiban Bhattacharyya (1992), this consciousness of *Puruṣa* is not about a personal self or *myself*, but somewhat above it. Pure consciousness is transcendental consciousness which is different from the consciousness of the embodied subject. Bhattacharyya's phenomenological presentation of the Sāṃkhya theory of consciousness unfolds a much broader philosophical canvas where he brings out four different philosophical versions of consciousness, namely, “I-consciousness, you-consciousness, we-consciousness and universal consciousness” (1992: 44–45). These philosophies unfold different layers of consciousness and their functions in engaging the self and the world. This engagement shows that the self is *incomplete*, and its self-awareness develops while being in a dialogical relationship with *the other*/the world. For Bhattacharyya, “the self-being engaged in a dialogical mode discloses not only the linguistic essence of consciousness but also its existence and presence” (1992: 65). Thus, the ontology of self in Sāṃkhya is comprehended through consciousness and its relationship with thought, feelings and actions. The direct and unified experience of consciousness illustrates how the self is part of the “empirical subject” and could operate beyond the realm of embodiment. The direct experience is the power of witnessing consciousness—*Sākṣin*. “The right discriminative power is the basis of having *self-knowledge* that awakens the normal empirical subject to transcend the realm of the empirical experiences which involves cognitive, conative and effective nature of consciousness” (1992: 57). In this regard, an analysis is necessary to bring out the realm of empirical consciousness that functions with its intentional attitude of being in the world, that is, being part of the primordial nature of *Prakṛti*.

Similarly, *Prakṛti*, in its *dynamic nature*, discloses a problematic scenario, that is, *Prakṛti* as *jaḍa* (insentient) but active and changing. It can bring changes in the state of existence, from the predominance of *rajas* to *sattva*'s predominance. One might question, is it unconscious? *Prakṛti* is unconscious, but an activity like thinking (*mahat*) is due to the *Puruṣaśaṃnidhi* mātra. *Prakṛti* is bounded—its primal nature binds it. The epistemological challenges to identifying the true nature of *Prakṛti* are essential for understanding the very foundational nature of consciousness in *udāsīna*, *drṣṭa*, *sākṣin*, etc. *Puruṣa* is beyond *guṇas* and the evolute. In other

words, *Puruṣa* is not affected by the causal reaction and the *bhāvas* created by the *Prakṛti*. The *bhāvas* are latent in the *mūlaprakṛti*; they manifest in the form of knowledge, particularly in the conditions of *jñāna* that lead to *siddhi*. Some *bhāvas* are included in *viparyaya* (ignorance), *āśakti* (attachment) and *tuṣṭi* (satisfaction). The *bhāvas* are a non-phenomenal part of the subtle body of the individual. Following the expository work of Kimball (2016) on *bhāvas*, one could further explore its cognitive power. As Larson also writes, "... the attainment of Sāṃkhya knowledge is a progressive process, involving an engagement first with the categories of the *pratyasarga*, then an understanding and cultivation of *bhāvas* which are conducive to continuing discrimination and finally an understanding of *tattvas* and discrimination between *Puruṣa* and *Prakṛti*" (Kimball, 2016: 543). There is a need to reflect deeply on the *tattvas*, *bhāvas* and *pratyasarga*, which are about the constitutive, projective, and consequent dimensions of *Prakṛti*, respectively (Larson, 1969: 70).

1.5 Self-Consciousness: Subjectivity, Normativity, and Causality

However, the conception of an embodied self is conceptualized by identifying the body as self or *I*. The consciousness expressed through the living body unfolds the intentional engagement of the embodied self with the world or nature—*Prakṛti*. While delving into this intentional engagement, Bhattacharyya mentions that this identity unfolds the "effective communion" between the self and the world. He construes this communion affirming that "...the body is not a prison house but a living link of an individual with the universe" (1992: 54). The link is explained by referring to the various functions of consciousness or *antaḥkaraṇa* in connection with *buddhi*, *ahaṅkāra*, and *manas*, representing intentionality, I- consciousness and ability of deliberation, respectively. The complex function of consciousness depends on the evolving conditions characterized by three elements of *Prakṛti*: *sattva*, *rajas*, and *tamas*. In this connection, it is essential to understand the phenomenological account of the body and how the body consciousness substantiates the notion of subjectivity (Sharma, 2011). Is subjectivity an objective fact? (Searle, 1992) Conceding this question positively would justify naturalism that claims consciousness is ontologically a part of the world. That is to also endorse the epistemic functions of consciousness to be ultimately reduced to a certain form of material existence. But for Sāṃkhya, the function of consciousness is not merely epistemic, but rather ontological in the sense that it has a distinct position regarding the very function of the ego and the self. How does the self-encounter the world? In this connection, Bhattacharyya emphasizes that desires and self-interests are realized through the body. The embodied subjectivity thus becomes central to the discourse of self-fulfilment. Does this self-fulfilment ultimately lead to the state of *kaivalya*?

The subjectivity of the body consciousness or subjective experience operates in the realm of feeling and acting. Being the witness of this feeling allows transcending

the limitations of the ego and other intentional deliberative attitudes. This transcendence exemplifies a case of higher order subjectivity and illustrates self-awareness which is conditioned by transparency. In the case of self-knowledge, transparency is an essential epistemic condition that is caused by the predominance of *sattva* (Sharma, 2011: 17). How does an individual sustain that *self-knowledge*? This may be a normative question grounded on the notion of discriminative witnessing ability that *ought to* aspire and act for the true identity of the self, that is, self-consciousness.

Patañjali recognizes the importance of this normativity with the injunction of *dharma* for attending to the ultimate true knowledge. We have already discussed this concerning Shyam Ranganathan's commentary on *Yogasūtra*. The theoretical underpinning of *dharma* indicates the regulating power of *Rta*. Moreover, on a similar outlook, the power of self-knowledge would be sufficient to transform the intentional attitude both in terms of external moral observances and the internal purification of the psyche to attain the spiritual end (Ranganathan, 2009: 22). Therefore, we need to reflect upon how consciousness functions in harmony with the *Rta*. *Yogasūtra* provides that experimental ground for a normative-aesthetic perception of the yogic experience. In this regard, Larson's view referring to the philosophy of *Yoga* is fascinating as it substantiates the experimental approach. He reminds us that "the *yoga* system has the potential philosophical and scientific significance for understanding the body's functioning and the mind." According to Larson, "Yoga is the oldest experimental, empirical-based research programme on mind-body interaction known to the human species, and it deserves to be taken seriously as an important chapter in the quest for human understanding" (2013: 182). In this connection, he appeals to demystify and demythologize one of the oldest philosophical systems and unfold a new conversation concerning consciousness for contemporaneous understanding.

A deep analysis of the metaphysics of the *Puruṣa-Prakṛti saṃyoga* directs us to the discourse of causality—*pariṇāma-vāda* and *satkārya-vāda*. Sāṃkhya's *satkārya-vāda* which essentially maintains the pre-existence of effects in the cause shares the dynamic state of the existence of *triguṇas* and their operations during both evolution and dissolution. There is a need to investigate the nature of causation as well as evolution conceptualized by Sāṃkhya. When the effect is said to pre-exist in the cause, how is the effect different from the cause? The notion of *identity* and *difference* (*bhedābheda*) seems to be a troubling field of analysis. However, the concept of effect as a product or being produced by the cause implies it is not different from the cause. The problem lies in addressing the question concerning the *non-existence* of effect before its production. On the contrary, the effect is newly produced or being manifested in a new form—that is, "The effect is the cause in a new form" (Mohanty, 2000: 76). The effect as *non-existence* has an implicit presence. For instance, the pot is implicitly present in the stuff-clay; when the stuff-clay exists, the pot does not exist. Hence the pot is a non-existent one being implicitly present in the clay. The process of making the pot explicit from its pre-existence implies that clay as primordial stuff fundamentally exists. The Sāṃkhya does conceptualize this relation between the *mūlaprakṛti* as the cause of everything manifested in multiple forms. The experience of the multiplicity and cognizing the presence of universal *Prakṛti* is something beyond the capacity of sense perception. According to Mohanty, this

universalization in epistemology is inevitable and Sāṃkhya cosmology takes us to the original and most “ubiquitous substance.”

The substance has the potentiality (*śakti*), and its manifestation (*abhivyakti*) in multiple forms shows that the operation (*kriyā*) not only brings about the changes in the form of existence but also shows the inherence of a new form in the stuff itself. The Saiva interpretation (Rotie, 2014) of *satkāryavāda* maintains that “causality relation is apparent externalization” through which “the universal consciousness manifests itself as if it were external to itself.” “Being an effect is nothing but being an object of knowledge and the sense organs, that is to say, it is nothing but universal consciousness, manifesting as an object external to the subject” (Rotie, 2014: 139). Saiva philosophers have tried to look at this identity and difference relationship from the viewpoint of epistemology and thereby give importance to the manifestation of cognition. How the pot is manifested in the form, and it shares an important relationship with clay; one can cognize the change by presupposing the efficient cause—the agent who could be the cognisor of this manifesting relation. Here, the presence of *Puruṣa* is thus treated as a witness.² For instance, what kind of shape a pot would take and so on.

The role of *nimitta-kāraṇa* efficient cause has an explicit presence in cases like a clay-pot causal relationship which cannot easily be overlooked, stating that transformation or manifestation of an effect in a new form is only due to *upādānakāraṇa* (Ray, 1982). The challenge here is how *satkāryavāda* incorporates the efficient cause/*nimitta kāraṇa* in its theoretical framework of causal explanation. According to Roma Ray, Sāṃkhya as *pariṇāmavādi* does not accept *nimitta-kāraṇa*, but it cannot be ruled out that they were not aware of the significance of a potter’s engagement in making a pot or a weaver’s engagement in making cloth. The significance of the agential causal power of transformation is acceptable if we locate *pariṇāmavāda* “not merely a doctrine of causality, but coinciding with the scheme of categories or *prameya* of the *sāstra*” (Ray, 1982: 391). Thus, *satkāryavāda* helps in theorizing the transformation (*pariṇāma*) that occurs in *Prakṛti*. However, that which is a transforming process (*pariṇāmi*) is a causal process.

1.6 Creation or Evolution in Sāṃkhya-Yoga

While contemplating the nature of evolution as creation and as a continual activity of transformation, we need to study how this creation is conceptualized in both the causal and the normative framework of life. Sāṃkhya advocates an early theory of causality—*Prakṛtipariṇāmavāda*. *Prakṛti* is a living body responsible for sustaining human well-being. Furthermore, this is a case of harmony between nature and life. *Prakṛti* is nature as a whole, and the whole is self-sustainable. However, teleologically speaking, sustainability demands human spiritual non-violent intervention to preserve its *tattvas*, serenity, and beauty. At the same time, the natural order is to be

² Alberto Pelissero emphasized this point during his lecture.

retained to understand holism. Thus, the notion of the environment as a phenomenal sustainable reality needs more philosophical intervention.

In Sāṃkhya's description of creation as an outcome of this causal process, as Ray suggests, it "ends with finite human beings and it also deals with major themes of human suffering and possible freedom from it" (1982: 394). This opens up a field for a critical philosophical inquiry concerning Sāṃkhya's philosophical engagement with the notion of agency and agential causation. In a larger epistemology context, one could further extrapolate the notion of agential intervention to talk about knowledge of the causal transformative process. Moreover, many times knowledge of the manifestation of effect in the form of externalization is not given to sense perception. Given this analogy, one could conceptualize the presence of universal consciousness in the whole transformative operation of *Prakṛti*, which is an ever-dynamic substance. The universal consciousness is always aware of possible effects and will be a supplement to reinforce the notion of teleological evolution.

Evolution, according to Sāṃkhya, is about the manifestation of the *Prakṛti*. In its dynamic form, *Prakṛti* brings changes in Nature, and we experience this in everyday life. The multiple manifestations of objects in Nature being constituted of *triṅgaṇas* define their origin and decay. Nevertheless, one could also imagine the manifestation of *guṇas* in the form of evolution beyond the realm of the physical. It could be conceptual and epistemic. The primordial notion of evolution—*śruti* was conceived theoretically to show the integration of *Prakṛti* and *Puruṣa* in the teleological form having cosmic causal relation. The nature of integration is a higher order effect of the proximity—*saṃyoga bhāṣā*. The proximity, as we have pointed, could be conceived in terms of an epistemic engagement where one is aware of several forces that are moving in the cosmic order and thereby making a case for possible harmonious conditions of living and flourishing life. How does one comprehend the ontological presence of *Puruṣa* without any deep meditative inquiry into the nature of its dynamism? The universe has a sustainable power of absorbing and creating a prevailing cosmic power continuum. We need to analyse further the integration of this power in the realm of metaphysics, cosmology and psychology (Torella, 1999).

Epistemologically, the *Puruṣa bhāṣā*—the reflection of *Puruṣa* could be construed in the meditative yogic ladder where there is a possibility of self-knowledge and self-realization. It is possible to conceptualize evolution through the mediative or yogic tradition rather than merely through an intellectual tradition. The intellectual tradition has construed the notion of evolution only from a physicalist–biological point of view. In Indian tradition, the notion of evolution is theorized by Sri Aurobindo much beyond its root in life's materiality. The challenge of interpreting the notion of evolution in Sāṃkhya remains challenging as it construes evolution as circular and teleological instead of linear and causal. The challenge lies in studying different types of evolution and their relation to the notion of emergence. The evolves and further in the form of knowledge or consciousness could be related to the notion of emergence. Biological evolution is only one kind of evolution which is termed causal and linear. The evolution of self-consciousness or *self-knowledge* refers to the evolution in the mental and spiritual realms. At this level, we talk about self-transformation. The notion of transformative personal identity could be theorized

concerning the intellectual and spiritual power of consciousness. Spiritual knowledge is about rising consciousness that unfolds novel paths—passage towards the eradication of *Duḥkha*.

1.7 From Suffering to Samādhi

Sāṃkhya philosophizes the journey of life—more or less about the drive of the individual self. It is pragmatic in its approach to the philosophy of life that begins its philosophical exegesis addressing the concept of *duḥkha*—suffering. Various conditions that cause afflictions unfold the *pravṛtti* of the individual self. The conditions show the profound psychophysical modifications that are grounded on the preponderance of *guṇas*. *Prakṛti* is absolute and is the manifestation of the *triṅguṇas*. Sāṃkhya maintains realism. At the same time, it accepts some form of idealism so far as *Puruṣa* or the realization of *Prakṛti* in the presence of *Puruṣa* is concerned. Hence, in our reading, we need to study the notion of *realism* in Sāṃkhya philosophy. This ontological *co-presence* and *cooperation* of the two divergently characterized metaphysical principles disclose the notion of *atheistic realism*. This point could be further explored through the notion of creation and harmony. The creation is an example of evolution in continuity which unfolds harmony between the two metaphysical principles, such as *Puruṣa* and *Prakṛti*, in a novel way building up a sustainable life in the universe. The sustainable relationship is not between humans and nature, but living together in nature or *Prakṛti* forms a realm of harmonious co-existence. Thus, atheistic realism is theorized beyond the notion of parallelism to show how ultimate unity could also be attained in an epistemic condition of realization that eventually signifies the value of co-existence and flourishing life.

Furthermore, this co-existence is often conceived in a normative ground where *Puruṣa* seeks the *Prakṛti* as the enjoyer—*bhakta*, and the *Prakṛti* becomes *bhogya*. This normative-aesthetic relationship undermines the worldview of a pleasure-centric life and instead highlights the importance of higher consciousness, *kaivalya*—the blissful state of being in peace. One who attains *kaivalya* is a *jīvanmukta* recognizes “the perfect *viveka* or insight for discriminating what is true and what is false” (Rukmini, 2005: 65). The *viveka jñāna* is an epistemic virtue accomplished through repeated practice. It is not just a part of determining the proper knowledge but the normative mode of exercising the will to be free from bondage and suffering. The *Puruṣa*—the consciousness thus enjoys the freedom of cultivating its true spirit of knowing oneself and one’s meaning in life. Hence, in this regard, the normative association between *Puruṣa* and *Prakṛti* is equally important for an accomplished life of being in the blissful state of *kaivalya*. Nevertheless, the two metaphysical principles are normatively blended as an indication of a fusion of intentionality from the *mind to the world* and the *world to the mind*. Thus, the intentional unification shows the significance of ontological, epistemic and normative co-existence that manifests in aesthetic and ethical life experiences.

In this connection, we can further our investigation by reflecting on the nature of *Puruṣa*—pure consciousness. How does one attain the blissful state of life? Sāṃkhya maintains a clear distinction between *mahat*, *ahaṅkāra*, and *manas*, which are psychological and the *Puruṣa*, entirely metaphysical. The psychic functions are different from the metaphysical function of the self. The self has a metaphysical existence and is defined in terms of pure consciousness, construed from phenomenology that delves into the intentionality of consciousness and its intentional structure of experience to understand how a specific form of intentionality is embedded in the living body—the *Prakṛti*. *Ahaṅkāra*—ego intellect and *manas* represent a function of intentionality, which is part of embodied consciousness. The living body becomes the locus of experience (Sharma, 2011). How does one bracket and transcend to the realm of pure consciousness? Consciousness in itself is self-intentional. Here, one could relate this to Yoga—modification of *Citta* and attain *cittavṛtti-nirodha*, which eventually will yield knowledge of attaining pure consciousness—*samādhi*. *Samādhi* is a state of union between the mind and the body in which the knowledge of pure consciousness is obtained. The dual existence of *Puruṣa* and *Prakṛti* is ultimately unified in the form of pure consciousness. This realization is *Kaivalya* which is achieved following the *aṣṭāṅga yoga*, where *samādhi*'s ultimate state is *asamprajñāta samādhi*. This state of nondualism is an “unannounced nondualism.”³ It is not merely an epistemic conception of the reality of consciousness; instead, it tries to show that the comprehension of such a form of consciousness unfolds the co-presence's transcendental unity.

1.8 A Normative Function of Yoga

The normative structure in which Yoga is practised is to articulate the right action—*niṣkāma karma*. That is, how the various forms of emotions are regulated and how one cultivates the spirit of performing good action. *Sāṃkhya Kārikā* of Īśvarakṛṣṇa begins with the rising of consciousness above suffering. Hence, the novel refers to the eradication of suffering—*duḥkha*. This reflective consciousness highlights not only the *prakriyā*—the prudential and the practical theory about consciousness but also the consciousness of life centred around *āhāra*, *viḥāra* and *vicāra*—that is, what to eat, how to live and how to think so that life unfolds the *nivṛtti mārg*—the paths for the evolution of higher consciousness (Dickstein, 2017). “This vows the normative or prescriptive dimension of *Yogasūtra* that positively orients the *yogins*. They ought to initiate a cleansing process that begins in *sādhanaṇa pada* to attain mental fitness that ultimately unfolds the attitude of compassion towards the suffering” (Dickstein, 2017: 615).

More importantly, Yoga's notion of mental fitness teaches us how to be in the right state of mind, empowering the self to be on the right decision-making path. Moreover, more importantly, one has the power to control *ahaṅkāra* (ego), *Kama* (desire for sexual pleasure), *krodha* (anger), *lobha* (greed), and *moha* (attachments).

³ Professor Pradhan stated while explaining the nature of modified consciousness.

Their reactions exhibit the power of *pravṛtti*. On the contrary, the *nivṛtti* through yoga brings the mode of purification of personality. That is, the change of character is an essential dimension of the practical aspect of philosophizing. Philosophizing as a mode of engaging oneself in critical and creative thinking must throw light on how these elements cause action and how these actions cause *attachment*—*pravṛtti*. Yoga lays down the path leading towards the *nivṛtti*.

Yoga unfolds the true nature of practical metaphysics. *Yogasūtra* of Patañjali studies the philosophical psychology of human consciousness deeply. A few important questions could be raised: How does consciousness operate at different levels of human existence? What is *Antaḥkaraṇa*- thinking? How does *vṛtti*s form action? How are good habits formed? How does one identify oneself with the world? How does one establish one's integrity? All these questions are interrelated. Yoga's approach to these questions is based on pragmatism (Whicher, 2010). According to Ian Whicher, "The practice of yoga allows us to understand the limitations of the material existence of life and elevate oneself to the higher spiritual state" (2010: 134). The elevation from *pravṛtti* is the root cause of having an afflicted identity to *nivṛtti* where one withdraws oneself and derives real strength from *viveka*—insight which ought to be cultivated continuously and regularly. It strengthens the discriminatory power of understanding right and wrong or *śreyas* and *preyas*. The attitude of *nivṛtti* motivates or induces the spirit of detachment from the world of pleasures and ultimately leads to *nirodha*—the progressive unfoldment of *yogi-pratyakṣa* (Whicher, 2015: 64). *Yogi-pratyakṣa* has the power of cognizing and transcending the false duality of the self. According to Whicher, there is no duality in *Prakṛti* and comprehending the universe as a whole; we need to reflect on *ahaṅkāra* and its function through the body. Yoga helps us regulate consciousness which manifests in the form of existence and causes suffering. Here, one is mistaken about one's identity, that is, "I am body-mind." As *Yogic*—*pratyakṣa* empowers the yogi in discerning the operation of senses over conscience—the consciousness and shifting of consciousness to a progressive state of unfoldment where one remains with oneself; in a true sense of integration of oneself with the other/world.

1.9 Summary of Chapters

The present anthology is comprised of eighteen chapters. Each chapter coherently and critically develops ideas concerning the various concepts of the Sāṃkhya-Yoga Philosophy of Consciousness. In this anthology, more than half a dozen concepts such as *Duḥkha* (Suffering), *Puruṣa* (Consciousness), *Citta* (self/the mental) and *cittavṛtti* (mental modification), *Prakṛti* and *Triguṇas* (Nature and its attributes), *Satkārya* (causation), Evolution, *Cittavṛtti nirodha*, (cessation of mental modification) *Samādhi* and *Kaivalya* (Aloneness/Liberation) are discussed. The discussions on the theme are briefly summarized.

The anthology begins with the notion of reconstruction of the metaphysics of consciousness, considering the nature of *Puruṣa* as an efficient and final cause.

According to Alberto Pelissero, Sāṃkhya metaphysics projects a speculative and innovative notion of the Puruṣa as the enjoyer and witness of the world. Puruṣa, as pure consciousness, underlies the world process as a motivating agential condition that gradually discloses its inactive and non-agential nature. Puruṣa is *chétanatva*. However, the emphasis is given to the primacy of consciousness by considering its ontological necessity. Puruṣa though is unaware of his distinction from the *guṇas* or *Prakṛti*. Puruṣa and Prakṛti's relationship is eternal. Professor Pelissero mentions that the *Prakṛti* and *Puruṣa* relation is like the relationship between *vāk* and *vyākāraṇa*—the grammar. Given that Sāṃkhya argues for a strict connection between Puruṣa and Prakṛti, it becomes important for us to reflect upon the ontological status of Puruṣa.

To comprehend the true nature of the ontology of consciousness, the second chapter provides a detailed textual analysis of the difference between the notion of consciousness and mind in Sāṃkhya-Yoga Philosophy. In this chapter, R. C. Pradhan maintains that *Sāṃkhya* metaphysics provides a speculative and innovative theory of consciousness. Puruṣa, being witness and seer, is referred to through its property of being both sentient and non-objective. Further, its isolated existence unfolds the teleological reason for unification. This epistemic process not only leads to the absence of experience in the realm of Prakṛti but also the occurrence of *viveka*. Pradhan clearly states that his interpretation is not a textual exegesis but a free interpretation considering the broad philosophical perspective of *Samkhyakārikā* where the concept of *vivekajñāna* becomes central to the discourse of liberation. The primacy of consciousness that is associated with the nature of Puruṣa becomes an ontological necessity for the explanation of itself as the first and final cause. Puruṣa is *jñātā* as well as *kartā*. The consciousness thus acts with its self-reflexive attitude. He conceptualizes the entire process of evolution of consciousness as teleological rather than mechanical which further underlines the cosmic manifestation of consciousness that is transcendental.

The transcendental consciousness of Puruṣa is contentless, argues C. D. Sebastian. The Puruṣa is non-intentional; having no desire of its own and thereby only acts as a *pure witness*—*sākṣin*. An intentionally conscious Puruṣa will be like the Cartesian self. The *cogito* in the philosophy of Rene Descartes is defined as *res cogitans*. Descartes accepts the ontology of the mental having substantive existence. But to say that self is a thinking substance would imply that what is the content of thinking. That is, thinking directed at something which is naturally present a case of a psychological self. The psychological self brings about the notion of an embodied self. But, the Puruṣa in Sāṃkhya philosophy is treated as absolute, eternal and changeless. Following the interpretation of K. C. Bhattacharya and Vijñānabhikṣu, the metaphysical notion of Puruṣa is highlighted as self-illuminating—*swayamprakāśh*.

However, the notion of witness consciousness is a significant concept further brought to the discussion by Shyamashree Bhattacharyya. A deeper account of the division between the psychological and higher or metaphysical consciousness is delved from the phenomenological account of the notion of witness. The intentionality of the psychological self is shown by the individuals striving for freedom from suffering. Liberation thus becomes the ultimate goal of life. The intentionality of engaging oneself freeing from the clutches of the *guṇas* of Prakṛti is an indication

of the arrival of *viveka*—“the contentless *jñāna*.” The liberated self is the *mukta* self which is free from its individuality. She also reiterates that discriminative knowledge is contentless and has no intentionality. It is rather empty, in the sense of Sartre’s *nothingness*. Nevertheless, Bhattacharyya maintains that the higher consciousness concerning the notion of *bhūtātman* and *kṣetrajñā* is transcendental.

While analysing the non-intentional contentless Puruṣa critically, Raghunath Ghosh characterizes Puruṣa as a “defunct consciousness.” The very conceptualization of Puruṣa as *bhoktā* and *udāsīna* is a false ascription. The Puruṣa cannot be an enjoyer as he has no desire to enjoy, but rather to be treated as *udāsīna*, we need to see that it is not affected by liberation. Sāṃkhya conceives that Puruṣa is necessary to disturb the equilibrium of the *guṇas* of *Prakṛti*. But *Prakṛti* is only been theorized as having the power of expansion and movement. Professor Ghosh brings many examples, citing quantum mechanics and the hydel power to show the dynamism embedded in *Prakṛti*. Being unconscious and active how does its owning and disowning become significant? The self-generated activities could be the false ascription of the Puruṣa., in addition to that to privilege that absolute Puruṣa as only an observer is to make Puruṣa *defunct*—i.e., a non-agent without any quality.

Can the Puruṣa be neither knower nor inactive? This question is further sympathetically delved into by looking at the intentionality of consciousness. The phenomenological notion of intentionality and its conceptual relation with Sāṃkhya consciousness is systematically brought out in the chapter “Sāṃkhya Concept of Intentional Consciousness” by Surya Kanta Maharana, while answering the question, i.e., how does Sāṃkhya exhibit a unique *antaḥkaraṇa*? Sāṃkhya’s modified consciousness is intentionally related to the external world. The intentional relationship with the world or the object of experience is different from the empiricists’ notion of experience which is primarily grounded on sense experiences. The phenomenological relation being intentional presupposes the consciousness or the self as the subject of experience. In Sāṃkhya, the transformation of modified consciousness in the individual is capable of receiving the reflection of the Puruṣa or pure consciousness. Thus, the notion of *antaḥkaraṇa* and its intentionality becomes central to the discourse of the Sāṃkhya philosophy of consciousness.

Pratibha Gramann has tried to explicate the notion of *antaḥkaraṇa* in Sāṃkhya showing its significance in cognitive psychology. How the *tattvas* operate along with the *antaḥkaraṇa* is an important focal point of this chapter where she discusses many cognitive psychological conditions of an individual concerning the notion of motivation, goals, clarity and transformation. The flow of *guṇas* in proportion becomes essential for the characterization of the form of being. Consciousness enlivens in the material form. In the case of the human mind, consciousness can influence our psychology. The notion of understanding is part of human consciousness in which intellectual abilities determine the cognitive function of the mind—the psyche. That is, how intellect and ego interact with *antaḥkaraṇa*.

The cognitive and intentional dimensions of the function of consciousness refer to the *process* by which the individual consciousness is modified. Though sometimes cognition is construed in material terms, this materiality in its finest form while when enlivened by consciousness, the intentionality is expressed in the form of “dancer

dancing,” as discussed by S. Panneerselvam, in his hermeneutic interpretation of Sāṃkhya philosophy of consciousness. According to Panneerselvam, the presence of consciousness has two dimensions: the spectator and the primordial materiality. The spectator or Puruṣa as witness represents contentless consciousness, whereas the *Prakṛti* as primordial materiality expresses the content of consciousness. However, he reminds us that being contentless is not to be treated as ordinary consciousness as we normally construe consciousness in the form of mental awareness. Sāṃkhya’s unique position in Indian Philosophy is not to be treated per with the dualism of Western philosophy. Hence, Sāṃkhya needs a hermeneutic interpretation with a constructive effort to unfold, as K C. Bhattacharya stated, “speculative insights that demand imaginative introspective effort.” Thus, the characterization of Puruṣa and Prakṛti interaction is not an easy undertaking if we miss the speculative imaginative framework that complements a yogic perception or *sādhana*.

To address this issue, Saroj Kanta Kar in his essay on “Consciousness and Causation” draws our attention while analysing the semantics of the nature of *samādhi*, *saṃsparśa* and *saṃyoga*. The notion of *saṃyoga* and *saṃsparśa* is meaningful to the notion of evolution. The evolutionary process unfolds *satkāryavāda*—the theory of causation. Kar discusses two types of causes, namely, the instrumental cause/*sahakārī kāraṇa*, and material cause/*upādāna kāraṇa*. The causal function of Puruṣa is something like the causal function of a magnet that attracts iron particles. Another example that is cited here is the presence of fire that emits heat. Thus, the *sahakārī kāraṇa* exemplifies Puruṣa as inactive and immanent. The changes brought in the realm of Prakṛti represent the function of *upādāna kāraṇa*. An understanding of the changes that occur due to the causal powers of Puruṣa and Prakṛti is possible through the meditative consciousness—*yogaja jñāna*. From the philosophical viewpoint of Sāṃkhya-Yoga, evolution is cosmic, rather than biological. Yoga, therefore, inculcates practices that are spiritually significant to understand the meditative experiences that unfold in a spiritual union.

The notion of causality is further examined by focusing the analysis on *satkāryavāda* and Gabriel Martino carries this out in the chapter “*Satkāryavāda: A Causal Explanation of Change within Eternal Being*.” According to Martino, *Satkārya* has little to do with the Aristotelian material cause. It is also suggested that causality has to be viewed from two different senses. One is concerned with the notion of evolution itself and another explains the emergence of *tattvas* from Prakṛti. The *tattvas* belonged to the realm of the eternal being. To understand the logic of causality, we need to focus on two aspects in which causa change is explicit. They are action and production could be discussed without contradicting the central ontology of Sāṃkhya. While being critically engaged with Ray Peret and Larson, Martino draws our attention to the grammar of being. That is, being *sat* refers to the notion of unchanging—the being within being. The transformation that occurs in the realm of existence is being regulated and caused, which could be conceptually related to action and production, respectively.

Sigfried Bleher’s essay could be brought to the discussion to highlight the notion of existence. Puruṣa’s presence as a source of evolution is compared with the notion of observer as being necessitated by quantum mechanics. This is because the quantum

has function before it is observed this includes thoughts, feelings and dispositions. They are observable by an epistemic subject. This observation being epistemologically significant, Bleher makes an important conjuncture that Sāṃkhyakārikā and quantum theory will be possible for a theoretical study provided the non-reductive physicalism is true. Physicalism, in its theoretical explanation, maintains that consciousness is an epiphenomenon and is causally reducible to certain neuro-physiological processes of the brain. This reductionistic insight thus rejects that there is the necessity of the presupposition of a conscious agent—the observer. This unfolds the possibility of the presence of the Puruṣa in *Sāṃkhya Kārikā*.

To comprehend the presence of Puruṣa, one must transcend physiological self-hood, which is the central theme of Daniel Raveh's essay titled "Rethinking Pātañjala Yoga Through the Concept of *abhyāsa* and *vairāgya*." Yogic life is a life lived through various stages, that is, the *astāṅga mārga*, as prescribed by Patañjali. *Vairāgya*, as a yogic act, signifies dispassion, and Raveh mentions the necessity of *parā vairāgya*, i.e., the ultimate dispassion which gradually helps in purifying the *antaḥkaraṇa*—the mental activity. The yogic practices must be carried out effortlessly and ceaselessly to achieve self-knowledge, which may be termed purified self-awareness. An individual understands who he/she is as the practices lead to *jñānaprasādmātram* which is entirely known as *purified awareness*. The purification of *antaḥkaraṇa* is nothing but purifying one's consciousness. The complete purification results from a form of detachment that leads to *dharmameghā samādhi*.

Three important concepts are discussed in the following chapters, they are, the notion of *vairāgya*, self-knowledge and *dharmameghā samādhi*. These are conceptually related to the discussion that has been initiated by Raveh in his essay. The concept of *vairāgya* is related to *vivekajñāna* which could be translated as self-knowledge. In the chapter titled "Discriminative Knowledge: A Way Forward to Higher Consciousness," I have tried to show that *vivekajñāna*—as higher consciousness elucidates the philosophical significance of self-knowledge. This chapter brings out the notion of the emergence of consciousness and its hierarchical function in the realm of psychological and transcendental. The consciousness that liberates the matter from its inertia transcends the psychological realm. The ego as a dominating evolute draws limits to a person's awareness or knowledge. The ego or *ahaṅkāra* operates at the psychological level. The emergence of ego from the realm of the Prakṛti shows the physical-psychological ground in which it operates and exercises its power ignorantly which leads to suffering. In this regard, *vivekajñāna* needs to be understood from the perspective of normative epistemology, enabling comprehension that *wisdom is good*. Wisdom arises in *buddhi* as a case of self-knowledge where the experience transcends the psychological realm of duality and enters into the realm of cosmic knowing. The epistemic concern must be nurtured by the normative attitude of seeking truth and practising it. Thus, it helps us realize how to overcome differences concerning the knowledge of the world and the cause of suffering. *Vivekajñāna* is essential for overcoming suffering.

Barada Laxmi Panda's essay titled "Self-Transformation and Self-Knowledge: A Way towards Ethics of Life" emphasizes the notion of a normative way of living. Yoga maintains that *Kaivalya* is the highest stage of life. This state is the *samādhi* state

which represents the highest self-consciousness. In the *samādhi*, an individual ought to aspire for it to overcome suffering. The *samādhi* is a perfect state of union where the individual self-consciousness merges with the universal self-consciousness. There is no dichotomy. The normative way of living life gives importance to freeing oneself from the clutches of the materiality of life and preparing for a spiritual life. The preparation here is mainly to achieve self-control, that is, having freedom from the ego. A *yogi* must strive for a true spiritual path that not only transforms his psychophysical self but also the transformation leads to *samādhi*.

The last chapter by Ian Whicher reflects deeply on the nature of *samādhi*, particularly the nature of *dharmameghā samādhi*. Whicher shows that the spiritual aspects of yoga are overemphasized, as some give importance to the otherworldly nature of *samādhi*. Rather, he suggests that the realization of the spiritual is a sincere endeavour of the normative dimension of the psychophysical being which is participating and transformative. The transformative aspect is highlighted concerning yogic perception and multiple forms of practice. It is because yoga is both epistemologically and morally oriented hermeneutic. It does not simply refer to the realization of the universal consciousness—Puruṣa, rather it is “getting it right with Prakṛti.” While rightly relating to Prakṛti, Whicher brings in the notion of harmony and integrity to show the ontological superiority of the state of *kaivalya*. The discussion unfolds the debates concerning the notion of participatory identity by advocating an integrated and embodied selfhood—the *engaged selfhood* for the *jivanmukta*. The normative account does supplement the epistemic concern of Īśvarakṛṣṇa concerning the desirability of knowledge—*jñāna* for liberation. Sāṃkhya’s concern was not ritualistic but rather purely intellectual analysis, which is also accomplished by the meditative practice of yoga. Whicher put importance to practice as he finds that “the top-down intellectual mode of engagement imputes the experiential foundation.” Therefore, the bottom-up approach demands a normative foundation for showing the significance of the practice, which leads to *cittavṛtti nirodha*.

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Chapter 2

Consciousness and Mind in Sāṃkhya and Yoga



Alberto Pelissero

Abstract This lecture, inspired by an online Lecture at the Indian Institute of Technology on invitation by Ranjan Kumar Panda, is focused on the distinction and the strict bound between Consciousness and Mind, as it can be viewed through two relevant sources of *sāṃkhyadarśana* and *yogadarśana*, namely the *Samkhyakārikā* by Īśvarakṛṣṇa (SK) and the *Yogasūtra* by Patañjali (YS), perused at the light of some of the more relevant commentaries thereon, first of all Vyāsa's commentary on *Yogasūtra*. The relevant passages being discussed are as follows: SK 19–22; 37; 61; 66; YS 1.3–4; 1.16; 2.6; 2.17–21; 2.25–27; 4.19; 4.22–26.

Keywords *Sāṃkhyadarśana* · *Yogadarśana* · *Samkhyakārikā* · *Yogasūtra* · Consciousness · Mind

This chapter, being the revised and enlarged transcription of a lecture, is focused on the distinction and the strict bond between Consciousness and Mind, as it can be viewed through two relevant sources of *sāṃkhyadarśana* and *yogadarśana*, namely the *Samkhyakārikā* by Īśvarakṛṣṇa (SK) and the *Yogasūtra* by Patañjali (YS). As far as SK is concerned, the *bhāṣya* by Gauḍapāda and the *Tattvakaumudī* by Vācaspati Miśra is to be considered; as far as YS is concerned, the *bhāṣya* by Vyāsa, the *Tattvavaiśārādī* by Vācaspati Miśra, the *Yogavārttika* by Vijñānabhikṣu, the *Rājamārtanda* by Bhojarāja and the *Yogasūtrabhāṣyavivaraṇa* by Śaṅkara, are to be taken into consideration, as relevant sources for the interpretation of the respective *mūla* texts. The relevant passages being discussed are as follows: SK 19–22; 37; 61; 66; YS 1.3–4; 1.16; 2.6; 2.17–21; 2.25–27; 4.19; 4.22–26.

Let's start from SK:

“And from that contrast, it is established the state of a witness (*sākṣitva*) for the *puruṣa*, to whom pertain isolation (*kaivalya*), neutrality (*mādhyasthya*), the state of a seer (*draṣṭṛtva*), the state of non-agent (*akartṛtva*)” [SK 19].

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The characteristics of a witness and a seer are indicated by the properties of being both sentient and non-objective: only a sentient being can be a seer, not an insentient one; only when objects are shown to a subject, can he become a witness. The *prakṛti* exhibits her creations to the *puruṣa*, playing the role of a witness. No object can be exhibited to one who is himself an insentient object: the *puruṣa* is both a witness and a seer because he is at the same time sentient and non-objective, a pure subject.

“Therefore, from the conjunction with that [the *puruṣa*], the insentient evolute [appears] as if he were endowed with consciousness (*cetanāvat*), and even though agency belongs to attributes (*guṇa*), the neutral [*puruṣa*] appears as if he were an agent” [SK 20].

“For the sake of exhibition of *pradhāna* to *puruṣa*, and for the sake of isolation of *puruṣa*, there is the union of both of them, like in the case of the lame and the blind; in such a way manifestation (*sarga*) is made” [SK 21].

Pradhāna being an object of enjoyment, it cannot be conceived without an enjoyer, the *puruṣa*. Furthermore, *pradhāna* is necessary for the sake of the isolation (*kaivalya*) of the *puruṣa*. The *puruṣa*, being unaware of his distinction from *pradhāna*, considers the three *guṇa*-s that really pertain to *pradhāna* as if they were his own attributes, and seeks emancipation from this bondage. Isolation is possible only in consequence of the knowledge that *puruṣa* is different from *pradhāna*: so the *puruṣa* needs *pradhāna* for his emancipation.

“From *prakṛti*, the Great (*mahat*) evolves; from that, the ego principle (*ahaṅkāra*) evolves; from that, the group of sixteen evolves; from the five out of this group of sixteen, the five elements (*bhūta*) evolve” [SK 22].

Prakṛti is unmanifest (*avyakta*), the Great principle and the ego principle (*mahat*, *ahaṅkāra*), are her first evolutes; the set of sixteen consists of eleven sense organs (five cognitive senses, five conative senses, plus the common sense or mental or internal sense). From the five primary elements out of the sixteen, five elementary substances evolve: space, earth, water, air and fire. Particularly, from sound (*śabda*), space (*ākāśa*) evolves; from touch (*sparsa*), air (*vāyu*) evolves; from form (*rūpa*), fire (*tejas*) evolves; from taste (*rasa*), water (*āpas*) evolves; from odour (*gandha*), earth (*pṛthvī*) evolves. Each one of these elements is endowed with the characteristics of the preceding ones, plus a specific character of one’s own.

“Because, it is the intellect (*buddhi*) that accomplishes everything for the experience of the *puruṣa*, and it is again [*buddhi*] that discriminates the subtle difference between *pradhāna* and *puruṣa*” [SK 37].

Buddhi is the principal organ, like a governor is considered superior to all other royal officers by virtue of his being the direct agent of the monarch, while other inferior officers such as village chiefs and so on are of secondary importance when compared to him. It is the *buddhi* alone that accomplishes the experiencing of objects for the *puruṣa*, by presenting them to the *puruṣa*, due to the reflection of *puruṣa* into *buddhi*, in reason of their mutual proximity. Experiencing, that is the enjoyment of pleasure and pain, is a feeling that takes place in the *buddhi*. The *buddhi* appears as if it has assumed the form of the *puruṣa*. Perception, observation, self-consciousness and so on, are all transmitted to the *buddhi*, taking their respective forms, and in just the same way, the functions of the senses too become identified with the *buddhi* in

its operation; just like the troops of the village chief become one with the troops of the Governor. In a similar way, the *buddhi* accomplishes for the sake of the *puruṣa* experience of all phenomena.

“There is nothing more modest than *prakṛti*: this is my opinion. Knowing «I have been seen», she no more comes within the sight of the *puruṣa*” [SK 61].

Modesty means extreme delicacy, the acute sensitivity of a maiden who cannot tolerate being exposed to the glance of a stranger. Having never been exposed to male eyes, if a maiden of noble descent, with her eyes cast on the ground, is seen by a stranger male when her body is exposed due to some inadvertence, she would hasten to hide herself so as not to be seen again in such an inconvenient condition. Just in the same way, *prakṛti*, being even more modest than a lady of noble birth, will in no case expose herself again to someone’s glance.

In connection with the image of the modest lady, it is to be noted a striking parallel with *vyākaraṇa* literature. In the Introduction by Patañjali to his *Mahābhāṣya*, the *Paspaśā* [PSP], we find the following passage:

“In connection with the passage *uta tvaḥ* [*Rgvedasamhitā* 10,71,4] «she uncovers her body», one indeed, although he sees, does not see speech. Another, although he hears, does not hear her. To still another, indeed, like a wife, wearing clean and pure clothes, having a desire for her husband, she spreads out her body [...] To explain, like a wife wearing clean clothes [that is, auspicious clothes put on by the woman after menstruation], having desire for her husband, uncovers her body, in just the same way, speech (*vāc*) reveals her body to one who is learned in speech. So that speech may reveal herself, therefore grammar should be studied” [PSP 38].

Please note the strict correspondence of *prakṛti* with *vāc*, both being undoubtedly feminine principles.

“She has been seen by me»: so one [*puruṣa*] becomes indifferent; ‘I have been seen’: so the other [*prakṛti*] ceases [to act furthermore]. Even though there is still conjunction, there is no reason for manifestation” [SK 66].

Once discrimination (*viveka*) occurs, then *prakṛti* produces no more experience for the *puruṣa*; in the absence of bondage, enjoyment cannot resist, just as there is no sprout in the absence of seed. Thus the *puruṣa* who has realized (through the very activity of *prakṛti*) to be entirely different from *prakṛti*, cannot consider any purpose as his own. Both experience and isolation are for the sake of the *puruṣa*: when both these purposes are accomplished, there will remain no reason more for any further activity of *prakṛti*.

Let’s go on about our topic with YS:

“Then there is the abiding of the seer in its own form” [YS1.3].

“Then,” that is, during the meditation state, not in the state of wakefulness, the unconditioned pure aspect of the *puruṣa* appears, just as when the rock crystal, seeming to be red due to the closeness of a flower whose colour is red, when this flower is removed, obtains its previous transparency again; so when the functions of the internal organ are removed, the *puruṣa* regains its pure unconditioned state, the pure light of consciousness without any content whatsoever. When the mind has reached the state of objectless unconscious attention (*asamprajñātasamādhi*), the *puruṣa* exists as consciousness himself on that circumstance, as at the time of

activity, and only because of the absence of the object, known as the modification of the mind, does not perceive.

“Otherwise, [there is] conformity to the functions (*vr̥tti*)” [YS1.4].

Otherwise, particularly during the state of wakefulness, the modifications of the *puruṣa* are identical with the modifications of the mind. The internal organ acts like a magnet, involved simply by its closeness, so the *puruṣa* seems to be an object of perception. The reason why the *puruṣa* perceives the mind lies in his only apparent eternal conjunction with it. Just as when the red flower is put near the rock crystal, a relation of closeness results into an erroneous conception of identity; and this results into the superimposition of the functions of the internal organ on the *puruṣa*. This superimposition is only a modification of the mind, it does not involve whatsoever the authentic nature of the *puruṣa*; but it leads to such notions as agency, discriminative knowledge and so on, with regard to the *puruṣa*, which remains forever free from all these. Vācaspatimiśra as well as Vijñānabhikṣu attribute this *sūtra* to the great master of *sāṃkhya*, Pāṇcaśikha. The question is: how can the perception of objects by the internal organ and the contentless perception by the *puruṣa* be one and the same? The perception of objects is a simple insentient function (*vr̥tti*) of *prakṛti*; whereas the perception of the *puruṣa* must be different from it, in fact it is only cognition in the aspect of simple contentless cognitive ability. The answer is that cognition is perception, that is, intelligence is *puruṣa*’s true form, not its cognition, as the question seems to assume, and it is in fact amenable to inference from authoritative sources, and not to routine perception during the state of wakefulness. During the state of wakefulness, the final cause is nescience, which leads to the apparent link of the *puruṣa* with the mind, which in turn leads to the conception internal to the *puruṣa* of possession, and therefore of common feeling of pleasant and unpleasant experiences. The mind is not really in touch with the *puruṣa*, but only in closeness with it, just as in the analogy of the rock crystal and the red flower. This proximity is not present in space and time, because *puruṣa* is not connected with them, because he is everlasting and present everywhere; it is only a sort of capability. Both capacities, the capacity of experience of the *puruṣa* and the capacity of being the object of experience of the mind, cannot be negated. Though experience in the aspect of objects of sense is a modification of the mind, it is being referred to as pertaining to the *puruṣa*, due to the identity of the modifications of both of them during the state of wakefulness. So, even though the *puruṣa* is not effectively in touch with the mind, he takes part in the advantages offered by mind, and is nonetheless not subject to change.

“Indifference to the attributes (*guṇa*), leading to the cognition of *puruṣa*, is his supreme aspect” [YS 1.16].

The agent who recognizes differences in objects becomes dispassionate with regard to them, then, his internal organ having been calmed by discrimination, becomes detached from the attributes. This agent, having been endowed with knowledge, reflects thus: “That which was to be attained has been attained, the afflictions which were to be destroyed have been destroyed, the succession of existences which has connected joins has been cut asunder, which, if not cut asunder, involves death after birth and birth after death.” The uppermost limit of this very same knowledge is

the supreme detachment. Liberation (*kaivalya*) is inseparable knowledge connected with this detachment.

“Egoity (*asmitā*) consists in the identification of the power to see (*drkṣakti*) with the power of vision (*darśanaśakti*)” [YS 2.6].

Puruṣa is the power to see; the internal organ is the power of vision. Egoity consists in the idea of the identity of these two. It is only due to the absence of discrimination of these two unblended and different faculties of enjoyer and enjoyed, that fruition arises. When the authentic form of these two has been ascertained through discrimination, isolation will follow, and enjoyment disappears. According to Pāṇcaśikha: “When due to delusion one fails to see that the supreme *puruṣa* is different from intelligence by its very nature, its character and its consciousness, he commits the error of considering that to be the self.”

“The root of what is to be blocked consists in the conjunction (*saṃyoga*) of the seer (*draṣṭṛ*) and the perceivable (*dṛśya*)” [YS 2.17].

The seer is the *puruṣa*, the cogniser of *buddhi*; the perceivable is the show, that which is seen within the *buddhi*. As a magnet operates due to mere proximity, through visibility alone the *puruṣa*, that in reality is pure consciousness, comes in, because the *buddhi* imbued with *sattva* becomes the object of experience by him. The *puruṣa* obtains his existence through a different aspect, and progressively he acquires dependence upon another, though by itself he is independent, on account of his being for another’s purpose. The conjunction of both of them, the seer and the perceivable, is produced for a purpose, and it is the cause of that which should be avoided, that is of suffering, both present and future. According to Pāṇcaśikha: “By avoiding the cause, in the form of the conjunction [with *buddhi*], there would result in an absolute remedy for pain.” Why? Because the antidote for the cause of suffering, that is, that which should be avoided, is as in the following example. The soles of feet are capable of being perforated, and a thorn is capable to perforate them; so the antidote hereof consists in avoiding to put the foot on the thorn, or in putting it on it, but only after having covered the feet with a pair of shoes. He who knows these three data, and had recourse to the antidote, does no more feel suffering, originated by the pricking of the thorn. Just in the same way, the attribute of *sattva* in the object of suffering is the cause of it. The reason why is that suffering must insist on an object, namely the object of the attribute of *sattva*; and not on the subject cognizing, the *puruṣa*, who is bereft of modification, devoid of action. Due to the fact that it is the *buddhi* that presents objects to the *puruṣa*, therefore when the attribute of *sattva* is involved, the *puruṣa* too, on account of his dependence on its form, seems to become involved. The *buddhi* endowed with *sattva*, though unaffected by sentient faculty, yet seems to be endowed with intelligence, through the transparency of the reflection, and as such experiences the different objects of sense. Only due to this fact, the seer enjoys the pleasures as they are presented to himself by the internal organ, which has taken the aspect of the specific object of sense. Such a consciousness becomes his own form. Having become the object of the spectator’s experience, existing in that time in another form, though per se independent, it becomes dependent on the *puruṣa*, due to the fact that it exists for another’s purpose. The three facts that must be known are (1) the afflictor, that is *rajas*, (2) the afflicted, that is *sattva* and finally (3) the remedy,

that is the separation of *buddhi* from *puruṣa*. *Buddhi* is one, but it is threefold too, being made of the three attributes, namely the radiant one, the dynamic one and the inertial one.

“The visible (*dr̥śya*) is of the nature of light, activity and persistence (*prakāśa*, *kriyā*, *sthiti*); it is made of elements and sensorial faculties (*bhūta*, *indriya*); it exists for the purpose of fruition and liberation (*bhoga*, *apavarga*)” [YS 2.18].

Sattva has the nature of light; *rajas* has the nature of activity; *tamas* has the nature of persistence. Thus the attributes (*guṇa*), being capable of conjunction and separation, having their respective closeness manifested in the occasion of their respective supremacy, due to the fact that these faculties are effectively employed in the achievement of *puruṣa*’s aims, through mere closeness just as in the case of the magnet and the iron filing, even though any predisposing cause, for example virtue and the rest, should eventually be absent, gradually are known as fundament or basis (*pradhāna* or *prakṛti*). This is called the visible (*dr̥śya*). This visible “is made of elements and sense faculties,” elements such as the earth and so on, in both their gross and subtle forms, and sense faculties such as the ear and so on, in both their gross and subtle forms. This operates in view of a distinct double purpose, that is *puruṣa*’s “fruition and emancipation.” Fruition consists of the attainment of the aspects of what is desirable and what is undesirable; liberation consists of the attainment of the true nature of experience. There is no further different perception besides these two. According to Pañcaśikha: “Even though only these three attributes exist, the unwise one grasps the different natural dispositions such as virtue and the rest, as presented to the fourth, the *puruṣa*, not subject to activity, simultaneously similar and dissimilar to the attributes, being the witness (*sākṣin*) of their activities. This being so, he does not conceive the possibility of any other form of perception.” How can these two, fruition and liberation, being in effect produced by *buddhi*, be misunderstood as *puruṣa*? Just as in a battle victory or defeat, really refer to the fighting soldiers, but are normally referred to their commander in chief, because he is entitled to enjoy the positive or negative results of the battle, so both bondage and liberation, that in effect pertain to *buddhi*, are correctly referred to *puruṣa*, because he is entitled to enjoy the positive or negative results of both of them. Every sort of mental acts such as perception, memory, inference, assumption, correct knowledge, and attachment, they all in effect pertain to *buddhi*, nonetheless they are supposed to exist in *puruṣa*, because he is entitled to enjoy the results of these all.

“The specified and the unspecified (*viśeṣa*, *aviśeṣa*), the solely dissoluble and the non-dissoluble (*lingamātra*, *aliṅga*), are the steps of the attributes (*guṇa*)” [YS 2.19].

Of these, space, air, fire, water and earth, are the five elements, together with their specified directly evolved effects of the unspecified sound, touch, colour, taste and odour (*śabda*, *sparśa*, *rūpa*, *rasa*, *gandha*) respectively. And in the same way, the ear, the skin, the eye, the tongue and the nostrils (*śrotra*, *tvak*, *cakṣu*, *jihvā*, *ghrāṇa*), the sense organs preposed to cognition, and even speech, hands, feet, excretion and procreation organs (*vāk*, *pāṇi*, *pāda*, *pāyu*, *upastha*), the sense organs preposed to action, and finally the internal organ (*manas*), all these eleven are the specified effects of the unspecified forms of ego-sense (*asmitā*). This 16-fold specified modification pertains to the attributes. The unspecified is six-fold: basic sound, basic touch, basic

colour, basic taste, basic odour, being endowed respectively with one, two, three, four, and five characteristics, these being the five unspecified ones, and the sixth is mere ego-sense. These are the unspecified functions of the mind, *mahat* or *buddhi*, mere capability to fulfil *puruṣa*'s purpose. That which is above the unspecified, namely the solely dissoluble, namely the seat where they take their position, the unspecified functions reach their highly developed steps; and when they dissolve, they take their position too, in the mere capacity of pure being, and finally transform themselves into the unmanifested and non-dissoluble primordial fundament, *pradhāna*, the basis that lies beyond both states of being, existence and non-existence. This is the solely dissoluble modification of the attributes; the non-dissoluble modification is beyond capacity and incapacity. The *puruṣa*'s aim is not the cause in the non-dissoluble, because in the beginning of this step, the *puruṣa*'s aim does not represent the prompting cause. So it is called eternal. In the beginning of the solely dissoluble, the unspecified and the specified states, the prompting is the *puruṣa*'s aim. So these three are known as non-eternal. The attributes share the properties of all of these, so they neither dissolve nor are produced. However, they appear as if they were endowed with the properties of birth and dissolution, due to the fact that they are connected with different individuals, and with the three divisions of time, namely past, present and future, connecting themselves with attributes, just in the same way as Devadatta is said to become poor because his cattle are dying. There is only the starvation of the cattle, not the annihilation of Devadatta's organism, that constitutes his poverty. The solely dissoluble, existing in strict closeness to the non-dissoluble, and originating therein, becomes divided consequently, due to the fact that the sequence is never broken. The same happens as far as the six unspecific modifications originating in the solely dissoluble are concerned: they become divided consequently according to the fixed sequential order of the modification. Just in the very same way, both the elements and the sense organs, originating in these unspecified ones, become divided consequently. In fact, there is nothing beyond the specified, there is no further modification of the specified into any other object.

"The seer (*draṣṭṛ*) is pure vision (*dr̥ṣi*); though being pure, still, he sees concepts (*pratyaaya*)" [YS 2.20].

"Pure vision": the pure and simple faculty of perception, non-charged with qualifications. Such is the *puruṣa*, who knows through reflecting into the mind. He is neither undistinct nor distinct with respect to the mind. Not undistinct, because the mind is modifiable, appertaining both to known and to unknown objects: its objects, such as jars, cows and so on, being known or unknown, prove it to be modifying; whereas the *puruṣa*, due to the fact that every object is always known to him, proves his feature of not being subject to modifications. Why? First of all, the mind, being the object of the *puruṣa*, cannot represent simultaneously both the perceiver and the non-perceiver. Every object is always known to the *puruṣa*, his unmodifying nature is proved. And secondly, the mind exists for another's aim, because it operates with the support of the sensorial faculties, the sensory objects and mental activity; whereas the *puruṣa* exists for his own sake. And finally, the mind, being able to determine all the objects, these being potentially peaceful, passionate or obscure, is made up of the three *guṇa*-s, and as such it is insentient; whereas the *puruṣa* is the seer of the three

guṇa-s. So the *puruṣa* cannot be said to be undistinct from the mind. Then should he be distinct from it? No, he is not entirely distinct from it either. Why? Because “though being pure, still he sees concepts,” because he perceives the ideas belonging to mind, and this process of perception seems to be undistinct from him, though really it is not so; as it has been said by Pāñcaśikha: “The capability of the experiencing agent, unmodifying and untransferable, seems to be as if it were transferred to the modifying object, to the point that it overlaps with the operation thereof; and the same capability, being endowed only with a mere mimicry of the intellectual operation which has been tinged by the touch of sentience, but as such it is uncontaminated by these intellectual operations, is called the operation of knowledge.”

“Only for his [i.e. *puruṣa*’s] purpose is the being of the visible” [YS 2.21].

The visible becomes the object of the *puruṣa* whose aspect is mere sentience; the aspect of the visible is for his own sake. Having accomplished fruition and liberation, the insentient aspect of the visible, attaining to its existence through another aspect, the sentient aspect of the *puruṣa* reflected therein, is no longer capable to be seen by the *puruṣa*. The destruction of this aspect would result into the destruction of the visible, but it is not destroyed. The visible is not annihilated for the emancipated *puruṣa*; he only stops to perceive it; and his sentience being no more mirrored in the *buddhi*, he ceases to perceive any pleasure or pain and so on, these being no more than the preceeding outcomes of his connection with the attributes of *buddhi*. Because of that act of knowing, which can be compared to action, of *puruṣa* who is of the nature of the seer, an object becomes fit to be seen only when it becomes *puruṣa*’s object. Everyone is agreed that the aim of existence of all objects is their becoming knowable objects of consciousness; therefore it is for *puruṣa*’s sake that the true nature of the attributes (*guṇa*-s) exists.

“From its [i.e. non-perception’s] absence, there is the absence of conjunction, that is removal; and that is the isolation of the seer” [YS 2.25].

From the absence of non-perception, there is the absence of conjunction of the *puruṣa* and mind, that is the total annihilation of bondage. This is removal, it is the isolation of the seer, that is the non-mixture of the *puruṣa*, the non-conjunction with the *guṇa*-s. When there is cessation of the cause of pain there is cessation of pain: this is removal. At that time it is said that *puruṣa* abides in his own form.

“The instrument of removal is [undisturbed] knowledge of discrimination (*vivekakhyāti*)” [YS 2.26].

“Knowledge of discrimination” consists in recognizing the difference between *puruṣa* and attributes. This kind of knowledge is perturbed by the persistence of false knowledge. But when the germinative capacity of false knowledge has been burnt up, and as such it stops sprouting, then the shining flow of discriminative knowledge belonging to *sattva*, altogether free from contaminations of suffering, abiding in the paramount wisdom, arises. That continuous discriminative discernment is the means to removal of association. Then there is the burnt-seed of misapprehension, and it does not sprout again. Therefore, this is the path to liberation, the means to removal of association. The cessation of contact of the *puruṣa* with the intellect alone is the direct cause of the removal of pain; discriminative discernment, on the other hand, by

removing ignorance which is the cause for contact with the intellect, is only indirectly the cause for liberation.

“For him the awareness to the supreme stage is sevenfold” [YS 2.27].

“For him,” that is, the one who has knowledge of discrimination, on the removing of enveloping impurities of *buddhi*, no further cognition is brought about, therefore the awareness of this wise one becomes sevenfold. Its steps are: (1) the object to be removed has been known, so there is nothing more to be known; (2) the causes of the suffering waiting for removal have been weakened, so there is nothing more of them left still waiting to be weakened; (3) the removal has been directly seen through a practice of suppressive meditation; (4) the means of removal in the shape of knowledge of discrimination has been fulfilled. Such is the fourfold lysis of knowledge. Then follows the threefold lysis of the internal organ: (1) the office of mind has been achieved; (2) the attributes without residues, like stones falling from the top of a hill, after having been dissolved into their cause, completely disappear, and after having been dissolved they are no more produced again, due to the lack of any purpose bound to their eventual production; (3) in this final stage, the *puruṣa*, left behind all attributive connection, uncorrupted and brilliant in his own original aspect, becomes isolated. The *puruṣa*, being the witness of this sevenfold knowledge, at its utmost stage, is called adept, because he is gone beyond the range of the attributes.

“[Mind] is not self-illuminating, because it is perceptible (*drśya*)” [YS 4.19].

Just as the other senses, such as sound and other objects, being subject to perception, are not self-illuminating, so also the internal organ must be intended to be so. Fire cannot be offered as an instance in this case, because even the fire does not illuminate its not luminous self. This illumination is to be seen only when there is a contact between that which is the illuminated and that which is the illuminator; and such a contact cannot exist with one’s own aspect. The meaning of the sentence “[mind] is not self-illuminating” is that it is not perceived by anyone. In the same way, space (*ākāśa*) cannot exist in any other object, due to the fact that it exists in its nature. People see that activities of living beings are based upon the awareness of the processes of their internal organs, such as “I am angry,” “I am afraid,” “with regard to this I feel attachment, with regard to this I feel aversion” and so on; and such knowledge cannot be explained unless there is a knowledge of one’s own intellect. “This illumination is to be seen”: each and every action is based on the relationship existing between an actor, an action and an instrument; just in the same way as cookery is based on the relation of the cook, the action of cooking and the food cooked; similarly, illumination is an action, therefore should also be based on a type of relation quite similar; and such a relation can possibly exist only among different objects, not at all within a single object.

“Consciousness, devoid of any activity whatsoever, knows its own intellect, when by reflection it achieves a sort of oneness with the mind” [YS 4.22].

The power of the experiencer is neither subject to change, nor to movement, due to contact with objects. It seems only to unite with the mutable functions of the mind, when it takes on the form of these functions. That which is identified with these functions of the mind, is called a modification of consciousness, but really it is only a mimicry of the function of the intellect, being enlivened by the reflection

of consciousness. It has been said: “Neither underworld, nor mountain caves, nor darkness, nor the hidden caverns of the deep sea, are the caves in which the *brahman* is hidden; the wise say it is the modification of the internal organ, when it is identical with him.” Even though consciousness (*citi*) does not move, the knowledge of its own modification of the mind happens only because of the changing form of the modification of intellect. This is the idea.

“The mind (*citta*), coloured by the seer and the visible, grasps all objects” [YS 4.23].

The mind is coloured by the cognisable object, and being itself an object is connected with the subjective *puruṣa* by modification as self. Then it is this mind alone that becomes “coloured by the seer and the visible,” that is enlivened by both subject and object, and shining as the object and the subject, assuming the form of being both conscious and unconscious. Though being of the essence of an object, it appears to be of the essence of non-object, just like the rock crystal, and it is said to be able to grasp “all objects.” Some who are deceived by this resemblance to the mind say that the mind itself is conscious; others declare that all this world along with all its causes is mere mind; any other objects, such as a cow, a pot and so on, do not exist. All these deserve to be pitied. Why? Because the mind, shining in the form of all objects, is the seed of their illusion. Consequently, in conscious *samādhi*, the object cognised having become a reflection (*pratibimbābhūta*), it is distinct from the mind, due to the fact that the mind is its real substratum. If this object were only the mind, then how could the form of insight be ascertained by insight itself? Therefore, that by which the object reflected in insight is ascertained, is *puruṣa*. In this way, those who divide the mind in its three forms as the cogniser, the cognition and the cognised, are the people with true insight. *Puruṣa* has been realized by them.

“Though coloured by countless latent impressions (*vāsanā*), it [the mind] exists for another, due to the fact that it acts by combination” [YS 4.24].

The mind, though coloured by countless latent impressions, exists for another’s purpose, that is, for the fruition and emancipation of another, the *puruṣa*, not for its own sake, because it acts by association, like a house. The mind, which acts by combination, cannot exist for its own sake. Neither the mental state of pleasure exists for the sake of pleasure, nor the state of knowledge exists for the sake of knowledge: both of them exist for another’s sake. This other one is the *puruṣa*, whose purpose is both fruition and emancipation. For instance a house fulfils the job of a bed and so on, only with the help of a bed, the body and so on; whereas *puruṣa*, being of the form of eternal consciousness, does not stand in need of another for the sake of consciousness, and *puruṣa* has no other useful activity, he is not one who functions in combination with others. This is the idea.

“For one who sees the difference, there is the cessation of all imagination (*bhāvanā*) about the nature of self” [YS 4.25].

Just as in the rainy season, one infers the existence of seeds of grass, seeing new blades of grass sprouting forth, so just in the same way, one infers that the conduct leading to liberation, which is the cause for insight into difference between the mind and self, has been achieved, when one sees the flow of tears of joy and the rising up of hairs, in him who hears of the path towards liberation. The thought pertaining to

his own states of being naturally comes to him. In the absence of such deeds, due to defects, he gives up his true nature thus described. Then arises a liking for the opposing view and no liking to the ascertainment of truth. In that case, the thoughts pertaining to his state of being appearing as “Who was I?” “How was I?” “What is this?” “How is this?” “What shall we become?” “How shall we become?” But this thought ceases in the case of one who sees the distinction. Why? Because this peculiar change belongs only to the mind; the *puruṣa* however, in the absence of nescience, remains pure, untouched by the characteristics of the mind. Therefore, the thought pertaining to his states of being ceases in the case of a person who is wise.

“Then the mind (*citta*) is inclined towards discriminative knowledge (*viveka*), and tilts heavily to isolation (*kaivalya*)” [YS 4.26].

The mind, previously tilted heavily towards sensual objects and inclined towards nescience, now becomes entirely changed, that is, tilted heavily towards isolation and inclined towards discriminative knowledge. Due to the cessation of that imagination, the result is that there is cessation of attachment and hatred with regard to heaven, hell and so on.

From our analysis of some relevant passages from *sāṃkhya* and *yoga* sources, we may conclude that the mind, that is mental activity together with its contents, lies on the side of *prakṛti*, the female active unintelligent principle; whereas consciousness, that is, the pure contentless seer, stands on the side of *puruṣa*, the male unactive intelligent principle.

The problem now is as follows: can this conclusion be properly and entirely derived from *sāṃkhya* and *yoga* sources alone, or may we suppose that it is actually the result of a sort of long shadow being cast on *sāṃkhya* and *yoga* doctrine by the vedāntic interpretation, as it can be derived by such doxographical sources as the *Sarvadarśanasamgraha* (SDS) by Mādhava? Perhaps a perusal of relevant passages from SDS (namely the chapters about *sāṃkhyadarśana* and *yogadarśana*) could eventually help us to cope with this dilemma.

The most famous text of the compendium (*saṃgraha*) literary genre is probably the *Sarvadarśanasamgraha*, “Compendium of all the darśanas” by Mādhavācārya (fourteenth century CE). The vast majority of manuscripts has only 15 chapters and do not contain a chapter on Śāṅkara’s philosophy. To the very same master Śāṅkara (Śāṅkarācārya, Ādiśāṅkara, sixth–seventh century CE) it has been attributed (with not so much plausibility) the possibly earlier work of this kind, the *Sarvavedāntasiddhāntasārasaṃgraha*, “Compendium of the resume of all the definitive conclusions of the vedānta,” nearly contemporary with an important jaina work, the *Ṣaḍdarśanasamuccaya*, “Collection of the six darśana-s” by Haribhadra Sūri (eighth century CE). The scene is enriched with an anonymous treatise (date unknown), the *Sarvamatasamgraha*, “Compendium of all opinions,” with the *Siddhāntaleśasaṃgraha*, “Small compendium of the definitive conclusions” by the śaiva teacher Appayya Dīkṣita (1552–1624), and completed with the *Sarvasiddhāntasaṃgraha*, “Compendium of all the definitive conclusions” by a group of scholars (under the patronage of the *marāṭha* king of Tañjāvūr of Śāhajī, 1685–1711).

The *Ṣaḍdarśanasamuccaya* by Haribhadra Sūri treats the *bauddha*, *nyāya*, *sāṃkhya*, *jaina*, *vaiśeṣika*, *jaiminīya* (= *pūrvamīmāṃsā*) and *cārvāka* (*nyāya* and *vaiśeṣika* must be considered together if we want to have the total sum of the six *darśana*-s). The *Sarvavedāntasiddhāntasārasaṃgraha* by Śaṅkara treats of the *lokāyatika*, *ārḥata* (= *jaina*), *bauddha* (*mādhyaṃika*, *yogācāra*, *sautrāntika*, *vaibhāṣika*), *vaiśeṣika*, *naiyāyika*, *prabhākara*(*pūrvamīmāṃsā*), *bhaṭṭa*(*pūrvamīmāṃsā*), *sāṃkhya*, the school of Patañjali (*yogadarśana*), of Vedavyāsa (the philosophy of the *Mahābhārata*), and finally *vedāntadarśana*. The *Sarvamataṣaṃgraha* treats two kinds of subjects, not Vedic (*bauddha*, *jaina*, *cārvāka*) and Vedic, that is the systems of Kaṇāda (*vaiśeṣika*), Akṣapāda (*nyāya*), *yoga*, *sāṃkhya*, (*pūrvamīmāṃsā*, and *vedānta*.

As far as the authorship of the *Sarvadarśanasamgraha* (floruit 1350) is concerned, a great debate is active about the identity of its author: should we consider Mādhava as the same as Vidyāraṇya (born to Māyaṇācārya and Śrīmatīdevī in Pampakṣetra), the brother of Sāyaṇa, or identical with Sāyaṇa or what else? Should we consider Vidyāraṇya as a different person, and Mādhava and Sāyaṇa as his disciples? The author of the treatise should be identified with Mādhava-Sāyaṇa, or with Bharatīūrtha, or with Cinnambhaṭṭa? Cinnambhaṭṭa (alias Cannibhaṭṭa, Cinnabhaṭṭa, Cennubhaṭṭa), one of the many scholars in the court of Mādhava, raised to the position of a royal preceptor, *rājapaṇḍita*, was a younger contemporary of Mādhava and Sāyaṇa, son of Sarvajñaviṣṇu who was the teacher of both of them and is considered as the author of a commentary (*Prakāśikā*) on Keśava Miśra's *Tarkabhāṣā*, and of another commentary (*Vivaraṇa*) on Varadarāja's *Tārkikarakṣāsārasaṃgraha*.

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Chapter 3

The Sāṃkhya Metaphysics of Consciousness: The Cosmic Versus the Individual Consciousness



Ramesh Chandra Pradhan

Abstract In this essay, I will attempt to reconstruct the metaphysics of consciousness in the Sāṃkhya system. The Sāṃkhya system of metaphysics has offered a very speculative yet innovative theory of consciousness in its theory of *puruṣa*. Though this is well known as a dualistic system of metaphysics of *puruṣa* and *prakṛti*, yet it tends to give primacy of place to the *puruṣa* as consciousness. The system of Sāṃkhya metaphysics aims at the liberation (*kaivalya*) of the *puruṣa* from its bondage to the *prakṛti*. Therefore, it appears that the Sāṃkhya makes *prakṛti* and its manifestations a means towards the liberation of the individual and embodied *puruṣa*. Sāṃkhya succeeds in making room for the liberation of the individual *puruṣas* within its transcendental metaphysics of consciousness by overcoming the limitations of naturalism. Thus, given the transcendental framework of the Sāṃkhya metaphysics, the resemblance between Vedānta and Sāṃkhya becomes conspicuous to a large extent.

Keywords *Puruṣa* · *Prakṛti* · Transcendental consciousness · Embodied “I” · Bondage · Liberation

3.1 Introduction

Sāṃkhya is one of the oldest systems of Indian philosophy. It is well known for its dualist metaphysics of *puruṣa* and *prakṛti*. The most notable contribution of Sāṃkhya is its metaphysics of consciousness. Though it differs from the Vedānta in many respects, especially from the Advaita Vedānta, it resembles the latter in its theory of transcendental consciousness in the form of *puruṣa* that is one, eternal, and unchanging in nature. *Prakṛti*, on the contrary, is taken to be unconscious and material in nature. However, the unconscious *prakṛti* gives rise to the manifold nature beginning from the *buddhi* (intellect), *ahaṅkāra* (ego), and *manas* (mind) to the gross elements of the material world under the influence of *puruṣa*. Sāṃkhya, therefore,

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paradoxically, keeps *puruṣa* and *prakṛti* united in the evolution of the natural world which contains the individual selves or *puruṣas* along with the subtle and gross material bodies.

In this essay, I will argue that Sāṃkhya dualism is not the kind of dualism that keeps matter and mind or consciousness completely separate from each other. Sāṃkhya allows *prakṛti* to be creative, though it is taken to be unconscious and material in nature. So *prakṛti* cannot strictly be unconscious and unintelligent because it gives rise to the conscious individuals. A completely unconscious *prakṛti* cannot be the material cause of conscious beings in the world. In this sense, *puruṣa* as consciousness dominates the world scene as it is not only the efficient cause of the world but also the final cause (Hiriyanna, 1932; Radhakrishnan, 1923). Besides, *puruṣa* or consciousness underlies the world process as the underlying principle, though it remains inactive and non-agential in its pure form. In Sāṃkhya, *puruṣa* is, thus, not only the enjoyer (*bhoktā*) of the world but the witness (*sākṣin*). From this, the primacy of consciousness follows as a matter of ontological necessity.

My essay is not a textual exegesis of the Sāṃkhya texts but a free interpretation of the main tents of the system, which are well known to any student of Indian metaphysics. However, I do not claim that my interpretation claiming the primacy of consciousness is entirely free from the transcendentalist and anti-naturalist bias.

3.2 Prakṛti and Puruṣa: The Sāṃkhya Dualistic Metaphysics

The Sāṃkhya concept of *prakṛti* as distinguished from *puruṣa* is unique in the sense that *prakṛti* or nature manifests itself at various levels because of the presence of the *puruṣa*. This shows that *prakṛti* itself is not self-sufficient to evolve or manifest itself though it is the material cause of the universe (Bhattacharyya, 1956). *Prakṛti*, or nature, is the sole source of the universe, but it is without intelligence and consciousness or will. It derives consciousness from the *puruṣa* and appears to be evolving towards a goal. Its teleology is derived and secondary (Hiriyanna, 1932; Radhakrishnan, 1923).

Given the insentient (*acetanā*) nature of *prakṛti*, it is easy to conclude that it is primarily matter in its substance and opposed to consciousness. However, this does not hold good because *prakṛti* can reflect consciousness as, in the evolution process, the *buddhi* (intellect) reflects the consciousness of the *puruṣa* because of close proximity (*Sāṃnidhya*). The *puruṣa* gets reflected in the intellect, so *prakṛti* appears conscious and intelligent in the world process. This consciousness may, of course, be deemed as derivative, but it is real and, for all practical purposes, remains throughout the course of the evolution of the *prakṛti*. From this, we can derive two conclusions:

1. *Prakṛti* is not completely *jaḍa* or without consciousness. It can receive consciousness from the *puruṣa*. The *buddhi* or intelligence is part of *prakṛti* or nature.

2. The evolution of the world is teleological and not mechanical. Had it been mechanical, it would not be the instrument of the liberation of the *puruṣa*.

Thus, it is accepted by the Sāṃkhya thinkers that *prakṛti* or nature is not a pure material principle and that the process of evolution is not a blind and mechanical process as suggested by modern mechanistic sciences.

The Sāṃkhya metaphysics of nature is not materialistic, nor is it naturalistic. Nature is itself not materially or physically closed as it is assumed by modern materialist theory of the world (Kim, 2011; Searle, 1992). The Sāṃkhya thinkers allow nature or *prakṛti* to look beyond itself to the transcendental reality of the *puruṣa* for its initial impetus for manifestation (Sharma, 1962). The Sāṃkhya metaphysics thus does not allow for the absence of consciousness from the world but the presence of consciousness, even in a modified form as the witness consciousness. For the Sāṃkhya, the world could not be without consciousness because it embeds consciousness in its cosmic manifestation.

3.3 Puruṣa as the Transcendental Consciousness

Puruṣa or consciousness is transcendent to *prakṛti* and the manifest world because, by its own nature, it is inactive and self-contained; it is neither a cause nor an effect (Bhattacharyya, 1956; Hirianna, 1932). It exists on its own and is eternal as it is beyond space and time. Thus, *puruṣa* is pure consciousness (Radhakrishnan, 1923). There is no other way of explaining it than as the transcendental consciousness which defies the laws of nature, that is, is beyond the three *guṇas* of *prakṛti*.

The Sāṃkhya thinkers accept that *puruṣa* cannot be understood except in metaphysical terms as an eternal and timeless reality. Thus, as pure consciousness, *puruṣa* is alone (*kevala*) without metaphysically presupposing the reality of the unmanifest *prakṛti* and the manifest world. It exists outside the world and can exist in principle even without a world. *Prakṛti* presupposes the existence of *puruṣa*, but *puruṣa* does not presuppose the existence of the *prakṛti*. Thus, Sāṃkhya dualism does not disallow the ontological priority of the *puruṣa* as this dualism is different from the conventional dualism of mind and matter defended by Descartes (Larson, 1979). The transcendental nature of the *puruṣa*, however, does not prohibit *puruṣa* from being caught in the web of the world because of its proximity to *prakṛti*. In fact, in the actual course of the evolution of the *prakṛti* as the manifest world, the *puruṣa* is entangled with the world.

The fall of *puruṣa* from its transcendental and pure existence into the worldly existence is a fact accepted by the Sāṃkhya thinkers. This fall, however, is a distortion in the nature of *puruṣa* as pure consciousness from which it ultimately has to escape. The world is presented to *puruṣa* with its manifold complexity for its enjoyment and ultimate escape only when *puruṣa* realizes its own true nature with the rise of *viveka* or true discriminatory knowledge (Bhattacharyya, 1956; Hirianna, 1932; Larson, 1979). Until the discriminatory knowledge or *viveka* arises, *puruṣa* remains ignorant

(*ajñāna*) about itself. This is a state of bondage of the individual *puruṣa* entangled in the world.

Puruṣa has been characterized as the spirit (Radhakrishnan, 1923) or the transcendental subject (Hiriyanna, 1932), or the self. This is true to the idea that *puruṣa* is pure consciousness. However, in that case, we have to accept that the *puruṣa* involved in the world is the empirical self or the embodied spirit as distinguished from the transcendental self. This is where *puruṣa* becomes the enjoyer (*bhoktā*) and one who seeks liberation from the world. The fate of *puruṣa* as the world-enjoyer and the active agent in the world is due to its entanglement with *prakṛti*. The world binds the *puruṣa* to its tantrums because of *puruṣa*'s own ignorance. Thus, there is the phenomenon of the individual *puruṣas* enjoying the world and undergoing suffering (*duḥkha*) in the world.

As the empirical self or subject, *puruṣa* becomes the knower (*jñāta*) and doer (*kartā*), which it is not. The attribute of being a knower and the doer is foisted on *puruṣa* because of ignorance and *aviveka* (non-discrimination). The empirical *puruṣa* identifies itself with *buddhi* and thus arises its own self-sense (*ahaṅkāra*). *Puruṣa* becomes the “I” which says “I know,” “I do,” etc. The empirical “I” symbolizes the complete involvement of *puruṣa* in the world process. The ego or the self-sense results in the embodiment of *puruṣa* with all associated organs for the purpose of the experience of the world (Hiriyanna, 1932).

3.4 The Cosmic Consciousness and the Individual and Embodied “I”

Puruṣa or consciousness, as the Sāṃkhya explains it, has both a cosmic presence and a psychological individual presence (Hiriyanna, 1932). This is proved by the fact that the Sāṃkhya account of consciousness is not psychological alone, as held by many thinkers (Larson, 1979). To say that the role of consciousness is confined only to individual psychological cases is to minimize the importance of the cosmic dimension of consciousness. *Puruṣa* has a cosmic role to play in that it triggers the evolution of *prakṛti* through its presence or being only. The being of consciousness, though transcendental, is cosmically important because, without it, *prakṛti* cannot evolve into the manifest world in which individual human beings as *puruṣas* come into being as the embodied “I” or self.

The Sāṃkhya system is cosmological in spirit because it has to explain nature with its complexity. Its evolutes, like *mahat* or *buddhi*, have a cosmic significance. So also *ahaṅkāra* or “I” has a cosmic importance. It is also true that *buddhi* and the self or “I” have an individual presence when considered with reference to their individuation in the empirical world. The individual “I” is an embodied self or *puruṣa* who has not only the *manas* or mind but also the sense-organs of knowledge (*buddhīndriya*) and action (*karmendriyas*). Thus the body becomes the new locus of the individual consciousness or *puruṣa*.

In the context of the world, it becomes significant to encounter the plurality of *puruṣas* (Bhattacharyya, 1956; Hiriyanna, 1932; Radhakrishnan, 1923). The empirical selves or the embodied egos are many because the individuality of each *puruṣa* in the world is reflected in *buddhi*. The *puruṣas* in themselves have no individuality, and to say that they are plural in number makes no sense. It is meaningless to say that pure consciousness is plural in number without any unique (*Viśeṣa*) feature of each so-called eternal consciousness. Ontologically, pure consciousness is without any feature. It is only the individuated *puruṣas* or selves which have unique features. Each individual *puruṣa* has a gross body as well as a subtle body. Because of the gross body, each *puruṣa* has experience of the world, which is consolidated through the mind and intellect or *buddhi* (Hiriyanna, 1932). The subtle body helps the *puruṣa* transmigration across births until freed from the world. All *puruṣas* in their individual life do not get freedom (*apavarga*) from the world simultaneously (Sharma, 1962).

The Sāṃkhya system has involved itself in the paradox of the plurality of *puruṣa* because of the ambiguity in the meaning of the concept of “*puruṣa*.” If *puruṣa* is plural, then all the *puruṣas* will be equally eternal, and all will influence *prakṛti* to evolve. In that case, all will be bound by the world simultaneously, and so all will be released from the world simultaneously. Then, in that case, the world can never dissolve because the world will continue to evolve eternally. However, this cannot be allowed in the Sāṃkhya system. This will also defeat the theory of liberation of the Sāṃkhya system.

3.5 Self, Agency, and Freedom

Now we can explore the Sāṃkhya idea of agency and freedom in view of the fact that the Sāṃkhya, like the Vedānta (Hiriyanna, 1932; Radhakrishnan, 1923), is very much concerned with the liberation of individual human beings. Though Sāṃkhya in its classical form (Larson, 1979) is overtly atheistic without being materialistic, it keeps a large space for the spiritual freedom of the individual selves or *puruṣas*. For this system, spiritual freedom is the highest value (*puruṣārtha*) which guides the teleological process of the evolution of the *prakṛti*. This is the final aim of *prakṛti* to liberate the *puruṣas* from their bondage to the world (Bhattacharyya, 1956; Hiriyanna, 1932; Radhakrishnan, 1923; Sharma, 1962).

However, the peculiarity of the Sāṃkhya idea of freedom is that the spirit as pure consciousness is neither bound nor free. Therefore, freedom is only for the *puruṣas* involved in the world and bound by *prakṛti* with its three *guṇas-sattva, rajas, and tamas*. The individual *puruṣas*, because of their bound nature in the world, are forced to suffer or have pain (*duḥkha*) (Bhattacharyya, 1956). This suffering can be eradicated only by *viveka* or discriminatory knowledge of the pure nature of *puruṣa* as transcendental consciousness. True knowledge consists in the separation of *puruṣa* from *prakṛti* and the realization of the fact that *puruṣa* in itself is beyond the world as pure consciousness.

Puruṣa, as pure consciousness, is not an agent because it does nothing. It has only being but no agency. The only agency possible is with regard to the individual egos or embodied selves. Only embodied selves say “I know” or “I do.,” etc.; that means they are agents who have experience of the world and who undertake actions in the world. The worldly individuals or *Jīvas* (Radhakrishnan, 1923) undertake actions of various kinds and thereby acquire merit (*dharma*) or demerit (*adharma*). This compels them to suffer and have pain. Thus agency is associated with pain and suffering. So the agential selves or the embodied *puruṣas* are bound to suffer in the world. Liberation from suffering, therefore, becomes the main aim of the *puruṣas* so far as they are in the world.

Puruṣa, as pure consciousness, does not suffer and needs no liberation from suffering. Therefore, the Sāṃkhya does not make the idea of liberation relevant for *puruṣa*. However, the moment we see *puruṣa* through the prism of the world, we find not only many *puruṣas* struggling for salvation but also for getting knowledge about one’s own nature. There is always a way of salvation built into the Sāṃkhya system, though it was made explicit later by Yoga, with which Sāṃkhya gets inevitably attached for practical reasons. At least the classical Sāṃkhya made room for *viveka* or discrimination to know one’s nature as pure consciousness. This is called freedom (*kaivalya*), which results from realizing the true nature of one’s transcendental self as *puruṣa*.

3.6 The False Identification of *Puruṣa* with the Embodied “I”

The greatest metaphysical error into which *puruṣa* falls is its identification with *buddhi* and *ahankāra* or the “I”-sense. The full-fledged “I” comes into being due to a false identification. *Puruṣa*, because of proximity with *prakṛti*, gets reflected in the *buddhi*, and thus there appears the embodied “I” which comes out of the *buddhi* reflecting *puruṣa*. The *ahankāra* is an immediate evolute from *buddhi*, leading to the emergence of the “I” embroiled in the network of the *buddhi*. The “I”-sense brings into its own being the intellect and the *manas* or mind. Thus the “I” becomes not only the pivot of the agential life but also there arises the search for salvation. The Sāṃkhya is concerned with the individual “I” (Larson, 1979) because that appears to be the pivot of the worldly life. However, we should not overlook that the “I” would not have been possible without *puruṣa* as a self-complete being. The individual “I” could not be a self-complete because it resulted from false identification. The individual *puruṣas* or the selves must ultimately be free from the false identification or the non-discrimination of one’s self from *prakṛti*.

If the Sāṃkhya had been “I”-centric or individual-centric, it would have lost its metaphysical importance because it would have ended with a psychological explanation of human nature. However, how can individual psychology be a substitute for a transcendental metaphysics of consciousness? The Sāṃkhya is concerned with

the metaphysical primacy of transcendental consciousness and not of the empirical psychological consciousness (Hiriyanna, 1932; Radhakrishnan, 1923). It is well known that the Sāṃkhya is concerned with the salvation of the individual *puruṣas*. But how can there be salvation if nothing is higher than the “I”-consciousness? How can the apparent “I” become the real *puruṣa* if they are identical? There is a gap between empirical *puruṣa* and the transcendental *puruṣa* (Hiriyanna, 1932; Radhakrishnan, 1923; Sharma, 1962). This metaphysical gap between the apparent “I” and the transcendental *puruṣa* is the crux of the Sāṃkhya metaphysical speculation.

If Sāṃkhya would have been *prakṛti*-centric and, therefore, a naturalist system that explains the cosmology of the universe, there would be a loss of the metaphysics of consciousness. In that case, consciousness would have been, if not a product of the *prakṛti*, at least a concomitant of the Sāṃkhya cosmology; consciousness would have been an individualized consciousness different from, though parallel to, the body. Pure consciousness would have been a mere metaphysical abstraction (Larson, 1979). However, how can the transcendental *puruṣa* be a mere abstraction? If the unmanifest *prakṛti* is real, then *puruṣa* as pure consciousness is equally real. In the absence of pure consciousness as a being, there would be no sense in saying that *prakṛti* cannot be manifest in the absence of pure consciousness. If the individual consciousness is the only reality, why would *prakṛti* evolve if the individual selves are already in the world process? *Prakṛti* gives rise to the individual *puruṣas* or selves and leads to their salvation because of the presence of pure consciousness, which leads to its evolution.

We can guess that the Sāṃkhya is concerned with the human situation no doubt (Larson, 1979), but it retains its cosmic and transcendental outlook intact for solving the human problem of suffering. No solution to the problem of suffering can be made available if there is no larger metaphysical scheme in which human beings are situated. The universe itself needs to be made intelligible in which human existence is posited. Man and the universe have the same internal nature of being dependent on a higher reality, *puruṣa* or pure consciousness.

3.7 Relation Between Consciousness and the Material World

The Sāṃkhya is concerned with the relation of *prakṛti* and *puruṣa* to explain how the two eternally real and opposed entities come together to make the manifest material world possible. This relation is explained with many analogies like the relation between iron and magnet, the blind and lame and so on (Hiriyanna, 1932; Radhakrishnan, 1923). All these examples do not solve the mysterious nature of the relation (Radhakrishnan, 1923: 200) because it is not intelligible how the conscious

puruṣa can come into contact with the unconscious *prakṛti*. The Sāṃkhya presupposes that such an association (*saṃyoga*) is real and that there is somehow a proximity (*Sāṃnidhya*) between the two. However, everything here remains in the realm of speculation.

Since *puruṣa* is eternally present, that is, since pure consciousness is timelessly real, it is *prakṛti* which is affected by the presence of *puruṣa*. *Prakṛti* is dependent on *puruṣa* for its evolution, whereas *puruṣa* remains the spectator and the witness of the vast panorama of the evolving *prakṛti*. *Puruṣa*, being eternally liberated, does not need *prakṛti* for its liberation. However, it is *prakṛti* which brings about the manifestation of the world, thus making *puruṣa* a partner in this universe. *Puruṣa*, being bound with the web of creation (*sarga*), becomes the enjoyer (*bhoktā*) of the creation. It is this human situation which makes the seeking of salvation a permanent possibility within the realm of the cosmic evolution of *prakṛti*.

The dependence relation mentioned above does not go from *puruṣa* to *prakṛti*. That is, consciousness does not depend on *prakṛti* and the manifest world, whereas the latter needs the guidance of *puruṣa* for its evolution. This entails the following:

1. The unconscious *prakṛti* needs the help of the conscious *puruṣa* to make itself intelligible.
2. The unconscious *prakṛti* gives rise to the manifest world, which contains *buddhi* or intellect because of the proximity of *puruṣa*.
3. The individual conscious beings or the embodied selves or *puruṣas*, which are part of the manifest world, derive their consciousness not from *prakṛti* but from the pure *puruṣa*.
4. The grossly material world, an evolute from *prakṛti* via *buddhi* and *ahankāra*, cannot be called completely material. The so-called material world is derivatively material as there is no genuine materiality in the Sāṃkhya system.
5. The space-time world contains the rudiments of consciousness because pure consciousness is transformed into individual consciousness because of proximity with *prakṛti*.

From the above, we can infer that in the Sāṃkhya, there is no genuine material world independent of consciousness. The world is a dependent reality that demands explanation only regarding consciousness and intelligence.

The mechanistic explanation of the universe (Larson, 1979) falls short of making the teleological view of the universe possible. If the material world is without any purpose, then it cannot serve the purpose of liberating the embodied *puruṣas*. Therefore, it cannot be the case that the Sāṃkhya can opt for a thoroughly mechanistic and purely material world. For the Sāṃkhya, the material world contains conscious beings or *puruṣas* constantly interacting with it. The world becomes the home of the *puruṣas* seeking salvation from the world itself. The world is instrumental in obtaining the salvation of the *puruṣas* (Hiriyanna, 1932; Larson, 1979). Therefore, it cannot claim absolute reality of its own.

The material world is subject to dissolution when the *puruṣas* are free, and therefore there is no further evolution unless the cycle begins again because of the proximity between *puruṣa* and *prakṛti*. In the ultimate analysis, *puruṣa*, and *prakṛti* remain

eternally real, the former as pure consciousness and the latter as the unmanifest *prakṛti*. At this stage, no evolution is possible. Now as to why evolution begins at the end of the dissolution of the present world, there is no explanation. It remains in the realm of speculation as to how the world comes into being and gets dissolved for the purpose of the salvation of the *puruṣas*.

3.8 The Sāṃkhya Metaphysics as *Puruṣa*-Centric

One cannot deny that the Sāṃkhya metaphysics gives primacy to *puruṣa* and makes the world a stage for the spiritual liberation of human beings (Larson, 1979). However, the fact that the world has no meaning except for the pursuit of salvation (*kaivalyārtham*) suggests that the world has a transcendental goal which may be fulfilled in the world, but then the world ceases to exist when freedom of the *puruṣas* is attained. The world annihilates itself when spiritual freedom is attained.

The question arises: Is the world not ultimately ephemeral or merely derivative? Is it not the case that what matters most is the *puruṣas* and their salvation? The answer is affirmative, implying that the Sāṃkhya inherits the Upanishadic bias towards the primacy of *puruṣa* and the resulting idealist and spiritualist bias of the Vedānta. Though the dualism of *puruṣa* and *prakṛti* is not denied, this dualism itself is tilted towards the primacy of the *puruṣa* (Hiriyanna, 1932; Radhakrishnan, 1923; Sharma, 1962). The Sāṃkhya was developed within an Upanishadic environment (Larson, 1979), so it is unsurprising if it retains a longing for spiritualism and idealism despite its avowed adherence to dualism. There is no naturalism and conventional dualism in the Sāṃkhya (Larson, 1979), so finding in it seeds of idealism cannot be ruled out.

The Sāṃkhya is not overtly inclined towards absolutizing the *prakṛti* as the materialists are, nor does it make the *puruṣa* the absolute reality as Vedānta does (Sankara, 1972). The reason for this is as follows:

1. If *puruṣa* would have been absolute like the Vedantic Brahman, then it would have been one more tattva or principle in the system in addition to the existing twenty-five.
2. There would have been an ontological distinction between Brahman and *Jīva*, the former as the absolute reality and the latter as the relative or apparent reality. Nevertheless, Sāṃkhya does not make this distinction to avoid being closely identified with the Vedānta.
3. All indications are that *puruṣas* are plural in number, and all are involved in the world process.

For the above reasons, the Sāṃkhya do not opt for absolutism and remain closer to the dualism of two realities, *puruṣa*, and *prakṛti*.

However, the Sāṃkhya dualism seems all right as a rationalist system of thought based on the naturalist and non-naturalist categories like *puruṣa*, *prakṛti*, *buddhi*, etc. The twenty-five *tattvas* include naturalist and non-naturalist categories to explain

the universe and human life. However, a little deep reflection shows that many unexplained features of the Sāṃkhya system need exploration. One of the unexplained features is the existence or being of *puruṣa*, that is, regarding whether its existence is outside the world or inside the world. If it is outside the world, it has to be a transcendental reality that is not very explicit in the Sāṃkhya. If it is inside the world, it will remain immanent, something like being in the world and not being of it (Larson, 1979). However, the latter position is very ambiguous as it suggests that the *puruṣas* are immanent beings involved in the world and are trying to escape it. If they are completely submerged in the world, they cannot get out of it; but if they are pure beings inside, it is unclear why they should try to escape it. Besides, when the *puruṣas* get liberated, they remain pure consciousness without having to do anything with the world. But if they are already in the world, how can they remain pure conscious beings?

3.9 The Sāṃkhya Transcendentalism

The argument for the transcendental consciousness or *puruṣa* follows from the Sāṃkhya thinkers' search for the ground (*adhiṣṭhāna*) of the universe and the final cause of the manifested world. This tends to suggest that *puruṣa* cannot be within the world, though the *puruṣas* as embodied beings are. We have to accept the reality of *puruṣa* as pure consciousness. *Puruṣa* in the singular does not mean anything except as the pure being of consciousness independent of *prakṛti* and the manifest world. We cannot make pure consciousness a part of the world because that will deny the reality of the *puruṣa* as the independent reality, which is a witness and spectator. It cannot be a witness or a spectator without being independent of what is witnessed and seen. The seer cannot be part of the seen.

The argument that the *puruṣas* are always many and are in the world as embodied egos prove that the world has already evolved out of *prakṛti* and that *puruṣa* has been reflected in the *buddhi*, so it appears as many *puruṣas*. In that case, the many *puruṣas* are not ultimately real as they are mere appearances presented in the *buddhi* and *ahaṅkāra*. The many *puruṣas* when they are free are no more many, and ultimately they do not remain as apparently real. In the infinite and pure consciousness which the individual *puruṣas* become when they are free, there is no distinction among the *puruṣas*. Therefore it is not easy to prove that the *puruṣas* are ultimately plural and remain eternally the same individual beings.

The more we explore the nature of consciousness in the Sāṃkhya system, the more we arrive at the conclusion that consciousness, unless implicated in the body and mind, remains beyond all modifications. However, once it is associated with the *buddhi*, mind and body, it becomes identified with the latter. The embodied *puruṣa* becomes the ego or the "I" which undergoes suffering. This ego must be freed from ignorance and false identification with the world. Pure consciousness remains the absolute reality from which the embodied *puruṣas* are alienated. They must return to their original pure being when they escape the *buddhi*, mind and body. The Sāṃkhya

thus is committed to the spiritual freedom of the *puruṣas* by their self-denial and attainment of the knowledge of their true nature.

The road to freedom lies in self-denial and removing the ego-sense. This will happen when the *puruṣas* rise to the transcendental knowledge of the ultimate reality, which is their true self. The true self is the pure consciousness which is real even if there is no world.

3.10 Conclusion

In this paper, I have tried to understand the Sāṃkhya metaphysics of consciousness from a transcendental point of view. The main argument is that unless we posit the transcendental reality of *puruṣa*, we cannot even explain the many *puruṣas* involved in the world process. To explain the spiritual freedom of the individual *puruṣas* or selves, we need to posit a transcendental reality called pure consciousness. This may appear parallel to the Vedantic metaphysics of the Ātman or Brahman, but that does not deny that the Sāṃkhya develops a theory of pure consciousness within a transcendental framework.

There is no effort in this essay to impose Advaitic ideas on the Sāṃkhya metaphysics of consciousness. The aim has been to see the Sāṃkhya transcendental metaphysics of consciousness in the right perspective.

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Chapter 4

Is Puruṣa a Contentless Consciousness in Classical Sāṅkhya?



C. D. Sebastian

Abstract In this paper, I try to show from the textual analysis of the *Sāṅkhyakārikā* that *puruṣa* is pure consciousness without any trace of content. Classical Sāṅkhya's conception of *puruṣa* is definitely not the *res cogitans*, the thinking substance, as the thinking happens in *manas* in Sāṅkhya, and *manas* is an evolute of *prakṛti*. *Puruṣa* is not a substance, as it does not seem to meet the criteria of substance. It does not have qualities, and it cannot act or move. It is pure witness. In fact, it is absolutely unchangeable. I make an attempt to map the nature of *puruṣa* as delineated in the *Sāṅkhyakārikā* and submit that the *puruṣa* is a contentless consciousness and it is entirely different from the *ātman* concept of Vedānta.

Keywords Consciousness · Mind · *Puruṣa* · Sāṅkhya · *Sāṅkhyakārikā*

The present study is strictly based on classical Sāṅkhya. By classical Sāṅkhya it is meant the formulation of Sāṅkhya system that one finds in the *Sāṅkhyakārikā* (hereafter *SK*) of Iśvarakṛṣṇa (Iśvarakṛṣṇa, 1995) which was written in the first centuries AD (c. 350 AD). The present study does not rely at all on the commentarial traditions like those of the commentaries of Gauḍapāda and Vācaspati-miśra, as they are, as the study of the present author goes, far in their interpretations from the original *SK*. Further, it is not about the Proto-Sāṅkhya that one finds in the *Bhagavadgītā* and the *Mokṣadharma* part of the *Mahābhārata*. At the outset itself, let me also state that it has nothing to do with the Sāṅkhya-Yoga-Vedānta combination of Viṣṇūanabhiṣu as found in his *Sāṅkhyapravacana-bhāṣya* and *Sāṅkhyasāra*—which has been in vogue since the sixteenth century AD.

At the outset, it is befitting here to have a word about the original Sāṅkhya, since this paper is about the notion of *puruṣa* in the classical Sāṅkhya.¹ In all probability,

¹ One can find a detailed study on classical Sāṅkhya in the work of G. J. Larson (Larson, 1969).

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the original Sāṅkhya was such a robust naturalistic system that it interpreted *reality* in terms of two categories, namely, “nature” (*prakṛti*) with its evolutionary process, and the multiplicity of the “life principle” (*puruṣa*), without giving any credence to a creator God or supreme being. I must also state that the philosophy of the Sāṅkhya system, particularly its ontology, has more to do with the philosophical paradigms that were found in the ancient Prākṛta² (Prākṛit language)—Jaina categories of thought in terms of *jīva* (conscious soul) and *ajīva* (matter).

If one vigilantly examines the Sāṅkhya texts and their commentarial traditions with their textual hermeneutics, one can decipher that there are two Sāṅkhya positions. Jain thinker of the fourteenth century AD, Guṇaratna in his commentary titled *Tarka-rahasya-dīpikā* on the *Ṣaḍ-darśana Samuccaya*³ of Haribhadra Sūri mentions two schools of Sāṅkhya, the original (*maulikya*) and the later (*uttara*).⁴ The classical Sāṅkhya is not the original Sāṅkhya. The Sāṅkhya that has been presented to us in modern times was labelled “Epic Sāṅkhya” by Richard Garbe and Hermann Jacobi because this is nothing but a hybrid combination of the classical Sāṅkhya and Vedānta (Belvalker and Ranade, 1927: 417). The classical Sāṅkhya of the *Sāṅkhyakārikā* and Īśvarakṛṣṇa is the systematized form of the Sāṅkhya philosophy, and it is not the original Sāṅkhya system, which gets grafted to the orthodox Vedic systems when other “classical” systems of *ṣaḍ-darśanas* got allied into one.⁵

In the first part of the paper, the notion of *puruṣa* is examined on the basis of the text *SK*. In the second part, the difference between mind and consciousness, *manas*, and *puruṣa* is shown. In the third part of the paper, based on the discussions in parts one

² Prākṛta was a prominent language together with Pāli, though at the earliest period it originated as vernacular dialects and *lingua-francas*, and it had a long history of more than one and a half millennia (c.600 BC–1000 AD). The main Prākṛta language included Ardhamāgadhī, Māgadhī, Mahārāṣṭrī, Śaurasenī, Gauḍī, Lāṭī, Paiśācī, Avantī, Gāndhārī, and Apabhramśa. It is a verity that some of the earliest developments in philosophical categories of thought of the Indian sub-continent took place in Prākṛta language. The terms and terminologies of *SK* have an overwhelming influence of categories and ideas that were expressed in Prākṛta language. For a detailed study on the contribution of Prākṛta languages to Indian culture see: (Katre, 1945) and (Jain, 2004).

³ Jain thinker Haribhadrasūri’s *Ṣaḍ-darśana Samuccaya* is the earliest known compendium of different systems of Indian philosophy composed in the sixth century AD. In this compendium he has selected Cārvāka, Buddhism, Jainism, Sāṅkyha, Nyāya and Vaiśeṣika (taken together, but dealt with separately in the text), and Mīmāṃsā of Jaimini. He treats all systems in his compendium as *āstika* (including Buddhism and Jainism) and considers only Cārvāka as *nāstika*. He has not included Vedānta in his compendium, implying that Vedānta had not evolved as a system of thought in the sixth century AD. In the text one does not find any criticism or adverse comments on any system of thought, but the text gives fundamentals of each system. His treatment of Sāṅkhya, Jaina and Nyāya is in greater details while others are dealt with briefly. Buddhism is placed first, then Nyāya, Sāṅkhya and Jaina. This is a small text in 87 verses. There is a commentary to Haribhadrasūri’s *Ṣaḍ-darśana Samuccaya*, and it is *Tarka-rahasya-dīpikā* by the Jain thinker Guṇaratna in the fourteenth century which is very elaborate. The text is available to us: *Ṣaḍdarsana-Samuchchaya* by Haribhadra with Guṇaratna’s *Commentary Tarkarahasya-dīpikā*, Luigi Suali, (ed), Calcutta: The Asiatic Society, 1905. (Haribhadra, 1905 and Guṇaratna, 1905).

⁴ Commentary on verse 36, lines 15–16 on p. 99 in *Ṣaḍdarsana-Samuchchaya* by Haribhadra with Guṇaratna’s *Commentary Tarkarahasya-dīpikā* (Guṇaratna, 1905: 99).

⁵ See the footnote on page 417 in Belvalker and Ranade, (Belvalker and Ranade, 1927: 417).

and two, *puruṣa* is shown as a contentless consciousness. However, this contentless consciousness is not like that of the *ātman* notion of the Vedāntic traditions.

4.1 Consciousness in the Sāṅkhyakārikā: A Textual Examination

In this section, the notion of *puruṣa*, as presented in *SK* is examined. Let us survey the pertinent *kārikās* of *SK*. *SK* 3 states that *na prakṛtirna vikṛtiḥ puruṣaḥ*, that is, *puruṣa* is neither the evolvent (from which everything evolves) nor the evolute (that which is evolved). *SK* 3 presents the ontology of the Sāṅkhya system and it unequivocally states that the primal *prakṛti* is not evolved (*mūlaprakṛtiravikṛtiḥ*) and *puruṣa* is not at all *prakṛti*. They both belong to different ontological categories.

In *SK* 11, it is said that the *puruṣa* is just opposite to the primordial (*pradhānam*) and manifest (*vyaktam*) *prakṛti*, which is constituted of three *guṇas*, lacking awareness (*aviveki*), with objective nature, general (*sāmānyam*) non-intelligent (*acetanam*), having the capacity to produce and create (*prasavadharmi*). *Puruṣa*, as termed in *SK* 11 “*pumān*,” is, thus, not affected by three *gunas*, is full of awareness (*viveka*), and is non-objectifiable with the help of senses, which would imply that the consciousness can never be with content.⁶ But the *puruṣas* can apprehend the object of the *prakṛti*, full of consciousness (*cetanam*) and not productive and generative like the *prakṛti*. The text goes like this: *Triguṇam-aviveki viśayaḥ sāmānyam-acetanam prasavadharmi; vyaktam tathā pradhānam tad viparīṭastathā ca pumān* (*SK* 11).

SK 17–21 are pointedly about *puruṣa*. In *SK* 17 one finds the five proofs for the existence of *puruṣa*. It is interesting to note that *SK* 17 speaks of *puruṣa* as non-composite. The composites exist for another—*sanghātaparāthavāt*. Explaining this phrase that is found in *SK* 17 on the basis of the *Yuktidīpikā*, Ramesh K. Sharma in his erudite study states that the *Yuktidīpikā*’s “point, in other words, is that since body, being composite, is meant for another which is not of the same nature, this other must be the entity called self (or consciousness), which therefore ought to be held to exist” (Sharma, 2018: lxxxiv). According to the explanation of the *Yuktidīpikā*, *puruṣa* is non-composite, and it is “imperceptible, unlike the composites like (the embodied individual) Devadatta or chariot etc.” (Sharma, lxxxiv). Ramesh K. Sharma explains further in this regard that *puruṣa* is neither self-manifesting, as in Advaita Vedānta,

⁶ It is important to mention here that Vācaspatimiśra in his *Tattvakaumudī* comments: The manifest is constituted of three *guṇas*—pleasure, pain and delusion. Further he states, “by this statement the theories of all those (Tārkikas and others) who hold that pleasure, etc., are the qualities inhering in Spirit (soul) are refuted” (Vācaspatimiśra, 1995: 40). Satkari Mookerjee had given a gist of Nyāya theory of soul and cognition in this way: The soul develops consciousness when acted upon by sense-object contact. In turn, it comes to discharge the function of an agent when it develops cognitive and volitional activity, and it is looked upon as an enjoyer—as it experiences pleasure and pain (Mookerjee, 1935: 140). One can find more on this in Chap. 8 of the said book, titled ‘The Soul-Theory of Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika’ (Mookerjee, 1935: 140–153).

nor susceptible to mediate or introspective knowledge as, e.g., in Nyāya” (Sharma, 2018: lxxxv). *Puruṣa* in Sāṅkhya is a consciousness which is not conscious of itself (Sharma, 2002: 107–108).

SK 18 explains the multiplicity of *puruṣa*. In *SK* 18, the proof for many *puruṣas* shown (*puruṣa-bahutvam siddham*). Hence, the notion of *puruṣa* in *SK* is not similar to the one conscious reality called *ātman* or *brahman* in the Vedāntic traditions.⁷ Some scholars interpret the *puruṣa* of *SK* as akin to the one *ātman* of the Advaita paradigm. For instance, almost a century ago, in his study on Sāṅkhya, A. K. Majumdar had argued for two kinds of *puruṣas*, namely, one Supreme *Puruṣa* and multitudes of individual *puruṣas* which appear to be so. His interpretation of Sāṅkhya was like an interpolation of Vedāntic stance.⁸ It is noteworthy to recall the juxtaposing positions of *SK* and Vedānta: there are many *puruṣas* in Sāṅkhya, whereas there is only one consciousness, that is *ātman*, in Vedānta. But the one reality that is not many in *SK* is *prakṛti* and not consciousness.

SK 19 shows that *puruṣa* is a pure witness, and exists apart from *prakṛti*. The term used is *kaivalyam*, which has reference to “*kevala*” meaning “isolation,” or that which is not associated or combined with another. So, *puruṣa* is “solitary,”⁹ and separate, and exists in isolation.¹⁰ The same nuance could be seen in the explanation of *kaivalya* in the *Yogasūtra* as commented by Daniel Raveh in terms of an existential position of “aloneness” and “freedom.” (Raveh, 2012: 5, 10 -11, 15–17). *SK* 19 goes like this: *Tasmācca viparyāsāt siddham sākṣitvamasya puruṣasya*;

⁷ *Ekameva hi paramārtha-satyam brahma* - Commentary of Śaṅkara on the *Taittirīya Upaniṣad* 2: 6 (Śaṅkara, 1998).

⁸ A. K. Majumdar wrote: “..., though there is One Perfect Absolute *Puruṣa*, His differentiations, modes, or moments, are unlimited in number, and, consequently, He appears to be multitudinous, by reason of His connexions with those multitudinous investments and embodiments. The One *Puruṣa* appears to many *Puruṣas*” (Majumdar, 1925: 69).

⁹ As seen translated in *Sāṅkhya Kārikā of Īśvarakṛṣṇa with the Tattva Kaumudī of Śrī Vācaspati Miśra*, Swami Virupakṣhaananda (tr) (Vācaspati Miśra, 1995: 61).

¹⁰ There are varied opinions about the meaning and implication of the term “*kaivalya*” in Sāṅkhya system. The most common meaning that is understood by scholars in India today is something like ‘*mokṣa*’ or liberation as understood in other Vedāntic schools. But the term in *SK* is unrelated to this *mokṣa* conception that looms large in the discussion among the interpreters of Sāṅkhya system today. The term *kaivalya* in *SK* has much to do with the “*kevala*” conception in Jainism which has the connotation to perfection, fullness, completion and rightness. The nuances of *mokṣa* in the term *kaivalya* got incorporated into Sāṅkhya system after the works of Vijñānabhikṣu who combined Sāṅkhya, Yoga and Vedānta in his texts (fifteenth–sixteenth centuries AD), namely, *Sāṅkhya-sāra*, *Sāṅkhya-sūtra-bhāṣya*, and *Sāṅkhya-pravacana-bhāṣya*. Relying on the interpretation of Vijñānabhikṣu, a learned scholar of Indian philosophy A. K. Majumdar had written a century ago this: “Here the word *Kaivalya* seems to raise some difficulties. With some commentators the word means isolation, while with others, Vācaspati, for instance, it means liberation from three kinds of pain. I agree with the latter commentators, because their interpretation is consistent with the fact that separation or isolation between *Puruṣa* and *Prakṛiti* is out of question. And that this is the true meaning is further confirmed if we consider what *puruṣārtha*, or ultimate object of an individual *Puruṣa* is. The *Sāṅkhya Pravachana Sūtram* says: ‘Now permanent prevention of the threefold pain is the supreme purpose of Life.’ The same thing is said in the *Yoga Sūtram* too” (Majumdar, 1926: 263). The present author does not subscribe to the view expressed by A. K. Majumdar as Sāṅkhyan conception is not akin to that of Vedāntic.

Kaivalyam mādhyasthyam dr̥ṣṭatvamakartṛbhāvaśca. The starting words of *SK* 19, namely *tasmācca* (*tasmāt ca*) and *viparyāsāt* (meaning “in contrast to that”) refer to the three *guṇas* mentioned in *SK* 18, implying that the *puruṣa* is different from the functions of the three constituents of *prakṛti* (*guṇas*). It is established that *puruṣa* is pure witness (*asya-puruṣasya sākṣitvam siddham*), exists in isolation or solitarily (*kaivalyam*), indifferent, impartial, or neutral (*mādhyasthyam*), only a seer or mere spectator (*draṣṭṛtvam*), and is a non-agent or not in the state of agency (*akartṛbhāvaḥ*). It must be stated here that in the *kārikā*, *mādhyasthyam* does not mean “mediation” (as the term has also the meaning of mediation), but here it means indifferent or neutral. Thus, *SK* 19 is very important to understand the real nature of the *puruṣa*.

SK 20 is to be read together with *SK* 19 as we find further explanation of *SK* 19 in *SK* 20. *SK* 20 makes it clear that *puruṣa* is not the agent, but due to the association of the evolutes as well as the *guṇas* of *prakṛti*, the *puruṣa* appears as if it is the agent (*karteva bhavati*),¹¹ and the *puruṣa* is absolutely passive (not active), neutral, disinterested or indifferent (*udāsīnaḥ*).¹² Thus, *puruṣa* is not the agent that acts. In Sāṅkhya texts it is explained in many ways that *puruṣa* is only a beholder. It does not act, feel, think or will. But it seems to do them all. It seems to be glad, sorry, or fear. We get a comparison of *puruṣa* in this manner in the *Sāṅkhya Aphorisms of Kapila* II: 35. It goes like this: *Kusumavacca maṇiḥ*, meaning like a gem over which hangs a red flower of Hibiscus. The colour of the flower is reflected on/from the gem so that the gem appears to be red (Ballantyne, 2003: 123).

SK 21 should be read in conjunction with *SK* 20. If in *SK* 20 the status of *puruṣa* is shown as indifferent and neutral (*udāsīna*), in *SK* 21 it shows some sort of interaction and cooperation between the neutral *puruṣa* and *prakṛti*. *SK* 21 brings home the Sāṅkhyan paradigm of the operation of the two ontological realities, namely, *puruṣa* and *prakṛti*, that exist and function in the world. *Puruṣa* should not be seen as something entirely outside, like an alien, when it comes to the ontology of two realities in the Sāṅkhya system. Though they are unconnected, the existence per se is only of both these two realities. There is a reason or purpose for the interaction between *puruṣa* and *prakṛti*, namely, for the isolation of the *puruṣa* or remaining detached (*puruṣa*) from the *prakṛti* (*purusasya kaivalyārtham*).¹³ *SK* 21 would show

¹¹ *SK* 20: *Tasmāt-tat-samyogād-acetanam cetanāvadiva lingam; Guṇa-kartṛtve'pi tathā karteva bhavatyudāsīnaḥ*.

¹² The term used in *SK* 20 about *puruṣa*'s status is *udāsīna* to denote that *puruṣa* is not an active agent at all. The term *ud* + *āsīna* (*ās* means to 'sit') simply means, to sit apart or to be indifferent and neutral. The nuance of this term becomes clearer when one takes cognizance of the Pāli and Prākṛti meaning of the term (in Prākṛt: *udāsīṇa*) that was prevalent in the philosophical circles in India when the *SK* was composed. The term *udāsīna* has the meaning of having no emotion, lacking interest, one who is sitting or staying away, neither friendly nor hostile, having no desire or aversion, etc. All these nuances of the term that one finds in Indian philosophical language of the early centuries of current era could be applied to *puruṣa* as we find the term *udāsīna* in *SK* 20. It simply means that *puruṣa* is not the agent at all of anything that happens in *prakṛti*.

¹³ See the explanation of the term *kaivalya* under *SK* 19 above and also the footnote 10.

the analogy of the coming together of the lame and the blind to explain the “contact” (*samyoga*)¹⁴ between of *puruṣa* and *prakṛti*.¹⁵

In *SK* 36 there is the mention of the twelve instruments (*karaṇa*), of which ten are external organs and the two are internal organs (*manas* and *ahamkāra*) presenting everything to *buddhi* (*buddhau prayacchati*)¹⁶ for the sake of *puruṣa* (*puruṣasyārtham*). It is important to note that the twelve *karaṇas* are the modifications of the three *guṇas*¹⁷ (or they function due to the influences of the *guṇas*), and not because of the *puruṣa*.¹⁸ *SK* 39 would state that it is *buddhi* that accomplishes the experience of all objects for the sake of *puruṣa* (*buddhiḥ sarvam prati-sādhayati*

¹⁴ The term *samyoga* here in *SK* 21 needs to be interpreted in the *Sāṅkhyan* paradigm, and not in other meanings of the term *samyoga* in other linguistic and philosophical traditions. *Samyoga* has the meaning of “conjunction” in Vaiśeṣika philosophy, as according to Vaiśeṣika system, *samyoga* is one of the seventeen *guṇas*. This meaning shall not be given to *samyoga* in *Sāṅkhya*. Many Indian interpreters take this meaning and interpret *SK* 21 which is not in tune with the *Sāṅkhya* view. The term *samyoga* has a meaning of “combination” of two or more substances in *Āyurveda* (like the combination of honey, milk, etc.). The *Sāṅkhyan* meaning of *samyoga* does not mean ‘combination’ either. The meaning of *samyoga* in *Sāṅkhya* should be taken as “contact” and this is the contact between *puruṣa* and *prakṛti*.

¹⁵ *Puruṣasya darśanārtham kaivalyārtham tathā pradhānasya; Pangvādhavadubhayorapi samyogastatkṛtaḥ sargaḥ* (*SK* 21).

¹⁶ According to *SK*, there are total thirteen *karaṇas* including *buddhi*. It is said in *SK* 32: *karṇam trayodaśavidham*. Among them, three are internal—*buddhi*, *ahamkāra* and *manas* (they are the three *antaḥ-karaṇas*, as it is said in *SK* 33: *antaḥ-karṇam trividham*) and ten are external (as it is said in *SK* 33: *daśadhā bāhyam*, that is, the ten *bāhya-karṇas*)—five *jñānendriyas* (in *SK* 34 it is called *buddhīndriyāṇi*) and five *karmendriyas*. It is interesting to note the simile used in *SK* 35 to explain the functions of the thirteen *karṇas* as the three door keepers (three *antaḥ-karṇas*) and the doors (the ten *bāhya-karṇas*). It goes like this: *Tasmāt trividham karṇam dvāri dvārāṇi śeṣāṇi* (*SK* 37b).

¹⁷ Vācaspatimiśra in his commentary explains it: The external organs, the Mind (*manas*) and the I-Principle (*ahamkāra*) are the various modifications of the *guṇas*. Though they are mutually contradictory by their very nature, yet, they are led in unison for the purpose of the *puruṣa* in the forms of bringing experiences of enjoyment and emancipation. It is like the wick, oil and fire, though opposed to each other, they combine together in the form of lamp to show forms, colours, etc., This meaning should be taken to the expression ‘*ete guṇaviśeṣāḥ*’ in the *SK* 36 (see Vācaspatimiśra, 1995: 84).

¹⁸ *Ete pradīpakalpāḥ parasparavilakṣaṇā guṇaviśeṣāḥ* (*SK* 36).

*puruṣasya upabhogam*¹⁹). It is again *buddhi* alone (*sa eva ca punaḥ*) that distinguishes the subtle difference between *prakṛti* and *puruṣa*.²⁰ And this discriminating wisdom (of *buddhi*) is not a part of *puruṣa*, but it is part of *prakṛti* itself.²¹ SK 42 states that even the subtle body, thanks to the union of the power of *prakṛti*, takes different roles for the purpose of *puruṣa*.²² SK 56 would clearly state that the evolution takes place as brought about (by the modification of) *prakṛti* (*prakṛti kṛtaḥ*) for the liberation of each *puruṣa* (*prati-puruṣa-vimokṣārtham*).²³ In SK 58 again it is clearly said that the *prakṛti* engages in activity (*avyaktam pravartate*) for the liberation of *puruṣa* (*puruṣasya-vimokṣārtham*).²⁴ SK 60 states that *puruṣa* is devoid of any *guṇa* (*agunasya*), whereas *prakṛti* is endowed with *guṇas* (*guṇavati*). In SK 61, there is a mention of *puruṣa*, and here too *prakṛti* is mentioned as separate from *puruṣa*.

To conclude this textual analysis, let me put it in this way: according to SK, *puruṣa* exists in complete independence of the material realm, so the dualism is between consciousness and matter—*puruṣa* and *prakṛti*. Hence, the mind, the three *guṇas*, feelings, emotions, etc., belong to the world of matter, while the consciousness *per se* belongs to the realm of pure awareness (*cetanaḥ puruṣaḥ*) as seen in SK 55. *Prakṛti* with its all evolutes, like mind, etc., in reality, is not conscious (*acetanam*), as shown in SK 11 and 20, though it seems to be conscious (*acetanam cetanavat*—SK 20). Thus, as Paul Schweizer shows in his recent study, “the mind and the consciousness are ontologically distinct. Movement and form are characteristics of matter, and they are also characteristics of thought, which is a manifestation of matter, while consciousness is held to be intrinsically formless and unchanging” (Schweizer, 2019: 237). *Puruṣa*, thus, according to SK, is contentless *sans* any form and change. And

¹⁹ The term “*upabhogam*” needs to be explained here. It is generally taken for the meaning of “experience” or “enjoyment.” It has even a meaning of “cohabitation” in Sanskrit. But in Jainism and Prākṛta *upabhoga* has a different meaning. In *Tattvārthasūtra* 7: 21, it has the meaning of “consumable” (Umāsvāmī, 2011: 101). In Jainism *upabhoga* is used with *antarāya* (obstructing karmas) which is one of the eight types of *prakṛti* related bondages (*prakṛti-bandha*). In *Tattvārthasūtra*, particularly in Chap. 8: 13, *bhoga* and *upabhoga* are used (Umāsvāmī, 2011: 120). Objects that are getting over and are unusable after their use or enjoyment once is called ‘*bhoga*’ (like, oil, money, etc.), and objects that can be used again and again are called *upabhoga* (like clothing, house, etc.). As mentioned earlier, in Jainism *upabhoga* has something to do with the bondage called *prakṛti-bandha*. And in SK 39, the word *upabhoga* is used with *puruṣa* that gets the experience facilitated by *buddhi*, which is part of *prakṛti* which makes the *puruṣa* into an imagined bondage.

²⁰ *Sarvam pratyupabhogam yasmātpuruṣasya sādhayati buddhiḥ*;

Saiva ca viśiṇaṣṭi punaḥ pradhāna-puruṣāntaram sūkṣmam (SK 39).

²¹ Rodney J. Parrott says: “Wisdom is not a state of consciousness; it is not a function of *Puruṣa*. Wisdom is a function of inconscient *Prakṛti* in the form of *buddhi*. *Puruṣa* is the locus of true identity as consciousness, *buddhi* is the locus of knowing. *Buddhi* in the state of wisdom, discerns that *Puruṣa* and *Prakṛti* are in fact different” (Parrott, 1985: 245).

²² *Puruṣārthahetukamidaṁ nimittanaimittikaprasaṅgena*;

Prakṛter vibhūta yogaṇṇatavadvyavasthite lingam (SK 42).

²³ *Ity eṣaḥ prakṛtikṛto mahadādiviśeṣabhūtaparyantaḥ*;

Pratipuruṣavimokṣārtham svartha iva parārtha ārambhah (SK 56).

²⁴ *Puruṣasya vimokṣārtham pravartate tadavadvyaktam* (SK 58).

“it is important to remember that verses 21–61 of the *Kārikā* are written from the viewpoint of the falsely identified *Puruṣa*” (Parrott, 1985: 251).

4.2 Mind and Consciousness

In *SK* *mind* and *consciousness* belong to different ontological categories. Mind (*manas*) belongs to the realm of *prakṛti* which is intrinsically unconscious. The mind (*manas*) is an evoluate of *prakṛti* which is incapable of producing consciousness. In contrast to the perceived view in philosophy of mind today, the mind in *SK* is an evoluate of *prakṛti*. Paul Schweizer writes in his recent study:

Subjective awareness is seen as a distinct ontological category, and in principle, it cannot be derived from the stuff of which objects are made. So, in sharp contrast to the current view in philosophy of mind, Sāṃkhya philosophy holds that the Hard Problem of consciousness cannot, in principle, be solved within a physicalist framework. And in sharp contrast with Cartesian dualism, the mind and the cognitive activities it sustains, are held to be intrinsically unconscious, since *manas*, *buddhi* and *ahamkāra* are all manifestations of *prakṛti*.” (Schweizer, 2019: 236).

As I have stated above, the mind seems to be conscious, but it is unconscious (*acetanam cetanavat*—*SK* 20) in *SK*. The mind is a part of the materiality, and it is metaphysically grounded in *prakṛti*. The body and mind are, thus, in *prakṛti* or evolutes of *prakṛti*. Hence, the body and mind belong to the same metaphysical substance, *prakṛti* (Schweizer, 1993: 847–851).

According to *SK* 11, 12, and 13, the three *guṇas* determine the dynamics of *prakṛti*. Let me explain a little about the term *guṇa* in *SK*. Though the term *guṇa* has been interpreted in several ways in different systems of Indian philosophy, the conception of *guṇa* is something peculiar to the Sāṃkhya system.²⁵ The three *guṇas* are *not* to be translated as “attributes” or “qualities,” but as the three basic types of constituent of physical substance embedded in *prakṛti*. The “*guṇas* are not the adjectival qualities of *prakṛti*, but are they very ‘constituents’ of *prakṛti*” (Rao, 1963: 62). As M. Hiriyanna states “It is not only *Prakṛti* that consists of these *guṇas*; everything that emerges from it is also similarly constituted” and the *guṇas* are “cosmic constituents” (Hiriyanna, 2005: 108–109). That is why *guṇas* are not treated as a principle or *tattva* among the twenty-five *tattvas*. The interactions of the *guṇas* determine the dynamics of *prakṛti*. In *SK* 13 one finds that the three *guṇas* (namely *sattva*, *rajas*, and *tamas*) correspond roughly with “light in weight and buoyancy” (*sattvam laghu prakāśśakam*), “desires, exciting, and mobile” (*iṣṭam upaśtambhakam calam ca rajah*), and “heavy and enveloping” (*guru varaṇakameva tamaḥ*). Paul Schweizer in his recent study would put it this way:

All physical phenomena are believed to consist of unstable mixtures of these three types of constituents, and the instability of these mixtures is responsible for the evolution and

²⁵ For a detailed study on the notion of *guṇa* in Sāṃkhya system see K. B. Ramakrishna Rao (Rao, 1963: 61–71).

transformations of the material world. Thus the conceptual processes sustained by the mind are governed by the mechanical and unconscious interplay of the *guṇas*, and to this extent, mental phenomena are viewed in purely 'physicalistic' or mechanical terms. The unfolding of thought forms is an integral part of the evolution of *prakṛti*, and mental processes are simply the result of appropriate transformations of unconscious material substance (Schweizer, 2019: 236).

Consciousness, in contrast, is held to belong to a different ontological category altogether. Consciousness is placed in the realm of *puruṣa*. *Puruṣa* is described as pure and undifferentiated awareness, and it is held to be immutable and inactive, to be formless and without parts or limiting characteristics. This undifferentiated awareness is not the awareness that we speak of in other Indian philosophical traditions, as it requires "the differentiation of 'awareness' (*citta-vṛtti* or *antaḥkaraṇa-vṛtti*) from 'consciousness' (*puruṣa*)" and "requiring a radically different kind of dualism, namely, a dualism between a closed causal system of reductive materialism (encompassing 'awareness' or 'private' life of the mind), on the one hand, and a nonintentional and contentless 'consciousness' on the other. It thereby rejects idealism" (Larson, 1983: 220–221), (though Larson rejects the "idealist" way of looking at the Sāṅkhya system, a recent study has shown that it is nothing but an idealism²⁶). *Puruṣa* in *SK* is held to exist in complete independence of the material realm of *prakṛti*. Mind (*manas*) belongs to the world of matter, *prakṛti*, and consciousness belongs to the realm of pure awareness. What *SK* asserts is that mind and consciousness are ontologically distinct, they are not the same. Mind an emergent of *prakṛti*, the matter. Consciousness (*puruṣa*), on the other hand, is held to be distinct from *prakṛti* and it is intrinsically contentless, which we will take up in the next part.

4.3 *Puruṣa* as Contentless Consciousness

In this third part of the paper, *puruṣa* as contentless consciousness is considered. From the analysis we have made in parts one (textual analysis) and two (where the difference between *manas* and *puruṣa* was discussed), we come to the conclusion that according to *SK*, consciousness is contentless. *Puruṣa* in *SK* is not a consciousness *of* or *about* something. It is not directed towards anything. It has no intentionality.

²⁶ An interesting recent study in this regard is by Biju Antony. In this study, the author argues that in the light of textual evidences as well as phenomenological interpretation, Sāṅkhya metaphysics can be viewed as a form of idealism. The author begins by proposing that the established realistic interpretation is based on an assumption that *prakṛti* and its evolutes are material and cosmic. In fact, *prakṛti* and its evolutes are mental categories, and the ontological dualism of *puruṣa* and *prakṛti* enunciated in the Sāṅkhya system is nothing but a form of idealism. The *prakṛti* and its evolutes are the principles/ categories of cognition or experience. The conception that evolution is a process in *prakṛti* that takes place in the presence of *puruṣa* can also be conceived after the manner of form idealism. In fact, even the conception of *puruṣa* being simple and pure consciousness, together with its notion of liberation as aloneness of *puruṣa* and its separation from *prakṛti* and its activities (*kaivalya*), tends to advocate a form of idealism (Antony, 2016: 151–164).

In this sense, one would disagree with Ramesh Kumar Sharma as he had argued that “the reality of *prakṛti* (primal material matrix) is the object (*viṣaya*) of *puruṣa* (self or consciousness)” (Sharma, 2004: 425). Instead, *puruṣa* is “the name of bare awareness, or perhaps better of an instance of bare awareness, a pure consciousness free from intentionality (in the sense of being ‘about’ something, specifically, about *prakṛti*)” (Collins, 2019: 7). *Puruṣa* has nothing of its own and does not have the quality of being an “I” (*nāsmi na me nāham*) as we see *SK* 64. Paul Schweizer shows in his recent study how *puruṣa* does not have content when he discusses the role of *buddhi* and *manas*. “So *buddhi* receives cognitive structures from *manas*, and conscious ‘light’ from *puruṣa*, and in this manner, specific mental structures are capable of being illuminated by an external source, and thereby these structures can appear conscious. But consciousness itself is entirely independent of the particular thought structures it happens to illuminate” (Schweizer, 2019: 237).

Puruṣa in *SK* is not the *res cogitans*, a thinking thing, as thinking takes place in *manas* which is nothing but an evolute of *prakṛti*. G. J. Larson and R. S. Bhattacharya have elaborated on a contentless consciousness in Sāṅkhya (Larson & Bhattacharya, 2006: 73–83). Further, G. J. Larson’s studied view on the *puruṣa*, as it is seen in *SK* 19, is the “contentless consciousness” which is only a purely passive presence (*sākṣitva*), and different and isolated (*kaivalya*) from the *prakṛti* and its process of tripartite constituents (*guṇa*) and their transactions with its passive presence (*mādhyaस्थ्य*), the basis for the sort of subjectivity (*draṣṭṛtva*) and devoid of any activity (*akartṛbhāva*).²⁷ Larson explains the *puruṣa* in this way: “It is outside the realm of causality, outside space and time, completely inactive, utterly simple, unrelated apart from its sheer presence, uninvolved in emergence or transformation, without parts, completely independent, transcendent yet always immanent because of its presence” (Larson, 2006: 81). As we mentioned above in the first part while making a textual analysis of *SK* 19 that *puruṣa* is not an agent and incapable of any activity (*akartṛbhāva*). It is “potentially present in the awareness of all intellects as *not* being that awareness,” and “even the discrimination (*viveka*) of its very presence is delegated to the intellect” (Larson, 2006: 81), or *buddhi*.

Puruṣa in *SK* is a contentless consciousness.²⁸ This is echoed in K. C. Bhattacharya’s view when he says that *puruṣa* is “pure consciousness, not embodied consciousness nor consciousness of a content having the form of the object” (Bhattacharya, 2008: 192). *Puruṣa* is only pure witness. *SK* 19 is very pertinent to understand the nature of contentless *puruṣa*. In *SK* 19, as we have explained in the first part above while analysing the text, it is established that *puruṣa* is pure witness (*asya-puruṣasya sākṣitvam siddham*), exists in isolation or solitarily (*kaivalyam*), indifferent, impartial or neutral (*mādhyaस्थ्य*), only a seer or mere spectator (*draṣṭṛtva*), and is a non-agent or not in the state of agency (*akartṛbhāvaḥ*). In

²⁷ *Tamācca viparyāsāt siddham sākṣitvamasya puruṣasya;*

Kaivalyam mādhyaस्थ्यam drṣṭatvamakartṛbhāvaśca. - *SK* 19.

²⁸ For an explication of the contentless consciousness, see also the exposition of *SK* 11 above in the first part of the paper.

SK 19, the term *mādhyasthyam* does not mean “mediation,” but it means “indifferent” or “neutral.” C. C. Everett explained it in this way: “The *Puruṣa* is the pure consciousness abstracted from all content. We are, for instance, conscious of walking; but the consciousness does not walk, So, to these thinkers, while we are conscious of reasoning, the consciousness does not reason. We are conscious of suffering, but consciousness does not suffer. The consciousness is only the beholder (*SK* 19, 20)” (Everett, 1899:313). *Puruṣa* is contentless sentience which is existing without any modification. M. Hiriyanna explained it in this way: “*Puruṣa* is mere sentience. It is changeless, eternal and omnipresent. It is also entirely passive, all activity being restricted to *prakṛti*” (Hiriyanna, 1994: 279).

It must also be mentioned that the *puruṣa*, though it is contentless, is not akin to the conception of “self” (*ātman*) delineated in Vedāntic thought.²⁹ One is afraid whether K. C. Bhattacharya’s interpretation of *puruṣa* in his “The Self or *Puruṣa*” (Bhattacharya, 2008: 190–197) goes in the manner of Advaitin’s “self.” It seems to me that K. C. Bhattacharya depends on the interpretation of Vijñānabhikṣu who combined Sāṅkhya, Yoga and Vedānta philosophies in his interpretation of Sāṅkhya system³⁰ as we see in his *Sāṅkhya-pravacan-bhāṣya* (Vijñānabhikṣu, 1856) and *Sāṅkhya-sāra* (Vijñānabhikṣu, 1862). K. C. Bhattacharya writes in an Advaitic tone that “... the dual function of the mind is illusorily referred to the self. The self appears to take the reflection (*pratibimba*) of *buddhi-vṛtti* which reflects the object and to be itself reflected in *buddhi-bhāva* which projects the objects. ... Vijñānabhikṣu who presents this double *pratibimba* theory...” (Bhattacharya, 2008: 190). Again, Bhattacharya sees the “self” of Advaita in the *puruṣa* of the Sāṅkhya. He writes: “Apparently to Sāṅkhya, the being of the *mukta* self or absolute consciousness is then unmanifest or unconscious. Whether it is individual or not can never be asserted. The conflict between Vedānta and Sāṅkhya on this point may, therefore, yet disappear” (Bhattacharya, 2008: 197). The *SK* does not adhere to the spiritual path of the Vedāntins. For, “the Sāṅkhyas do not think their way to spiritual perfection” (Parrott, 1985: 252). *SK* gives primacy to *prakṛti* as the major part of the text is all about *prakṛti*. *Prakṛti* and its evolutes are celebrated in *SK*. If there is a spiritual discipline in *SK*, that is the spiritual discipline of observing and understanding *prakṛti*. Rodney J.

²⁹ For an explication of non-Vedāntic stance on the nature of *puruṣa* see also the exposition of *SK* 18 above in the first part of the paper.

³⁰ Vijñānabhikṣu could be considered a Sāṅkhya interpreter in the third phase of Sāṅkhya development where Sāṅkhya gets an orthodox Vedic incorporation. “The third and last period in the development of Sāṅkhya thought begins approximately at 1300 A. D., and its duration extends over about three centuries” (Hulin, 1978: 151). For a detailed exposition of the development Sāṅkhya on the basis of literature, see Michel Hulin’s work (Hulin, 1978). Though Sāṅkhya has “non-Vedic origins” (Natarajan, 2001: 1398), “consistent efforts were made in the history of Indian philosophy to bring the system of thought under the fold of orthodoxy even though evidence points to its non-Vedic origin” (Natarajan, 2001: 1398). It must be mentioned here that the Sāṅkhya system was the *pradhāna malla*, main wrestling opponent, for Śankara as seen in his *Tarkabhāṣya*. However, with Vijñānabhikṣu, one finds a combination of Sāṅkhya, Yoga and Vedānta philosophies which had a tremendous influence on Neo-Vedānta movement in later times. But I would opine that the Sāṅkhya interpretation of Vijñānabhikṣu does not go in line with either original Sāṅkhya or classical Sāṅkhya.

Parrott, it seems to me, rightly observes when he says: “In verses 22 through 61 the Sāṃkhya poets discuss the manifest world in a way which speaks directly to the seeker who is practising the spiritual discipline of world observation” (Parrott, 1985: 249).

Thus, in conclusion, it can be said that the *puruṣa* in *SK* is a contentless consciousness. The conception of *puruṣa* in *SK* is not at all like the conception of *ātman* in Vedāntic thought. *Puruṣa* is not composed of *guṇas*, and it is different in different bodies, as there are many *puruṣas*, whereas *prakṛti* is one. *Puruṣa* is non-productive, and neither a cause nor an effect (*SK* 3). *Puruṣa* in *SK* is not a consciousness *of* or *about* something. It is not directed towards anything. It has no intentionality. It has only a purely passive presence (*sākṣitva*), and it is different and isolated (*kaivalya*) from the *prakṛti* and its process of tripartite constituents (*guṇa*) and their transactions with its passive presence (*mādhyaṣṭhya*), the basis for the sort of subjectivity (*draṣṭṛtva*) and devoid of any activity (*akartṛbhāva*). *Tamācca viparyāsāt siddham sākṣitvamasya puruṣasya; Kaivalyam mādhyaṣṭhyam dṛṣṭatvamakartṛbhāvaśca* (*SK* 19).

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Chapter 5

Puruṣa as Witness Consciousness in Sāṃkhya Philosophy: Some Observations



Shyamasree Bhattacharyya

Abstract This article tries to explore the nature of puruṣa (witness consciousness) in Sāṃkhya philosophy. Puruṣa is admitted for the sake of liberation but as both bondage and liberation are attributed to prakṛti, they are secondarily attributed to Puruṣa. The prakṛti or primordial materiality can generate a set of discrete subdivisions in the presence of pure consciousness where pure consciousness is a mere spectator. The primordial matter evolves only in the presence of puruṣa. Sāṃkhya offers three reasons for admitting the self, firstly, the complex unity of mind and the body acts as a simple, and has a purpose, acting for consciousness which is reflected in it. The simple real being distinct from other bodies, is the enjoyer of the object but distinct from the object and this is the essence of the character of sākṣin striving for salvation and is known as pure consciousness. The individual or the self, comprises of the body, manas and self where the self as an independent entity attains salvation. The self being a mere spectator of the mental states retains its autonomy and is called sākṣin puruṣa or witness consciousness but loses its status as the knower and the doer, as it lapses into prakṛti due to viveka. In Sāṃkhya, both the mind and the body belong to the material realm prakṛti, and hence the Cartesian dualism does not arise, but a different sort, i.e., subject-object dualism is present. The consciousness after attaining salvation relapses into prakṛti and becomes contentless, and this contentless consciousness is never admitted in phenomenology, since for Husserl, consciousness is always intentional. Hence consciousness being contentless will signify the absence of consciousness. Now, for Sartre, consciousness remains empty, nothingness, all materiality lies outside in the world, ego is not within consciousness but in the world. Hence the Sāṃkhya notion of consciousness comes closer to that of Sartre's notion.

Keywords Puruṣa · Sākṣin · Prakṛti · Kaivalya · Bhāva · Vṛtti · Transcendental apperception · Intentional

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Philosophical thinking unlike science and mathematics, has its roots in both culture and history. In almost every philosophical tradition, it is the identity of the empirical and the transcendental that gives rise to the problem as to how an “I,” a concrete, situated human being through reflection strives to become something else. This “I” is the self or the subject which is understood in various ways in different philosophical systems. It has been a matter of controversy regarding the existence of the soul apart from the body in both Western and our traditions. Apart from the Cārvāka, all other schools of thought in our tradition admit that selfhood is a separate entity over and above the body, mind, and senses and this has a direct impact on their ethical and religious views. Udayanacāryya in his *Ātmātattvaviveka*, noted that there is a theoretic agreement regarding the liberation or *apavarga* or cessation of pain and this cannot be achieved merely by the death of the body (Dravid, 1995: 3).

In the ancient Brahmanical and heterodox periods, speculation was rife regarding the notion of selfhood, starting from the cosmic *ātmā* of the ancient Upaniṣads to kṣhetrajña, *bhūtātmā*, *mahān-ātmā*, the Jaina notion of *jīva* and the age-old notion of no-self in Buddhism (Larson & Bhattacharyya, 1987: 74). How selfhood and the phenomenal experiential world were related was a pressing issue even in the earliest phases of speculation.

There are various theories of self in our different systems of thought, where the term *buddhi* is taken to be synonymous with *upalabdhi* and *jñāna* in the Nyāya system while *buddhi* is taken to be the modification of the first evolute of *prakṛti* or *mahat* in the Sāṃkhya and Vedānta view, while *jñāna* or consciousness is the nature of the self.

In this article, I have tried to analyse the notion of self in the light of Sāṃkhya philosophy and have discussed how this notion has been interpreted by modern philosophers belonging to both the Eastern and Western schools of thought. Let me first explain the Sāṃkhya view of *puruṣa*.

Sāṃkhya philosophy was not only *Vedic* but also atheistic, as it admitted a self, for every individual. There was already the theory of the *ātmā* in the Vedantic thought but apart from this school, it was the emergence of a different line of thinking which viewed the world as evolving out of the three elements, water, fire and earth. In Śvetāśvatara Upaniṣad V7, 8, and 12, *prakṛti* is described as constitutive of three colours referring to *sattva*, *rajas*, and *tamas* respectively. The schools of both Buddhism and Jainism had their sources in this ancient materialistic doctrine. Later, the theory of evolution of the sensory world evolved out of this undifferentiated nature. The three *guṇas* were in a state of equilibrium or *samyāvasthā* which was disturbed while encountering *puruṣa* or self. With this disturbance, the evolution of *prakṛti* began with progressive heterogeneity in the unequal distribution of the three components. Here *prakṛti* gets attached to the self, due to its inability to distinguish itself from the psycho-physical complex which itself is nature’s evolute or creation.

The Hindu science is said to be influenced by the Sāṃkhya view of *prakṛti* where the distinction is made between the three *guṇas*. Sāṃkhya philosophy admits twenty-four principles that constitute the one *prakṛti*, or “existent” that is primordial materiality constituted of the three *guṇas*. However, Sāṃkhya asserts a second kind of “existent” different from the primordial materiality that remains passive in

all activities, yet a *necessary* component for the manifest functioning of the materiality. This second entity is termed *puruṣa* in the Sāṃkhya system, where the term “*puruṣa*” though usually meaning “man” or “person” and is usually taken to be synonymous came to acquire a peculiar meaning in Sāṃkhya philosophy (Larson & Bhattacharyya, 1987: 74) Both the primordial materiality and *puruṣa* are separate from one another, ungenerated, outside of ordinary space and time, stable, simple, unsupported, non-emergent (or non-dissolvable), without parts and independent as has been enumerated in Sāṃkhya *Kārikā* X.

Hetumat anityam a-vyapi, sakriyam, anekam, āśritam, liṅgam.

Sāvayavam, parātantram, vyaktam, viparītam, a-vyaktam.

The above *kārikā* states the similarity and differences between the manifested (*vyakta*) and the unmanifested (*avyakta*), and the proper understanding will be conducive to *vivekajñāna* (discriminatory wisdom). The manifested is that which is produced or comes into effect. It is non-eternal (*anitya*), non-pervasive (*a-vyapi*), active (*sakriya*), has many forms (*aneka*), dependent (*āśrita*), and is a *liṅga* or mark for inference, made up of parts (*sāvayava*) and subordinate (*parātantra*) to its cause. The unmanifest first cause is just the opposite of all these qualities attributed to its products or effects. It is only the effect which is pervaded by the cause and not vice versa. For instance, the *buddhi* and the other products being non-pervasive can never pervade *pradhāna*. *Buddhi* and other evolutes are forever active, and mobile as they give up the bodies they had occupied previously and enter other bodies. They are manifold as they differ from person to person (as many evolutes as there are persons). *Buddhi* being manifold, *puruṣa* is also many, as Sāṃkhya admits the plurality of *puruṣa*.

The metaphysical issue is regarding the admission of *puruṣa* in the Sāṃkhya system. Is it a redundant concept as it is neither the knower nor the doer but an inactive witness consciousness? The question which plagues us is whether it is a matter of belief or a matter of logic which compels us to believe in the self. Of course, it must be admitted that it is our firm conviction of the experience of I-ness or the subjectivity underlying all our experiences. It is inconceivable to have a thought without a thinker, an experience without an experiencer, an object without a subject. Awareness presupposes and involves consciousness, and it is much wider than the field of cognition. Consciousness involves the processes of knowing, willing and feeling. At the same time, it is noted that sceptics such as Buddhists and Hume rejected the very notion of the self and tried to prove that the logical basis of our belief is unfounded. Yet, we cannot totally dispense with the idea of a self, and we fall back upon the psychological evidence for justifying our beliefs in the self. In the context of the Sāṃkhya system, how do we justify this notion? In *kārikā* XVII, Īśvarakṛṣṇa gives reasons for its justification.

Samghāt-parārthāvat, trigunādiviparyayāt, adhisthānāt and bhokṛbhāvat.

The relation between the experiencer and the experienced cannot be accounted for without postulating the self or “I.” Sāṃkhya argues that *Kaivalyārtham pravṛttesca*,

(desire for liberation) which means that the *puruṣa* must be admitted for the attainment of liberation or there must be the *pravṛtti* or wish for the attainment of *kaivalya*. But bondage and liberation are both attributed to *prakṛti* and are secondarily attributed to *puruṣa*. There seem to be two distinct strands of thinking which are sometimes parallel and sometimes converging in the Sāṃkhya thesis. They are the impersonalism of the primordial nature or *prakṛti* and the personalism which is consistent with our understanding and the philosophy of *Ātmavāda* so widespread in the Upanishads. We are then left with the materialism of Sāṃkhya, where *prakṛti* is said to be unconscious or *acetana* while *puruṣa* is the conscious one. But one should not understand the meaning of *acetana* as material, though all the adjectives like *avyakta*, *sūkṣma*, *pradhāna*, and *bibhū* are attributed to it, *prakṛti* is not material in the sense understood by the materialists. It is also *guṇakarta* where *guṇakartrtva* is attributed to her, that is it is also an agent and *puruṣa* is not the agent. The term *cetana* has been used in the sense of reflective consciousness capable of turning upon and reflecting on one's activities. *Puruṣa* is self-reflective in a way *prakṛti* is not, *prakṛti* and her evolute *mahat* or *buddhi* have certain attributes such as *dharma*, *adharma*, *jñāna*, *ajñāna*, *vairāgya*, *avairāgya*, *aiśvarya*, and *anaiśvarya*, while *abhimāna* and *ahaṅkāra* (ego-sense) *adhyavasaya* are attributed only to *buddhi* which is an evolute of *pradhāna* or *mulāprakṛti* (Chakraborty, 1988: 68–69). How does one explain the relation between *puruṣa* and *prakṛti*?

The relation between the *puruṣa* and *prakṛti* is that of a seer and a doer. In *kārikā* XIX, Īśvaraḥ discusses the relation between the *prakṛti* and *puruṣa* where the relation between the two is of co-presence. (Jha, 1896: 37).

*Tasmāt, ca, viparyāsāt siddham, sāksīvamasya puruṣasya
Kaivalyam, madhyasthyam, draṣṭṛtvam a- karṭṛi bhāvah, ca.*

Pure consciousness is inherently inactive, while *prakṛti* or primordial materiality is inherently generative in the sense that it can generate a set of discrete or manifest subdivisions when activated by the catalytic presence of pure consciousness where pure consciousness being a mute spectator i.e., a mere witness is uninvolved in any actions of the worldly affairs. The twenty-three subdivisions are described as being generated, temporal, spatial, unstable, composite, supported, and emergent (dissolvable), made of parts, and contingent as stated in *kārikā* X. *Prakṛti* is subjected to eternal transformation which is never ending where both enjoyment and liberation are affected by the process of nature, while its process becomes endless.

But this primordial matter remains incomplete only if we suppose that this is a mechanical analysis to which no purpose or teleology has been added. Why does the primordial matter or *prakṛti* evolve in this way at all? There must be a spiritual constituent of the self which transcends these material constituents and whose purpose the spiritual self is trying to fulfil.

The individual is ordinarily understood as consisting of a body, a mind and a self. The self is regarded as the most important essence of the individual, where it is a combination of the body and the *manas* or mind, but being an independent entity, its goal is to attain liberation. When the self dissociates itself from the body and the *manas* it attains salvation. According to the Sāṃkhya theory, the self reveals

or witnesses the mental states and occasionally the objects of mental states when the conducive situation arises. The self merely witnesses the mental states and their activities, while remaining aloof without being involved and in this way retains its autonomy and it is said to be self-conscious. This free self while keeping its autonomy preserved but at the same time witnessing the function of the mind is known as *sākṣin puruṣa* or witness consciousness. This witness consciousness is capable of referring to a particular mind or ego without transcending itself which makes it particular. The *sākṣin* cannot refer to another mind or witness the mental states of others, hence *sākṣin* or *puruṣa* in the Sāṃkhya theory are many in number. (Bhattacharyya, 1964: 136–137).

The *puruṣa* then appears as a conditioning factor for the manifestation of *Prakṛti*. It is obvious that Sāṃkhya should admit as many selves as possible in addition to the many bodies. They argue that if there was only oneself for all individual *jīvas*, then with the birth or death of one, all individuals would be born or die, again if anyone was blind or lame others would also suffer the same fate. Either they would have to admit many individuals from many selves or from the *sākṣinhood* of the selves to the plurality of individuals. In the Indian tradition, death does not signal the end of the self's journey, men are born again and again and die several deaths till the connection between the body and the self is totally severed which is calculated to prevent further rebirth. Their theory holds that even after the death of the body, the individual retains its subtle body where grosser elements attach to form grosser bodies.

The self in this view has certain characteristics, it is distinct from the object, never known by itself as there is no intuition of it. It is pure consciousness, neither embodied nor having any content in the form of the object. It is not really inferred but known in reflection. Even in other Indian traditions, such as Nyāya, consciousness is known by posterior cognition known as *anuvyavasaya*, never directly intuited. Inference helps in clarifying this reflection which is a transcendental one in Sāṃkhya. In *kārikā* XVII, various grounds are provided for proving the existence of *puruṣa*.

Samghāta parārthātvaṭ and adhisthānāt—these are the three reasons provided in support of the self. The object is known as being other than the self through introspective consciousness (*triguṇādi viparyayāt*) of the self as feeling and experiencing (*bhokṛ-bhāvāt*) and striving for freedom (*kaivalyārtha- pravṛtteh*). *Samghāta* is the qualitative unity formed by the combination of the three *guṇas*, *sattva*, *raja*, and *tamas* which are fused together. What is referred to is the unity of the body, which is a purposive being, for the *bhoga* and *apavarga* of the self. This is the basis for claiming that the emergence of simple functional unity in a qualitative combination necessarily serves a certain purpose and is teleological. In addition to this, there is another ground for the inference of the self, viz- *adhisthānāt*. The self is regarded not only as the final cause but also the immanent cause of the body. The self serves as the explanatory function of the body which in a way solves the problem of its redundancy. The body functions as a simple unity and is undistinguished from a simple unity which appears to function for its own good. If a complex i.e., the unity of the mind and the body acts as a simple then the act must be purposeful, acting for an external simple unity i.e., consciousness which is reflected in it. This simple real is taken to be the self which is distinct from all other objects being at once the

bhoktā or enjoyer of the object as freeing itself from the object. This understanding of the object as distinct from the self, brings out the character of the subject (*sākṣin*) namely as an absolutely distinct (*kevala* alone or unrelated), as effectively detached (*madhyastha*) as knower (*dr̥ṣṭi*) and not an agent (*akartṛ*). The immediately known inferred self-reflected in the object is *draṣṭṛ*. In the final stage while striving for liberation it is known as knowledge or consciousness, and it will appear as a pure individual. Since there is no object for the self to be conscious of, this liberated self cannot be treated as a *sākṣin*. It lapses into *prakṛti* due to *viveka* where the self becomes contentless *jñāna* and not as the knower or *jñātṛ*, which cannot be inferred in its essential nature, being evident to the terminal reflection *viveka* (Bhattacharyya, 1956: 191–194).

There is an internal tension between the self being detached and the agent, the material body present in the Sāṃkhya system which was criticized and rejected by the Buddhists. But the Sāṃkhya philosophy has certain merits of its own as it tries to dispense with the mind–body dualism as the mental states and the properties are included within the material evolutes where the mental substrate *buddhi* is regarded as the subtle evolute of the unmanifest inert matter. The usual mind–body dualism has no place in Sāṃkhya theory, as they do not belong to two different categories. The Sāṃkhya dualism does not fit into the traditional dualism of the Cartesian variety. It is apparent why it does not belong to the classic one as Descartes in his *Meditations* remarks that one has a clear conception of oneself as an unextended thinking thing, which he terms as a soul, which is diametrically opposite to the extended thing as possessing a body. Again, in *Principles of Philosophy*, he states that the body is a corporeal substance which has length, breadth, and depth and thought constitutes the nature of the thinking substance. The mental and the corporeal belong to two different realms altogether and hence this dualism of the mind and body arises (Larson & Bhattacharyya, 1987: 74). But in Sāṃkhya philosophy, both the mental and the non-mental (the body) owe their source to the primordial *prakṛti* which is material in nature. Their style of philosophizing has resulted in the redundancy of the assumptions of mind–body dualism where the Cartesian dualism is easily avoided. Furthermore, this theory avoids epiphenomenalism (the theory that the mental is the effect of the physical but cannot be the cause of the physical) as the mental can neither be the cause nor the effect of the physical as it is the evolute of the physical matter i.e., *prakṛti* while causation is taken to be the manifestation of the unmanifest and hence the two horns of the dilemma, dualism and the identity theory do not arise.

Instead in Sāṃkhya, one finds a dualism of a different sort, the dualism between the subject and the object, where the existence of each reality is independent of the other. The nature of the object must be understood about the self where the self is by nature intelligible. The character of the object is always conceived along with its manifestation about the self, its nature is such that it is always involved with the self but at the same time distinct from the self (Bhattacharyya, 1956: 151).

For Bhattacharyya, the genius of Sāṃkhya philosophy lies in its emphasis on “reflection as spiritual function” and is more of a philosophy of spontaneous freedom. The interpretation of Sāṃkhya philosophy is a constructive rather than a historical problem. It is purely a spiritual quest for freedom based on its contradictory character

of the feeling of pain. Freedom for Sāṃkhya starts from life itself and is continuous with the life process as contrasted with the Vedānta Philosophy where freedom is a miraculous process and is not a part of the natural process (Larson & Bhattacharyya, 1987: 49).

According to K.C. Bhattacharyya, it is the dual function of the mind which is illusorily referred to as self. Let me explain this dual function of the mind. The mind anticipatively takes the form of the object to restrict itself to a *vr̥tti* reflecting the object. This reflecting or mirroring is also the projecting function of the mind. The mind is modified into *vr̥tti* similar to the object and simultaneously functioning in a noncausal manner as *bhāva*, without which the object cannot be manifested. The mind through its reflection makes the phenomenal object out of *prakṛti*, and the reflected object is constructed. The object is both projected by and reflected in *buddhi* as *bhāva* and *vr̥tti*. *Vr̥tti* of the *buddhi* appears as self-reflecting the object and *bhāva* as the self, projecting the object. This dual function of the mind is illusorily referred to as the self. The self appears to take the reflection or *pratibimba* of *buddhi vr̥tti* which reflects the object and gets itself to be reflected in *buddhi bhāva* which projects the object. This is how the mutual reflection of the self and *buddhi* is understood (Bhattacharyya, 1956: 190–191). This theory of *pratibimbavāda* is not present in Sāṃkhya *kārikā* but has been mentioned by Vācaspati Miśra in his *Tattvakaumudī*.

Bhattacharyya's contention is that the *vr̥tti* as the function in the mind causally reflects the external object and assumes the form of the external object and becomes a mode of that object, and is considered to be *bhāva* where the mind functions non-causally and manifests the object. Here non-causally suggests that the mind does not undergo any modification but only manifests the object. It is the mind's subjective function that is represented in *bhāva* and by which it becomes an "object of knowledge." It is at the *vr̥tti* level that the self gets presented as mere "me," its illusory reflection in the *buddhi bhāva* is subjective, and the self is presented as different from the mind in the mental modification or *vr̥tti* of the form "I am I" or as "I am me" and not as mere me (Sharma, 2004: 431).

Bhattacharyya states that the mind in its act of reflecting the self in *vr̥tti* does not take on the form of the self as the self is not an evolute of *prakṛti* and is not a phenomenal object. On the Sāṃkhya theory, there must be some similarity between the knowing *buddhi* and the phenomenal world for the *buddhi* to know the object in its true form and as both are evolutes of *prakṛti*, this becomes possible. The problem arises as Bhattacharyya rightly states that the liberated self or *mukta* self loses its individuality, as the Sāṃkhya philosophy admits that the being of consciousness can only be manifested to *buddhi*. In liberation or *kevalajñāna*, there is the lapse of the *buddhi* and consequently, there would be no manifestation of any self. Even if the self exists as a liberated individual, is existentially unconscious and not conscious of its individuality. Its individuality and its being conscious become manifest only through the association of *buddhi*. So, either the self must be a cosmic one or the individuality of the liberated self cannot be accounted for. (Sharma, 2004: 439).

Without the postulation of the puruṣa, as distinct from the phenomenal world, the world would be only an undifferentiated mass with a multitude of beings. The earlier Sāṃkhya or the proto- Sāṃkhya was closer to the teachings of the Upaniṣads, and

they admitted only one *puruṣa*, the cosmic one. But in Sāṃkhya *kārikā*, there is the mention of many *puruṣa*, where *puruṣa* is free. Had it been a part of the world it would have been determinate, incapable of attaining liberation (Larson & Bhattacharyya, 1987: 169–170.)

Now this notion of pure consciousness is understood and interpreted differently by philosophers of Western tradition. It is a debatable issue as to whether any notion in a system can be compared with another notion which might seem analogous to it from outside that system. But it is always rewarding as well as enriching to understand a notion through comparison which is an intellectual exercise. To understand man's being in the world, the postulation of autonomous bodily behaviour will not do. The world experience has a definite structure, a field or a framework, a background given to consciousness. Against this experiential background, the subject-object unity being qualitative appears as the basic component of our experience, where the primary perceptual act indicates a direction and is not merely an isolated "physicochemical happening" (Merleau-Ponty, 1967: 93). A perceptual act is more complex involving the binding together of the body to have a perspective or significance towards not only the perceived as such but also towards the very act of sensing. It is a conglomeration of the body with its activity that makes perception possible. To have that perspective or recognize the significance of what is given to the experience as a figure in the background, the Gestalt would admit a consciousness, a self or a mind (Sinari, 1988: 57). The body's function can best be understood with the help of the primordial drives by which it is conscious of itself as a psycho-physical unity, not depending on the causal explanation where the sensation or perception is simply a mechanical process. It is this creative consciousness, which is active, but further removed from bodily behaviour.

So far as the Sāṃkhya notion of *puruṣa* or witness consciousness is concerned, no concept in the Western tradition can adequately convey the hard-core significance of *puruṣa*. Be it Kant's notion of "intuitive understanding," Husserlian notion of the transcendental ego, or Sartre's notion of the transcendental ego, all have been recognized as near parallels to this notion of *puruṣa*. Let me first explain Kant's notion of intuitive understanding.

According to Kant, the phenomenal experience that is encountered is made possible by the principles which are things-in-themselves and whose knowledge is unreachable through our intellect. These things-in-themselves are like the transcendental schemata, the intuitive ground of our experiences conferring meaning on all that we know about the world. To have a perception of the unity of things or unity of the world is to admit a continuous and cohesive consciousness and to have a set of unity in the soul. In the *Critique of Pure Reason*, he writes,

Now there can take place in us no cognitions, and no connection and unity of cognitions among one another, without the unity of consciousness which precedes all data of intuitions and by reference to which all presentation of objects is alone possible. Now, this pure original and immutable consciousness I shall call transcendental apperception (Kant, 1996: 158–159)

For Kant, to have continuous and cohesive consciousness of any kind, on which the very perception of the unity of the things or the unity of the world itself is based, is to have a primordial set-up of unity in the soul. He further wrote,

There can be in us no items of knowledge, no connection or unity of one item of knowledge with another, without that unity of consciousness which precedes all data of institutions, and by relation to which representation of objects is alone possible. This pure unchangeable consciousness I shall name transcendental apperception (Kant, 1929: A117, 142).

Kant draws a distinction between empirical consciousness and a transcendental one where sensation is a component of empirical consciousness and a gradual transition from empirical to pure consciousness is possible. Consciousness for Kant is strictly transcendental, the sensory components make it seem empirical. Pure consciousness as belonging to an I as unified in one single self-consciousness is transcendental consciousness and is the ultimate condition of the possibility of knowledge of objects. In Sāṃkhya, we find that basic indiscrimination happens to be the primary predisposition of the intellect, which is an evolute of prakṛti, and it creates the phenomenal world out of ordinary space and time and causality. While Sāṃkhya makes a distinction between the phenomenal and the noumenal world, for them the noumenal world is knowable after attaining liberation. In the Kantian theory, the noumenal world is unknown and unknowable, i.e., is not an object of knowledge but an object of natural disposition.

According to Sāṃkhya philosophy, what is being manifested is unreal and projected on what is real before one has the true discriminative knowledge that the *prakṛti* is different from the *puruṣa* as consciousness is without content and has no intentionality, it seemingly takes on the content of the three *guṇas* and the mingling of the three *guṇas* appears to possess consciousness. This beginningless process towards discriminatory knowledge leads naturally to the experiences of bondage and liberation.

Now Robert W. Luyster writes: “In Husserl’s terms, consciousness is intrinsically intentional, there is no consciousness without an object of consciousness: if this be so, then the absence of objects may be taken to signify the absence of consciousness, and if consciousness is identical with self, this would suggest the loss of self as well” (Luyster, 1970: 59). According to Husserl’s theory, Sāṃkhya notion of consciousness cannot be admitted as it is contentless, lacking intentionality or directedness. Whether this notion of consciousness will be similar to Husserl’s notion of transcendental ego is to be examined. But again, ego in the Sāṃkhya view is material in nature, so they cannot be treated as similar.

Husserl’s phenomenology is based on the notion of transcendental subjectivity which is treated as a necessary methodological presupposition which is reached through the epoché. By bracketing the thesis of the existence of the natural world, the realm of transcendental consciousness is revealed in reflection. But our experience remains enmeshed in the surrounding world, along with the causal relations. The phenomenological critique of experience is towards the inner core of consciousness, which is to be presupposed as the ground for the possibility of the articulation “I,” though the phenomenological method is directed to reduce all meanings of being to

the region of “purified consciousness” egoless consciousness, the main concern of phenomenology remains self-experience—in other words, I am having a world for me and others.

The problem of relating transcendental subjectivity or consciousness to human reality or mundane subjectivity is a threat to Husserl’s phenomenology. He recognizes a basic paradox of human subjectivity, subjectivity for the world, constituting the latter, and subjectivity in the world, constituted in the latter (Smith, 2013: 246). These two irreconcilable aspects of subjectivity bring into focus the essentially human question in phenomenological reflection. Are transcendental subjects functioning as the precondition of the world, men (i.e., real psycho-physical beings)? The question becomes more perplexing when Husserl draws a distinction between us as *men* and *us* as finally grounding accomplishing subjects. The transcendental ego remains anonymous about the factual ego.

Now, for Sartre, consciousness as pure subjectivity is egoless. The ego appears on the subjective level as a synthetic complex as an object of reflection. There is no “I” on the reflective level. There is no “I” in the case of mental absorption. The ego is phenomenologically revealed to us as an object of reflection and not as the essential part of the structure of consciousness. The ego is an object apprehended but also an object constituted by reflective consciousness. “There is no ego *in* or *behind* consciousness, the ego is out there in the world, an object among objects” (Sartre, 1957: 21). Again for Sartre, consciousness remains empty, nothingness, all materiality, being-in-itself, the world falling outside of it. In a sense, the dualism of Samkhya comes close to Sartre’s notion of consciousness.

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Chapter 6

Can There Be Defunct Consciousness in Sāṃkhya?



Raghunath Ghosh

Abstract The present paper considers whether the Consciousness or Puruṣa in Sāṃkhya can be an enjoyer (*bhoktā*) who is taken as indifferent (*udāsīna*) and beyond transformation (*aparīṇāmī*) or not. If it is considered as indifferent and beyond transformation, it is defunct (*niṣkriya*) in nature. In reply, one justification is given by the Sāṃkhya that the Consciousness or Puruṣa possesses the property of being an enjoyer (*bhoktr̥tva*) not in reality (*tattvata*) but metaphorical (*aupacārika*). It seems that the Sāṃkhya contradicts its philosophical position as it proves that the bondage, release and migration have no relation with Puruṣa. In fact, Puruṣa is not at all in bondage—*na kaścīt Puruṣo badhyate*. Hence it cannot migrate and relate with this-worldly matter (*saṃsāra*)—*na kaścīt saṃsārāti*. Puruṣa is also beyond release or emancipation—*na kaścīt Puruṣaḥ muktaḥ* 18. So far as the actual state is concerned, bondage, worldly existence and release are not befitting with the nature of Puruṣa. It is commonly seen that a particular bound individual alone tries to get rid of it by seeking release. Hence, Puruṣa can neither be in a state of liberation nor be in a state of bondage. Hence, the property of being inactive or defunct is the real one of Puruṣa while the property of Puruṣa as active or functional is nothing but imposition.

Keywords Prakṛti · Puruṣa · Aupacārika · Udāsīna · Vivekāgraha · Sāmyāvasthā

Paper

“Yā devī sarvabhūteṣu cetanetyabhidhīyate”- Mārkaṇḍeya-purāṇa

The present paper considers whether the Consciousness or Puruṣa in Sāṃkhya can be an enjoyer (*bhoktā*) who is taken as indifferent (*udāsīna*) and beyond transformation (*aparīṇāmī*) or not. If it is considered as indifferent and beyond transformation, it is defunct (*niṣkriya*) in nature. In reply, one justification is given by the Sāṃkhya that the Consciousness or Puruṣa possesses the property of being an enjoyer (*bhoktr̥tva*) not in reality (*tattvata*) but metaphorical (*aupacārika*). It is said in *Sāṃkhyakārikā*—“*karteva bhavtyudāsīnaḥ*” i.e., Puruṣa is indifferent (*udāsīna*) in Sāṃkhya but

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the properties of Prakṛti like agency (*kartṛtva*), enjoyerhood (*bhokṛtva*), etc., are superimposed on the Consciousness (*Puruṣa*).¹

The Sāṃkhya believes in the automaticity of an object capable of being extended. It is not logically tenable that that matter does not possess the capacity of being extended and subtracted. The case of metaphor of magnet has been cited by Sāṃkhya while refuting Advaita view of world origination found in the *Sankarabhāṣya*. As a magnet is having an attractive power to draw the small iron-pieces adjacent to it, it is not possible to think of a conscious entity to justify the movement, attraction of iron-particles, etc.² An object of material nature has got object some internal force capable of being manifested at any situation. From the fact of its manifestation, it may be presumed that it is an object of material nature. Water which is material nature possesses its inner force manifested sometimes spontaneously or sometimes if it is thrown to the downwards from higher altitude. Such inner force remaining in water is known as hydel power. Just as in a seed oil remains in non-manifested form, inter force remains in water in a non-manifested manner. In the like manner, energy or power is found even in garbage or human foetus. If the power were found in all places without the association of a conscious being, it would have been found would have been found always in the matter. Hence, it is not an absurd idea that matters possess an internal force of being extended. Therefore, the presumption that Prakṛti, being matter, cannot have inner force cannot be taken for granted.³

It is said in Sāṃkhya that this world full of diversity has been created by Prakṛti for the sake of the enjoyment of *Puruṣa* (*Puruṣasya darśanārtham*).⁴ In this context, one can argue that Prakṛti cannot possess her own intention on account of the fact that she is an unconscious entity and “intention” or “desire” is to be taken as belonging to conscious entity. Now we may think over the justification of the activities originated in Prakṛti. Having inner force Prakṛti spontaneously generates different activities in spite of having no intention of her. On the event of equilibrium (*sāmyāvasthā*) in three *guṇas* of Prakṛti there is dissolution. If the status of equilibrium is somehow disturbed due to the preponderance of one *guṇa* over another, the creation starts.⁵ Change is a natural phenomenon and hence it undergoes certain spontaneous changes from time to time which have no criterion at all. If such change bears some criteria, it

¹ “Tasmāt tatsaṃhyogādacetanaṃ cetanādiva lingam/
Guṇa-kartṛtve ca tathā kartṛtva bhavatyudāsīnaḥ//”

Sāṃkhya-kārikā -20. *Sāṃkhya-tattva-kaumudī* with Adhyāpanā by Narayan Chandra Goswami, Sanskrit Pustak Bhandar, Kolkata, 1982. Henceforth, *Sāṃkhyakārikā* with *Sāṃkhya-tattva-kaumudī*.

² *Sankarabhāṣya* on Brahmasūtra (Tarkapāda), “Puruṣamavaditi cettathāpi”- 2.2.7. *Vedāntadarśanam*, Ed by Pandit Nalininath Roy, Basumatī Sahitya Mandir, Kolkata, 1341 (Bangabda), pp. 278–279. Henceforth, *Sankarabhāṣya* on Brahmasūtra

³ Raghunath Ghosh: “The Concept of Matter: A Physics-Philosophy Inter-phase” *Philosophical Papers*, Journal of the Department of Philosophy, University of North Bengal, Vol-XIII, March, 2017, pp. 36–44.

⁴ “Puruṣasya darśanārtham kaivalyārtham tathā pradhānasya//”
Sāṃkhyakārikā-21 with *Sāṃkhya-tattva-kaumudī*.

⁵ “Guṇa-pariṇāma-viśeṣānnānātvaṃ vāhyabhedasca.”
Ibid, *Kārikā* No. 27.

would not be considered as “natural,” which is not caused by external forces. These dynamic and natural activities are owned by Puruṣa due to its false identification with Prakṛti. From the standpoint of Prakṛti it is not possible for her to own or disown due to her material nature. On account of this, actions are self-originated (*svayambhū*) and hence she does not require any external force for their origination. Puruṣa owns them due to the false ascription (*aupacārikī*) arising out of non-ascertainment of knowledge of discrimination (*vivekāgraha*).⁶

The said automaticity existing in matter has been echoed in the theory of Quantum Mechanics of Physics. To them all things in this earth are previously determined leaving no room for their accidental occurrence. An atom has got electron and proton having small quantity of force and wave generated by Nature. It may be concluded in this context that the activities are generated by Nature without any assistance of Conscious Being. The physicists are still in search of divulging the mystery remaining in the world of atom which is unconscious or matter. They are also concentrating to the discovery of truth how inner force comes into being in atom to combine itself with another one, how the conjoining force found within an atom, how electron and proton have acquired movement around the atom, and also how much electron and proton receives movement in its orbit, etc. From this it is presumed that in the world of atom there is no involvement of Conscious Force. But the Naiyāyikas have raised some problems with the Physicists.⁷ To them an atom, being a matter or unconscious in nature, cannot be conjoined automatically with another one giving rise to a binary atom. Had a matter been associated with energy conjoining another atom, the phenomenon of conjoining would go on for an endless period of time leading to the impossibility of world's dissolution (*pralaya*). Hence, they believe in the existence of Conscious Being behind an atom's conjoining with another one. Such Conscious Being is no other than God (“*sargādikālīna-dvyaṇuka-prayojakaṃ karma prayatnājanyaṃ karmatvāt*”).⁸

If the above-mentioned characters of Prakṛti are admitted, it can be said that the three constituents of it are the roots of suffering (*tāpaka*). In other words, suffering is grounded in three *guṇa*-s of Prakṛti. The following query has been raised by Sankara. Suffering is a relative term and for this reason no suffering (*tāpaka*) remains in this world without the existence of a sufferer (*tāpya*). The three constituents (*guṇa*-s) of Prakṛti are taken to be the roots of suffering. If Puruṣa identifies himself with Prakṛti, though falsely, suffering obviously will come to him making him a sufferer. Puruṣa feeling unidentified with Prakṛti must have the knowledge of discrimination or distinction with Prakṛti (*vivekajñāna*) which is the mark of a liberated state. On Puruṣa's liberation, the causes of suffering, i.e., three *guṇa*-s of Prakṛti, remain

⁶ “Tena nivṛtta-prasavāmarthavaśāt saptarūpavinivṛttām/Prakṛtiṃ paśyati puruṣaḥ prekṣakavadavasthitaḥ svasthaḥ/” *Sāṃkhya-kārikā* No. 65 with *Sāṃkhya-tattva-kaumudī*.

⁷ Raghunath Ghosh: “The Concept of Matter: A Physics-Philosophy Inter-phase” *Philosophical Papers, Journal of the Department of Philosophy, University of North Bengal*, Vol-XIII, March, 2017, pp. 36–44.

⁸ *Dinakarī* on *Siddhāntamuktāvalī* on *Bhāṣāparichheda*, verse no.1, edited by Hari Ram Shukla, Chowkhamba, p. 29, 1951.

defunct amounting to their non-existence. But Prakṛti is already admitted as existent and hence the question of her non-existence does not arise at all, because three *guṇa*-s, the causes of suffering are very much remains in her nature. On account of this, the three *guṇa*-s cannot become free from their essence of being the cause of suffering.⁹

The three *guṇa*-s (constituents) spontaneously can reveal the mental and extra-mental or material objects of the external world. Real objects of the world have got the property of existence called *sattā* in them and hence, they are capable of being understood intellectually. If an object is known, it proves its existence. A non-existent object cannot come under the domain of our cognizance. The absurd ideas like sky-flower (*ākāśa-kusuma*), barren woman's son (*vandhyāputra*), etc., cannot be known due to their non-existence (*asattā*). Had there been no real objects in the external world, there would not have been any epistemic world (*pramāṇasāstra*). Hence, the priority of *sattā* or existence of an object is to be given initially. As an object is having a *sattva* element in it, it has got *sattā* or existence. The terms "*sattva*" or "*sattā*" bear the same meaning in so far as the grammatical rules are concerned.

If the internal characters of the known entity are carefully reconsidered, we may come across with some more features like size, dimension, form, etc. These features are mainly for having heaviness of an object. An object is heavy by nature due to which it can take the form baring its complete destruction for having some internal changes in the form. This heavy character in an object comes from the constituent called *tamas* of Pradhāna. It is the nature of an object to undergo some changes from one form to another, which go against its unmoved character. An object cannot remain unchanged even for a moment, which is possible for having another constituent called *rajas* (*rajoguṇa*).¹⁰

In this connection some affinities with the Buddhist notion of momentariness (*kṣaṇikavāda*) cannot be ignored. To them an object is unique particular (*svalakṣaṇa*) and free from mental construction (*kalpanā*). Such an entity is said to be existent if it has got causal efficacy (*arthakriyākāritva*). An object free from mental ascription and having unique character can serve our purpose-oriented action (*arthakriyākārī*), which is mark of existence.¹¹ An object, if exists, cannot remain unchanged even for a moment, as change is taken as the mark of existence. For, if serving some purpose-oriented action proves the existence of some object, it, being existent, will go on serving some purpose without remaining static for having the existence of *rajoguṇa* of Prakṛti. An object involves a change due to having the influence of *tamas* quality of Prakṛti which makes an object to assume proper form and to make it distinct from others.

In so far as the Sāṃkhya view is concerned, these *guṇa*-s—*sattva*, *rajas* and *tamas* are the bearer of qualities like lightness, kinetic, and massiveness respectively,¹²

⁹ *Sankarabhāṣya* on Brahmasūtra No. 02.02.09.

¹⁰ Sāṃkhya-kārikā No. 54 with Tattvakaumudī.

¹¹ Sāyanamādhava: *Sarva-darśana-saṃgraha*, *Bauddhadarśana*, with Hindi translation by Umasankar Sharma, Chowkhamba, Varanasi, 1964.

¹² Sāṃkhya-kārikā No. 13 with Tattvakaumudī.

which do not exist through the relation of inherence in a substance (*dravya-samaveta*). One quality is not capable of being intermingled with other qualities. The three *guṇas* like *sattva*, etc., are apparently attached with and actually detached from the Puruṣa.¹³ If the Vaiśeṣika view is taken for granted, the *guṇa*-s cannot remain in Puruṣa on account of the fact that the *guṇa*-s remain eternally and inseparably (*ayutasiddha*) in a substance through the relation of *samavāya* or inherence (*dravya-samaveta*). Puruṣa cannot be considered as a substance, as the *guṇas* like *sattva*, etc., are the substances themselves.¹⁴ If it is said that all the *guṇa*-s remain in themselves without being constituents of Prakṛti, it testifies another fact that Prakṛti is self-dependent entity having dynamic change, internal force, etc., without taking any assistance from any Conscious Principle. These three *guṇa*-s of Prakṛti permute and combine themselves and producing all objects in this world.

From the above-mentioned arguments it is proved that Prakṛti is a self-dependent entity from which the physical and mental world has been originated. It can never be denied that these changes are real having internal force. The world which we experience is always changing but not immovable in nature. This empirical world (*vyavahārika jagat*) is known from its changing and kinetic nature. In other words, the empirically known world cannot be free from movement and change. On the other hand, change in this world is evidenced from its inner pull and push factors arising out of the dynamic character of three *guṇa*-s. The identity and difference and similarity and dissimilarity which are clear and obvious are justified by three *guṇa*-s of Prakṛti. The identity of the objects is due to the identity of the ultimate Prakṛti and her *guṇa*-s or constituents (three-elements), but diversity is caused by the different types of situations of these constituents. In this phenomenal world cause and effect, substance, and qualities are in a sense identical if their source is taken into account. For, all are identical in the sense that they remain in the stuff on account of their belief in the theory of *satkārya* i.e., the pre-existence of effect in its material cause or *upādānakāraṇa*. As for example, the effect i.e., oil pre-exists in its material cause, i.e., oil-seed. The world is different of it is seen from the point of view of forms and names. The world is diversified in so far as it is known through different forms and names.

If Puruṣa is not endowed with the property of being an effect (*akārya*) and being a cause (*akāraṇa*), there is no necessity of admitting this. According to the Sāṃkhya, the presence of Puruṣa is required by Prakṛti for the sake of evolution of this world. The presence of Puruṣa disturbs the equilibrium of three *guṇa*-s, which helps in starting creation or evolution. If the existence of Puruṣa is not admitted. The equilibrium of three *guṇa*-s would not be disturbed failing to create the world. Moreover, the contact of Prakṛti with Puruṣa is required for creating an atmosphere of disbalancing the three *guṇa*-s, which is described as *sāmyāvasthā-bhanga*. The Sāṃkhya believes that, when the state of equilibrium is disturbed, there is creation. On the other hand, if Prakṛti takes her original state of balance among the three constituents,

¹³ Vijñanabhikṣu: *Sāṃkhya-pravāna-bhāṣya* on Sūtra.1/61, edited by Richard Garbe, Harvard University Press, Cambridge, 1943.

¹⁴ *Sankarabhāṣya* on Brahmasūtra No. 02.02.12.

there is dissolution (*pralaya*). For this the factor of disjoining Prakṛti with Puruṣa is required. In other words, had there been no contact and disjoining of Prakṛti with Puruṣa, the creation and dissolution (*sṛṣṭi* and *pralaya*) would not have been explicable. Though Puruṣa does not act in any way yet its existence is to be admitted in order to facilitate the manifestation of an effect in the cause. To Sāṃkhya, the effect is pre-existent in its cause before its manifestation according to its presupposition of *Satkāryavāda*. If this theory were not admitted at all, there would arise the contingency of arising anything from any object, which is not possible. As per the Sāṃkhya-view if something exists in its material cause in a non-manifested manner, it is manifested as an effect. This point may be substantiated following Vācaspati's view as reflected in his commentary called *Tattvakaumudī*. To him a large number of artisans cannot transform blue into red on account of the fact that red can never exist in blue.¹⁵ For this reason the material cause (*upādāna kāraṇa*) is, for Sāṃkhya, the real cause while the auxiliary cause (*nimitta kāraṇa*), according to Sāṃkhya, is meant for eradicating the impediments to an effect's manifested revelation in the cause. This is the necessity (*prayojana*) of its presence without producing anything. In other words, though it does not have any capacity of producing anything yet its presence is more fundamental. Moreover, material cause remains in the effect while the auxiliary cause (*nimitta kāraṇa*) is not found to be present in the effect itself. Hence, we are in search of its substitute or *vikalpa*. In so far as the auxiliary cause is concerned there is a substitute. As for example, one can take the help of electric current instead of using stick to rotate a wheel. But no substitute (*vikalpa*) is found for the material cause, which is always present in the effect without any exception. That is why, the Sāṃkhya philosophers do not think to lay much importance to the phenomenon of efficient cause. Further, the Sāṃkhya philosophers characterize Puruṣa as *aprakṛti* (non-prakṛti) and *avikṛti* (non-modified), i.e., *akāraṇa* (non-agent) and *akārya* (non-effect). This ultimately proves that the Sāṃkhya philosophers do not treat Puruṣa as *nimittakāraṇa* or auxiliary cause. Puruṣa thus is not essential for the creation of the world as Sāṃkhya observed. But for the termination of suffering, it is essential. The knowledge of discrimination between *vyakta* (manifested) and *avyakta* (non-manifested), i.e., Prakṛti on the one hand and Puruṣa on the other (*vyakta-avyakta-jñā-vijñāna*) is an inevitable factor for the ultimate cessation of all sorts of suffering. It (the discriminative knowledge) does not remove absolutely suffering only but provides liberation from bondage.

This situation is also not free from problems of the following type. If review the status of an individual who is *baddha* (in bondage or bound) and who is *mukta* (free), some inconsistencies will come on the way of our understanding. First it is admitted that the stages of bondage (*bandhana*) and liberation (*mukti*) of Puruṣa finally are possible through the knowledge of discrimination (*vivekajñāna*) between Puruṣa and Prakṛti. But *Sāṃkhyakārikā* tells us that really Prakṛti is *baddha* owing to her contact (*saṃyoga*) with, or pseudo-contact (*saṃyogabhāsa*) with or merely proximity (*sānnidhyamātra*) with Puruṣa. Prakṛti becomes *mukta* when such knowledge of discrimination (*vivekajñāna*) is revealed. Īśvarakṛṣṇa argues that creation or

¹⁵ *Sāṃkhya-kārikā* No. 19 with *Tattvakaumudī*.

evolution of the world from the ultimate cause, Prakṛti, starts primarily for the enjoyment of *Puruṣa* (*Puruṣasya darśanārtham*) and ultimately for the release of *Puruṣa* (*kaivalyārtham*) from the clutches of Prakṛti.¹⁶ Sankara rightly raised an objection that enjoyment (*bhoga*) or liberation (*apavarga*) is not possible of *Puruṣa* who is considered to be utterly inactive or defunct and hence, the enjoyment in *Puruṣa* is not at all possible without some kind of function. Moreover, if it is said that *Puruṣa* is supposed to enjoy, there will be no end of such enjoyment at all. For, Prakṛti will continue to create enjoyable objects ceaselessly for the enjoyment of *Puruṣa* as per her nature and *Puruṣa*'s enjoyment, on the other hand, will go on for endless period of time, which is an impediment towards the attainment of liberation.¹⁷ Again, *Puruṣa* is said to be ever liberated (*mukta*) by nature as opposed to *baddha*. *Mukti* by virtue of its own *svatūpa* (nature), is not further attainable. For, an attained thing can never be attained again. Further, if, for the argument's sake, it is taken for granted that the liberation of *Puruṣa* is not at all attained, it will continue forever to attain this, which makes the cycle of creation impossible. The Sāṃkhya seems to contradict to his own view when it emphatically says that *Puruṣa* is not affected by its bondage, liberation and migration at all. *Puruṣa* is not stated to be bound at all—*na kaścit puruṣo badhyate*. It is not liberated and receives *saṃsāra* or worldly life—*na kaścit saṃsārati*. That it is not liberated is known from the following text—*na kaścit puruṣaḥ muktaḥ*.¹⁸ As a matter of fact, bondage (*bandhana*) worldly existence (*saṃsāra*) and liberation (*mokṣa*) are not embedded in the nature of *Puruṣa* at all. Moreover, liberation presupposes bondage. Hence, *Puruṣa* is not in a position having a state of liberation or in a state of bondage. For, *Puruṣa* is free from *kleśa* (pain following from ignorance), *karma* (action originated from merit and demerit) and *āśaya* (*citta*, the substratum of law of *karma*). *Puruṣa* is described as utterly indifferent, inactive, unchanging and devoid of *guṇa*-s. Vācaspati correctly observes: *Savāsanā-kleśa-karmāśayānāṃ bandhana-samākhyānām? Puruṣa aparīṇāminyasambhāvāt*.¹⁹ The term “*vāsanā*” signifies *saṃskāra* arising from previous impressions. The term “*kleśa*” means *avidyā*, *asmitā*, *rāga*, *dveṣa* and *abhiniveśa*. “*Karma*” denotes merit (*dharma*) and demerit (*adharma*) coming from our good or bad deeds and “*Āśaya*” for *citta*. *Puruṣa*, being indifferent (*nirlepa*), unchangeable (*aparīṇāmī*), and absolutely inactive (*niṣkriya*) in nature remains unaffected by *bandhana*, *saṃsāra*, *kleśa*, *karma* and *āśaya*. Hence *bandhana*, *saṃsāra* and *mokṣa* are not pertaining to *Puruṣa*'s real nature. These are superimposed to *Puruṣa* through secondary implication (*aupacārika* or *lakṣaṇā*). This imposition is comparable to an army's success or failure—victory or defeat, which is secondarily attributed to a king who owns it. In fact, *Prakṛti* is bound or liberated. The bondage (*bandhana*), etc., are the results of three-fold *guṇa*s belonging to *Prakṛti*. Such superimposition as shown above is due to the absence of

¹⁶ *Ibid*, Kārikā No. 21.

¹⁷ *Sankarabhāṣya* on Brahmasūtra-02.02.06.

¹⁸ *Sāṃkhya-kārikā* No. 62 with *Tattvakaumudī*.

¹⁹ *Tattvakaumudī* on Kārikā No. 67.

the knowledge of discrimination (*vivekāgraha*) of Puruṣa and Prakṛti. In fact, enjoyment (*bhoga*) and liberation (*apavarga*) are secondarily attributed to Puruṣa who is not worthy of these.

Īśvarakṛṣṇa justifies the fact of imposition by saying that Puruṣa apparently suffers from the pain due to old age and death (*jarāmaraṇakṛtaṁ duḥkhaṁ prāpnoti cetanaḥ Puruṣaḥ*). It is an apparent truth but the real truth is as known from Sāṃkhya literature that Puruṣa is *viśuddha caitanya* or pure consciousness described as *nitya* (eternal), *śuddha* (pure), *buddha* (conscious), and *mukta* (free). Therefore, *jarā* (old age) and *marāṇa* (death) cannot be its property. This bodily suffering is superimposed on conscious Puruṣa who considers the sufferings of the body as its own due to the absence of the knowledge of discrimination. In fact, Puruṣa having above-mentioned nature of eternity, pure, etc., remains untouched by bodily affections.²⁰

The evolution of Prakṛti spontaneously comes into being just as milk from the udder of the cow. But one thing is to be remembered that spontaneity presupposes some intentionality which Prakṛti does not have. Cow, on the other hand, has got a feeling-oriented intention of the nourishment of the calf. As a matter of fact, Prakṛti, being devoid of consciousness by virtue of being matter cannot have intentionality of evolution at all. So, the evolution of Prakṛti for the liberation of Puruṣa cannot be admitted.²¹ The truth is that Prakṛti evolves automatically without being guided by any conscious principle and hence, the release of Puruṣa is not real but apparent. Prakṛti evolves apparently for the benefit of Puruṣa after considering it as its own. Prakṛti does not have any expectation of reciprocation from the side of Puruṣa. Just as an appointed cook prepares food for the satisfaction of his master and leaves the kitchen when the food is cooked, similarly Prakṛti evolves for the liberation of each *Puruṣa* (*puruṣa—vimokṣārtham*) after considering the interest of Puruṣa as its own—*svārtha, na parārtha*.²²

This view of Sāṃkhya is vitiated with inconsistencies. The Sāṃkhya philosophers declare that Prakṛti and Puruṣa are both eternal, absolute and independent realities. Had Puruṣa been really independent requiring no assistance from Prakṛti, the cycle of creation (*sarga*) and destruction (*pralaya*) would remain indetermined and unexplained. For, the difference in effect cannot be brought about by the same cause. To explain, according to Sāṃkhya, Prakṛti is the material cause and Puruṣa is meant for helping manifestation of that already remaining in the material cause. If manifestation does not take place without the assistance of somebody, it should be regarded as one of the causes. Otherwise, manifestation is automatic like the flowing of milk from the udder of the cow. In this context it is to be noticed that the cow is a conscious agent and flowing of milk is also caused by the motherly affection towards its offspring. But Prakṛti is bearing an opposite nature as she is unconscious and hence its automatic changes are not possible. If such automatic change is admitted then it is to be justified how and why Prakṛti evolves in both creation and destruction of the world. In other words, the state of equilibrium (*sāmyavāsthā*) of Prakṛti is

²⁰ *Sāṃkhya-kārikā* No. 55 with *Tattvakaumudī*.

²¹ *Sankarabhāṣya* on *Brahmasūtra* No.02.02.03 (“payambuvaccet tatrāpi”).

²² *Sāṃkhya-kārikā* No. 61 with *Tattvakaumudī*.

to be disturbed for the evolution of the world by the presence of Puruṣa. The question of its presence as real or apparent or mere proximity is not much important. In order to get the equilibrium disturbed the contact between Prakṛti and Puruṣa. The important fact is that there must be some contact between Puruṣa and Prakṛti so that this is essential leading to overpowering one *guṇa* on another or rest for the sake of creation. From this it is assumed that Prakṛti cannot be independent or absolute. Moreover, if Puruṣa and Prakṛti are both eternal (*nitya*), their contact must also be the same, which is tantamount to say that creation will continue for the endless period of time leading to the impossibility of dissolution. If, on the contrary, dissolution is taken as the *svarūpa* of Prakṛti, heterogeneous changes in Prakṛti would not be possible by the threat of losing its real nature (*svarūpa-praṇāśa-bhayāt*). Hence, creation and destruction cannot be justified by Prakṛti alone. For that, we require an apparent or proximate contact or absence of contact with Puruṣa. This makes us convinced that Prakṛti is not absolute (*nirapekṣa*) or independent (*svatantra*). If she is independent, she cannot serve the purpose of others. If it is argued that Prakṛti serves the purpose of others just as a cook does so of others, she will be considered as dependent or subordinate to other, which goes against her independent character. It may be said that Prakṛti serves the interest of Puruṣa being detached without having any self-interest. If it is true then it is very difficult to explain Prakṛti as blind. It is a well-known fact that a blind person cannot actualize his plan on account of the fact that it will go against her unconscious nature. It is true that both a lame and a blind man are conscious in nature and hence they are capable of accomplishing certain activities. The lame man, though not capable of walking, can give verbal instructions to guide the blind. In this way a work can be accomplished through mutual co-operation. So, the metaphor of a lame man stands for Puruṣa who is inactive and that of a blind man stands for Prakṛti who is unconscious. Such metaphor is not an appropriate one as it leads to the defect of “contradiction regarding metaphor and the object metaphorized” (*dṛṣṭānta-dārṣṭāntika-virodha*) as pointed out by Sankara. Prakṛti and Puruṣa that are metaphorized (*dārṣṭāntika*) with the metaphors (*dṛṣṭānta*) of lame and blind person respectively. Both of Prakṛti and Puruṣa do not match with lame and blind man due to their conscious nature.²³ Concerning Puruṣa there are a lot of confusions and contradictions. Puruṣa is known as pure consciousness (*viśuddhacaitanya* or *kevalacaitanya*) having no bondage or liberation or worldly existence. Though the statement is true yet the Sāṃkhya philosophers are found to talk about the plurality of Puruṣa on the ground of birth, death, and activity (*janana-maraṇa-karaṇānam*).²⁴ But it is known to us that birth, etc., cannot affect eternal (*nitya*) and inactive (*niṣkriya*) consciousness. Hence, birth, etc., may be taken as the qualifications of the phenomenal Ego or *Jivātmā*, a product of the reflection of Puruṣa on *Buddhi*. Puruṣa is beyond to such phenomenalism. The Sāṃkhya philosophers do not admit a distinction between these two kinds of self-Puruṣa proper and *Jīva*. If the arguments in favour of the existence of Puruṣa are critically examined, it seems that all of them are in favour of the existence of *Jīva*-s. It is not known to us

²³ Sankarabhāṣya on Brahmasūtra No. 02.02.07 (“purusasmavaditi cettathapi”).

²⁴ Sāṃkhya-kārikā No. 21 with Tattvakaumudī.

Sāṃkhya fails to reduce the many *Jīva-s* into one absolute Puruṣa just as they have reduced diversified material entities into one primordial matter called Prakṛti. They could have applied the same logic in the case of Puruṣa. So far as my understanding goes, this inherent inconsistency has led formulation of certain commentators like Gauḍapāda, Vācaspati, Vijñānabhikṣu, etc., to abandon the plurality of Puruṣa and accept the theory of one Puruṣa instead. The Sāṃkhya thinkers emphatically declare in the beginning that the internal changes of Prakṛti for the evolution of the world are arising keeping two purposes of enjoyment and liberation of Puruṣa in view. Afterwards, they revised their above-mentioned position by declaring that Puruṣa is not really bound or liberated or migrated. Prakṛti really binds herself, liberates herself and migrates herself. The so-called bondage of Puruṣa is simply attributed falsely (*aupacārika*) because of the close contact of Puruṣa and Prakṛti. In this context the term “*bhoktrtva*” (enjoyerhood) means “*draṣṭṛtva*” (being an observer). That is why, it is said that Puruṣa is disembodied, conscious, observer, eternal, all-pervading, defunct, non-agent, having no quality and subtle- “*Amūrtaścetano bhogī nityaḥ sarvagato ’kriyaḥ/akartā nirguṇaḥ sūkṣmaḥ ātmā kāpiladarśane//*” Just as there is the reflection of the moon and its qualities like movement, etc., on water, there is the reflection of the qualities of the non-existent matter on Self who is taken to be an observer (“*Yathā jale candramasaḥ kampādistatkrto guṇaḥ/dṛśyate’sannapi drasturātmano’nātmāno guṇaḥ”//*).²⁵ If there is a shadow theory, the characteristic of one may be imposed on the other just as the moon is reflected on water. An individual having no cognition of discrimination can see all these as true though they are really untrue. On account of this Puruṣa has got the cognition of agency in the form- “I am an agent” (*ahaṃ kartā*) and inclination is possible for this. Though the consciousness is the property of Puruṣa and agency is that of intellect (*buddhi*) yet due the superimposition between them Puruṣa has got an illusory cognition—*I am an agent* (*ahaṃ kartā*). Just as the victory and defeat of the soldiers are imposed on king, the property of being an agent, etc., which are the properties of intellect, are imposed on Puruṣa.²⁶ Hence, the property of being inactive or defunct is the real one of Puruṣa while the property of Puruṣa as active or functional is nothing but imposition.

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²⁵ Sāṃkhyikārikā No.20 with Vivaraṇī, Edited by Bipadbhanjan Pal, 1st Edition, Sadesh, Kolkata, 2010, p. 41.

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Chapter 7

Sāṃkhya Concept of Intentional Consciousness



Surya Kant Maharana 

Abstract The paper titled “Sāṃkhya Concept of Intentional Consciousness” intends to discuss the concept of consciousness as presented in the philosophy of Sāṃkhya. It commits to investigate a specific dimension of consciousness, namely, the intentionality of consciousness. The concept of the intentionality of consciousness is primarily a Western philosophical concept which began its journey from Aristotle followed by an array of philosophers including Franz Brentano and Edmund Husserl and many others in the phenomenological and existentialistic tradition of contemporary Western philosophy. The paper takes up the Husserlian model of intentionality as an ideal structure of consciousness and proposes to investigate whether the age-old Sāṃkhya philosophy also claims to exhibit such an intentional structure of consciousness. It is finally submitted that Sāṃkhya is concerned with the intentionality of consciousness up to a certain extent; but then, it transcends the boundary of intentionality in order to explain the real nature of consciousness and attempts to propound an unparallel and unique concept of consciousness ever unfounded in the Western philosophical tradition, namely, the pure non-intentional consciousness, which has been identified with the pure self, the *Puruṣa*.

Keywords Pure consciousness · Intentionality of consciousness · Unconsciousness · Modified consciousness and Non-intentional consciousness

7.1 Introduction

To discuss the Sāṃkhya concept of intentional consciousness, I divide the paper into two parts. First, I will discuss the nature and definition of intentionality, confining my discussion to the domain of Husserlian phenomenology. Next, I will discuss the Sāṃkhya theory of consciousness and investigate whether the intentional feature of consciousness can be accommodated in the Sāṃkhya theory of consciousness. In conclusion, I will submit that in Sāṃkhya, intentionality can be ascribed to the

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modified consciousness as well as the *Puruṣa* as long as it is in the bondage of the *antaḥkaraṇa*, the internal organ or the modified consciousness and that Sāṃkhya exhibits a unique transcendental feature of consciousness which is of the nature of non-intentional or non-referential.

7.2 Doctrine of Intentionality

Phenomenology aims to obtain greater clarity in consciousness and explain its meaning and scope. The notion of consciousness, as says Merleau-Ponty, is the main discovery of phenomenology. Consciousness has been defined here as “All consciousness is consciousness of something.” Every act of loving is a loving of something; every act of seeing is a seeing of something. The point, for Husserl, is that disregarding whether or not the object of the act exists, it has meaning and a mode of being for consciousness, that is, it has a meaningful correlate of the conscious act. This allowed Husserl to explore a whole new domain—the domain of the meaning and correlates of the consciousness act, their interconnections and binding laws before one had to face ontological questions concerning actual existence, and so on. While phenomenology turns to consciousness, it is nevertheless a science of consciousness based on elucidating the intentional structures of acts and their correlative objects—what Husserl called the noetic-noematic structure of consciousness. Husserl saw intentionality as a way of reviving the central discovery of Descartes’s *cogito ergo sum*. Instead of proceeding to an ontological account of the *res cogitans* as a thinking substance as Descartes himself did, one can focus on the intentional structure which Husserl describes as *ego-cogitatio-cogitatum*—the self, its acts of consciousness, and its objective correlate.¹ Thus, the quintessential concept in phenomenology is “intentionality.” What is “of” or “about” something other than itself is said to be “intentional.” Consciousness is intentional because it is “of” something. What a consciousness posits as its object is said to be its “intentional object.”²

Husserl called his phenomenology “transcendental phenomenology.” His use of the term “transcendental” has a Kantian voice. He meant that everything in the world, and the world itself, derives its meaning from consciousness and intentionality. The purpose of this programme is to demonstrate that all things are constituted in consciousness, and this sense of consciousness is said to be transcendental. But consciousness is not only intentional but also temporal as the process of constitution is a temporal one giving rise to the historicity of the transcendental consciousness and the world which it constitutes. It explains how “I” as a transcendental ego comes to share a common world with other co-constituting transcendental egos. “Constitution” (*konstitution*) is a central notion in Husserl. The term “constitution” itself has a pre-history in Kantian philosophy. In the Kantian sense, the term refers to how

¹ Moran (2000, p 16).

² Burte (2013).

objects are “built up” for consciousness out of a synthesis of sensory intuitions and various categories which are applied according to certain rules. In his early work *Philosophy of Arithmetic*, Husserl used the term to mean a study of the constitution of mathematical entities. In *Logical Investigations*, “constitution” refers to how non-intentional sensations are interpreted and brought into objectifying intentions to produce objects for consciousness. The performance of the *epoché* and reduction reveals the intentional structures which show how objectivity is constituted out of subjectivity. Husserl’s notion of constitution perhaps means a kind of “setting out” or “positing” (*setzung*), as a giving of sense or “sense-bestowing.” (*sinngebung*)³ It is life “manifesting” and “exhibiting” as equivalent to “constituting.” Further, it is spoken of as a kind of “producing,” “making” or even “creating.” Thus, in *Cartesian Meditations*, Husserl speaks of new objects being constituted for consciousness as “products” (*erzeugnisse, leistungen*).⁴

Phenomenology, for Husserl, is a discipline which is a science of consciousness, but not a science of psychology. It is a “phenomenology” of consciousness instead of a natural science about consciousness. What Husserl means is that psychology is concerned with “empirical consciousness,” with consciousness from the physiological, neurological or biological standpoint. For example, it deals with questions such as “how consciousness functions in the brain, in various parts of the body” and considers consciousness as an empirical being in the order of nature. But phenomenology is interested in “pure consciousness,” that is, consciousness from the phenomenological point of view, in which the belief in the natural reality of the world is suspended. It wants to unearth consciousness and looks at it as it “appears” in ordinary experience. Husserl’s notion of consciousness may be said to have developed in several stages, and it is very difficult to draw a strict line of demarcation among these. I have restricted my discussion about the nature of “consciousness” in Husserl’s phenomenology under three heads: (a) Consciousness in *Logical Investigations*, (b) Consciousness in *Ideas* and (c) Consciousness in *Cartesian Meditations* and later works. It is to be noted here that the levels of description of consciousness, followed by a careful study of the ego or consciousness, is achieved by the employment of a methodological device called “reduction” (which is already discussed above). The theory of ego or consciousness unfolds itself through such notions as the “empirical ego,” the “phenomenological ego,” the “pure or polar ego” and the “monad or the transcendental ego.”

7.3 Consciousness in Logical Investigations

Consciousness is understood by Husserl in the *Logical Investigations* as “intentional.” It is this “openness to” that is the foundational structure of consciousness. It is a relation between a “meaning act” and “that which is meant,” its object, which is

³ Sokolowski (1964, p. 196).

⁴ Cairns, Sect. 38, 77.

meant as its object and defined as its meaning. In his search for a philosophical explanation of mathematical and logical concepts, Husserl formulated the thesis that the being of these concepts is exclusively to be the objects of consciousness. It means, in other words, that the logical and mathematical beings are, in the most fundamental sense, meanings for me and consciousness is to be thought of as a relation *sui generis* to an apprehended object. Thus, after the publication of *Logical Investigations*, Husserl came to gradually realize that intentionality is not only a characteristic feature of the acts of consciousness but is the very essence of consciousness.

Husserl understands the ego or consciousness as the conscious unity or the contemporary bundle of experiences, the continuous thing-like unity constituted in the unity of consciousness which functions as the personal subject of our experience. The description of an experience refers to the relation to the ego, but the experience itself doesn't have the ego as its part. The description takes place after the experience is over, in which the ego appears as itself related to the object of its act. Thus, "the ego judges about the object" means that "such and such experience of judging is present in the ego." Husserl's understanding of the "empirical ego" is in terms of the "person" in ordinary discourse. Agency here is not understood as something in consciousness but simply as the person undergoing experiences. This ego, as he puts it, is a "thing-like object and can be perceived" just as we perceive an external thing.⁵ It is this ego that performs the *epoché*. Husserl then arrives at the notion of a "phenomenological ego" in his *Logical Investigations* by an application of the method of reduction, centrally focusing on consciousness and its experiences by turning away and not attending to the various external objects with which consciousness is ordinarily occupied. The ego that is now encountered is nothing unfamiliar; it is the psychologically functioning ego. Even if its focus is on inner experiences, phenomenological psychology is not at this point very remote from empirical psychology operating with naturalistic assumptions about the ego. Thus, the "phenomenologically reduced ego," to quote Husserl's own words, "is nothing peculiar, floating above many experiences; it is simply identical with their interconnected unity."⁶

Husserl's position at this point, as has been noticed by many, "is not dissimilar to that of David Hume." Husserl, however, explicitly states that he was unable to find any pure consciousness or pure ego as a "primitive centre of relations" or as a transcendental subject. It is possible that in his understanding of the "interconnectedness," which accounts for the unity of consciousness, Husserl was influenced by Brentano's idea of "primordial association." He found it unnecessary to postulate a transcendental ego above or behind the conscious processes since the contents of consciousness have "their law-bound ways of coming together, of losing themselves in comprehensive unities."⁷ This itself constitutes the phenomenological ego or the unity of consciousness without the need for any additional ego. In any case, what needs to be noted is that, at this stage, Husserl rejected the notion of an ego principle "which supports all contents and unities."

⁵ Findlay (1970, pp. 541–551).

⁶ Ibid., p. 541.

⁷ Ibid., p. 51.

7.4 Consciousness in *Ideas*

In *Ideas*, Husserl frankly admitted a “pure consciousness or pure ego” as “necessary and indubitable.” To quote Husserl, on the one hand,

...consciousness, considered in its ‘purity’, must be reckoned as a self-contained system of Being, as a system of Absolute Being, into which nothing can penetrate, and from which nothing can escape which has no spatiotemporal exterior, and can be inside no spatiotemporal system, which cannot experience causality from anything nor exert causality upon anything ... On the other side, the whole spatiotemporal world, to which man and the human ego claim to belong as singular subordinate realities is according to its meaning mere intentional Being, a Being therefore which has the merely secondary, relative sense of a Being for a consciousness. It is a being, which consciousness in its experience posits, and is, in principle, intuitable and determinable only as the element common to the motivated appearance-manifolds, but over and beyond this, is just nothing at all.⁸

Here, a clear distinction emerges between the empirical and the transcendental ego. The empirical and the pure ego are now seen as intentional objects, as unities which are results of the intentional constitution and “over and beyond this nothing at all.” The pure ego is “neither experience nor a process” but “the active and affected subject of consciousness.” In *Cartesian Meditations* Husserl describes pure ego as that which “lives in all processes of consciousness and is related, through them, to all object poles.”⁹ This is a description of the ego in its transcendental aspect, which does not involve any ontological commitment. It is outlined that the transcendental features of the pure ego and its acts are universal and necessary. It includes (a) the mere subject pole of all intentional acts, (b) the genesis of an ego that is, an account of how an ego’s life unfolds, and (c) the general form of time in which all experiences of an ego come together as one compassable world.

In *Ideas*,¹⁰ Husserl says that in principle, every *cogitatio* can change and can come and go, but in contrast, the pure ego appears to be necessary in principle. It remains self-identical in all real and possible changes of experience; it cannot be considered as a real part or phase of the experiences themselves. The ego lives its life in a special sense in every actual *cogito*, and all experiences also within the mental background belong to it, it to them, and all of them, as belonging to one single stream of experience. It is like, in the words of Kant, “The ‘I think’ must be able to accompany all my potentialities.” Based on these considerations, Husserl speaks of the relation that every experience has to the pure ego—being directed towards an object; being occupied with it; adopting an attitude; and undergoing something all imply the essential characteristic that they are “something from the ego.” “This ego is a pure ego, which no reduction can ever remove.” Husserl thinks that the essential nature of the sphere of experience contains a two-sided fact of great importance: (1) Everything is *cogito*, as *cogito* is directed to an object or *cogitatum*; (2) it is also and of necessity a *cogito* of this ego. It is in every wakeful *cogito* that a regard of

⁸ Gibson (1931, p. 153).

⁹ Cairns (1967, p. 66).

¹⁰ Gibson (1931, p. 153).

the pure ego is directed to the object of the correlate of consciousness considered at that time, and the ego possesses consciousness of this object in one of its typical variations. However, the phenomenological background shows that this directedness towards the correlated object cannot be found in every experience, as intentionality may remain concealed in it. The objective background from which the perceived object of the *cogitation* emerges when it is selected by “the glance of the ego” is an objective background in a sense that can be experienced. When our consciousness is turned towards the pure object in the manner of the *cogito*, various objects appear. We become intuitively aware of them. The objects blend into the unity of a single intuition, which is the unity of a consciously grasped field of objects. It is a case of a potential field of perception in the sense that a special perception can be directed towards everything that appears in this way. The variations of the sensory perspective as present in a single visual field cannot be objectively grasped until they take the shape of intuitive appearances of objects.

7.5 The *Noesis-Noema* Structure of Consciousness

The phenomenological analysis of consciousness reveals the *noesis noema* structure of experience. *Noesis* is the objectifying act, and *noema* is the intended object. In other words, *noesis* and *noema* correspond to the subject and object poles of experience respectively. Every *noesis* has its corresponding *noema*. However, the same object can be apprehended differently. That is to say, many intended objects may refer to the same object grasped in various intending acts. This implies that there is an underlying unity or identity of different *noemata* of varying acts. Without this unity, we cannot support any claim to objectivity.¹¹ Perception has its *noema* and the “perceived as such” constitutes the perceptual meaning. The *noematic* correlate is referred to as “meaning,” only to the extent that it is immanent in the experience of perception, judgement and so on. We can have an idea of the “perceived as such” by grasping fully what is essentially given. This makes the faithful description of “that which appears as such” indissolubly bound up with the essence of perception. We obtain then the “material thing,” “plant,” “tree,” which are given in perception. Husserl thinks that the “tree” as it exists in nature, is completely different from this perceived tree as such. The real tree can be destroyed or burnt, but the meaning of this perception cannot be destroyed, neither can it be separated from its essence. As Husserl’s phenomenological approach is an exploration of the “meaning” of consciousness, phenomenological analysis tends to show that both *noesis* and *noema* are the two poles of the same consciousness though the relation between *noesis* and *noema* is not one of equality. Helmut Kuhn points out that *noesis* has primacy over *noema*. To quote him, “The very objectivity of object is to be defined in terms of objectivating activity.”¹²

¹¹ Tharakan (1998, p. 216).

¹² Kuhn (1968, p. 110).

7.6 Consciousness in *Cartesian Meditations*

A clearer picture of Husserlian description of consciousness appears as one further considers the *Cartesian Meditations*. In the *Fourth Meditation*, the problem of the self-constitution of the consciousness is dealt with. Under the section “The ego as the identical pole of subjective processes,”¹³ it is observed that consciousness not only experiences itself as the flow of mental life but also as “I.” The “I” who lives that mental life and the “I” whom “I” experiences as myself are the same “I.” The mental acts are unified not merely objectively, that is, as directed to the same object, but also as belonging to an identical ego. The ego is the active and passive subject of consciousness. The section entitled “The ego as the substrate of habitualities,” however, states that the ego is not merely an empty pole of identity. Every intentional act which I perform generates in me a new property which lasts until it is cancelled. Every decision that I take and every belief that I acquire leaves in me a corresponding property. Such a property itself, however, is not a temporal process. In this manner, consciousness continuously constitutes itself as a personal ego with a relatively abiding style known as its character. Husserl distinguishes between the ego taken in its full concreteness from both the above conceptions of the ego and calls it the monad. As a monad, the ego includes not only its flowing intentional life but also the objects meant in that life. Thus, the consciousness sets up its surrounding world consisting first of those objects with which I am acquainted and then of those which I anticipate as possible objects of acquaintance.

To conclude from the above discussion on “ego” or “consciousness,” one can arrive at the thesis that the empirical and the transcendental consciousness are not two numerically distinct entities, but rather one and the same entity regarded from two standpoints. Aron Gurwitsch says that consciousness is not taken as part of the real world and as one reality among others. We have a right to characterize consciousness as absolute only to the extent that we conceive of it exclusively as a medium and, so to speak, as the theatre in which the constitution of all sorts of objects—including psychical and human realities, such as the soul, the mind, the ego, the personality, our social and historical being, etc.—takes place.¹⁴

However, Husserl derives the concept of intentionality from the philosophy of Franz Brentano. The most crucial concept of Brentano’s philosophy is intentionality. The term intentionality is derivative of the traditional scholastic doctrine of intentionality. For Brentano, intentionality means that every mental act is related to some object. He construed it as the mind’s awareness of an object, or of its content. He speaks of the *intentional object* or the *intentional relation*. In his ground-breaking work, *Psychology from An Empirical Standpoint*, he states,

...mental phenomenon is characterised by what the Scholastics of the Middle Ages called the intentional (or mental) inexistence of an object and what we might call the direction towards an object or immanent objectivity. Every mental phenomenon includes something as an object within itself, although they do not all do so in the same way. In any presentation,

¹³ Cairns, (1967, p. 31).

¹⁴ Embree, (1974).

something is presented, in judgement something is affirmed or denied, in love loved, in hate hated, in desire desired and so on.¹⁵

As a matter of fact, Brentano uses terms like “intentional inexistence” or “intentionally contain” which he introduces to distinguish psychical phenomena from physical phenomena. For example, an isolated quality such as red is a physical phenomenon; but red as belonging to consciousness is a psychical phenomenon.

The following illustration makes the notion of intentional relations very clear.

Psychic act—intentionally relates to—immanent objectivity.

(It may or may not be a real thing).¹⁶

However, Husserl and phenomenology in general, would hold that phenomenology is interested in the fact that every mental act intends an object, not that there is a fundamental distinction between the physical and psychical domains. With this idea of the intentional nature of consciousness clear in mind, let us turn to the Sāṃkhya theory of consciousness and look for an intentional dimension of consciousness.

7.7 Sāṃkhya Theory of Consciousness

Puruṣa is defined as the nature of pure consciousness. Consciousness is pure in the sense that it is not the consciousness either of body, mind, senses, ego, intellect or any substance. It is construed as the transcendental self, subject and knower. Although it is the very self, it is inactive (*udāsīna*), a non-doer (*akartā*) and a seer (*dr̥ṣṭa*). To Sāṃkhya, it is the foundation of knowledge but itself is not an object of knowledge. Further, the pure consciousness is of the nature of witness,¹⁷ liberated, peaceful, and eternal. It is beyond space and time, change and activity, and therefore, transcendent to the three *guṇas* of *Prakṛti*. As the foundation of knowledge and experience, it is ever self-luminous (*sadā prakāśa svarūpa*), self-proved (*svayam siddha*), and therefore, indubitable, uncaused, and all-pervading.

Sāṃkhya puts forth the following arguments¹⁸ for the existence of *Puruṣa* as pure consciousness:

1. *Prakṛti*, the principle of matter and unconsciousness, evolves to serve the ends of *Puruṣa*.
2. *Puruṣa* is the witness of three *guṇas* but beyond them.
3. *Puruṣa* is the knower, therefore, all knowledge presupposes it.
4. *Puruṣa* as the principle of consciousness and enjoyer (*bhoktā*) enjoys the products of *Prakṛti* which *Prakṛti* itself cannot do as she is the enjoyed (*bhogyā*).
5. *Puruṣa* strives to attain liberation from suffering.

¹⁵ Moran, (2000, p. 47).

¹⁶ Ibid., p. 57.

¹⁷ Virupakshananda (2006, p. 19).

¹⁸ Ibid., p. 17.

Hence, *Puruṣa* exists.

To the question, of whether *Puruṣa* is one or many, Sāṃkhya contends that there is a plurality of *Puruṣa* and in support of this claim, Sāṃkhya further advances the following arguments¹⁹:

1. The *Puruṣas* are many owing to different births and deaths; possession of different sense organs and thereby experience of difference in terms of enjoyment of pleasure and pain indicate the manliness of *Puruṣas*.
2. The birth and death, bondage and liberation, etc., of one does not apply to that of others. Hence, there must be manliness of *Puruṣas*.
3. *Puruṣas* are different because they are endowed with the quality of either *sattva*, *rajas* or *tamas*. It, therefore, entails that there are many *Puruṣas*.

S.K. Saksena, in his masterpiece *Nature of Consciousness in Hindu Philosophy*,²⁰ maintains that *Puruṣa* can be approached from various perspectives, such as, ontological, epistemological, and transcendental. From the ontological perspective of consciousness, which generally asks the question, “What is consciousness?” Consciousness is held to be eternal, pure, unobjectified, distinctionless, infinite reality. It is of the nature of knowledge, foundational consciousness, independent, uncaused, and unproduced. Further, it is neither illusory nor abstract; rather concrete but transcendental. It is the unchanging principle of light and intelligence. In this sense, *Puruṣa*, the pure and transcendental consciousness, is distinguished from its modification called *buddhi* or intellect. It is the *buddhi* that makes a distinction between knower, known and knowledge.

Next, from the epistemological perspective of consciousness, it is responsible for self-illumination. Cognition is the psychic function of *buddhi*. *Buddhi* is known by *Puruṣa* since *buddhi* cannot be known by itself owing to its unconscious nature. So is the case with *Manas*. Both of them are the objects of *Puruṣa*, the pure consciousness which comprehends both object and cognition as self-luminous.

Finally, from the transcendental perspective, consciousness is transcendental as far as it is pure, unmixed with anything and different from an empirical knowledge event. Transcendental consciousness is a consciousness which is changeless, permanent and timeless. The category of time is within consciousness, and without it, no time can be imagined. Consciousness exists in three periods of time. It stands immutable and is a permanent spectator beholding all changes while remaining unchanged. The form of language in which the pure self is expressed is not the form in which the self exists. The confusion created in philosophical thinking is by linguistic form or the power of words. According to the *Sabda Māhātmya of Yoga Bhāṣya*,²¹ the power of linguistic knowledge creates mental modification even in the absence of corresponding reality. The grammatical forms often mislead us into believing in realities which do not exist in the same form. So, the nature of the transcendental consciousness has to be comprehended with care. Now, having discussed the Sāṃkhya theory

¹⁹ Ibid., p. 18.

²⁰ Saksena (1971, p. 87).

²¹ Prasada (1912), 1.9.

of consciousness, the Sāṃkhya principle of the unconsciousness or matter, technically called *Prakṛti*, needs to be discussed very briefly. This is because it is due to the joint venture of both *Puruṣa* and *Prakṛti* that the origin of intentional consciousness can be accounted for.

7.8 Prakṛti, the Principle of Unconsciousness

Prakṛti is defined as material (*jaḍa*). Hence, it is an unconscious principle unlike *Puruṣa*, the principle of consciousness. The state of equilibrium of the three *guṇas*, namely, *sattva*, *rajas* and *tamas* is called *Prakṛti* (*guṇānām sāmyāvasthā*). It is the *Puruṣa–Prakṛti* contact caused due to the nearness of *Puruṣa* (*Puruṣa saṃnidhi mātra*) and semblance of contact (*samyogābhāsa*)—the *appearance* of a contact and *no real contact*—that disturbs the equilibrium. Consequent upon the disturbance of such equilibrium, the evolution of the 24 principles of *Prakṛti* begins. After evolution, *Puruṣa* gets reflected in the *mahat*, the *buddhi* or intellect or the modified consciousness; it wrongly identifies itself with its reflection in *buddhi* and thus becomes bound. It is to be noted here that it is the reflection of the *Puruṣa* and not *Puruṣa* itself which is bound. Now, let us move on to the second part which intends to investigate the intentional nature of consciousness in Sāṃkhya.

7.9 Intentional Nature of Consciousness

Puruṣa can be construed as intentional, that is, consciousness of something. The intentional activity of *Puruṣa* is presented beautifully by Vachaspati Mishra, a renowned Sāṃkhyaite, in his thought-provoking work *Tattvavaisārādī* wherein he has given a detailed account of the Sāṃkhya theory of intentionality. To Vachaspati Mishra, the *buddhi* or intellect is directed towards or intended to the object through the medium of the sense organs. *Buddhi* assumes the “form” of the object and manifests the object only after receiving the reflection of the self since *buddhi* itself is unconscious. Thus, the *Puruṣa* knows an external object through the mental modification or *buddhi* on which it gets reflected. *Puruṣa* here is ascribed to being intentional through the modified consciousness. Vijñānabhikṣu, another great Sāṃkhyaite, contends, in this regard, that there is a mutual reflection of the self on the *buddhi* and vice-versa. This double reflection enables the *Puruṣa* to know the external object.

Now, given this position, the question is whether the *Puruṣa* is self-conscious, that is, the consciousness of itself or not. To *Yoga Bhāṣya* of Maharshi Patañjali, *Puruṣa* cannot know itself directly although can be inferred through its reflection. For instance, we cannot see our faces. But then, we can infer our face through its reflection in a mirror or water, for it must have an original. Nevertheless, the transcendental self as pure consciousness can know the empirical Self, the modified consciousness, but not vice-versa. The *Yoga Bhāṣya* also mentions that all *cittavṛtti* are argued to

have their *viṣaya*, the concept which has been identified with “intentional object” as the correlate of consciousness. *Cittavṛtti*, therefore, is argued to be intentional, and thereby equivalent to intentional mental processes. It is “mental acts” or “mental processes” which are conscious, hence intentional. Yoga exhaustively enumerates the five kinds of *cittavṛtti* and all of them are “intentional” therefore the concept of *Cittavṛtti* is equivalent to “intentional” mental processes.²²

According to the Western notion of consciousness, in general, the mind is a conscious (intelligent) substance by its inherent nature. For Sāṃkhya, however, the “mind,” technically called *antaḥkaraṇa* or internal organ comprising the intellect (*buddhi* or *mahat*), ego (*ahankāra*) and mind (*manas*), is in itself non-intelligent or unconscious. This is because it is a product of *Prakṛti* which is non-intelligent or unconscious by nature. It is *Puruṣa*, the principle of intelligence, which illuminates it and lights it up by its inherent nature of pure consciousness (*suddha chaitanya svarūpa*). Being lit by it, the intellect, being very near to consciousness and having the function of manifesting itself and others, appears to be conscious or intelligent, though it is utterly unconscious. This happens when the unconscious intellect receives the reflection of the consciousness of *Puruṣa* and hence its consciousness or intelligence is a borrowed one. It may, therefore, be called a modified consciousness, rather than the original or pure consciousness.

For example, when an iron bar is heated, the heat is borrowed, not from its intrinsic nature, but from fire. So, the intellect, by being the nearest to *Puruṣa*, appears to be intelligent or conscious. The real knower of the thoughts or objects is not the modified consciousness, but the *Puruṣa*. The point to be noted here is that the mind or *manas* and the senses work for the modified consciousness, while the modified consciousness itself works solely for the *Puruṣa* and enables it to discriminate itself from *Prakṛti*. Thus, the *antaḥkaraṇa* is the instrument of knowledge just as the sense organs or motor organs are also the instruments of knowledge. Moreover, Sāṃkhya admits a supreme unitary consciousness standing behind the modified consciousness which is the real knower.

In this regard, K.K. Chakrabarti,²³ in his masterpiece *Classical Indian Philosophy of Mind*, observes that the *antaḥkaraṇa* has priority over the external organs, the *bahiskaraṇa*, such as the eye. Without the internal organs, the external organ cannot function as a cognitive organ at all. The external organ can only come into contact with an external object, but cognition is possible only when the internal organ is activated. Another indication of the priority of the internal organ over the external organ is that each external organ is restricted to a particular kind of object. For example, the eye can grasp colour but not smell. The nose can grasp smell but not colour and so on. However, the internal organ is not restricted in this way.

The Sāṃkhya account of perception (*Pratyakṣa*) reveals that when the modified consciousness becomes intentionally related to an external object through a sense organ, such as a pot, the reflection (*pratibimba*) of that object is cast on that organ.

²² Burte (2013).

²³ Chakrabarti (2001. pp. 175–183).

Then, the organ carries that reflection over to the modified consciousness. The modified consciousness, being dominated by *sattva*, is transparent and luminous. When the reflection of the object is carried onto it, the modified consciousness assumes the form (*ākāra*) of that object. This transformation of the modified consciousness in the form of an object remains possible since it is transparent and therefore capable of receiving the reflection of *Puruṣa* or the Pure consciousness. And, when the reflection of *Puruṣa* falls on the transformation of the modified consciousness as some object, there is cognition of that object.²⁴ Cognition is not a quality (*guṇa*) of the self as held by the Nyāya system; it is a modification of the *buddhi* and belongs to the latter. Thus, cognition is a real modification of *buddhi* but not of *Puruṣa*. To take an example, *Puruṣa* remains unaffected by the process just as the sun is not affected by its reflection in water. If there is a current in the water containing the reflection of the sun, the sun may appear to be moving. But the movement is of that water alone and not of the sun. Similarly, the transformation taking place in the event of cognition or any other internal state is that of *buddhi* and not of *Puruṣa*. However, the reflection of *Puruṣa* enables the unconscious *buddhi* to reveal the object in the way the moon can reveal things by borrowing the light of the sun although the moon has no light of its own.

From the aforementioned discussion, it can be observed that a living person is an evolute of *Prakṛti* which is devoid of consciousness. In other words, a living person is a product of the three unconscious substances called *sattva*, *rajas* and *tamas*. The body is dominated by *tamas* and the internal states are dominated by *sattva*. Cognition and other internal states appear to be conscious because of the reflection of *Puruṣa* or consciousness in them. But, in reality, they are devoid of consciousness. Thus, in a way, Sāṃkhya agrees with the materialist who claims that consciousness is nowhere to be found either in the body or in the internal states. The bodily states and the internal states are not radically different (contrary to a Cartesian dualist who claims to maintain that the former is unconscious and extended and the latter is conscious and unextended).

7.10 Conclusion

In conclusion, I wish to submit that intentionality can be ascribed to *Puruṣa* as long as it is entangled within and by the modified consciousness. Intentionality, as such, is confined to the modified consciousness or *buddhi*. The moment *Puruṣa* is liberated from the bondage of *Prakṛti* by the discriminative knowledge that it is fundamentally different from *Prakṛti* and its 24 principles, it returns to its original nature as the non-intentional or non-referential pure consciousness. Such a non-intentional pure consciousness is unique and sounds pretty close in spirit to the Advaitic notion of pure non-intentional or non-referential consciousness. There is nothing called non-intentional consciousness or pure consciousness, as found in the Sāṃkhyaite sense,

²⁴ Goswami (1982).

in the Western Phenomenological tradition. Husserl talks about pure consciousness but only to purify consciousness of all presuppositions.

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Chapter 8

Sāṃkhya, Tri-Gunas, and Psychology



Pratibha Gramann

Abstract Sāṃkhya philosophical thought has its origin in the Vedas. Sāṃkhya explains twenty-four *tattvas* principles as the evolutionary source of all creation. Yet prior to the *tattvas* exists the eternal *prakṛti* consisting of three *guṇas* or energetics: *Sattva*, *Rajas*, and *Tamas*. The three *guṇas* first gave rise to the five elements known as space, air, fire, water, and earth. The elements gave rise to the *tattvas* and every form, aspect, and quality of the manifest world. Examining the *triguṇas* reveals cognitive psychology useful for motivation and achieving aims. The premise of this paper proceeds to investigate the validity of the workings of the three *guṇas* as a useful system of psychology for clarity, motivation, achieving aims, and transformation.

Keywords Guṇas · Sattva · Rajas · Tamas · Psychology · Mind · Transformation · Motivation · Aims

8.1 Introduction

The workings of the three *guṇas* as the substratum of creation reveal a fascinating operation of continual phenomenology. These operate continually on a cosmic level and simultaneously in the mind of every creature, including, of course, the human. The key difference between humans and other creatures lies in form and capabilities because every creature has a unique form and qualities. The human form consists of the most highly evolved abilities to perceive and understand. This includes complicated ideas, deep thought, reflections, making choices, performing actions of many types, engaging in conscious breath movements, and much more. Humans are the only creatures who can use the *triguṇas* as cognitive and transformational psychology.

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8.2 Historical Significance of Sāṃkhya

Sāṃkhya was written by Kapila approximately 2700 years ago as a system of cosmic thought. Approximately 2500 years ago, Gautama the Buddha used Sāṃkhya as the foundation for his teachings. Sāṃkhya emphasizes that the human person consists of two factors. One is the eternal Nature principle, and the other is the eternal Consciousness principle. The Nature of the materiality principle is that we are made from changes momentarily. Everything having form has a beginning followed by continual increments of change, gradually moving from young to old. The other eternal principle, Consciousness, that we are made of has no form and never changes. The function of Consciousness is to enliven the otherwise lifeless Nature. Nature *Prakṛti*, or materiality, and Consciousness *Puruṣa* always work together but do not mix. They are separate principles that exist within proximity and remain separate. Nature is enlivened by the presence of Consciousness, but consciousness is not influenced by Nature or material factors. Consciousness is described as illumination itself. It is like the sun that continually enlivens materiality. Consciousness does not discriminate in the same way as the sun does not discriminate regarding what or whom it shines upon.

8.3 Three Guṇas—Substratum of Creation

Essentially, the three guṇas are of three distinct types. Sattva guṇa is a revealing power of light and clarity. Rajas guṇa is a projecting power of action. Tamas guṇa is a veiling power of dullness and density. Sattva and Tamas are stationary quality, but Rajas are of the quality of action. The three continually flow and change in proportion from moment to moment. Atoms and molecules are created; every form in our world is created. Every form is enlivened by consciousness.

Within the human mind, we are the only forms that can influence our psychology. We can make choices about which guṇa dominates in our mind. No other creature has the capability of understanding that the human has.

It is the form itself that determines the capability of a creature. Form determines the intelligence of every form. A tree grows tall. A tomato plant only produces tomatoes; it will not produce bananas. Yet, it is consciousness that enlivens and reflects the material form. Without consciousness, the plant would not grow; it would die. It is the same for the human. When a person dies, consciousness leaves the body through the air passages or five vāyus.

The three guṇas work together, creating varying proportions of light, dullness, and movement. The resulting combinations are the substratum of every aspect and dimension of life. The Rajo-guṇa moves between Sato-guṇa and Tamo-guṇa, continually reorganizing the proportions. The result of the changing and varying qualities is the phenomena of each season, object, creature, thought, emotion, form, and more. The

proportions are seen in the uniqueness of plants, animals, humans, processes, formations, sensations, intellect, egos, will, thoughts, emotions, and all that is animate and inanimate (Larson, 1987).

Humans are the last creatures to evolve and have the most advanced intellectual capabilities. Unlike other creatures, humans can determine their path in life. People can choose, delve into a subject, and create unique systems. No matter how simple or complex a creature is, the physical and neurological form will be pervaded by consciousness, which is the essential factor that enlivens. Nature does not enliven. Nature only works due to the presence of illumination. Humans, having the most advanced intellect, neurological system, and form, can discern and discriminate, unlike other creatures. Hence, humans can discern, plan, achieve, and grow in knowledge. Humans can discern between the aspects that characterize each of the three *guṇas*. They can come to know whether their senses, their intellect, and their ego are more *Sattvic*, *Rajasic*, or *Tamasic*. With this knowledge and mental intention, humans can shift their minds to select by choice the dominance of a particular *guṇa*. (Gramann, 2016; Larson, 1969).

It could seem that the essence of light, motion, and dullness (*sattva*, *rajas*, *tamas*) is a substratum of cosmic forces residing only in the sky, but the *guṇas* are universal and apparent on Earth in every form. That which is subtle and detected through the five senses are none other than the three *guṇas* in different manifestations.

Light, kinetic movements, and inertia seem best understood according to their operations. Example: Trees can be described according to varying proportions of light, movement, and dullness. The spectrum of colours in the tree is the “light,” “Action” is in the movement of growth and decay and the motion of air as it moves the leaves. “Dullness or inertia” is apparent in the tree’s mass and density. Each is unique in characteristics of size and shape.

Figure 8.1 shows *Sattva* *guṇa* as an orange colour of light, closest to the radiating sun, and having the power to reveal and give clarity. *Rajas* *guṇa* is red because the action can create heat and project due to radiation of the heat. *Tamas* *guṇa* is the black colour, absent of light; therefore, it is the veiling quality of ignorance.

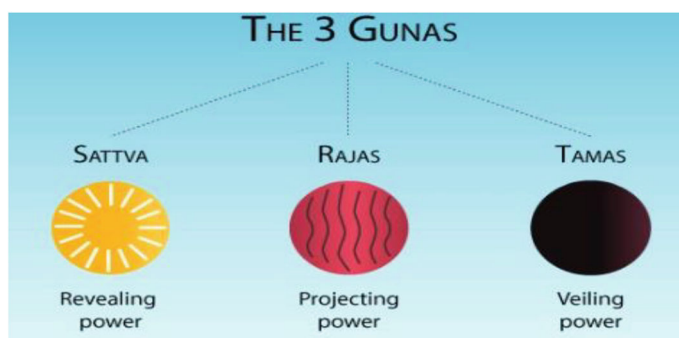


Fig. 8.1 Dimensions of categories

8.4 Essential Qualities of the Guṇas

The qualities of Sato-guṇa embody that which we desire in a harmonious life. This includes clarity, intelligence, pleasantry, attention, truth, and happiness. The qualities of Tamo-guṇa are the opposite of Sattva. Tamasic qualities include dullness, density, doubt, confusion, resistance, and indifference. Stability, required for many things to succeed, is also an aspect of tamo-guṇa. Rajo-guṇa, characterized by activity and action, is the transformational agent that moves energy between Sattva and Tamas. Example: The state of sleep is an example of tamo-guṇa predominance, yet the proportions of guṇas during sleep describe the quality of sleep (Satyasangananda, 1984).

Tamasic guṇa brings a heaviness to the body and mind necessary for sleep; rajasic guṇa is the amount of restlessness and dreaming; sattvic guṇa is the degree of pleasantry and peacefulness of the sleep. Throughout one night of sleep, the guṇa predominance might shift many times or a few times. This can depend on several factors, including physiology based on food eaten that day, mental and emotional mindset, and psychological mood (Gramann, 2016).

Thoughts, emotions, and actions result from the shifting proportions of the three guṇas. Diverse types of dreams can be characterized by the dominance of one guṇa and supported by the other two. Never separate, the guṇas operate together as the cause and manifestation of the entire world, seen and unseen.

Rajas moves between sattva and tamas, continually seeking balance among the three guṇas. This shifts the dominance and proportion among the guṇas in the cosmos and mind. Does light, kinetics, and inertia work together in the same way, according to the science of physics (Steinhardt & Turok, 2007)?

8.5 First Creation of the Guṇas—Five Elements

The first creation performed by the three energetics was the five elements: ether/space, air, fire, water, and earth. Could this be considered a parallel for what science calls the “big bang”? The five elements, in turn, became the process of evolution for the rest of creation.

In science, the table of elements identifies 92 + basic substances. It would be an interesting study to explore the makeup of all elements identified by science—relative to their varying combinations of the five basic elements. This would mean hydrogen, nitrogen, carbon, etcetera, each have a quality and quantity unique to the five basic elements. Gaseous formations will contain more ether and air, volatile formations will contain more fire, and dense formations will contain more water and earth. Earth is an element which consists of all five elemental substances. For instance, soil has solidity; it holds water; it can be porous like air; it has ether/space between granules, and it holds heat, a quality of fire (Chakravarti, 1951; Larson, 1961).

8.6 Trigūṇas Affect Cognition, Motivation, and Change

Humans have a psycho-physiological constitution enabling them to achieve goals, make choices, plan, and live according to a particular lifestyle. The human form is characterized by a complex nervous system and psyche with varying qualities and proportions of light, motion, and dullness. No one is found to be exactly like another in form, nervous system, or psyche because of the constant shifting guṇas. This action is due to rajas pulling between sattva and tamas. Consider the example of the differences in guṇa quality and quantity that occur between an athlete and an engineering professional. The athlete will have more rajasic physical movement, but the engineer will have more rajasic mental activity. Even in the situation of twin infants, each is born with a unique psychophysiology.

Figure 8.2 illustrates the three guṇas relative to movement and dominance. Rajas continually moves and pulls. Correspondingly, increases and decreases occur in the proportions of Sattva and Tamas. Any of the three guṇas may be dominant in position, and the other two supportive. The guṇas remain together like a braid or rope of three strands. This underlies the claim and feeling that change occurs in everything from moment to moment, including in the human mind. So also, the question arises whether there is a way to control the energetics that continually flow into the mind.

The human mind is complex, and each person, as explained, is unique, with varying tendencies and abilities. Yet each person's mind consists of three aspects that work together. These are the senses, the intellect, and the ego, called *antaḥkaraṇa*. Basically, the senses and manas gather content and information from the external environment or memory. The intellect buddhi identifies and analyses the content, and the ego (ahāṅkāra) either accepts or rejects the results from the intellect. This is a process that describes the three aspects of the mind working together as one unit (Gramann, 2013).

Citta is the relationship of the mind to the three guṇas. Having three aspects, the mind can manage the influence of the three cosmic guṇas that continually enter and affect cognition. Two people with the same subject content in their minds but holding different dominance of the guṇas will view situations differently, reflecting differences in clarity, interest, and understanding.

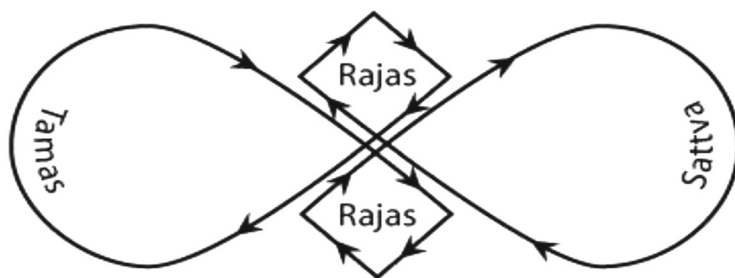


Fig. 8.2 Dimensions of dynamism

Another example: Even though it is dark outside (tamasic energy) in the early morning, the sattvic-intentioned mind can get up more easily than the tamasic-intentioned mind. A sattvic-intentioned mind accompanied by rajas will find it easier to make changes. A tamasic attitude of mind will have more resistance and find reasons to defend procrastination. In the above example, though the atmosphere of the early morning may be tamasic due to darkness or heaviness due to the season, the sattvic mind can override the influence of the tamasic energy more easily. So, a person can have more influence on one's mindset, feelings, and emotions by increasing awareness about the qualities of the *guṇas* and engaging in appropriate action that increases the desired result (Bhawuk, 2008, p. 390).

People with much tamasic energy can make new decisions and choices by shifting their intentions and desire to be more sattvic. By so doing, lethargic energy will be reduced, and simultaneously, an increase in rajasic action will occur. The will contained in the ego has the last say, as it accepts or rejects the intellect's intentions and ways of viewing situations. It is this very process that allows a person to make choices, change, organize, focus, increase attention, acquire skills, and more.

Example: It is moderately raining, and it is time to leave the house. With a sattvic dominant attitude, a person thinks this is no problem, and the person unites with rajasic energy to feel okay about leaving the house. On the contrary, a tamasic attitude will more likely hold back with resistance and prefer to wait out the rain. The sattvic dominant mind will seek to keep the mind pleasant. A tamasic attitude will have more doubt, dullness, attachment, and resistance.

Looking closely at varying creatures, structures, and seasons, the qualities of light, darkness, density, ignorance, resistance, and more can reveal one's awareness and perceptions. Examining and self-determining the *guṇas* you want to characterize your life is most efficacious. In this way, a person with a sattvic mentality coupled with appropriate rajas can live in the present and have more presence of mind, finding it easier to conduct their life more consciously (Potter et al., 1987).

Sattva and rajas working together characterize a close relationship to the principle of consciousness or illumination. The motivation and qualities needed for developing concentration, focus, attention, clarity, making changes, and achieving aims can be found here.

In the case of ordinary life filled with routine, the mind can become bored and stressed. Negative thinking and depression can set in. In this instance, if the mind's thoughts and emotions are examined, it will become apparent which *guṇa* is dominant.

Depression has a tamasic density and lethargy, too. By making a mental intention to be more sattvic, the mind begins to have more sattvic feelings of lightness and less oppression. Following a transformation, emotions of well-being and happiness make a person more active. Here, the psycho-physiological *guṇas* in the mind-body have shifted from tamasic to sattva plus rajas, directed by the will (Rao, 2005).

The three *guṇas* can be viewed as a psychological tool and a model for transformation. The will to increase sattvic qualities of light and inspiration can be used as an experiment. By observing the effects of willful intentions, a person feels happier

about oneself and has the power to make choices that affirm preferences to live, work, and interact consciously.

The sattvic energy plus appropriate rajas energy is closely aligned with the cosmic principle of consciousness. It can become the path to the spiritual heart and final liberation. On the other hand, tamasic energy is based on inappropriate clinging and paves the way for more pain and suffering.

Yoga, pranayama, meditation, self-reflection, and determination are tools that shift dullness into activity and light. In this way, tamo-guṇa is transformed into rajo-guṇa and sato-guṇa. The results will be more psychological clarity and action (Gramann, 2016).

8.7 Each Guṇa Characterized—by Different Set of Qualities

Sattva is characterized by intelligibility, pleasantry, attention, concentration, happiness, clarity, light and lightness, and related qualities and virtues.

Rajas is an active force and influence. It includes all types of actions from slow to speed. It includes the practice of pranayama. It continually pulls in a magnetic way between sattva and tamas, which are stationary forces.

Tamas is characterized by density, inertia, lassitude, mass, indifference, confusion, doubt, oversleeping, addictions, and clinging attachments (Rao et al., 2008).

8.8 Antaḥkaraṇa—Aspects of the Mind

The constituents of the human mind are said to consist of four aspects. These are the five senses: manas, the intellect buddhi, the ego ahaṅkāra, and the mind's relationship to the guṇas chit or citta. Within this structure of the mind is how a person lives and makes choices.

The guṇas work as a cosmic phenomenon, pervading every form, characterized by a continual flow of innumerable proportions. The flow also pervades the minds of humans, whereby our thoughts, desires, and intentions are influenced. However, we humans have a will and can direct our minds. We can coordinate with the proportion of the flow of the three guṇas at any one moment in time, or we can choose a direction of our own making.

Suppose before you sleep at night, you decide to awaken and arise at five am in the morning. Five a.m. is generally characterized as a more tamasic dominate hour. You can either fall back to sleep at this tamasic time or suggest to yourself that you prefer to be more sattvic. With this mind's suggestion, you can more easily get up. Accompanying the act of getting up, the rajas guṇa chips away at tamas, decreasing its

influence. Simultaneously, the sattvic proportion increases. Rajas continually move between sattva and tamas, and innumerable proportions of the three guṇas occur.

At the same time, consciousness is illuminating the flow of the changing guṇas. We, as humans, naturally want a more pleasant, success-filled life. Reducing the amount of tamas in our lives is the key to activating the rajas with the dominance of Sattva. This combination is the best to bring the kind of life that has clarity, goodness, and satisfaction (Potter et al., 1987).

8.9 Transformation—Mental and Emotional Change

It is stated in the Sāṃkhya-kārikā of Īśvarakṛṣṇa that Sattva dominance increases in totality by living a Sattva-dominated life combined with Rajas. This combination is also closest to the Consciousness Purush principle, the principle that increases enlightenment, intelligence, appropriate dispassion, and final liberation.

So here it can be seen that it is a choice that humans can make to influence their psycho-physiological and emotional well-being by coordinating their lifestyle and aims with more sattvic-rajas energetics. Nearly everyone has ideals they want to realize but do not put any action to their ideals. When the sattva is added, the motivation of rajas is not far behind, and the tamasic inertia begins to be chipped away. Realizing that choice is possible by desiring to be more sattvic is the key to change and transformation. Reduction of pain and an increase of happiness makes a person feel more free and closer to Consciousness. (Rao et al., 2008).

8.10 Summary and Implications

In conclusion, the effect of three cosmic energetics on our psyche and our lives is all-encompassing. Whether it is considered a discovery by science or a cosmological substratum, the qualities of light, action, and dullness are present in our world_externally and psychologically. The three key qualities continually shape, guide, and influence our lives. However, as humans, we are the only species that can direct the cosmological guṇas that flow in our mind. A one-pointed mind can influence the proportions of the three guṇa-energetics in one's mind, simultaneously increasing mental clarity, physical energy, or ability to do whatever is needed.

Increasing knowledge about the qualities, dimensions, and interactions of the guṇas can also increase knowledge about oneself. Through a willful desire to increase intentions and methods of light/sato-guṇa, there will be an increase in kinetics/rajo-guṇa and an automatic reduction in dullness/tamo-guṇa. This essay indicates a philosophical and working model to motivate oneself to become a co-creator of one's quality of life.

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Chapter 9

The Hermeneutic Phenomenology of the Sāṃkhya Philosophy



S. Panneerselvam

Abstract Hermeneutic phenomenology gives priority to the historical symbolization of understanding over the pure interiority of consciousness. One can show how both hermeneutic as well as phenomenological trends are visible in the ancient system of Sāṃkhya. The approach of Sāṃkhya about *puruṣa* is a unique contribution of the system. It talks about the contentless consciousness. Sāṃkhya supports the realistic philosophy since there is the acceptance of the objective world. One of the important problems that is discussed in Sāṃkhya is the nature of pure consciousness which could be compared with the Husserlian phenomenology. Husserl says that the intentional act not only objectivates but also establishes the identity between two objects, which are transcendental to it. With the Husserlian background, one can see the phenomenology that is visible in Sāṃkhya philosophy. The nature of consciousness in Sāṃkhya is explained in terms of pure passive presence (*sākṣitva*), incapable of any activity (*akartṛbhāva*), and the foundation for subjectivity or pure consciousness (*draṣṭṛtva*) and is different from the tripartite process.

Keywords Hermeneutic phenomenology · Contentless consciousness · Intentional Act · Fundamental and foundational consciousness · Pure self

9.1 Introduction

Hermeneutic Phenomenology is a new philosophical tradition created by the synthesis of two different continental orientations. In the writings of Schleiermacher and Dilthey, we see a new direction to hermeneutics, which may be termed a hermeneutic theory of interpretation. Similarly, the phenomenological orientations with the background of Husserl, Heidegger, and Gadamer have shaped thinkers like Ricoeur very much to formulate the “hermeneutic phenomenology,” which is the result of these two different continental traditions. However, it should be noted that it is not simply a synthesis of two traditions. It is much more than this. For example,

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romantic hermeneutics viewed the historical “distanciation” of meaning as a threat to reflective subjectivity. Ricoeur’s “hermeneutic phenomenology” gives priority to the historical symbolization of understanding over the pure interiority of consciousness. Thus one can see the revision of both the phenomenological and hermeneutic traditions. The entire phenomenological movement owes a lot to Heidegger. According to Heidegger, phenomenology in its essence, is hermeneutic. It is a study concerned with phenomena as they are directly given to our experiences and whose ruling motive is to be faithful to those phenomena in their self-governance. There is original and immediate access to the phenomena. Phenomenal description is an immediate beholding thus making it different from interpreting. Heidegger argues that the need for phenomenology is to be hermeneutic. For him, all phenomenological methods are to be hermeneutical. Phenomenology is committed to the new form of “concrete thinking.” It is the method developed by Edmund Husserl at the beginning of the century. But this method of Husserl took different directions in the hands of Heidegger, Sartre, Merleau-Ponty, Gadamer, and others. These are the multiple interpretations of phenomenology. Heidegger applied the method to the question of Being, Sartre to the question of human freedom, Merleau-Ponty to the question of our bodily relationship to the world and Gadamer to the method of hermeneutical interpretation of tradition and understanding. Heidegger explained the need for all interpretations to rise from a previous understanding. He openly refuted the idea that understanding can be presuppositionless. “All interpretation is grounded in a fore-sight and a fore-conception,” says Heidegger.¹

The Sāṃkhya philosophy occupies a unique place in the philosophical discourse of India. As a dualistic school, it gives a methodology for understanding life as it is based on the acceptance of matter and spirit which is often highlighted in the Western tradition. The influence of Sāṃkhya on other Indian schools of philosophy is remarkable as it speaks about Indian culture and human values. Gopinath Kaviraja says that it is not one of the ancient philosophies of India but Sāṃkhya is *the* philosophy of India. It has a greater impact on Indian culture and the lived experience of human beings. K.C. Bhattacharya is of the view that Sāṃkhya represents a “constructive and bold philosophy,” and also points out that the role of the interpreter in understanding the Sāṃkhya system is important.² Many other scholars like Garbe, S.N. Dasgupta and others have argued in favour of a “reconstructive approach” in the philosophy of Sāṃkhya. The influence of Sāṃkhya on other schools is very significant as Śāṅkara says that to demolish the school of Sāṃkhya is to demolish by implication the other schools of Indian philosophical thought.

The main objective of this paper is to show how both hermeneutic as well as phenomenological trends are visible in the ancient system of Sāṃkhya. Though the aim is not to say that what the continental thinkers have said has been, long back anticipated in Indian philosophy, especially, in Sāṃkhya; one can attempt to show

¹ Heidegger (1962, p. 190).

² Larson and Bhattacharya, (ed.), (1987, p. 44).

how some parallels are visible in these two traditions, the Western as well as Indian. Emphasising the importance of this comparative perspective, B. K. Matilal observes that it is philosophically important to ponder over the question of why very similar puzzles evoke different responses from different people.³

9.2 Indian Hermeneutics: Tools for Interpreting Sāṃkhya System

It is argued by many thinkers that many of the characteristic notions of the Sāṃkhya were central to the later issues of Indian philosophy.⁴ K.C. Bhattacharya argues that much of Sāṃkhya literature appears to have been lost and there seems to be no continuity of tradition from ancient times up to the age of commentators.⁵ Thus the role of commentators plays a significant role in understanding the system. K.C. Bhattacharya further argues that the interpretation of any ancient system requires a constructive effort.⁶ He says that the construction in many places involves supplying missing links from one's imagination. The missing link has to be completed by the commentator according to the principles of hermeneutics. Here the three perspectives given by Gerald James Larson and Ram Shankar Bhattacharya about the reading of the Sāṃkhya have to be taken seriously. They are the cultural historian's perspective, the perspective of the historian of philosophy, and the perspective of a pure philosopher. For a cultural historian, Sāṃkhya provides an interpretive perspective which can help in understanding religion, art, law, mythology, etc. For the historian of Indian philosophy, Sāṃkhya provides a sharper awareness of the network of archaic notions and values which are necessary for the systematic understanding of Indian philosophy. For a pure philosopher, Sāṃkhya provides a better grasp of understanding concepts like being, non-being, change, causality, etc.⁷

The significance of interpretation in understanding the texts and a system has been emphasised by K.C. Bhattacharya in his way. He says that the interpreter must engage in "supplying of missing links from one's imagination."⁸ This statement of K.C. Bhattacharya has a lot of implications in the context of interpretational theory. This means "searching for relations, bundles of relations and possible interpretive perspectives that may not be directly expressed in the text, but that bring together into more coherent patterns."⁹ In hermeneutic understanding, the meaning of text as well as interpretation plays an important role. The textual tradition allows us to interpret the text. Sometimes, multiple interpretations of the text are evident in Indian

³ Matilal and Shaw, (ed.), (1985, p. 1).

⁴ Larson and Bhattacharya, (ed.), (1987), op.cit. p. 44.

⁵ Ibid.

⁶ Ibid.

⁷ Ibid.

⁸ Ibid., p. 45.

⁹ Ibid., pp. 45–46.

tradition. The text, *Yuktidīpikā* for example, gives multiple interpretations in understanding the Sāṃkhya system. Similarly the work, *Tattvayāthārthyadīpana* interprets Sāṃkhya by using the Vedāntic methodology. Though this Vedāntic interpretation is not intended by the original text or by the author, it must be admitted that it gives space for more than one interpretation of the age-old Sāṃkhya system. Another important aspect which is significant in hermeneutical understanding is the concept of “reconstruction.” The reconstructive approach is very much visible in Sāṃkhya which has been discussed by thinkers like Richard Garbe, S. Dasgupta, E. Frauwallner and K.C. Bhattacharya. For example, Garbe shows how while reading the Sāṃkhya system as an ancient system, one has to take into account the entire Sāṃkhya literature to reconstruct it. This is nothing but the “whole-part relation” which is highlighted in the hermeneutic tradition, according to which that to understand the whole, we must know the parts and vice-versa. Garbe argues that one has to read the entire literature to reconstruct a system. A piecemeal approach can never help us in understanding the tradition. Similarly, Dasgupta points out that the Sāṃkhya system could be better understood through the interpretive perspective of Vedāntic metaphysics. K.C. Bhattacharya says that the Sāṃkhya system is a bold “philosophy of the subject” based on the speculative insight that demands imaginative introspective effort at every stage on the part of the interpreter.”¹⁰ The conceptual system of Sāṃkhya has undergone modification and we have to take into account all these factors while studying a system like Sāṃkhya.

Kapila, the founder of this system wrote the important work, *Sāṃkhya-sūtras*. It is said that this being a very brief and terse text, Kapila wrote another, but elaborate work entitled, *Sāṃkhya-pravacana-sūtras*. His disciple, Asuri and his disciple, Pañcaśikha wrote on the *Sāṃkhya-sūtras* of Kapila. Unfortunately, these works were lost and Īśvarakṛṣṇa’s *Sāṃkhya-kārika* is considered to be an important text on the Sāṃkhya tradition. Later works like Gaudapāda’s *Sāṃkhya-kārika bhāṣya* and Vācaspati’s *Tattvakaumudī* are important in understanding the Sāṃkhya tradition. One of the important tools for understanding philosophical hermeneutics is the notion of tradition, the other two being, interpretation and understanding, and language. Tradition plays an important role in understanding the text as well as the particular school of thought. The tradition is transmitted from generation to generation providing space for reasoning, without losing its vitality.¹¹ The commentaries perform the role of interpretation. In Western hermeneutics, the method of interpretation has been the nucleus point. Schlerimachar says that hermeneutics is the art of “avoiding misunderstanding.” This means that the reader or the interpreter should interpret the text in a meaningful way, not deviating from the tradition. The Indian hermeneuticians go beyond this to show how the interpretation or commentaries function at two levels: (1) the first-order commentary and (2) the second-order commentary. The commentary otherwise traditionally known as *Bhāṣya*, is the basic sutra-work which is the first-order commentary. A *Bhāṣya* is expected to bring out the meanings of the words of the text, the context, and the purpose of the text. The second-order commentary plays

¹⁰ Ibid., pp. 46–47.

¹¹ Balasubramanian (2008, p. 14).

an important role in the tradition which is known as *vārtika*. A *vārtika* is defined as a commentary which examines what is said (*ukta*), what is not said, and what is not well said (*durukta*) in the original. Thus, a *vārtika*, has threefold work, first by explaining the original text, secondly by supplementing it, and thirdly by offering alternative interpretations not mentioned in the original.¹² The distinction between the first and the second-order commentary is the unique contribution of Indian hermeneutics. The creativity of Indian hermeneutics is that since it is not mere “interpretation,” which is largely discussed in Western hermeneutics, the *vārtika* work is the “interpretation of interpretation” which plays an important role, thus not deviating from the original text.

Īśvarakṛṣṇa’s *Sāṃkhya-kārika* presents the philosophical discourse of the Sāṃkhya system that prevailed in ancient days. Though the date of the above work is not known exactly, the commentary and translation of the work in Chinese by Paramātha during 557–569 shows that the work can be placed in the middle of the fourth century. One important commentary on the above work is *Suvarṇasaptati* which again is a Chinese translation. Garba points out that in *Arthasāstra* of Kautilya which emerged during 300 BC, three systems are mentioned, namely, Sāṃkhya, Yoga, and Lokāyata. This shows that Sāṃkhya is one of the oldest philosophical systems of India. It is also said by scholars those philosophical ideas of Sāṃkhya are found in pre-Buddhistic literature which proves the antiquity of the system.

The work, *Sāṃkhya-kārika* speaks about how all-pervasive principles, namely, pure consciousness (*puruṣa*) and one primordial materiality (*mūlaprakṛti*), which is made up of three *guṇas*, i.e., *sattva*, *rajas*, and *tamas*. For the Sāṃkhyas, *kaivalya* is possible only through discrimination between *puruṣa* and *prakṛti*, i.e., the spirit and matter. Through *aviveka*, non-discrimination, the *puruṣa* identifies itself with *prakṛti*. The relation between spirit and matter is one of the key factors of the Sāṃkhya system. It can be said that though there is a distinction between matter and spirit, as a dualistic system, it talks about the materiality of the spirit and spirituality of the matter. The self is neither bound nor released and both release and bondage and rebirth are the actions of *prakṛti*.¹³ Once the self understands the real nature of *prakṛti*, ignorance is removed. It is said that like a dancer who disappears from the stage after entertaining the spectators, the *prakṛti* disappears after the rise of discrimination.¹⁴ The ultimate aim of the system is to show the significance of *kaivalya*. Thus, while talking about the distinction between transcendent consciousness and primordial materiality and its three constituents, the Sāṃkhya system emphasizes the significance of transcendental consciousness.

It is claimed that Vedānta absorbed the conceptual structure of Sāṃkhya.¹⁵ It is argued by scholars that sometimes, Sāṃkhya is seen through the prism of Vedānta which is not correct, thereby destroying the independent nature of Sāṃkhya which is unique in Indian philosophical tradition. To “Vedānticise” Sāṃkhya is to swallow

¹² Ibid., p. 16.

¹³ Virupakshananda (2019), *Sāṃkhya-kārika*, 62. Henceforth, *Sāṃkhya-kārika*.

¹⁴ *Sāṃkhya-kārika*, 50.

¹⁵ Larson and Bhattacharya, (ed.), 1987, *Sāṃkhya*, op.cit, p. 30.

the independent nature of the system and by giving the Advaitic colouring, we ignore the valuable contribution of the Sāṃkhya which is a systematic reflection of Indian philosophy.¹⁶ As a dualistic system, it speaks about *puruṣa* (pure consciousness) and one primordial materiality (*mūlaprakṛti*), which is made up of three *guṇas*, *sattva*, *rajas*, and *tamas*. Though it talks about twenty-five principles, only the first two are independent existents and they are separate from one another. While commenting on this, *Sāṃkhya-kārika*¹⁷ says that they are ungenerated, stable, without parts, and independent. The relation between them is that of simple “co-presence.” According to Sāṃkhya, pure consciousness is inherently inactive, whereas primordial materiality is inherently generative. It is capable of generating a set of manifest divisions when activated by the catalytic presence of pure consciousness. The nature of pure consciousness is that it is non-intentional and it is contentless wherein objects are not seen. By saying that is non-intentional, it is different from ordinary mental awareness. The primordial materiality is ungenerated, whereas the intellect, etc., are both generated and generative. It is said that the pure consciousness is neither generated nor generative,¹⁸ (*na prakṛtir na vikṛtiḥ puruṣaḥ*), and also it is different from the tripartite process and transcends all objectivity. The approach of Sāṃkhya about *puruṣa* is no doubt a unique contribution of the system. Now the question that arises here is this: How does the contentless consciousness help the Sāṃkhya? This has to be answered to show its impact on its philosophy. It is said that the primordial materiality and the evolutes are necessary to explain the nature of the empirical world. Thus, it can be said that Sāṃkhya supports the realistic philosophy since there is an acceptance of the objective world. The beauty of the system is that the objective world presupposes that there is something which is not implied in the process and that which is not objective. So, in this system, there is a movement from the objective world to the non-objective since the primordial materiality functions due to the pure consciousness. But here it is essential to understand that the nature of pure consciousness is such that it is non-intentional and is incapable of producing anything. Moreover, the substratum for the primordial materiality is consciousness. The presence of contentless consciousness can only be intuited by the intellect. By accepting the functioning of the objective world, the Sāṃkhya is closer to naturalism and rationalism. Thus the distinction between *puruṣa* and *prakṛti* can be explained in the following way, i.e., *puruṣa* is consciousness, intelligence, the one who witnessed the manifestation of nature, whereas *prakṛti* is non-conscious and non-intelligence. The Sāṃkhya approach to consciousness is one of the boldest steps in the philosophy of India since normally non-dualism is highlighted in Indian philosophy.

The Sāṃkhya system points out that *prakṛti* i.e., matter is singular, eternal, unconscious, and uncreated by power and is the basic stuff. It is impartial and non-intelligent. The *puruṣa* on the other hand, is numerous, conscious, and non-generative. This means that *puruṣa* cannot cause the emergence of things. The *guṇas* are indestructible constituents of nature and function in a state of constant flux

¹⁶ Ibid. p. 46.

¹⁷ *Sāṃkhya-kārika*, 10.

¹⁸ *Sāṃkhya-kārika*, 3.

and change. Kapila points out that there is a complete separation of *puruṣa* and *prakṛti*, though they are in proximity to each other, they are not in actual contact. The *mūlaprakṛti* which is primordial undergoes modification which is manifested in the world and the *puruṣa* begins to witness this transformation. It is shown that *prakṛti* functions because of the presence of *puruṣa*. While it is said that *puruṣa* is consciousness, intelligent, one who witnessed the manifestation of nature, *prakṛti* is non-conscious and non-intelligent. What is generated or what emerges from *prakṛti* is called *vikṛti* says, Kapila. With the cessation of *prakṛti*, the *puruṣa* after attaining separation from the body, attains liberation. Larson says that “the doctrines of Sāṃkhya philosophy are inextricably involved with one another, and one must take them together in order to get the full force of the Sāṃkhya point of view.”¹⁹

9.3 Intentionality of Consciousness: Phenomenological Tools in Sāṃkhya

In the phenomenology of Husserl, consciousness is one of the important aspects of understanding the nature of the empirical world. It is said that the essence of consciousness is “intentionality.” In the *Ideas*, Husserl says: “The essence of consciousness, in which I live as my own self, is the so-called intentionality.”²⁰ The intentionality of consciousness is related to the object. The significance of the content of consciousness is explained in Husserl by showing how human experiences are related to each other. He says that intentionality is the essence of consciousness. The experience of the object is based on the intention of understanding the object. He says: “...in so far as they are conscious of something, they are said to be intentionally referred to this.”²¹ What is highlighted by Husserl is that “of- relation” is the key factor in experiencing something. The issue, namely whether consciousness and knowledge are intentional (*saviṣaya*) is discussed at length by J.N. Mohanty in his work, *Reason and Tradition in Indian Thought*. He asks the question, of whether there is any consciousness that is non-intentional.²² He explains how in systems like Advaita, Sāṃkhya, and Yoga, the nature of pure consciousness is discussed. Here he examines the nature of pure consciousness by making a distinction between “weaker” and “stronger” consciousness. He says that the weaker concept of pure consciousness, though non-intentional by definition, is still individuated. “It has no *viśaya*, i.e., object, but it has an *āśraya* or locus, i.e., it belongs to someone. The stronger pure consciousness has neither *viśaya* nor *āśraya*. It is both non-intentional and non-egological.”²³ Human experience, according to Husserl, is not simply the fact of consciousness, but consciousness is always “consciousness of something.”

¹⁹ Larson and Bhattacharya, (ed.), 1987, Sāṃkhya, op.cit.p. 166.

²⁰ Husserl (2000, p. 112).

²¹ Husserl (1983, p. 73).

²² Mohanty (1992, p. 42).

²³ Ibid.

The essence of consciousness is to intend some object or other. Our experience is based on our projection towards the intended object. This means that for Husserl, the essence of consciousness is intentionality. By intentionality, he means that any object of my consciousness (for example, a tree, or building), is something meant and constructed which is intended by me. It cannot be denied that the possibility of pure consciousness must start from ordinary experience.

One of the important problems that is discussed in Sāṃkhya is the nature of pure consciousness which could be compared in the Husserlian phenomenology. Husserl says that the intentional act not only objectivates but also establishes the identity between two objects, which are transcendental to it. With the Husserlian background, one can see the phenomenology that is visible in Sāṃkhya philosophy. It is interesting to note that the Sāṃkhya system talks about a contentless consciousness. It is to be seen what kind of contentless consciousness they are talking about. The Sāṃkhya philosophy can be argued in terms of “contentless consciousness” as well as “content-consciousness.” When they are talking in terms of primordial materiality, the role of “content-consciousness” is evident, since it is here, that we have transactions with the objective world and it is here the objects are presented to consciousness. The Husserlian notion of “of relation” is very much present. It is here consciousness is intentional. In the Western tradition, there is a dualist position, especially in the writings of Descartes, Kant and Husserl. Two radically different kinds of realities namely, matter and spirit are highlighted. For example, in the West, we see the distinction between the physical and the mental as in the case of Descartes, and to some extent in Plato. The Kantian distinction between noumenon and phenomenon, and the phenomenological dualism of noesis and noema are often used by scholars to compare them with the dualistic methodology of Sāṃkhya. Though this approach is somewhat similar to the Sāṃkhya position, it is to be noted that there is a major distinction between the Western position and the position of Sāṃkhya. In Sāṃkhya, the primordial matter undergoes a continuous transformation. The dualism which Sāṃkhya supports can be explained in this way. The contentless consciousness is essential according to the Sāṃkhya and it is non-intentional and incapable of producing anything; there should exist a sentient principle that by its mere presence exercised a function of passive overseeing. Moreover, there must be a substratum that is beneficial to the awareness of primordial materiality. Consciousness is contentless, non-intentional, and incapable of performing any activity and it cannot know or intuit itself. But can be intuited by the intellect that it is not consciousness. The presence of consciousness is an awareness that occurs within the intellect, an awareness that the intellect itself is not consciousness. The relation between contentless consciousness and primordial materiality is often compared to spectator and materiality is the dancer dancing. Consciousness is also compared to that of the young calf, and matter to milk, and also to that of master and servant.²⁴

It is necessary to compare the Advaitic position with that of the Sāṃkhya in the context of consciousness. It is argued by many scholars that the Advaitins have not rejected the Sāṃkhya theory of *prakṛti*. The Sāṃkhya argues in favour of plurality of

²⁴ Sāṃkhya-kārika, 13 and 21.

consciousness. It is contentless and hence cannot be known through materiality. The nature of pure consciousness is often compared with that of the Advaitic Vedāntic notion of self. It is argued that the Self becomes not-self because of its relation with the bodily adjuncts. Though this appears similar to that of the Sāṃkhyas, there is a major difference. The Sāṃkhyas talk about the plurality of consciousness, whereas in the pure consciousness state of Advaita, the plurality of consciousness is denied. The nature of consciousness in Sāṃkhya is explained in terms of pure passive presence (*sākṣī*), incapable of any activity (*akartṛbhāva*), and the foundation for subjectivity or pure consciousness (*Draṣṭṛ*) and is different from the tripartite process.²⁵ Thus the Sāṃkhyas make it clear that pure consciousness falls outside the causality, space and time, inactive, without parts, completely independent. Moreover, it is neither an object nor a subject and completely is indifferent. When the Sāṃkhya speak about primordial materiality they give enough scope to accept the ordinary experience. It is here one can see the phenomenology of Sāṃkhya. Moreover, the relation between contentless consciousness and primordial materiality is like between a lame and blind man wherein it is said that one needs the support of the other. This example clearly shows that one needs to be supported by the other which is essential. The distinction between the “functional consciousness” (in three states of experience) and “foundational consciousness” (in *turīya*) is not like that of the relation which is given in the Sāṃkhya system. When the Sāṃkhya talks about pure consciousness, it is clear that they are talking in terms of non-intentional consciousness. For them, the external world is fully real and its existence cannot be denied.

9.4 Sāṃkhya and Advaita: Two Paradigms of Interpreting Consciousness

While dealing with the problematic of the enworlded subjectivity, the Advaitins argue that this involves two notions, worldliness, or embeddedness on the one hand, and subjectivity on the other, which do not go together and create tension in our understanding.²⁶ For them, consciousness is the subjectivity and it is transempirical, trans relational, and hence is disembodied. Thus, the Advaitins make a distinction between embodied and disembodied and they see that there is a dichotomy between these two. But when they claim that there is the involvement of consciousness in the objects of the world. i.e., when consciousness becomes worldly. The question which is raised by the Advaitin is this: “How is it possible that consciousness, which is essentially different from everything else presented to it as its objects, gets itself, involved in the objects of the world surrounding it, losing its identity in such a way that it is not reckoned as an entity in its own right along with other objects?”²⁷

²⁵ Sāṃkhya-kārika, 19.

²⁶ Balasubramanian, (ed.), (2006, p. xxxiii).

²⁷ Ibid., p. Xxxiii–xxxiv.

According to a well-known Advaitin R. Balasubramanian, there is a dichotomy between consciousness and what is presented to consciousness. This distinction, otherwise known as the distinction between “*asmad*” and “*yusmad*,” is the subject and the object, or the Self and the not-self. He contends: “Absorbed as we are in our day-to-day life under the overwhelming influence of an attitude, which is native and natural, we fail to notice the radical distinction between the subject and the object, and confuse and mix up the one with the other. The native and natural mode of thinking and its resultant activity are due to our ignorance of the Self, the pure consciousness, the transcendental subjectivity.”²⁸ According to him, something is known through consciousness, and it is only through consciousness, that something is accepted or rejected. In this context, he talks about the “intentionality of consciousness.” Interestingly, the intentional performance is not ascribed to the pure Self or consciousness, but only to consciousness associated with the ego or “I” which is transcendent to consciousness. There is no problem for one to accept the intentionality of consciousness because here one accepts consciousness about some object or other. This position would be acceptable to Sāṃkhya also since they also believe that in the primordial materiality, the world is known through experience, and hence, the intentionality of consciousness, which Husserl speaks of, is acceptable. But the problem comes when the Advaitins take the notion of consciousness further to argue that there can be consciousness, which is devoid of objects and things. For Husserl and Sartre, consciousness is always “consciousness *of* something” which has been already shown at the beginning of the paper. While writing about Husserl’s position, it is said: “The intentional act not only objectivates but also establishes the identity between two objects, which are, transcend to it. Further, it connects one aspect of the intentional object with its other aspects through ‘fulfilment.’ Finally, it ‘constitutes’ the intentional object. As a result of these features introduced by Husserl, the intentional object, we have to say, is known only as what the intentional act makes it: it becomes something constituted by the intentional consciousness.”²⁹ We need to see the position of Advaita as well as Sāṃkhya to see the role of intentionality of consciousness. The Advaitins make the distinction between the pure consciousness and the intentionality of consciousness. Advaita is interested in the question, of whether consciousness per se is intentional or whether the ego-consciousness is intentional. According to Advaita, consciousness per se is not intentional but it becomes intentional because of the ego. Is there any evidence to say based on a thoroughgoing application of the phenomenological method that consciousness is always and necessarily consciousness *of* something? Consciousness in the waking experience as well as in the dream experience, is always consciousness *of* something and hence it is intentional. But in the case of dreamless sleep, it is not so. Here no object is presented to consciousness but it does not mean that consciousness is absent. R. Balasubramanian says: “The point is that consciousness reveals objects if they are present; and when there are no objects to be revealed, consciousness remains alone...Consciousness becomes intentional only as a result of its association with the

²⁸ Balasubramanian (1992, p. 77).

²⁹ Ibid., p. 81.

mind, and it has this connection with the mind in waking and dream experiences. But in deep sleep experience, mind as mind is absent with the result that consciousness remains alone without being intentional.”³⁰

Thus for R. Balasubramanian, the position maintained by Husserl and Sartre, namely that intentionality is essential to consciousness and consciousness is defined by intentionality is not acceptable to Advaita. For the Advaitins, that intentionality is not essential, but only adventitious to consciousness. This position is acceptable neither to Husserl nor to the Sāṃkhya system. “While it is true that there is no phenomenon without consciousness, there is no phenomenological evidence to say that there is no consciousness without the phenomenon.”³¹ But the question is this: Can consciousness be non-intentional? Since consciousness cannot be empty, it must be always relational and hence intentional. Bare consciousness which is devoid of objects is not acceptable. It is always related to some object or other. The uniqueness of consciousness is this “of relation,” which has not been taken seriously by the Advaitins. Moreover, if consciousness were something, which exists apart from myself, independent of my own, then one can always question the validity and the use of such consciousness. Śaṅkara might say that consciousness is the basis of proof, and so it is established before the process of proof. “The Self does not wait on a means to know it.”³² This will not solve the problem. Here one can say that Sāṃkhya’s position is more acceptable than Śaṅkara’s for the main reason that Sāṃkhya admits that consciousness is always relational. Because consciousness is always related to objects and hence intentionality is said to be the fundamental characteristic of consciousness. Otherwise, consciousness becomes abstract and not useful for our experience of the empirical world. For the Advaitins, consciousness is transcendental which means it is devoid of all characteristics (nirviśeṣa) which Samkhya would reject. Thus one can see the methodology of the Sāṃkhya system very well fits in with the phenomenology of Husserl and not the position taken by the Advaitins.

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³⁰ Ibid., p. 83.

³¹ Balasubramanian, 1992, op.cit., p. 83.

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Chapter 10

Consciousness and Causation in Sāṃkhya



Saroj Kanta Kar 

Abstract The article ponders over the most debatable aspects of Sāṃkhya philosophy. One such issue is whether consciousness can be one of the causes of evolution or not. It resolves with the affirmation that it may be the instrumental cause in the limited sense that its proximity or contact only issues forth the evolution. The second issue is about the nature of that consciousness, which takes part in evolution. Upon this, it is assumed that it is the transcendental consciousness and not the individual one that is the instrumental cause of cosmic evolution. This discourse further focuses on the methodological aspects of the study of Sāṃkhya. In this connection, it distinguishes between different approaches, namely, the Yogic Experiential Approach, Truth-Oriented Approach or Seekers' Approach, Traditional Approach, Textual Approach, Piecemeal Approach and Holistic Approach.

Keywords Samavāyi kāraṇa · Upādāna kāraṇa · Sahakārī kāraṇa · Nimitta kāraṇa · Saṃnidhi

10.1 Introduction

Consciousness or *Puruṣa* is one of the central realities in Sāṃkhya. Materiality or *Prakṛti* is the other reality, which is highlighted as the cause of the evolved cosmos. The process of evolution sparks up in *Prakṛti* due to the *saṃnidhi* (proximity), *saṃyoga* (connection) or *sparśa* (contact) with the *Puruṣa*, as per the Sāṃkhya Philosophy. For this reason, can *Puruṣa* be considered a cause of the evolution? Further, it is the *Puruṣa*, which is reflected in the evolved materiality. For this reason, why is not *Puruṣa* considered as represented in the evolved? If so, who is that *Puruṣa*, the single, transcendental and absolute one, or the innumerable, multiple ones who are *Buddhas*? Does Sāṃkhya speak of or support these two types of *puruṣas*? If so, which of the consciousnesses can be ascribed to be the cause of the evolution? On these perplexing issues, the present deliberation is an attempt to bring out the role of the

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consciousness or *Puruṣa* in the causation of evolution and its presence parallel to the evolutes, in each evolute. At least it may be considered an instrumental cause (*nimitta kāraṇa*) or supportive cause (*śahakārī kāraṇa*) of evolution, as *Prakṛti* is considered the material cause (*upādāna kāraṇa*).¹ This way, if consciousness becomes the passive cause of evolution, it must be the consciousness that always coexists with the unmanifest *Prakṛti* before evolution. This consciousness, then, must be the primal transcendental consciousness, which is one and not the reflected multiple individual consciousnesses, which are manifested *with*, *after* and *in* the evolution. That evolution may also be called cosmic evolution and the primal consciousness is the cosmic consciousness (*Puruṣa*).² Considering this way, it may be argued that the sense organs, which were relevant to the multiple individual consciousnesses (*puruṣas*), might not have evolved at once in the cosmic evolution, because at that phase, multiple consciousnesses were not reflected as multiplicity, and individuality was not evolved. Therefore, these sense organs must have evolved after the individuation and subtle and gross elements and multiple individuations of them. Hence, it is posited that the reflection or presence of consciousness in such multiple individuations as beings are the reason for the evolution of the eleven sense organs (*indriyas*) in the highly evolved beings. Such multiple consciousnesses are taken as immanent aspects of the transcendental, absolute and cosmic consciousnesses, which coexist with unmanifest *Prakṛti*. This is what this discourse humbly attempts to elaborate on. In this direction, it is also necessary to discriminate between the primal transcendental cosmic *Puruṣa* and multiple individual *puruṣas*.³ Before this, it is essential to indicate the proper methodology for studying the comprehensive issues in the compendium of Sāṃkhya as a philosophy by eradicating the modern non-Sankritist scholars' approach which distinguishes classical Sāṃkhya from the latter one, even in all fundamental issues, muddling up the matter. This also presupposes choosing a method of study of issues in the *Sāṃkhya*.

10.2 Methodology of Study of Sāṃkhya

Sāṃkhya Philosophy is unique in the sense that it establishes two absolute realities. It has been elucidated by many scholars, notably by Īśvarakṛṣṇa and explained by Gauḍapāda, Vācaspati Miśra and Vijñānabhikṣu at different times. Subsequent scholars, who practiced Sāṃkhya, not only by intellection but by meditation, and could communicate with the Sanskrit language, have taken Sāṃkhya philosophy as a unique philosophy. However, most English-speaking scholars of today lack

¹ Hiriyanā (1932).

² Larson and Bhattacharya (1987).

³ The expression *Puruṣa* or Consciousness (with always "P" and "C" in the capital) indicates Cosmic and transcendental "*Puruṣa*" or "Consciousness," respectively. The immanent is expressed with normal except in the beginning of the sentences.

the potential to decipher the language. Almost all of them do not have any meditative practice and are influenced by other philosophical viewpoints that they find suitable. When they happen to teach Sāṃkhya to elementary students, they often distort the matter. At times, it happens that ignorant people move in circles like the blind being guided by another blind (*dandramyamāṇā pariyanti mūḍhāḥ andhenaiva niyamānāḥ pathāndhāḥ*).⁴ Hence, proper personality, knowledge, skill and methodology for studying Sāṃkhya (and similar philosophy) are important, at least for this discourse, where the issues concerning consciousness and causation are dealt with, and the subject matter is extended to other fields.

There are many methods adopted for the study of Sāṃkhya. The foremost is the Yogic Experiential Approach. Sāṃkhya Philosophy is the contribution of yogic experiences by Mahārṣi Kapila and similar experiences by its followers. Later on, it was established in a rational argumentative manner. One can touch the spirit of Sāṃkhya if he or she has followed some meditative technique and has experience. For example, the comprehension of “Consciousness alone” without the involvement of *Prakṛti* can be experienced only in a deep level of meditation and not in ordinary experience. Almost all philosophers and thinkers in ancient India have had similar experiences through long meditative practice.⁵ Even some contemporary philosophers are aware of meditative and helpful spiritual practices, by which they achieve yogic experiences, advanced mental faculties, processes, and extraordinary knowledge, and then the comprehension of the Sāṃkhya. Through the long practice of meditation or living with the culture of meditation or yoga as the Sāṃkhya *ācāryas* and their followers, one can comprehend the Sāṃkhya philosophy as the *ācāryas* did. Such practices follow the tradition of comprehension and realization. In earlier times, thinkers, preceptors and pupils adopted meditative practices (as said above) like the Buddha and his followers to neutralize much of the external and internal noises, and to attain purity of mind where the truth could be clearly reflected.

The Truth-Oriented Approach or Seekers’ Approach is different. What is truth? What is reality? Such open-ended questions drive the pursuant, who is the seeker of truth or reality. The original thinkers and pioneers of philosophy were seekers, who went by tradition wholly or partially and reached some intimate levels of truth. Here, one adopted meditation⁶ as well as critical analysis and constant examinations, like in the case of Bhartṛhari, to attain truth. Vijñānabhikṣu, it may be said, adopted this

⁴ *Avidyāyāmantare vartamānāḥ svayaṁ dhīrāḥ paṇḍitaḥ manyamānāḥ |Jaṅghanyamānāḥ pariyanti mūḍhā andhenaiva niyamānā yathāndhāḥ || Muṇḍak.1.2.8 ||* Himself being in the midst of ignorance, yet considering himself intelligent and wise, the ignorant receives trouble, as a blind led by another blind.

⁵ For example, Buddha has learned and succeeded in “meditative attainment of neither perception nor non-perception” (naivasamjñānāsamjñāsamāpatti) and nothingness (akiñchajñāyatana). From Alarakalama and Uddaka Ramaputta. Wynne (2007). It may be that both the teachers’ meditations were theoretically dependent upon Sāṃkhya philosophy, which was widely preached at that time.

⁶ It is to be noted that the Yogic experimental method is also used in some of the seekers’ approaches, but the difference is that yoga is adopted here as one of the methods only (along with other methods, like critical analysis) and with the intention to get the truth or answers, while in the yogic experimental approach the yogi only practices yoga and eventually gets at the truth.

approach for which he brought some modifications in Sāṃkhya. For seeking truth, one may not be lenient towards some schools and against others, or like or dislike schools for personal reasons. Instead, one has to maintain neutrality. For example, one may not put non-Vedic philosophy, such as Buddhism or *Cārvāka* as one category, just because *aniśvaratā* is common among them, or due to the fact that the reader has a personal aversion to Vedic lineage.

The third is the Traditional Approach. Keeping up the tradition or maintaining the line of the school of thought (*sampradāya*) is undoubtedly one of the great approaches for scholars. Some of the Sāṃkhya scholars always try to safeguard its fundamental position at any cost. This, however, hinders the progress in some cases.

The fourth is the Textual Approach. It is a very elementary approach for elementary levels of study, where a single text, like only *Sāṃkhya Kārikā*, is taken up. It is suitable for classroom teaching and giving exposure to the primary levels of scholars. It is helpful to know the perspective of the text but is not helpful to understand the issue in general. In advanced stages, interpretative texts, such as in Sāṃkhya, writings of Gauḍapāda and Vācaspati Miśra are to be taken up. Whereas, to study issues such as consciousness and causation, and similar issues that are related to the core aspects of Sāṃkhya, a critical and comparative study of multiple texts is demanded. Here, restricting the study to one text results in only partial exposure to the issue. One may comprehend what Īśvarakṛṣṇa or somebody else says, but not the philosophy as a whole. Conceptual analysis and hermeneutical exercises may be made on specific texts. It may be a constraint that all texts may not be touched, but at least too much of restrictions to one text or one chapter should be removed for comprehension of the issue. It is because the aim is not studying the text but the issue, which is extended beyond particular text. The text or texts can be taken by the reader or scholar under the influence of his/her tradition, that is, with which he is familiar. This sometimes creates problems of comprehension.

The fifth is the Piecemeal and Holistic Approach. It is sometimes required to dissect or divide a complex issue into different parts and then approach them one by one. This is much practiced by the analytic trends as was seen in Buddhist teachings and preaching.⁷ It is helpful to understand complex issues. However, this can be useful for understanding a whole system, when all the pieces of understanding are consistently connected and the system is looked at holistically. If there is a discordance at any point, the specific piece of understanding might be revised.

To count the sixth approach, the piecemeal and holistic approaches may be taken together as an Integral Approach. However, this integrality is not applied by many scholars of Sāṃkhya, and they end up establishing a partial viewpoint of it or limiting it to some aspects, which many times represent an absolutely wrong understanding of Sāṃkhya. Thus, so far as methodology is concerned, the present discourse on consciousness and causation in Sāṃkhya adopts a composite of seekers' approaches and goes beyond the textual or traditional approach. In this, experiential and intuitive inputs show the light and direction of comprehension.

⁷ The Buddha was referring to him as analysts (*Vibhajjavādoharī*). The context of Nagasena explaining to king Milinda is an example of analysis.

10.3 Causation in Sāṃkhya

There are standard agreed conditions to define something as cause or *kāraṇa*. It must invariably be the pre-existence (*niyata pūrva vṛtti*) of the *kārya*. Invariability or necessity (*niyatattva*) emphasizes the necessary conditionality of the *kāraṇa*, which is prior or antecedent conditionality (*pūrva vṛttitva*) of the *kārya*. The cause must be prior to the effect, even though the former inheres in the effect like a lump of gold existing in the ornament produced from the same lump of the gold. It makes the pre-existence of cause, but it does not deny inherence or *samavāyi kāraṇa*. The third condition is the indispensability of a cause (*ananyathāsiddha*). This reinforces the first two conditions and ensures again that without the cause, the effect would not be possible. If the effect is possible without it, with any alternative, then it is not a material cause proper. This only reinforces the first condition of the invariability but does not rule out alternative instrumental or efficient causes or accessory causes (*nimitta kāraṇa* or *sahakārī kāraṇa*). To take up all the conditions, the cause is an invariable and indispensable antecedent of cause. These three primary conditions of causality and other categorizations of causes such as *upādāna kāraṇa*, *nimitta kāraṇa*, *sahakārī kāraṇa*, *samavāyi* and *asmavāyi kāraṇa* may also be considered in deliberating upon consciousness and causation in Sāṃkhya.

Causation in Sāṃkhya is a major theory under the category that says that the cause exists prior to the effect and elements of effect do latently pre-exist in the cause (*satkāryavāda*).⁸ These assertions of causation are applicable in the specific senses of metaphysics of *Prakṛti*, in the context of cosmology and spirituality, not in any ephemeral worldly contexts of ordinary things. Causation in Sāṃkhya primarily relates to evolution. Here, the primary elements evolve as something taking the materials or stuff from their pre-evolved state. This kind of causation is different from the seeds being germinated as they sprout and then as a plant in a limited time, and due to other conditions. The seed as a cause may also lose some of its energy/ stuff that is not preserved or come into the plant, or add up something that was not in the seed. However, this does not happen in the evolution in Sāṃkhya, where there is no time and no varied external conditions (except one); nothing is lost to something else nothing is added up. It is because, there is nothing else for *Prakṛti*, and the whole of causal things, *sattva*, *rajas* and *tamas*, gets evolved as the cosmos. Whatever was there in the unmanifest state, the same thing becomes manifest in a different form which is called *prakṛti pariṇāma vāda*. The stuff of cause and effect are the same, nothing is lost, and nothing is added. This is the cosmic causation in Sāṃkhya, which cannot be comparable with any intra-cosmic causation. The examples of cosmic causation given in books are only for near approximation of the subject matter but

⁸ In favor of causation as *Satkāryavāda*, Sāṃkhya argues, (i.) if the effect does not latently pre-exist in the cause it could never be produced from the cause (*asadakaraṇāt*). (ii) The effect takes out the material stuff from the cause (*upādānagrahaṇāt*). (iii) For this reason, a particular effect which is latent in the cause is produced from that particular cause (*śaktasya śakya- karaṇāt*), (iv).and not everything comes out of everything (*sarvasambhavābhāvāt*). (v) Without a cause no effect arises (*kāraṇābhāvāt*). Sāṃkhya Karika of Iśvarakṛiṣṇa, 9. (Henceforth the same source is referred to as SK).

lack exact similitude. Further, the causation in Sāṃkhya is not to be understood as the creation because there is no creator as an efficient cause (outside the consciousness and matter). The modification of effectuating happens to be the same, which was the cause, the primordial matter, which happens to be something else, as the cosmos and the essential stuff of the cause, *sattva*, *rajas* and *tamas* continue in the form of the effect. This does not happen in the case of creation. Hence, it is emphasized as evolution and not creation. Evolution is caused by the pre-evolved stage of matter.

Evolution, further, may be understood in its two broad scales—cosmic, at the macro level, and individual, at the micro level. The former starts from binary absolute—transcendental absolute Consciousness or *Puruṣa* and primordial unmanifest matter or *avyakta Prakṛti*, making five subtle and gross elements. Sāṃkhya brought out the building blocks of the evolution of the cosmos. It does not deny, describe or assert, as modern science argues, that there may be continuous, multiple and parallel cosmic evolutions. Once the cosmic evolution starts, within it, the process gets multiplied continually in the evolution of gradually refined individual beings.

10.4 *Prakṛti* and *Puruṣa* in Causation

Causation is understood for evolution and it starts with the reaction in *Prakṛti*. As described, in its unmanifest state, all three of its aspects, namely *sattva*, *rajas* and *tamas* remain in semblance. As and when the semblance is disturbed (*vikṛti*) or sparked by Consciousness (*Puruṣa*), it manifests or evolves, which is its transformation or modification (*pariṇāma*) as *mahat* or *buddhi*. The next phase of the evolution is explained as the principle of individuation (*ahaṅkāra*), and then as the five *tanmātras*, five *mahābhūtas*, five *jñānendriyas*, five *karmendriyas* and the mind. Thus goes the description of evolution. Here, *Prakṛti* is the material cause of the produced realities. The materiality continues to remain as the building stuff in all of its effects, in the form of three *guṇas*, as in the original material element; in this sense, the *Prakṛti* is the material cause or *upādāna kāraṇa* of the cosmos. However, how does this causation happen, and why does this happen? These two are the original questions that bugged the thinkers to the utmost extent, challenging the rational strength of Sāṃkhya.

On the above-mentioned question, Sāṃkhya attempts to opine some rational explanation, such as proximity (*saṃnidhi*) or contact (*saṃyoga* or *sparśa*) of the Consciousness (*Puruṣa*) with the materiality (*Prakṛti*), which sparks the imbalance in the *guṇas* in the *Prakṛti*. In this respect, it is worth considering that the logical and material distinction, however, was not maintained in proper context, and it is wrongly taken as *Puruṣa* and *Prakṛti* as two entities separate from each other as if they are things in space and time so that evolution starts at a time due to their nearness or contact.⁹ Such an understanding may be represented by speculating the

⁹ This discordance arising due to supposing *Puruṣa* and *Prakṛti* as separate entities were eradicated by conceiving consciousness and materiality as one Reality, in the conception of Brahman or Śiva

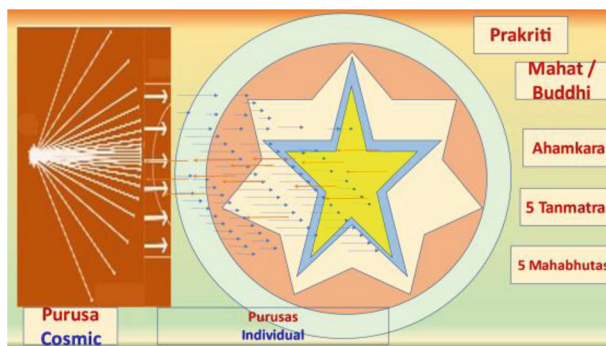


Fig. 10.1 *Puruṣa and Prakṛti*

realms of *Puruṣa* and *Prakṛti* being staying apart, and when their vicinity happens, the influences or energies emanating from *Puruṣa* make different vibrations in the *Prakṛti*, and the radiances of *Puruṣa* through the evolutes of *Prakṛti* appear as many *puruṣas* (Fig. 10.1).

However, this could not satisfy the insatiable reason, and again, it is questioned, “Why does such *saṃnidhi* happen?” Further, contact or proximity are meaningful in space and time; when things are separate, their coming together is due to an event or action. However, all these conditions are supposed to be available as post-manifested matters of facts and, therefore, not applicable, nor also available in the situation of the pre-manifested or unmanifested state of *Prakṛti*. Again, as *Puruṣa* is described as inactive and *Prakṛti* as unconscious, the event or action of their proximity or contact is not logically possible. These types of counterarguments lead the *Sāṃkhya* to ambiguous standpoints. To eradicate these types of discordance, it may be understood that *Puruṣa* and *Prakṛti* are two fundamental realities but remain in the same locus. The locus may be *Puruṣa*, as there was no manifestation of *Prakṛti* to make its locus at that time, and it was *avyakta* or unmanifest at that time. This may seem *Vedāntic* with one eternal absolute, and in it, the potential other appeared; or it may be the *Pūrāṇic* understanding that *Brāhma* or *Lakṣmī* appeared in Viṣṇu or the almighty. The *Yogamāyā* remained as his potential power, which appeared and disappeared. These figurative narrations might be indicating the true case, though imprecisely. To understand the truth, if something is unmanifest (*avyakta*), its separate existence is not conceivable. Once, it manifests, that is, becomes *vyakta*, which means, it must manifest in that which existed, and that is *Puruṣa*, because, there was no other, not even space. After this, they became coextensive, and as a result, there is a continuity or *saṃnidhi* (connection) or *saṃyoga* or (contact) *saṃnikarṣa* between them, which is also continuously maintained. This may be understood by words such as *saṃnidhi*, *saṃyoga* or *saṃnikarṣa* as nothing existed apart from them, and therefore spatio-temporal difference cannot be conceived. This is a matter of understanding, and there

or Viṣṇu, and *icchā*, or *līlā* of that Reality was taken at the cause of the evolution or creation and dissolution.

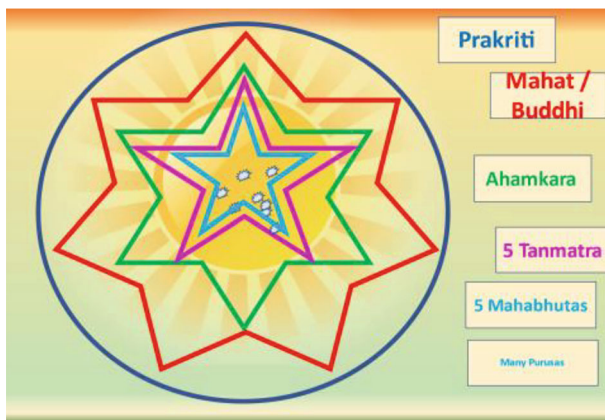


Fig. 10.2 Evolution of *Prakṛti*

is no contrary account of this understanding in the Sāṃkhya. After the manifestation of the *Prakṛti*, it has to be coextensive with the *Puruṣa*, and then, further evolution might be starting as the following. The situation of their co-existence and evolution may be depicted as the following Fig (10.2).

The Sun with its lights in the background represents the transcendental *Puruṣa*; the outer circle signifies the *Prakṛti*, which manifests from the unmanifested stage¹⁰; the seven-cornered star indicates the position of the *mahat* within and of the same stuff as the *Prakṛti*; the six-cornered star stands for *ahaṅkāra*; the outer five-cornered star symbolizes *tanmātras* and the inner five-cornered star points to the *mahābhūtas*. Within the *mahābhūtas*, the little bubbles represent the living beings, where the light of the *Puruṣa* is captured or reflected. Here, everything comes out of the same *Puruṣa* and *Prakṛti*.

As indicated above, the supposition of eternal *saṁyoga* between *Puruṣa* and *Prakṛti* may imply that their separation is not possible, and therefore evolution is unending. It seems right that these two distinct realities may not be thought of to be separate in different loci on any time scale, inasmuch as there is no separate locus for them and no time was possibly thought of there. Perhaps, there was no locus at all apart from them. Among them, one is the locus of the other or they are coextensive and the loci of each other. Preferably, it is easier to think that the *Puruṣa* is the locus of itself and the unmanifest *Prakṛti*, as logically it is more difficult to conceive that an unmanifest becomes the locus of the other. It may also be the case that they are coextensive. In such a case, it may be argued that in this context, their separation is not conceivable, and if so, evolution is continuous.

If the locus of the two realities is the same and evolution is continuous, it may be argued that the *Puruṣa* will never be free from the *Prakṛti*, which means *kaivalya*

¹⁰ The situation of *Prakṛti* as unmanifest and is an object of inference, and that it is coming into the manifested state at the *Samnidhi* of *Puruṣa*, may afterwards give rise to the conception of eternal Gods, like Śiva or Viṣṇu arises their creative Power as Śakti.

(loneness, *puruṣa* being alone without *prakṛti*) is not possible. Examining this, it can be asserted that coextensiveness and a single locus may be the fact. First of all, *kaivalya* may be understood as happening not to the cosmic, absolute and transcendental *Puruṣa*, but to the evolved intra-cosmic, multiple *puruṣas*, like us, who are the reflection or representation of the former *Puruṣa* in the different individuations of *Prakṛti*. *Kaivalya* is also to be understood as cognitively and realizationally a separate state of being from *Prakṛti* and by discrimination (*vivekajñāna*), he is the reflection of the cosmic *Puruṣa*. It is possible due to discrimination by knowledge, and not due to any empirical separation in time and space. It happens through knowledge, in consciousness, and by that wisdom, one lives and finally experiences the *kaivalya* at yogic levels. The absolute is realized as the eternal truth, the true character of the individual *Puruṣas*.

Further, as proposed here, the Sāṃkhya is not a descriptive account of the creation. Rather, it may be understood as a system of Yogic realization, where a yogin gradually surpasses or transcends the limits, controls senses and then gradually transcends the realms of *tanmātras* and *mahābhūtas*, and reaches the state of *ahankāra*; there one realizes himself/herself as an individual pure consciousness in the individuation of *Prakṛti*. This experience gradually alters as in the next stage, the *yogin* is submerged in *buddhi* or *mahat*, which is universal consciousness; he/she loses individuality and experiences or becomes universal consciousness. At that stage, the individual realizes himself/herself as pure consciousness. The next immediate level is dissolving individuality and realizing reality or *Puruṣa*. Thus, the road of gradual transcendence and final realization of the transcendental aspect of the *Puruṣa* is complete. In this journey, the *yogin* achieves gradual detachment from materiality, and the latter stages are quickened as one realization leads to another. This experience of loneness or the detached state and state of pure consciousness is the original state which is realized, and that happens from bottom to top in ascending mode of yogic progress and realizations. This might be the original state and conception of logical distinction or rational discrimination between *Puruṣa* and *Prakṛti*.

In consonance with the above-mentioned comprehension, the context of causation in the scale of evolution may be understood with a deeper mode or proposal. It is no doubt that *Prakṛti* is the material cause. The three *guṇas* of *Prakṛti* may be understood as the different wavelengths of photons/light, which can be seen as different colours by defragmentation and deflection of the same colourless light. The three *guṇas* in semblances are like the clear light, all are aspects, elements or energies of *Prakṛti*. Now, since *Prakṛti* is unmanifest, but exists, so also the transcendental *Puruṣa* exists, rather always exists as a manifest entity, and the fact that there is no conception of spatio-temporal setup allows or leads to conceive them to coexist, which is connotated in the expression *saṃnidhi*. It may also be logically understood that the existence of unmanifest must be there in the manifest. Had it been any otherwise co-existence, how would that be, that is, how can an unmanifest coexist along with a manifest, and they must be separate from each other, and come nearer when there is no space and time, and no movement in the part of consciousness and no intelligence in materiality? To this, no answer is found in the Sāṃkhya, for which it is often thought that the system could not answer the demand of reason. However, to sort out the

matter, for our purpose, we have to understand “the unmanifest” as a state of pre-manifestation of evolution, and its existence along with the *Puruṣa*. For this reason, it is better to conceive the alternative models as unmanifest in the manifest—one in another or both as one. In all these situations, further, it is also understandable to conceive that causation is continuous and eternal as *rajas* predominates, and we see the effectuation of subtle *mahābhūtas* or *tanmātras* (*tanmātra sarga*) and then more gross forms of them as the *bhūtādi sarga* evolves. Within these, there are incessant individuations of the *pañchamahābhūtas*, including individuations up to the vegetable life, instinctive animals, insects and up to much more rational human beings and other higher beings. The reflection or warmth or power of consciousness of the *Puruṣa* that coexisted with *Prakṛti* has been kept on reflecting on *Prakṛti* and passing on to all its evolutes as well through *mahat* and *ahankāra*, and runs through them along with their heredity still visible in the elevated living beings, such as, humans. That reflection or representation of consciousness might be called many *Puruṣas*, who are in the state of *Buddhas* as reflected ones and not realizing that they must return to their pristine, pure transcendental *Puruṣa*.

The presence of elements of *Prakṛti* and reflection of *Puruṣa* in all evolutes may allow us to understand them as a material cause or *upādāna kāraṇa*. The three *guṇas*, to say in an alternative expression, are the inherent cause or *samavāyi kāraṇa*.¹¹ It is an attempt to make a subtle difference between *upādāna* and *samavāyi*. In the case where the causal ingredients completely get transformed as the effect just like in the case of milk becoming curd, we would call the milk as *upādāna kāraṇa* of the curd. In contrast, where the causal ingredients remain in the same form in the effect, which is produced in conjunction with the causal ingredients, like in the case of threads in cloth, it may preferably be called the *samavāyi kāraṇa*. Thus, something is *samavāyi kāraṇa*, which retains its original form while being inherent as part and portions of the effect, as in the case of thread in the cloth. Accordingly, the *mahat*, the first evolute, which is universal may be argued to be present in all evolutes, as in the form of *buddhi* in the living beings. *Ahankāra* and five subtle as well as gross elements are similarly universal, but due to individuation, distributed in the individual things and beings as distinct from each other from ego-consciousness and the eleven *indriyas*. They all are *samavāyi kāraṇas* in all evolutes. The *Prakṛti* is the *upādāna kāraṇa* as it gets completely transformed as the evolutes, but its three *guṇas* are inherent in all evolutes, like threads in cloth, and therefore can preferably be called *samavāyi kāraṇa*.

10.5 Consciousness as a Cause

From the above, it may humbly be tried to argue why the transcendental cosmic Consciousness or *Puruṣa*, which is the locus of or coextensive with the *Prakṛti*, is to be considered as another cause of evolution, even as a passive one, as without its presence

¹¹ Larson (1979).

and reflection, or *saṃnidhi*, no evolution is possible? This saying is highly debatable but is not cogent and necessary. The *Puruṣa*, which coexists and is coextensive with *Prakṛti*, qualifies all the characteristics of cause that are invariably pre-existent (*niyata pūrva vṛtti*) and indispensable (*ananyathāsiddha*) and like *Prakṛti*. It may look debatable *prima facie*, as the *Puruṣa* is described as not active by himself inasmuch as indifferent (*mādhyastham*) and not an agent of action (*akatṛbhāvaḥ*), and therefore may not be an active cause. If so, the *Puruṣa* may safely be said to be the passive cause. One may see that (i) if *Puruṣa* is described as indifferent (*mādhyastham*) (*akatṛbhāvaḥ*), how is it also described as (ii) enjoying and aspiring for *kaivalya* (*bhokṛbhāvāt kaivalyārtham pravṛtteśca*). Does it not indicate that he is inactive in part (i) and active in part (ii)? To eradicate the contradiction, it is to be understood that part (i) is said in the context of many *puruṣas* to be the active agents, reflections of the transcendental *Puruṣa*, and part (ii), that is, indifference, is said to be the transcendental aspect of the cosmic *Puruṣa*, who is inactive. This has not been clarified properly in the extant scriptures of Sāṃkhya, but is consistently derived from whatsoever is said. The indication is cryptically left for understanding. Further, the description of *madhyastha*, which can be translated as the neutral, central or principal one, does not strictly describe that he is defunct, though he is not a part of the evolution. Though Sāṃkhya describes the transcendental *Puruṣa* as passive, other texts, however, refer to its role as regulator or *niyāmaka*. For example, the *mahābhārata* describes the *Puruṣa* as *anādi*, *ananta*, *sarvadarśin* and *niyāmaka* or controller and devoid of three *guṇas*.¹² This is said about the transcendental *Puruṣa* and not the multiple *puruṣas*, who are *puruṣābhāsas*. If these two categories of *Puruṣas*, the transcendental *Puruṣa* is the one in the proximity of which the *Prakṛti* evolves into the cosmos. If this transcendental *Puruṣa* is not accepted, as many scholars do by only accepting many *Puruṣas*, then who among the many *Puruṣas* in contact with that does evolution happen and the five subtle and gross elements (*mahābhūtas*) come into being? However, in trying to resolve the matter, it can humbly and safely be understood that it is not the individual *puruṣas*, but the one transcendental cosmic *Puruṣa*, which coexists with *Prakṛti* (as described in Sāṃkhya) as argued above; *saṃnidhi* of this transcendental *Puruṣa* functions as the passive cause of the evolution, just as the presence of the magnate causes reactions on iron or presence of fire is simply enough for the emanation of heat in the atmosphere. Thus, there are two categories of *puruṣas*—the transcendental *Puruṣa*, *saṃnidhi* of which sparked the imbalance in the *guṇas* in *prakṛti*, and the reflection or defragmented energies or light of the transcendental *Puruṣa* in or through the *Prakṛti* causes many empirical *puruṣas*, who are actually apparent *puruṣas* (*puruṣābhāsas*).

The necessity of the transcendental *Puruṣa* for evolution may lead us to think that it is also a condition and cause for the evolution of the elements. It is well established in the Sāṃkhya that the proximity of the *Puruṣa* is necessary for starting the evolution of *Prakṛti*. It may be argued that by its presence, being the cause or condition of breaking the semblances in the *Prakṛti*, the *Puruṣa* is the passive *sahakārī kāraṇa* / *nimitta kāraṇa* and its proximity is the condition for the evolution.

¹² *Mahābhārata*, 12.291.43.

The transcendental *Puruṣa* can be considered as the *upādāna kāraṇa* to all empirical *puruṣas*, which are its reflections, impressions, lights or energies. To explain more, for the primal unmanifest *Prakṛti*, the presence of the transcendental *Puruṣa* is the *sahakārī kāraṇa/nimitta kāraṇa* and *mahat* is the evolute. In the aforementioned model, the transcendental *Puruṣa* is accepted as the very backdrop where the *Prakṛti* becomes manifest from its unmanifest state. To the rest of the evolutes starting from *mahat*, if consciousness is found anywhere, either directly or in the process of evolution, it can be accepted that the *Puruṣa* is also the *upādāna kāraṇa*. If it is accepted that consciousness is ubiquitous, which only manifests depending upon the material richness and constitutions, such as the brains of human beings or when the flow of electricity can create a magnetic field, then consciousness will be the *upādāna kāraṇa* therein. Simultaneously, its reflection or *saṃnidhi* is responsible for any further evolution at any level that makes it *sahakārī kāraṇa*. That is to say, if the initial spark of the evolution is responsible for each individuation, then also the *Puruṣa* is the *sahakārī kāraṇa*, and in each individuation, if its energy is passed on or is there to be expressed (along with materiality), then it is also one of the *upādāna kāraṇas*, while the other *upādāna kāraṇa* is the *Prakṛti*. The three *guṇas* are the *samavāyi kāraṇas*. Thus, the transcendental *Puruṣa* qualifies all the three conditions of *kāraṇa*, such as invariability, pre-existence, (*niyata pūrva vṛttitva*) and indispensability (*ananyathāsiddha*).

The presence of *Puruṣa* as *sahakārī kāraṇa* is of a different category. Generally, a *sahakārī kāraṇa* is not a necessary *kāraṇa* in the sense that any other object or entity may replace one of the *sahakārī kāraṇas*. But, the presence of *Puruṣa* as *sahakārī kāraṇa* is not replicable or avoidable or denied in the process of evolution. It is therefore a necessary *sahakārī kāraṇa*. Since it is a necessary *sahakārī kāraṇa*, it is also an indispensable instrumental cause or *nimitta kāraṇa*. It is the *upādāna kāraṇa* as far as its reflections are concerned in the evolutes. It would also be *samavāyi kāraṇa* if its clear initial pure form were there in the evolutes, but as the *yogin* advances to realize its clearer reflections, for him, it is also a *samavāyi kāraṇa*.

A little more supposition may be made about “the presence of which of the *Puruṣas* or consciousness could be the cosmic cause and the intra-cosmic cause of individual *indriyas*?” In this regard, can it be asserted that the transcendental *Puruṣa*, which is described to coexist with unmanifest *Prakṛti* and which sparks the evolutions in *Prakṛti*, is the transcendental absolute *Puruṣa*? It is one and *bibhu*. Its energy or reflection is ubiquitous, as the three *guṇas*, in *mahat*, *ahaṅkāra*, five subtle and gross elements and through traces of *buddhi* and *ahaṅkāra* in all individuals. In this way, its reflection is present in all sentient beings, and in higher beings, called individual *puruṣas*. Each of these individual *puruṣas*, as it is supposed here, sparks the evolution of the eleven *indriyas* in their embodiments. Thus, the multiple individual *puruṣas* which are reflections of the cosmic *Puruṣa*, constitute the core of the embodied selves, which may be called *jīvas* when shrouded with *ahaṅkāra*.¹³

¹³ *Viśiṣṭasya jīvattvaṁ Anvayavyatirekāt, Sūtra.6.63, Bhāṣya- Jīvatva Prāṇadhāraṇayoriti jīvatvaṁ prāṇītvam tat cha ahaṅkāra visista puruṣasya dharmah natu kevala puruṣasya. Sāṅkhya Pravachana Bhāṣya, 6.63.*

They, however, implicitly carry out both the transcendental and immanent aspects of the absolute *Puruṣa*. This way of understanding cosmic transcendental *Puruṣa* and many individual *puruṣas* may look debatable, but can be proved from the simple reason that I or my readers who are embodied beings, who are there due to the evolution in the *Prakṛti*, can never be the cause of evolution. So, as evolutes, we are not the cause of primary evolution. Hence, it must be the transcendental *Puruṣa*, which is narrated as coexisting with the unmanifest *Prakṛti*, which is the cause of evolution. From there, the energy of *Puruṣa* is carried out by the evolutes of *Prakṛti*, the same is the consciousness that we are in our core aspects. But, as said above, when our individual personality evolves, the transcendental energy of *Puruṣa* that is presented in every being might be the cause of the evolution of our respective eleven *indriyas* in each of us. It is because, at each level of evolution, the responsibility goes to the consciousness coexisting in proximity with the material element. So, in the scale of evolution, the individuation of the *pañchamahābhūtas* is refined as individual beings, and the coexisting consciousness in the evolutes is the trace of consciousness that is carried out from the absolute consciousness.

As indicated above, to make a complete understanding of the presence of one transcendental *Puruṣa* as the cause of cosmic evolution, and the presence of individual *puruṣas* as individual evolutions, it is necessary to comprehend the former as One¹⁴ and absolute and the latter as multiple immanent *puruṣas*. It is important to accept the one transcendental absolute *Puruṣa* and its traces or flashes of energy as multiple immanent *puruṣas*, which may be called “spirit” in the scale of evolution. It may be proved from the arguments and adjectives given for the *P/puruṣa(s)*. The transcendental and immanent character of *Puruṣa* is described when its existence is proved as a *Puruṣa*, (*puruṣo'sti*) who (a) transcends the causation (*saṃghātaparāthavāt*), (b) is beyond the three *guṇas* (*triguṇādiviparyāt*), (c) is the basis of evolution (*adhiṣṭhānāt*) and (d) enjoys and aspires for *kaivalya* (*bhoktṛbhāvāt kaivalyārtham pravṛtteśca*).¹⁵ In the next verse, the multiplicity of *puruṣas* or spirits is established by *Sāṃkhya* citing the reason that (e) they are due to diverse modifications of the three *guṇas*, (*traiguṇya viparyayāt*), (f) ordained with (*pratinayamāt*) their individual deaths, births and possession of *indriyas* (*janma-maraṇa-karaṇānām*) and (g) the diversity of their actions (*pravṛtteḥ ayugapat*).¹⁶ Having described the multiplicity of *puruṣa*, *Sāṃkhya* establishes the *Puruṣa* as (h) the witness (*sākṣitvam*) who is (i) solitary (*kaivalyam*), (j) indifferent (*mādhyastham*), (k) spectator (*draṣṭuttvam*) and (l) not an agent of action (*akatṛbhāvaḥ*).¹⁷

In the above, the adjectives, “a,” “b,” “c,” “k,” and “l,” grouped as (1), describe the transcendental characteristics of *puruṣa*, while “d,” “e,” “f,” and “g,” grouped as

¹⁴ In interpreting “Pumān Ekah,” Mathara, and Gaḍapāda accepts the *Puruṣa* as one. Ref. Mathara Vṛtti, 11, and Gaḍapāda. karika, 11.

¹⁵ *Samghātaparāthavāt triguṇādiviparyādadhiṣṭhānāt | puruṣo'sti bhoktṛbhāvāt pravṛtteśca*, SK, 17.

¹⁶ *Janm-maraṇa-karaṇānām, prati niyamāt ayugapat pravṛtteḥ ca || Puruṣa bahutvam siddham traiguṇya viparyayāt ca eva ||* SK, 18.

¹⁷ *Tasmācca viparyāsāt siddham sākṣitvamasya puruṣasya | kaivalyam mādhyasthyam draṣṭṛtvmakartṛbhāvaśca*, SK, 19.

(2), point out to the immanent characteristics. All individual *puruṣas*, that is, spirits, possess type “2” characteristics explicitly, and type “1” implicitly. Type “2” cannot be attributed to the absolute *Puruṣa*, which is transcendental, and *saṁnidhi* or *saṁyoga* which causes *mahat* in the *prakṛti*. Type “1” directly and explicitly applies to the absolute. This *Puruṣa* is the cosmic *Puruṣa*, and due to his light or spirit, the multiple individual reflections were there in the multiple individuations of the *Prakṛti*, which are multiple *puruṣas*. The characteristic “h,” “I,” “j,” “k,” and “l,” to be grouped as (3), describes the transcendental characters of the inherent individual *puruṣa*, and are generally forgotten or lost under the influence of *Prakṛti* in the line of evolution. But by recognizing and imbibing the same, the individual *puruṣa* starts to brighten or proceed to his transcendental state of cosmic *Puruṣa* in the realization of the *kaivalya*. The distinction between the one, cosmic, absolute, transcendental *Puruṣa*, and many individual *puruṣas* or spirits, which is emphasized in this discourse, looks cogent.

10.6 Concluding Remarks

The aforesaid discourse attempts to point out the methods of studying Sāṁkhya in proper perspectives and approaches. It deliberates upon the transcendental and immanent aspects of multiple individual consciousness or *puruṣas* (who may be taken as *puruṣābhāsas*), the spirits. They are the lights or energies of the one absolute transcendent *Puruṣa*, who coexists with unmanifest *Prakṛti*. *Prakṛti* exists in the same locus as *Puruṣa*, due to which their *saṁnidhi* or *saṁyoga* or *saṁnikarṣa* remains continuous. Evolution may be eternal, periodic or cyclic, but it makes cosmic evolution continuous as *rajas* predominates. Nevertheless, *kaivalya* is possible for those who through discrimination and knowledge get disinterested in *Prakṛti* and dive deep into *Puruṣa*. This is the cosmic *Puruṣa*. With its *Saṁnidhi*, the cosmic evolution starts with the first evolute as *mahat* till the evolution of *indriyas* for each individual spirit. The deliberation is pointed out that the presence of Consciousness as it sparks the evolution is the *nimitta/sahakārī kāraṇa* (instrumental/supportive cause) of evolution, whereas *Prakṛti* (materiality), as generally understood, is the *samavāyi kāraṇa* (inherent cause) as well as *upādāna kāraṇa* (material cause) due to its ubiquitousness in all evolutes. Here, the reflection of the *Puruṣa* (cosmic consciousness) is diversely refracted as the unities of multiple *Puruṣas* (multiple individual consciousness) as per the Sāṁkhya. However, if the initial spark and the refraction of the consciousness go on with each level of consciousness that would be just like the Vedāntic understanding of immanence of consciousness in every bit of *Prakṛti*, and this looks appropriate as in every bit of *Prakṛti* is an compact unit of expression of not only mass and energy but also that with orders, principles, compatibilities, self-adjustments and evolutions, which would not be expected from the inert and unintelligent *prakṛti*. Upon this argument, if it can be said that *Puruṣa* is immanent and omnipresent in everything, then *Puruṣa* is also the *samavāyi kāraṇa* (inherent cause) as well as *upādāna kāraṇa* (material cause) due to its ubiquitousness in all evolutes. This may

look like a Vedāntic interpretation of Sāṃkhya, but it may be examined as per the understanding of the truth/reality and that too with self-consistency.

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Chapter 11

Satkāryavāda: A Causal Explanation of Change Within Eternal Being



Gabriel Martino

Abstract The present paper offers a discussion and an analysis of the notion of *satkārya*, taking into consideration both the specific way in which Īśvarakṛṣṇa articulates his thought and some problems regarding the interpretation of the so-called *satkāryavāda*. We show, firstly, that the reflection on causation in ancient Indian philosophy is deliberate, conscious, explicit, systematic and nuanced. We also discuss some of the problems entailed in the most usual way of understanding Classical Sāṃkhya's theory of causation, which sees *prakṛti* as an entity and as a material cause. Secondly, upon the analysis of the text, we suggest that the notion of *satkārya* implies two correlative theses. One thesis is that products or effects, that is, the *tattva*-s evolved from *prakṛti*, belong to the sphere of (eternal) being. The other one is that relations of cause and effect are real. Finally, we show that Īśvarakṛṣṇa employs derivatives of the verbal root KṚ to categorize the inner dynamics of being, in order to explain caused change without contradicting the main ontological principle of the mutual exclusion between being and non-being. Consequently, we propose that Īśvarakṛṣṇa's conception of causation can be understood as a grammar of being, since it seeks to explain the process and rules of derivation and change imitating the method of classical Sanskrit grammar.

Keywords Sāṃkhya · Causation theory · Being · Change

11.1 Introduction

Sāṃkhya is one of the oldest philosophies of ancient India, and many of the ideas that constitute the later systematical Sāṃkhya school or *darśana* can be found in early texts as the Upaniṣads, and a few of them even in the *Samhitā*. Some important

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ancient Sāṃkhya texts have been lost, but significant Sāṃkhya formulations have reached us embedded in other textual corpora, such as the *Mahābhārata*, Āyurvedic treatises, and even in a Buddhist narrative of the life of the Buddha.¹

Around the fifth century of the Common Era, the Sāṃkhya doctrine was systematized and standardized in a *sūtra*-like treatise, similar to the other philosophical schools' foundational *sūtras*. This treatise, however, was composed by Īśvarakṛṣṇa in a meter called *kārikā*, and in around seventy stanzas, it manages to provide the main tenets of what we can consider the classical Sāṃkhya system of philosophy.² One of the central doctrines that the *Sāṃkhya-kārikā* puts forward is a theory of causation called *satkārya*. In the present paper, we examine the way in which Īśvarakṛṣṇa articulates this theory, and we offer a discussion about issues regarding the interpretation of the doctrine.

11.2 Thinking Causation

The notion that things, actions and events are selectively connected to each other by relations of cause and effect is a conception that classical Indian philosophers inherited from their Vedic predecessors. Almost everything in the universe, whether it belongs to the human, the nature or the divine sphere, was conceived as subject to relations of implications and correspondences. This conception was the basic understanding of reality that made *karman* or the performance of ritual actions possible and even necessary.³ By the time that Īśvarakṛṣṇa composed his treatise, the notion of *karman* had a much broader scope of application than exclusively to sacrifice. However, the notion of activity as a hinge that linked the past, the present and the future with almost unavoidable connections was still present, and its nature was a subject of polemics among the philosophical schools.⁴ Classical Indian philosophy contains different and competing accounts of the workings of causality, and the doctrine advocated by the Sāṃkhya school is one among other theories.

Some schools explicitly rejected the idea of causation. Haribhadra writes in his *Ṣaḍdarśanasamuccaya* (eighth century C.E.) that “The materialists argue as follows. There is no Self, no liberation; there is no good and bad moral, and no fruit of virtuous and non-virtuous (actions).” For them, “this world only extends as far as do the

¹ For a discussion of pre-classical Sāṃkhya sources see Larson (1998 [1969]: 75–134).

² Interestingly, parts of the verses of the *Sāṃkhyakārikā* are referred to as *sūtras* in the *Yuktidīpikā*, its most important commentary. See Bronkhorst (2010: 183).

³ Cfr. Renou (1941–1942), “*Karman* [...] appartient aux milieux rituels où le mot, depuis le RV., désignait l’acte par excellence, c’est-à-dire le rite.” In Staal (1972: 464). See, as well, Bina Gupta (2012: 8) “Originally, *karman* referred to correct performance of ritualistic activity with a view to receiving the desired results. It was believed that if a ritual is duly performed, nobody, not even divinities, could stop the desired results.”

⁴ For an exhaustive discussion on the notion of *karman* see Gerow (1982: 87–116).

objects of our senses,” for which they “think that it is foolish of people to renounce the manifested world in favour of the unseen world.”⁵

According to Hariḥbhadrā, the Lokāyata school rejected the notion that actions bear fruit, *i.e.*, that they are causes of some effects, according to their degree of *dharma* and *adharma*. They also refused to engage with what cannot be seen, be it a future life or a subtle knowledge(able cause), which could provide a basis for understanding or regulating what can be seen.

The defense of causation, hence, was deliberate and conscious in classical Indian schools such as Sāṃkhya, not only because it was explicitly and systematically articulated but also because it was dialectically advocated against opposing views. However, the intellectual repertoire of ancient Indian doctrines regarding this topic is not limited to pro- and anti-causation. Classical Indian thought on causality is nuanced, since the different pro-causation schools supported divergent accounts of causality.

Roy Perret provides an instructive taxonomy of the differing theories of causation and points out that they are traditionally classified by reference to the question of whether the effect is a mode of the cause. He explains that two basic models dominate Indian thinking about the nature of causal relations. One is the identity theory, which holds that the effect is identical to the cause, a manifestation of what is potential in the cause. The other is the non-identity theory, which denies that the effect pre-exists in its cause, claiming that the effect is a new entity. The first one, says Perret, was advocated by Sāṃkhya-Yoga and by Vedānta, though with important differences. The second one was held by Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika and by some Buddhist schools. A third compromising position was the Jaina theory of non-absolutism, says Perret. The Jains suggested that the effect is pre-existing in the cause from one point of view, while from another viewpoint, it is not.⁶

According to Perret, Sāṃkhya defends a notion of causation that understands causes and effects in terms of substance and entities, with the relevant addition of conceiving that effects are only a modification of the substance, which is the material cause.⁷ Larson, in turn, holds that classical sāmkhya entails a causal system of “reductive materialism” in that it “construes or reduces mind thought, idea, feelings, etc., in terms of some material stuff, energy, or force.”⁸ Such a conception is explicit in the definition he provides of *prakṛti* as “nature or materiality in its unmanifest and manifest condition; the ultimate material cause [...]”⁹ As we can see, these descriptions of the Sāṃkhya theory of causation explain it, introducing the concepts

⁵ Verses 80, 81 and 85. We follow the English translation with minor changes and the Sanskrit text in Qvarnström (1999: 198–199).

⁶ Perrett (2016: 155–158).

⁷ “In fact, a cause and its effect are not two separate, discrete entities but instead two states of the same enduring substance.” Perrett (2016: 157).

⁸ Larson, (1998 [1969]: 223).

⁹ Larson (1998 [1969]: 242).

of entity, substance and matter.¹⁰ This procedure, however, is deeply problematic, and scholars have also raised objections to it.

Dasgupta already pointed out almost a century ago that “*prakṛti*, though a substantive entity, is yet a potential power” and that “being of the nature of power, the movement by which it actualizes itself is immanent within itself and not caused from without.”¹¹ The introduction of the notions of power and immanent movement is relevant for our understanding of *prakṛti* because the insistence on the Aristotelian vocabulary of entity, substance and matter carries philosophical implications that distort our comprehension of Sāṃkhya philosophy. In order to make these implications explicit, let us briefly discuss Aristotle’s notion of entity.

The notion of *ousía* or entity in Aristotelian philosophy is complex. From the perspective of the *Categories*, an entity is primarily the individual being: *this* man, *this* horse. From the perspective of the *Metaphysics*, the individual being is also an entity, but it owes its entitative character to Form. In both cases, an entity is something determined. Individual beings or “compounds” are thus analyzed in *Metaphysics* in terms of their composite nature constituted by Form and matter. Matter is the substrate, but it is in itself undetermined and in potency, and in order to be actualized, it needs a Form. The possibility of matter existing without any Form is problematic, and its notion is rather the result of spurious reasoning, but Form is defined as being able to exist separately.

For this reason, the power of actualization does not belong to matter itself but is brought to it by Form. An entity understood as a compound result from the actualizing power that Form brings to matter. In the case of an immaterial entity, such as the First Unmoved Mover, it is pure Form, and since it is immaterial, it is pure act. Lastly, as it could be the case that things in potency could never be actualized, the First Cause has to be pure and eternal act, that is to say, eternally deprived of being in potency in any way.¹²

This brief explanation of the Aristotelian notion of entity allows us to highlight some important contrasts between Aristotle’s and Sāṃkhya philosophies. For Aristotle, matter is not an entity because considered by itself it is completely undetermined, while many accounts of Sāṃkhya philosophy characterize *prakṛti* both as matter and as an entity. This would make the account inconsistent in Aristotelian terms since *prakṛti* should be conceived as an entity or matter, but it cannot be both

¹⁰ See, as well, Hiriyaṇṇa (1995: 107–110). “*Prakṛti* is the name which it gives to the principle or entity, out of which is evolved the physical universe in its infinite diversity”; “The material cause and the effect are not accordingly taken here to be quite distinct” and “the nature of these entities, as indicated by their names, shows that *Prakṛti* adjusts itself first to the needs of *Puruṣa* by evolving the most important aids to life’s experience, viz. the organ of thinking and the principle of consciously or unconsciously appropriating the thought or regarding it as one’s own.” A similar view is held in Hiriyaṇṇa (1952: 51 ff.), “The Sāṃkhya is frankly dualistic. It recognizes two ultimate entities –nature and spirit- [...]”

¹¹ Dasgupta (2002[1924]: 84).

¹² For an introductory discussion on this topics see: Cohen (2009: 197–212), for the notion of entity or substance; Lewis (2009: 162–185), for the notions of Form and matter; and Hankinson (2009: 213–229) for the Aristotelian theory of causes.

things simultaneously. The same applies to the Aristotelian notion of substance since this term is another translation for the Greek notion translated as “entity” (*ousia*). These contrasts lead us to one last important difference. Aristotle’s theory of causation distinguishes four ways in which we understand cause. Tradition has given the four following names: *material* cause, *efficient* cause, *formal* cause and *final* cause. We would like to stress that even though efficient, formal and final causes could be eventually identified for Aristotle, material causes would always remain distinct from the others since Aristotle’s notion of matter ultimately lacks any formal, efficient and final component. Hence, considering *prakṛti* as a material cause is also problematic due to the inner dynamic of *prakṛti* by which it transforms itself in its determined evolutes, as if efficient and formal (and even, in some sense, final) causes were constitutive to “material” *prakṛti* itself.¹³

However, the problems we are raising here are not new. Larson himself asserted in 1975 that the usual discussions of *causation in Sāṃkhya*, “which relate the notion to the Aristotelian idea of material cause, have missed the point of the Sāṃkhya notion, or better, have interpreted it on the wrong level.”¹⁴ Furthermore, he concludes that the notion of *satkārya* “has little to do with Aristotelian material cause.”¹⁵ Larson suggests, in turn, that we should look at Sāṃkhya’s theory of causation from a new point of view and proposes the perspective of Structuralism with the three key ideas of wholeness, transformation and self-regulation as a much more adequate approach. From this point of view, *satkārya* “appears to function as an explanatory principle for maintaining *prakṛti* as a closed, transforming, self-regulating, intelligible (but not intelligent) whole, which provides for a series of progressive mediations (*puruṣārtha*).” Larson considers, however, that Sāṃkhya is “a kind of structural psychology or even a structural anthropology” and that “to discuss *satkārya* in the context of traditional Western conceptualizations of the problem of causation is seriously to distort and misread the intention of the Sāṃkhya analysis. He states that whereas most Western discussions of causation are directed to explain the problem of the rational compatibility between the natural world and man, the intention of the Sāṃkhya discussion is “to explain precisely the discontinuity of the world and man.”¹⁶ We agree with Larson that there is an important “contextual divergence” between Sāṃkhya and, generally, as he says, “Western thought.” In what follows, nevertheless, we propose a way of understanding the notion of *satkārya* that preserves

¹³ For a discussion on other problems related to interpreting *prakṛti* as matter see Burley (2012: 97 ff.). Burley (2012: 100), for example, stresses that we have to understand *prakṛti* as both form and matter (but “in the Kantian sense of the terms”).

¹⁴ He also adds that “The Sāṃkhya tradition itself is partly responsible for this misunderstanding because of its use of such analogies as water, rain, juice, etc.” Larson (1975: 35).

¹⁵ Larson (1975: 38).

¹⁶ For an interpretation that views the Sāṃkhya-kārikā as both a cosmological and a psychological treatise and that considers that the schema presented in it can be understood as a “metaphysics of experience” where the “metaphysical theory and soteric practice combine to form an integrated whole” see Burley (2012: 106–132 especially).

its character of a doctrine of causality, and that views the *Sāṃkhya-Kārikā* as a metaphysical treatise which seeks to provide a solution for the problem of (caused) change within (eternal) being.

11.3 Īśvarakṛṣṇa's Theory of Causation

As we mentioned in the previous section, the Lokāyata refused to admit anything but perception as a valid means of knowledge, for which they rejected causation as an invariable relation of dependence between events.¹⁷ This tendency was not prevalent among ancient Indian thinkers, and certainly, it was not the one advocated by Sāṃkhya. Īśvarakṛṣṇa, in fact, in the first verse of his *Sāṃkhya-kārikā* states that there is a cause (*hetu*) and that suffering stirs a desire of knowing (*jijñāsā*) this cause.¹⁸ The theory of causation, hence, is already present in this introductory *kārikā* implied in the desirability of knowledge. These ideas are repeated throughout the treatise. In stanza 44, we read that by knowledge (*jñāna*), we can attain liberation, while due to the opposite of this, *i.e.*, ignorance, bondage is desired.

Contrary to the Lokāyata belief, it also states that by *dharma*, there is elevation, but by *adharma*, decadence. In *kārikā* 64, we also read that by means of studying the Sāṃkhya doctrine (*tattvābhyāsa*), liberating knowledge (*jñāna*) is obtained. However, the knowledge involved in these statements is not any knowledge. Ritual knowledge is discarded as ineffective in *kārikā* 2, and knowledge limited to perception is also discarded. In *kārikā* 2, we are consequently told that the adequate cause for the elimination of suffering is the knowledge that discriminates between the knower (*jñā*), the unmanifest (*avyakta*) and the manifest (*vyakta*): a knowledge that the whole treatise develops in detail.

Knowledge is a *hetu*, a cause, and one of the items that must be known is the *jñā* or knower. Īśvarakṛṣṇa is dealing here with two different notions of knowledge: *puruṣa* is a knower, *jñā*, in the sense that he is conscious of *prakṛti*, but the knowledge that is the cause of liberation has as its agent or subject something other than *puruṣa*: intellect or *buddhi*. Causation and agency, in fact, belong to the realm of *prakṛti* exclusively. Īśvarakṛṣṇa clearly states that it is *prakṛti* which causes liberation (*vimocayati*) for the benefit of *puruṣa* (*puruṣārtham prati*).¹⁹ Therefore, even the agency and causation involved in liberating knowledge do not belong to the realm of the self or *puruṣa*. The self, in turn, is conceived as non-productive (*na prakṛti*) but also as a thing

¹⁷ See Perret (2016: 159).

¹⁸ See, for example, Larson's (1998 [1969]: 255) rendering of the first *kārikā*, who sees the locatives of the first verse as a complement to *jijñāsā*. "Because of the torment of the threefold suffering (arises) the desire to know the means of counteracting it. If (it is said that) this (desire—*i.e.*, inquiry) is useless because perceptible (means of removal are available), (we say) no, since (perceptible means) are not final or abiding."

¹⁹ See *Sāṃkhya-Kārikā* (SK.) 63.

not produced by another (*na vikṛti*).²⁰ It is characterized as a non-agent (*akarṣṭ*),²¹ and though it seems to be an agent (*karteva*), it is standing apart—or sitting apart—(*udāsīna*). Because agency belongs in reality to the three *guṇa* (*guṇa-karṭṛtve*), and the three *guṇa* are exclusive of *vyaktam* and *pradhana*²² (or *avyaktam*²³), i.e., of *prakṛti*.²⁴

Īśvarakṛṣṇa, hence, circumscribes causality to the realm of *prakṛti*, both the causality related to liberation, i.e., knowledge (and correct dispositions) as a means for liberation,²⁵ and the causality related to the evolution of the multiple *tattva*-s from *prakṛti*.²⁶ But our main concern in this paper is the theory of causality related to the evolution of *prakṛti*, the *liṅga-sarga* as he calls it in *kārikā* 52, and this is due to two reasons. Liberating knowledge implies the evolution of *prakṛti* in two different senses. There is no knowing (and, hence, liberating) agent if *prakṛti* has not evolved into the different *tattva*-s, and, secondly, the workings of this evolution constitute the object of liberating knowledge; its study is what brings about *jñāna*. From this perspective, causation related to liberation is secondary to and dependent on causation related to evolution.

Bhattacharyya draws an interesting distinction that helps us to explain further the limitation of our discussion of the notion of causality to the evolution of *prakṛti* in the different *tattva*-s. In his analysis of *kārikā* 52, the scholar explains that it contains a distinction between two kinds of manifestations of *buddhi*. One is the expression of the “outward grades of objective substance,” while the other is the expression of “the objective function (appearing as subjective function).” He characterizes the first as a causal and the second as a *non-causal* manifestation of the metaphysical object²⁷: “The former is what *prakṛti* becomes and the latter what it appears.”²⁸ Bhattacharyya explains that a *causal* manifestation of a real is a distinct real or *tattva*, existing distinctly *in* the cause and not as distinct *from* it, while a *non-causal* manifestation of a real is just what is called a “phenomenon.”²⁹ In the following section, we examine the so-called “causal manifestation” of *prakṛti* such as it is explained in the *Sāṃkhya-kārika*.

We must also stress that the central notion of Īśvarakṛṣṇa’s theory of causation is that of doing something that entails something (else). A prolific use of the Sanskrit

²⁰ SK. 3.

²¹ SK. 19.

²² SK. 11.

²³ SK. 14, 16.

²⁴ SK. 60.

²⁵ Which can be identified with (a specific aspect, i.e., *siddhi* or perfection, of) the *pratyaya-* or *bhāva-sarga* or intellectual creation. See SK. 46 and 63.

²⁶ Which could be identified with the *liṅga-sarga*. See SK 52. Īśvarakṛṣṇa even distinguishes a third realm of causation, the *bhautika-sarga* or the creation of divine, human and sub-human beings. See SK 53–54.

²⁷ Bhattacharyya (1956: 158).

²⁸ Bhattacharyya (1956: 161).

²⁹ Bhattacharyya (1956: 159).

verbal root *KṚ* expresses this general idea. It is present not only in the word *prakṛti* but also in most of the categories that Īśvarakṛṣṇa uses to articulate his theory. Some additional though less frequent terms are *hetu(-ka/mat)*, *nimitta*, derivatives of the root *VṚT*, *sarga*, etc. As we show in the following sections, “to do” is said in many ways: there is the product of doing, the instrument for doing, the differentiation in the doing, the doer and so on, but all of these expressions are not used merely homonymously: they refer to the same process of causal derivation and production within the realm of being.

We have already mentioned the connection that the notion of *karman* has with the performance of ritual, but the term *karman* itself appears only once in the *Sāṃkhyakārikā*, and is used to refer to the faculties of action (*karmendriya*, SK 26). The copious use of the root *KṚ* leads us to another related field of analysis (ultimately of ritual language): *grammar*, where derivatives of the same root *KṚ* are employed to name different grammatical accidents.³⁰ Louis Renou has stressed the importance of Sanskrit grammar for understanding how ancient Indian thought was articulated to the point of asserting that “to adhere to Indian thought means, first of all, to think like a grammarian” and that “Indian thought has as substructure reasonings of a grammatical nature.”³¹ We could suggest, hence, that Īśvarakṛṣṇa is reproducing the methodology that grammar uses to analyze the process of speech, recurring to terminology derived from the root *KṚ* to denominate the categories of modifications that a base (*prakṛti*) undergoes when manifested. In this sense, we could understand classical Sāṃkhya’s theory of causation not so much as a “reductive materialism” but as a grammar of being which focuses on understanding the process and rules of derivation and change within reality.

11.4 Satkāryam

Let us now analyze Īśvarakṛṣṇa’s formulation of *satkāryavāda* briefly taking into consideration the context in which the theory appears. In *kārikā* two, we read about distinguishing between the knower, the manifest and the unmanifest since this knowledge can free man from the torment of the threefold suffering. However, the unmanifest state of *prakṛti* cannot be apprehended by the senses. This is due to its extreme subtlety (*saukṣmyāt*) but not because of its non-existence (*nābhāvāt*). However, this unmanifest state of *prakṛti* is apprehended from what it is produced (*kāryam*) of which Intellect is the first. Moreover, this is different yet similar to *prakṛti* (*prakṛtivrūpaṃ sarūpaṃ ca*).³²

³⁰ See Renou (1941–1942: 464 and note 80).

³¹ “Adhérer à la pensée indienne, c’est d’abord penser en grammairien” (Renou, 1953: 86) and “La pensée indienne a pour substructure des raisonnements d’ordre grammatical” (Renou, 1942: 164) quoted and translated into English by Bronkhorst (2000: 166–173).

³² SK 8.

After having argued in this manner, Īśvarakṛṣṇa states in *kārikā* nine what has been called the “*locus classicus* for the *satkāryavāda*”³³:

*asadakaraṇād upādānagrahaṇāt sarvasambhavābhāvāt /
śaktasya śakyakaraṇāt kāraṇabhāvāc ca satkāryam //*

The structure of this *kārikā* is quite simple, though not so much its translation and interpretation. The verse states *satkāryam*, “what is produced, the effect, is existent,” and provides five ablative expressions that can be understood as the reasons for (asserting) the effect’s existence.

The expression *satkāryam* has often been interpreted as implying not only that the product or effect is real and that it exists but also that it “preexists in its material cause”³⁴ or that the “effect exists (before the operation of the cause).”³⁵ We could believe that if the word *kārya* is understood as a gerundive of the root KR, “what is to be produced”³⁶ with a sense of something to be done in the future, the *kārikā* would affirm that “what is to be produced exists,” implying that it already exists even before being produced. Nevertheless, the numerous appearances of the term *kārya* lead us to understand it differently. There are, in fact, two different uses of the term in the treatise. One is relative to the products of *prakṛti*, by which we apprehend it: *mahat* and the others. The second use is relative only to the 13-fold instrument (*karaṇam... kāryam ca tasya* SK 32) and refers to the ten objects of the ten *indriya*. Both uses, however, always imply actual products or effects alluded to as conditions for proof or evidence for an assertion.³⁷ We could even say that as long as there is the need for *tattvābhyāsa*, effects are (being or already) manifested.

We consider that the expression *satkāryam* has to be interpreted in the context of a general conception of being, *sat*, for which there is evidence both in pre-classical Sāṃkhya as well as in the commentaries of the *Sāṃkhya-kārikā*. For example,

³³ Halbfass (1992: 56).

³⁴ Halbfass (1992: 56).

³⁵ Larson (1998 [1969]: 258).

³⁶ See, for example, Monier Williams (2010: 276) and Ruppel (2017: 318).

³⁷ The term *kārya* appears in seven different *kārikā*. We have already seen that in *kārikā* 8 it is introduced to assert that the unmanifest state of *prakṛti* can be apprehended from what it is produced (*kāryam*). In this instance it cannot be understood as something to be produced in the future, because if it hadn’t been already produced there would be no means for apprehending *prakṛti* nor an individual in need of apprehending it. In *kārikā* 14 it is introduced to allude to the demonstration of the nature of its cause (*kāraṇa*). As a demonstration is involved, here too products must be referred to as having been already produced. In *kārikā* 15 the reference is to the separation or distinction (*vibhāga*) between the cause and the effect. *Kārikā* 32 introduces the term in relation to the “instrument,” and it is asserted that its products are (to be) seized, held, manifested. It is interesting to note that this three characterizations are also expressed with gerundives, but, again, it is not possible to understand them with a future sense, that of mere possibility or duty to be complied, because as long as there is manifestation, this products have been already manifested or are being manifested. In *kārikā* 43 it is said that the embryo depends on the effect. Again, *kārya* has to be understood as an actual effect, since an embryo is said to be dependent on it. It is interesting to note that *kārya* is here distinguished from *karaṇam*.

Bhagavad Gītā, in its second chapter (II 16), introduces the well-known ontological principle according to which “there is no coming to be of what is non-existent (*asat*), there is no ceasing to be of what is existent (*sat*).”³⁸ Gauḍapāda formulates a parallel statement in his *bhāṣya* to *kārikā* 9. He explains that “If it is existent (*sat*), it cannot become inexistent (*asat*), and if it is inexistent (*asat*), it cannot become existent (*sat*).”³⁹ It is interesting to bear in mind that the only other time that the treatise employs the participle *sat* to qualify something is used concerning *puruṣa* (SK 60).

Nevertheless, *kārikā* 9 is not simply repeating the ontological principle of the absolute separation between *sat* and *asat*; it combines the notion of *sat* and *kārya*. The expression *satkārya*, hence, would be asserting two different though mutually implicated thesis: that products (*kārya*) belong to the sphere of (eternal) being (*sat*), so to say, and that the existence of something *as* a product is real. The first thesis implies that a product cannot be said to come from non-being or to cease from being; the second thesis implies that cause and effect relations are real. The five ablative expressions in *kārikā* 9 justify the assertion *satkāryam*, considering the two theses just distinguished.⁴⁰

- (1) *Asad-akaraṇāt*: Given the non-causing of what is non-existent.
- (2) *upādāna-grahaṇāt*: Given the selection of the underlying cause.
- (3) *sarvasambhavābhāvāt*: Given the impossibility of a common origin of everything.
- (4) *śaktasya śakyakaraṇāt*: Because causation of that which has the potency of being produced belongs to that which has the power to produce it.
- (5) *kāraṇabhāvāt*: Given the (type of) being of the cause.

The first reason combines the opposite or correlative terms of the expression *satkāryam*: instead of “being” and “effect,” we find here “non-being” and “(non) cause,” for which we could understand that its purpose is to prove the same view denying the contrary idea. Nevertheless, the expression has been interpreted in two different ways. The term *asat* can be understood in the subjective or objective sense: “*asat* has no causing power” or “*asat* cannot be caused.” Larson and De Palma, for example, understand it in the first sense.⁴¹ Traditional commentators, León Herrera and other scholars seem to understand it in the second sense.⁴² Both readings are feasible, and neither contradicts the main tenet of Sāṃkhya regarding being and non-being. Nevertheless, we believe the second option is more adequate since the issue here is not non-being but *kārya* and its beingness. Therefore, the argument would be

³⁸ See, as well, *Yogasūtrabhāṣya* IV 11 *nāstyasataḥ sambhavaḥ, na cāsti sato vināśa iti*. “there is no coming into being of non-being (*asat*), and there is no destruction of being (*sat*).” For other references, see Halbfass (1992: 59).

³⁹ *Yadī sat asannabhavatīm, athāsat sanna bhabatīti*. Text taken from Mainkar (1972: 61).

⁴⁰ We provide a tentative translation just for the sake of analysis. All translations elsewhere introduced are also ours unless we indicate otherwise.

⁴¹ See Larson (1998 [1969]: 258) and De Palma (1992: 180).

⁴² See Wadhwani-Shah (1989: 211–224) and Herrera (2012: 387–402).

stating that as something inexistent cannot be caused, *kārya* must exist (because it is caused).⁴³

The second reason seems to address the second thesis about the reality of causation, and it does so, alluding to our experience with production. Whenever we need to produce something, we select the adequate underlying cause for that production. Gauḍapāda gives the following example: the person who wants to produce curds uses milk, not water.⁴⁴ As this is so, the fact that a product –such as curd– is a product of a specific cause has to be true.⁴⁵

The following reason insists on the reality of causation, the second thesis, and it does so from the perspective of the product. It is not possible that all the different products arise from a common origin; only one or a few might arise from a common origin, and the rest must be products of different causes. As this is so, causation is real.

Reason (4) expands the idea of selectivity within the thesis of causation by employing the terminology of power (*śakti*), and it includes both the perspectives of the cause and the product. The cause is something with the power to produce (*śakta*)⁴⁶ but only about that which has the potency of being produced by it (*śakya*). Given this correlation, causation has to be real.

The last reason seems to return to the defense of the first thesis. It can be understood as expressing the idea that the cause is something that exists (*bhāva*) and hence its product must also be existent. Alternatively, it asserts that the cause is of a certain nature (*bhāva*) and implies that the effect has to be of the same nature.⁴⁷ That nature can be understood as “belonging to the sphere of being.” Therefore, if such is the nature of the cause, the product has to belong to the sphere of being, too.⁴⁸

Having analyzed *kārikā* nine and the related notions that appear in connected sections of the treatise, we can say that Īśvarakṛṣṇa is arguing to support the two interrelated theses that state that products exist as products (*i.e.*, that causal relations are real) and that products belong to the sphere of being. He invokes our familiarity with production, perception of distinctive origination, experience with the selective character of productive power, and the abstract ontological principle that being and non-being cannot be combined. Taking this into consideration, we can understand Gauḍapāda’s conclusion in his *bhyāṣya* to this *kārikā*: “From these reasons, (we can conclude that) production (arises) from being, it does not (arise) from non-being.”⁴⁹

⁴³ That *kārya* has a cause is established in *kārikā* 8 and 10. En 8 it is said that *prakṛti* can be apprehended through its effects (implying that *prakṛti* is their cause), and in 10 Īśvarakṛṣṇa says that *vyakta* is *hetumat*. This notion is stressed in *kārikā* 14, 16 and others.

⁴⁴ See Mainkar (1972: 61–62).

⁴⁵ For a psychological interpretation of this compound see Burley (2007: 94ff).

⁴⁶ Gauḍapāda gives the following examples. Of *śakta*: the potter and the instruments and materials he uses for production; of *śakya*: a jar or a pot. See Mainkar (1972: 62–63).

⁴⁷ This idea is taken up in *kārikā* 14 as a proof for the existence of *avyakta*.

⁴⁸ A parallel idea is introduced in *kārikā* 8, where the products are said to be similar (*sarūpa*) and different (*virūpa*) to *prakṛti*. The differences between *vyakta* and *avyakta* are explained in *kārikā* 10, while the similarities in *kārikā* 11.

⁴⁹ *Tasmāt sata utpattiḥ, nāsata iti*. See Mainkar (1972: 62).

The commentator's assertion implies both ideas, that there is production (*utpatti*) and that it can only occur in the realm of being.

There is one last issue that we would like to address. We explained that Īśvarakṛṣṇa adheres to the ontological principle of exclusion between *sat* and *asat*, for which reason, if causation is considered real, it must belong to the realm of *sat*. However, if this is so, how does our treatise explain the passage from cause to product, from *avyakta* to *vyakta* and from one productive *tattva* to the *tattva* produced by it?

In 56, we read *eṣaḥ prakṛtikṛto mahadādiviśeṣabhūtaparyantaḥ*: "This, the limit of which is the distinct gross elements and which has *mahat* as its first term, (is) produced by *prakṛti*."

In Sect. 11.3 we suggested that Īśvarakṛṣṇa reproduces the methodology that grammar uses to study speech since he employs a series of derivatives of the verbal root *KṚ* as categories for the analysis of the workings of causality. In this *kārikā*, it is asserted that the products (*kārya*) are produced (*kṛta*) by *prakṛti*. Being and non-being exclude one another, and being is thus eternal, but there is room for activity and production in the realm of being. This activity and production, this causal activity, is systematically categorized in terms of *KṚ*. We find, in fact, twenty four nominal derivatives of the root *KṚ* in the treatise that appear more than fifty times in total. These terms are: *prakṛti* 3, 22, 42, 45, 56, 59, 61, 62, 63, 65; *prākṛtika* 43; *vikṛti* 3; *avikṛti* 3; *vaikṛta* 25, 43; *vikāra* 3; *kārya* 8, 14, 15, 32, 43; *kāryatas* 8; *kṛta* 21, 55, 56 (70); *karaṇa* 9, 18, 29, 31, 32, 33, 35, 47; *akaraṇa* 9; *kāraṇa* 9, 14, 15, 16; *akāraṇa* 67; *karṭṛ* 20; *karṭṛtva* 20; *akartṛ* 19; *kriyā* 58; *sakriya* 10; *karmendriya* 26; *ahamkāra* 22, 24, 25; *samskāra* 67; *antaḥkaraṇa* 33, 35; *anupakārin* 60; *upakāriṇī* 60.⁵⁰ These different expressions are employed either as categories which imply the role of a certain thing in the process of causation (such as *prakṛti*, *vikṛti*, *vikāra*, *avikṛti*, *karaṇa*, *kārya* and others) or as a denomination of a group of products (such as *antaḥkaraṇa*), or as a denomination of an individual product (such as *ahamkāra*), or as a descriptive term (such as *upakāriṇī*, *karṭṛ*, *kṛta*), etc. They mean different things, but they are used concerning one central idea: the process of production and causation. Even when they are predicated from *puruṣa* (such as *akartṛ* or *anupakārin*), the purpose is to deny any relationship with production or causation to it. Let us also analyze one *kārikā* in which this vocabulary is used significantly.

"Primordial *prakṛti* (*mūlaprakṛti*) is not produced (*avikṛti*). The seven - the great one, etc. are both produced and productive (*prakṛti-vikṛti*). The sixteen are produced (*vikāras*). *Puruṣa* is neither produced nor productive (*na prakṛtir na vikṛtiḥ*)."⁵¹ As we can see, Īśvarakṛṣṇa uses here four different derivatives of the root *KṚ* to explain what we can term the workings of causality. *Avikṛti* implies that something is not a production of another thing and is predicated on *mūlaprakṛti*. *Prakṛti* can be understood here as "productive" and is used to deny productivity to *puruṣa* and ascribe productivity to many of the *tattva*-s evolved from *prakṛti*. *Vikṛti* implies that something is a transformation of something else. It is predicated on seven of the

⁵⁰ We also find the conjugated form *kāryate* in 31, a causative of the passive voice.

⁵¹ We follow Larson's translation (1998 [1969]: 256) though we left the term *prakṛti* untranslated and changed the terms "created" and "creative" for "produced" and "productive."

tattva-s. *Vikāra*, lastly, is used to classify the *tattva*-s that stand at the end of the production sequence, being a product but not producing other *tattva*-s.

We can see, hence, that Īśvarakṛṣṇa uses two central notions in his system, drawing from tradition both the principles and the linguistic instruments to articulate his philosophy. He takes the notion of being as expressed by the root AS and the notion of action or production as expressed by the root KṚ. He defends the existence of two principles to which he attributes being. One is *puruṣa* (SK 60), and the other is *prakṛti*.⁵² The first one is not related to production, neither as a producer nor as a product. The second one is the realm of regulated production itself (*prakṛti*)⁵³ and, hence, of causality. We can say, lastly, that for Īśvarakṛṣṇa, the notion of production implies the notion of being since only what belongs to the sphere of being can undergo a process of production. (Eternal) Being, hence, is a necessary condition for production and causation. However, the notion of being does not necessarily imply production and causality since *puruṣa* belongs to the realm of eternal being but is free from any internal and external causal relation and change.

11.5 Conclusions

In the present paper, we offered a discussion and an analysis of the notion of *satkārya*, taking into consideration both the specific way in which Īśvarakṛṣṇa articulates his thought and some problems regarding the interpretation of the so-called *satkāryavāda*. We suggested firstly that the reflection on causation in ancient Indian philosophy was deliberate, conscious, explicit, systematic and nuanced. The contrast and polemics between schools that denied causation and defended different conceptions of causality made this evident. We then discussed some of the problems entailed in the most usual way of understanding Classical Sāṃkhya's theory of causation, which sees *prakṛti* as an entity and as a material cause. In the first part of the third section, we distinguished two different senses in which causation can be understood in the *Sāṃkhya-kārikā* and showed that the main sense is the one related to the evolution of *prakṛti* into subsequent *tattva*-s. In the second part, we analyzed *kārikā* nine and suggested that we have to understand the notion of *satkārya* as implying two correlative theses. One thesis is that products or effects, that is, the *tattva*-s evolved from *prakṛti*, belong to the sphere of (eternal) being. The other one is that relations of cause and effect are real. The second thesis implies the first because if we accept that causation is real, (causes and) effects must belong to the sphere of eternal being. We also examined the different reasons that Īśvarakṛṣṇa gives in favor of these theses. Finally, we showed that Īśvarakṛṣṇa employs derivatives of the verbal root KṚ to categorize the inner life, so to say, of being, in order to explain caused change

⁵² Technically *sat* is predicated of *kāryam* in SK.9. But existence is also predicated of the cause, (*karaṇa*) in SK 16, where we can read "the cause exists as not manifested and it comes forth by the combination of the three *guṇa*."

⁵³ Also qualified as *upakāriṇī* in SK 60, for example.

without contradicting the main ontological principle of the mutual exclusion of being and non-being. Given that Indian grammar applies a parallel linguistic procedure, we suggested that the classical Sāṃkhya's conception of causation can be understood as a grammar of being since it seeks to explain the process and rules of derivation and change within being. We can add, finally, that though for Sāṃkhya being (*sat*) is unchanging about its beingness, Īśvarakṛṣṇa articulates a philosophy for which there can be enough room within being for regulated transformation, i.e., caused change understood in terms of action or production.

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Chapter 12

Relationship of Puruṣa and Prakṛti in Sāṃkhya Kārikā—A Perspective from Quantum Theory



Siegfried Bleher

Abstract In the Sāṃkhya Kārikā of Īśvakraṣṇa, the notion of proximity or affinity Puruṣa bears in relationship to Prakṛti is presented as the reason Prakṛti evolves: “The presence of the Spirit by the side of the Prakṛti is sufficient to make the latter evolve, by disturbing the equipoise of the constituents.” At the same time, however, Puruṣa is regarded to be neither producer (“cause”) nor product (“caused”). And, although *mahat* or *buddhi* is the tool that discerns, it is *acetana*, it lacks consciousness that one might consider necessary for the presence of discernment. What appear to be contradictions or difficulties with the Kārikā, resolved in various ways by commentators or later texts, may also be viewed as the inevitable consequence of limitations with language. (By this we mean the limitations of language if restricted to classical or Boolean logic. An alternative form of logic is that proposed by Birkhoff and von Neumann to be appropriate for quantum mechanics. (Birkhoff & Birkhoff, G., & Von Neumann, J. (1936). *The Logic of Quantum Mechanics*. *Annals of Mathematics*, 823–843) An alternative language that may help reconceptualize the relationship between Puruṣa and Prakṛti is that of mathematical physics. Emergence of structure in complex systems, for example, appears to require external organizing intelligence, but does not when such systems “self-organize.” (“A self-organizing system acts autonomously, as if the interconnecting components had a single mind. And as these components spontaneously march to the beat of their own drummer, they organize, adapt, and evolve toward a greater complexity than one would ever expect by just looking at the parts by themselves” [Samuels, L. K. (2013). *In Defense of Chaos: The Chaology of Politics, Economics and Human Action*. BookBaby]) The specific way in which microscopic systems evolve observably when they are governed by the rules of quantum mechanics is indeterminable without specifying macroscopic boundary conditions, such specification seemingly requiring the influence of a conscious observer. With a focus specifically on the classic non-theistic version of Sāṃkhya of Īśvakraṣṇa, and Patañjali’s Yoga Sūtra, we describe a conceptualization of consciousness that addresses the difficulties in the Kārikā mentioned

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above and that agrees with at least one of the many interpretations of quantum mechanics.

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12.1 Introduction

The author arrives at the thesis of the present article by way of professional training in theoretical physics and a decades-long interest in ontology, both from the perspective of Western philosophy and from training in Rāja yoga in the tradition of B.K.S. Iyengar. This article explains how quantum theory may provide insights into some of the difficulties presented in the classical non-theistic Sāṃkhya Karika, such as what precisely is the relationship between a Puruṣa who is not a doer, and a Prakṛti that is unintelligent or *acetana*—what does proximity of Puruṣa and Prakṛti mean, and how can it be causally effective? Our argument is presented in three parts. In Part I we briefly describe how quantum theory arose at the beginning of the twentieth century as the solution to an empirical problem. The philosophical implications of quantum theory include a reappraisal of the causal closure or causal completeness of classical physics¹ and the subsequent relevance of this reappraisal for a scientific account of the origin and causal effectiveness of consciousness. In Part II we present an outline of what physicist Henry Stapp calls a quantum ontology of consciousness. In this theory, the Copenhagen interpretation of quantum mechanics as strictly an epistemological tool to make empirical predictions is amended with the ontological notion that a phenomenon does not exist until it is observed. We describe how this ontological view of quantum theory is consistent with John von Neumann's axiomatic theory of quantum mechanics. Part III links the quantum ontology of consciousness to Sāṃkhya philosophy and some elements in Patañjali's Yoga Sūtra. Specifically, we argue in this part there is correspondence between *vyakta*, what is manifested in nature according to Sāṃkhya philosophy, with phenomena accurately described by classical physics on the one hand, and on the other, between *avyakta*, what is the unmanifested ground of natural phenomena in Sāṃkhya philosophy, with what is unobserved and describable only through quantum wave functions or quantum density functions. The identification rests on the deterministic nature of each, as well as their dual nature—manifest and unmanifest.

¹ Causal closure of the physical world means that every physical event has a physical explanation (Davidson, 2001). This principle is related to determinism, but not identical, since a causally closed system may admit random forces that results in indeterminate evolution of the system, even though it is causally closed.

12.2 Part I Quantum Theory

In the late 1890s physicists found a discrepancy between the observed spectrum of blackbody² or thermal radiation and theoretical predictions. In fact, classical theory predicted that each colour in the spectrum of thermal radiation should be equally represented. That is, the energy radiated by a blackbody is equal in each of an infinite number of modes (colours). Since the total energy radiated is additive over all colours, this leads to the unreasonable prediction that an infinite amount of energy is radiated, and to the expectation that most of the energy is radiated in the high frequency range of the spectrum (since higher frequency modes contain greater energy). What is observed, however, is that the spectrum peaks at a frequency that depends on the temperature of the object: the hotter the object, the bluer it appears. Max Planck solved this problem in 1901 by postulating that thermal radiation is emitted in smaller numbers at higher frequencies than at lower, and that it is radiated in discrete amounts rather than in continuously varying amounts. Moreover, Planck provided the link between frequency and energy that explains why radiation with higher energy appears bluer, radiation with lower energy redder. Planck used the term “quanta” to represent discrete amounts of radiation, or matter, or electricity (Planck, 1901). This was the birth of the “quantum.” In 1905, Albert Einstein proposed that light itself (and electromagnetic radiation in general) is radiated and absorbed in discrete amounts, now called photons, and used this to explain the photoelectric effect, according to which electrons on a metallic surface can be expelled from the surface by absorbing light only if the light has the right amount of discrete energy.

Attempts to understand the structure of atoms by Ernest Rutherford and Niels Bohr in the early 1910s led to the notion that not only does light get absorbed and emitted in discrete packets (amounts, which may be individual particles or amounts of energy), but particles exhibit dual-like nature as well: they can behave like waves under certain conditions such as Thomas Young’s double-slit experiment. In the double-slit experiment, particles emitted from a source propagate towards a barrier containing two narrow slits that permit the particles to go through. On the other side of the barrier the arrival of the particles that make it through the slits is detected and recorded by a detector screen. When coherent monochromatic light, such as laser light, propagates through the two slits, the pattern detected on the screen shows alternating regions of dark and light, indicating that the portion of a wave that propagates through one slit interferes with the portion of the wave that propagates through the other slit. The same behaviour is observed when particles are sent through the slits instead of light. That is, the particles that impinge on the slits behave as though each particle is a wave that sees and goes through both slits at the same time, as a wave would. This experiment confirmed the wave-like nature of particles such as electrons and

² A blackbody is an object that is perfectly absorbing of all incoming light—that is, it reflects none of it. Since it absorbs energy, it also radiates energy and appears to be a certain colour that depends on its temperature.

neutrons. The effort to account for this dual nature of both particles and light led to the discovery of the Schrödinger equation, and Heisenberg's uncertainty principle.³

However, along with excellent agreement of this theory with experiment, came conceptual difficulties interpreting the theory. Specifically, if electrons and photons alike sometimes behave like particles, and at other times like waves, then what *are* they? That is, does the quantum wave function represent something real—is it ontological, or does it only represent the best we can know about something we cannot see with our senses—is it an epistemological tool? Niels Bohr, Werner Heisenberg, Max Born, and others, who represented the Copenhagen school, believed in the pragmatic or epistemological interpretation of the formalism of quantum mechanics, according to which the wave function is only an abstract representation of our knowledge and that there are limits to what we can know about any physical system. According to this view, the wave function contains the maximum amount of information about a particle or a system of particles that can be known. And, since the wave function is a probabilistic object that only tells us the likelihood of the location and momentum (or other dynamical properties) of a particle or collection of particles before such properties are measured, such properties cannot be claimed to have an independent existence.

Until we observe it, the wave function tracks the time evolution of either a finite set or a countably infinite set of classically describable alternative trajectories of particles, only one of which is ever observed at a time. For example, once a measurement or observation is made, the many possible locations of a particle whose propagation is continuously evolved by the Schrödinger equation are “reduced” or “collapsed” to a single location. Moreover, if the experimenter chooses to measure one physical variable such as location, then she gives up any knowledge of the canonically conjugate variable (such as momentum): this fact Niels Bohr called the complementarity principle: certain aspects of nature occur in pairs such that only one of them is empirically accessible to arbitrary precision in any given experimental setup.

In practice, what this means is that when certain physical features of microscopic systems are observed, our attempts to observe them unavoidably disturb the systems in unpredictable ways. The philosophical implications of this are far-reaching: (1) quantum theory has revealed the unavoidable and irreducible entanglement of the observer or subject with the object of observation, (2) the causal closure of classical mechanics no longer holds,⁴ (3) until we look at something, we cannot say it is a definite “thing,” as its representation with the Schrödinger equation is a superposition

³ The Schrödinger equation describes the time evolution of a single particle or a collection of interacting particles as a wave that represents a possible configuration or arrangement of the particles (or location of a single particle). The wave is complex valued in a mathematical sense, so it is not observable. The Heisenberg uncertainty principle states that although the Schrödinger carries with it the maximum amount of information we can know about a system of particles, there is a limit to what we can measure—if we choose to measure one physical quantity such as location accurately, then we must relinquish knowledge of what is called a canonically conjugate physical quantity—in this case momentum (and vice-versa).

⁴ One might argue that the experimenter can be included in the time evolution of a more comprehensive wave function. As long as that wave function is not observed, many alternative trajectories of the system that includes the experimenter will be evolved that includes, for example, the many

of all the possible states the object can exist in, given the boundary conditions chosen by the experimenter. This implies that, until a measurement is made, the object has no definite location or momentum—that is, our lack of knowledge is not a statistical lack of information or a limited precision in our instruments, but a fundamental and irreducible inability to pin down specific properties of the object, (4) the fact that we ourselves are composed of the same microscopic constituents as we observe with our senses (including extended senses of instrumentation) implies that our physical, physiological, neurophysiological functions, and so on are also subject to the same laws of quantum mechanics.⁵

12.3 Part II: Quantum Theory of Consciousness

In this part, we outline a few key aspects of what Henry Stapp calls a quantum ontology of consciousness (Stapp, 2011). The key aspects are (1) a partitioning of an act of observation into several processes, one of which is purely physical, the others of which are psychological in nature, (2) irreducible holistic psychophysical events consisting of the combination of the physical aspect and the psychological aspects (that is, observation in Stapp's theory cannot be reduced to physical events—see subsection below), (3) an accounting for the quantum underpinnings of the neuropsychology of decision-making, and (4) the extension of what is essentially an anthropocentric description of the appearance and evolution of observable reality to one that accounts for the evolution of nature prior to human consciousness.

12.3.1 *Partitioning of Observation into Separate Processes and Its Holistic Nature*

Mathematician John von Neumann's formulates in (Von Neumann, 2018) an axiomatic theory of quantum mechanics in which he partitions the evolution of quantum wave functions into two separate temporal processes: process 2 that tracks the continuous time evolution of the wave function according to the Schrödinger

alternative trajectories particles and fields in the experimenter's brain can follow. The argument fails however once we include "seeing" or the act of observing, which the Schrödinger equation does not include. The only way the experimenter appears in the Schrödinger equation is by providing the frame of reference that determines the space and set of "possible alternative trajectories" for the system.

⁵ There are competing interpretations of quantum mechanics, such as the non-collapse or many worlds version that we have not discussed. Stapp makes convincing arguments for choosing the von Neumann version. As in the previous footnote, we mention here the Schrödinger equation does not include the act of observation of the experimenter.

equation (or its relativistic version in quantum field theory),⁶ and process 1, which he calls an “intervention,” that is responsible for selecting one of several or many possible alternative classically describable outcomes of an experiment. That is, when an experiment is performed, the conditions of the experiment must be determined by the experimenter, such as which physical variable is to be measured. If we use the example of the double-slit experiment, the experimenter can either choose to measure the location of the arrival of a particle that goes through the slits on a detection screen, or its momentum, but cannot measure both at the same time. Process 2 in this description is the evolution of the particle from the source to the slits, through the slits, and to the detection screen. Process 1 consists of the sudden collapse of the wave function upon striking the detection screen while it is being observed, to determine where on the screen the particle lands.

There are questions about when and why exactly does the collapse happen—is it during the physical process of absorption of the particle by the screen, or only when the observer becomes conscious that the absorption has occurred? And is consciousness causing the collapse? Ideas about decoherence, for example, claim that it is the interaction of a particle with the molecules of the detector that causes the “collapse” (Wheeler & Zurek, 2014),⁷ but Von Neumann argues that any step leading up to but not including the event “particle is observed to land at position X” can be folded into the deterministic process 2 describable by the Schrödinger equation; the specific moment of recognition by the observer that the physically describable event “particle has landed at X” has occurred is what is meant by process 1.

Process 1, which encapsulates the participation of an observer, can be further partitioned into the process whereby the experimenter selects the boundary conditions for the experiment, which Stapp calls process 0; process 1, in the stricter sense of the moment of performing the action of measuring or observing (which is responsible for the collapse of the wave function); and process 3 that is the particular choice made by nature⁸ from among its alternatives carried forward by the Schrödinger equation.

At the end of process 3 there is an observed or measured result that entangles the psychological process with the physical as the holistic quantum of action:

The observation itself changes the probability function discontinuously; it selects of all possible events the actual one that has taken place. (Heisenberg, *Physics and Philosophy*, 1958b: 54)

In the words of physicist John Archibald Wheeler,

⁶ Although process 2 occurs before process 1, we identify these events with nomenclature adopted by von Neumann (Von Neumann, 2018).

⁷ A wave that has many components or “wavelets” (that may represent many particles in the case of wave function) retains its shape and integrity (coherence) as long as the component wavelets do not interact with the environment. Once it interacts with the environment, the wave begins to decohere—its individual components interact differentially with the environment, which causes the wave to lose its shape and integrity.

⁸ Note that the equations and postulates of quantum theory are not able to predict which alternative outcome gets selected upon measurement or observation from among those evolved by the Schrödinger equation; the Born rule (named after Max Born) permits us to calculate probabilities for each alternative outcome.

No elementary phenomenon is a phenomenon until it is a registered (observed) phenomenon.
(Scully & Scully, 2010)

12.3.2 *Quantum Underpinnings of Brain Function*

The relevance of this aspect of Stapp's theory is clear: postulates and procedures of quantum theory used to describe physical and chemical systems should also apply to brain function and other life processes. The question which remains under active study is whether quantum processes in the brain are *functional*. That is, do quantum phenomena influence sensations, thoughts, or feelings of observers? Evidence to date appears to be limited to influence of quantum phenomena on certain biological functions, such as efficiency of photosynthesis (Rebentrost et al., 2009; Sarovar et al., 2010; Vattay et al., 2014), navigation in migratory birds through perception of the earth's magnetic field (Ritz et al., 2009), and enhancement of enzyme reaction rates due to quantum tunnelling (Cha et al., 1989; McFadden & Al-Khalili, 2016).

In the present context, we ask whether quantum processes are associated with intention and decision-making? Since at least the 1990s several researchers answer in the affirmative, but there is little agreement on the specific form this association takes, nor is there conclusive empirical support for any of the existing theories. We mention only three theories that seem plausible. The first is that of Henry Stapp (Stapp, 2011), who suggests there is a close association between moments of conscious awareness and collapse of wave functions at the scale of nerve synapses.⁹ These moments are, in his view, the actual occasions A. N. Whitehead describes in (Whitehead & Sherburne, 1957). Penrose and Hameroff (Hameroff, 2001) propose that the stream of consciousness is similarly composed of Whiteheadian "occasions," but these take place in cytoskeletal structures called microtubules, and the collapse of the wave function in a brain happens spontaneously due to a process they call "Orchestrated Objective Reduction." The third idea comes from McFadden (McFadden, 2002), who attributes conscious awareness to the information carried by the endogenous electromagnetic fields generated within and around brain neurons.

The issue for these theories is to show one of two things. One is to show the process 2 time evolution that is known to occur at the scale of individual molecules¹⁰

⁹ Nerve cells (neurons) receive electrical impulses from other neurons through thin branches called dendrites. The emitting neurons send such impulses through axons which end at small gaps called synapses near dendrites of the receiving neurons. When the electrical impulse arrives at the end of the axon, chemicals called neurotransmitters are released into the synapses, which causes small channels to open at the dendrite that allow charged particles (ions) to move through small channels from outside the membrane of the dendrite to inside, which causes the electrical impulse to then be carried to the dendrite and into the cell body of the receiving neuron. It is at the level of such ions that Stapp believes that moments of conscious awareness are associated with collapse of wave functions.

¹⁰ Ion transport through neural synapses in Stapp's theory, or electron transport in the tubulin molecules of neuronal cell membranes in Hameroff's theory, or the electromagnetic field generated by individual ions in McFadden's theory.

can influence feelings and thoughts. For this to happen, quantum coherence (and perhaps quantum entanglement) must be shown to persist in the noisy wet thermal environment of the brain long enough and over wide enough spatial scales to be functionally relevant. The other option is to show that process 1 interventions occur rapidly enough to prevent quantum wave functions from dissipating in a thermal environment. The quantum Zeno effect is such a possibility, preferred by Stapp, and known to play a role in the enhancement of efficiency in transport of electronic excitation in photosynthetic green sulfur bacteria (Mohseni et al., 2008; Rebentrost et al., 2009).

12.3.3 *Is Stapp's Quantum Ontology Physicalism?*

It is important for the argument in the final section for us to clarify that Stapp's theory is not a physicalist or materialist account of the mind-brain connection. In fact, he states in (Stapp, 2011) that conventional quantum theory has a “*causal gap* in the purely physical description.” This gap is what prevents classical mechanics from being causally closed, on the one hand, and it is what distinguishes Stapp's quantum ontology from physicalist accounts of consciousness.

I note, however, that physicalist accounts of the mind-brain connection contain elements close in kind to what I take to be the *prakṛti* side of Sāṃkhya philosophy.¹¹ A detailed treatment is not possible in the present context, but I highlight a few principles from physicalism I regard as overlapping with the Sāṃkhya philosophy account of the evolutes of *prakṛti*¹²: the token identity principle of reductive physicalism (Taylor, 1967), the principle of emergence (Aristotle, 1933; Ashby, 1968; Broad, 1925; Lewis, 2000; Lewis & Ferrari, 2001; Samuels, 2013), supervenience (Davidson, 1967), and Anomalous Monism (Davidson, 2001).

According to the principle of token identity, each individual mental event that is deemed the cause of a physical event must be associated with a traceable sequence of intermediate events governed by the laws of physics that culminates in the observed physical event. Similarly, each physical event that is deemed to be the cause of a mental event must be associated with a traceable sequence of intermediate events governed by the laws of physics that culminates in the mental event.

Although this picture appears to be a straightforward example of reductive physicalism, the full story of the relationship between mental events and physical events

¹¹ By this I mean to say that if one were to read only the parts of the SK that refer to the evolutes of *prakṛti* without mention of *puruṣa*, one might arrive at something like physicalism. There are, of course, esoteric aspects of *prakṛti* that fall outside of a strict reading of physicalism.

¹² The comparison we make here is between *principles* underlying Western philosophies of mind and Sāṃkhya philosophy. We are not considering whether the comparisons can be made in specific instances such as, for example, whether token identity physicalism and Sāṃkhya philosophy can both give comparable accounts of the relationship between the mind state characterized by the experience of pain and the neurophysiological conditions that may correlate with this mind state.

need not be reductive, if we permit for the following elements to hold: (a) the particular set of intermediate events that links between any pair of mental and physical events is not unique (this is essentially Hilary Putnam's argument of multiple realizability (Putnam, 1967); (b) the domain of physical events (for example neural correlates of mental events) on which it may be said mental events supervene is subject to self-organizing behaviour—specifically emergence of more complex levels of organization with new capacities and behaviours that cannot be predicted from the less complex levels; (c) the range or world of mental events is also subject to self-organization (for example through reasoning [Hodgson, 2012], and as modelled in the field of developmental psychology [Lewis, 1995, 2000; Lewis & Ferrari, 2001])—this is essentially the argument of anomalous monism (Davidson, 1967).

The world of the quantum not only vitiates the principle of causal closure of the physical, but it introduces the role of consciousness—which we regard to be distinct from the mental as it appears in most Western philosophies of mind.

12.3.4 *What Happened Before Humans Evolved?*

The need for a non-anthropocentric account of cosmology is made clear by considering the tracks made by charged particles moving through a cloud chamber. As Stapp points out:

Von Neumann's analysis of measurements shows that for all practical purposes one can assume that an appearing track actually came into being without any dependence upon our observations of it. But some sort of intervention is then needed, and a natural possibility is that any actual intervention is formally like an actual human observation. (Stapp, 2011)

I regard this step as the least well-developed, although Bertrand Russell has made an attempt with his Russellian Monism, Alfred North Whitehead with his process philosophy, which Stapp regards as a sophisticated form of panpsychism (Stapp, 2011).

12.4 Part III: Sāṃkhya-Yoga and Quantum Theory

In this third part, we review a few verses from the Sāṃkhya Kārikā of Īśvarakṛṣṇa (SK), and Patanjali's Yoga Sutra (YS) that seem relevant to the quantum theory of consciousness described in Part II. The verses and their translations are taken from (Mainkar, 1972); translations of the YS are drawn from (Feuerstein, 1989). An important consideration when we compare the yogic traditions with modern physics is that, although they each attempt to outline a consistent cosmology of nature, they each do so from a very different starting point. Whereas modern physics begins with a third-person perspective inquiry, Sāṃkhya-Yoga begins with a first-person perspective. Presumably, if they are each to conclude with universal statements that

are inclusive of first-person and third-person observations, each must reach in its cosmology overlap with the other's initial domain of inquiry. One the other hand, the language for one will necessarily appear different from the other due to this difference in starting points, as well as the wide gap in time that separates each respective era of development.

12.4.1 *Primary Constituents in Physics and Sāṃkhya-Yoga Philosophy*

One example is the notion of fundamental elements that make up observable nature: the *mahabhūtas* may indeed be intended to represent fundamental irreducible elements in nature, but they appear to be inspired by experiential qualities of solidity, fluidity, airiness, etc., rather than by a categorization of atomic structure as in the periodic table. The common ground here may be said to be the five phases all objects in nature can exist in: solid, liquid, gaseous, plasma, and complete absence of any objects—vacuum. Another example are the *triguṇas*, which may be compared with Einstein's (and Minkowski's) characterization of the space–time continuum.¹³ In a Minkowski space–time diagram (Minkowski, 2013), the horizontal axis represents space, the vertical axis represents time, and two diagonal lines represent particles such as photons that always travel at the speed of light. Any particle in nature when stationary exhibits inertia—the particle is represented in the Minkowski diagram by a point that moves upwards along the vertical time axis (*tamas*) but does not move along the spatial axis. A particle that has no mass (no inertia) is always found along the light cone and exhibits luminosity (*sattva*). When a particle that has mass is moving, it is represented by a point that moves along a curved path inside the light cone, which is the upper region of the diagram bounded by the two diagonal lines along which light travels, hence associated with activity (*rajas*). There is a fourth kind of behaviour that can be represented in this diagram. If an object has physical width, which all objects do (unless they are so small as to be effectively treatable as though point-like), then different parts of the extended object are considered spacelike-separated when observed at the same time. That is each part has its own light cone. Similarly, two particles that have interacted and become (quantum) entangled in the past may separate and bear persistent correlations even though they no longer interact. Such cases are not obviously represented by the *triguṇas*, but they do appear in quantum theory in particles that are quantum entangled.

¹³ Although the *guṇas* are unobservable and particles are observable, *all* particles may be said to carry one or more of the three qualities described by the Minkowski diagram. These qualities describe particles (and more subtle entities such as states of mind) without being themselves directly observable.

12.4.2 Causation in Physics and Sāṃkhya-Yoga Philosophy

We argue in this section that parallels exist in the concepts of causation between modern physics and Sāṃkhya-Yoga philosophy.¹⁴ Recall the discussion in Part II of four processes that take place in quantum theory before a measurement can be said to have taken place: select the boundary conditions of an experiment (process zero, which the experimenter decides), run the experiment (process 2, which nature conducts), observe the results of the experiment (process 1 that collapses the wave function), and the choice by nature of which of the possible outcomes manifests to the observer (process 3, which nature conducts). Consider each in turn.

The conscious decision by an experimenter in choosing boundary conditions for the experiment has greater implications in quantum mechanics than for classical mechanics. Since complementary properties in quantum theory cannot be measured simultaneously, the order we choose to measure physical properties leads to different outcomes in quantum mechanics, whereas in classical mechanics the order does not matter. Two sutras in the YS appear to relate to this situation, sutras IV.3 and III.15.

Yoga Sutra IV.3 *nimittam-aprayojakam prakṛtīnām varaṇa-bhedas-tu tataḥ kṣetrikavat* “The incidental-cause does not initiate the processes of evolution, but [merely is responsible for] the singling-out of possibilities—like a farmer [who irrigates a field by selecting appropriate pathways for the water].”

Feuerstein interprets the incidental-causes (*nimitta*) to be subliminal traits (*vāsanā*). Insofar as such traits reside within the *antaḥkaraṇa*, it may be said that they are also responsible for the choice an experimenter makes. This sutra implies such choices do not cause specific experimental outcomes, but they select the possible paths nature can take (Stapp’s process zero). Moreover, the act of observing (process 1) does not cause a particular outcome to appear—it is responsible for an instantaneous shift in nature from existing in a dynamic condition of time evolution of many potential and unobservable outcomes to a single observable outcome.

YS III.15 *krama-anyatvaṃ pariṇāma anyatve hetuḥ* “The differentiation in the sequence is the reason for the differentiation in the transformations.”

In this sutra we read a similar principle to that underlying Bohr’s principle of complementarity—that the outcome of two or more observations of any physical system governed by quantum mechanics depends on the order in which such observations are made. Hence, at microscopic scales we can only see a projection or shadow of what is there in any single observation. The common interpretation of sutra III.15 is that incremental changes that are barely perceptible lead to perceptible changes. We are interpreting this sutra in a very different way—that *krama* in this case refers to the importance of the order events occur in at a minute scale, not merely that one event follows the other. Moreover, if the order did not matter, then there would not exist all three kinds of transformation (*pariṇāma*).

The primary aim of this article is to address arguments in the Sāṃkhya Kārikā for the relationships among what is unseen (*prakṛti—avyakta*), what is seen (*vyakta*),

¹⁴ We rely on translations of the SK by Mainkar (Mainkar, 1972), but add where needed the Sanskrit terms in square brackets from (Virupakshananda, 2015).

and the seer (*puruṣa*), and attributions of consciousness and non-agency to the latter, but of intellect and agency to the former. We argue that arguments made in the SK are consistent with aspects of quantum theory, and that they both imply there exists an anomalous kind of causation that is distinct from the classical physics view of causation.

On the existence of the unseen *prakṛti* and its general relationship with the seen (the evolutes of *prakṛti*) we have the following four verses. In the first two the unseen is inferred to exist by what is seen and to predate what is seen. The following verses describe the unseen as cause of the seen and composed of primary constituents.

Verse 8 of SK: That original principle is not seen on account of its subtlety, not on account of its non-existence. It is perceived through its effects. Mahat, the intellect, and others are its effects and are both like the Prakṛti, the cause, as well as unlike it.

Verse 9 of SK: Effect subsists even prior to the operation of the cause: for that which does not exist cannot be by any means brought into existence: further, only appropriate materials are selected; everything is not by every means possible: capable causes produce only that which they are competent to produce; and the effect is not different from the cause.

Verse 15 of SK: A general cause, the Unevolved is to be regarded as existing because specific objects are finite [*bhedānām parimāṇāt*]; since there is homogeneity [*samanvayāt*]; since effects exist through energy [*śaktiḥ pravṛtteḥ*]; since there is an issuing forth of effect from the cause [*kāraṇa-kārya vibhāgāt*]; and since there is a reunion of the universe [*avibhāgāt vaiśvarūpyasya*].

Verse 16 of SK: This general cause, the Avyakta, functions by means of the three Guṇas, the constituents, both individually and in their combination [*samudayāt*]. It is modified [*pariṇāmataḥ*] like water [*salilavat*] by the specific nature residing in the respective constituents [*prati-prati-guṇa-āśraya-viśeṣāt*].

The unseen, constituted by the *guṇas*, may be compared with process 2 evolution of a wave function according to the Schrödinger equation (or its relativistic versions). In this case, the wave function is not observable for two reasons: it represents a set of probabilities, only one of which will ultimately be observed, and it contains imaginary components (in the mathematical sense). The wave function and its propagation are mathematical inferences, its discovery based on a lengthy interplay of experiment and mathematical insights described in Part I. Despite the fact the wave function is not directly observable, it does contain all the information that can be observed if a measurement is made: the relativistic wave function, when it is informed by the process 0 boundary conditions to be selected by the observer, is composed of dynamical elements as well as unchanging parameters (such as masses of particles, electric charge, spin). Since most of what we see around us, as well as our internal physiological processes, is governed by the electromagnetic force, wave functions for such processes all have embedded within their structure and content the properties

of light. Hence, put together, we could justifiably claim that wave functions describe in a general sense the interplay of the three *guṇas*.¹⁵

A stronger argument is possible than the one presented above for the correspondence of *avyakta*, *vyakta*, and *puruṣa* with the un-collapsed wave function, collapsed (observed) phenomenon, and the collapsing consciousness, respectively. We know the quantum formalism is a necessary inference from the result of empirical studies of the early 1900s, but can a realm with the characteristics of the quantum be inferred to exist from observations made by the authors of the SK?

Verses 15 and 16 argue that properties of *vyakta* lead us to infer the existence of *avyakta*. But they also appear to infer the existence of something with the properties of wave functions. We focus on only a few of observed properties of *vyakta* used to infer the existence of *avyakta*: the merging of whole world of effects (*avibhāgāt vaiśvarūpyasya*), which in quantum mechanics occurs when the wave function reconstitutes itself after in between measurements or observations; through the modification (*pariṇāmataḥ*) of the resulting properties of combining separate attributes (*prati-prati-guṇa-āśraya-viśeṣāt*), as might occur with water (*salilavat*). The key characteristic of wave functions that leads to all the unusual phenomena such as quantum tunnelling, and quantum entanglement is the way in which the properties of interacting particles add together as though they were waves. This property, called superposition, underlies the effects observed in the double-slit experiment mentioned in Part I. Seeing the effects of superposition, as verse 16 appears to be implying, leads us to infer the existence of an unseen realm where superposition is possible.

Consider now the following verses, together with a selection from Gaudapada's Bhasya on verse 11, which establish both what is manifest and what is unmanifest (*prakṛti* and its evolutes) to be non-discriminating, non-intelligent whereas the seer, *puruṣa*, is discriminating and intelligent.¹⁶

Verse 11 of SK: The Manifest, the evolved is composed of the three Gunas the constituents, is indiscriminative [*aviveki*], objective [*viśayaḥ*], common, non-intelligent [*acetanam*] and productive. The Pradhana is also like this. The Puruṣa, though similar is yet the reverse of these.

Bhasya to verse 11: the Manifest and the Unmanifest both are non-discriminative but the Spirit is discriminating.

Verse 22 of SK: From Prakṛti, the Primal Nature, issues Mahat, the Great One, intellect, thence Ahaṁkāra, individuation and from this the aggregate of the sixteen: from five among the sixteen proceed five gross elements.

Verse 23 of SK: Intellect is determinative [*adhyavasāyāḥ*]. Virtue, knowledge, non-attachment, and lordly powers constitute its Sāttvika form, i.e., its form when Sattva, goodness, predominates. The Tāmasa form, i.e., the form when Tamas dominates is just the reverse.

¹⁵ Since *guṇas* underpin all that is observable, including the intellect, emotions, and so on, a nontrivial comparison with wave functions requires identification of the quantum underpinnings of the mind's phenomena, such as mentioned in Part II.

¹⁶ Note that we have kept the term "intelligence" in Mainkar's translation of the following verses (Mainkar, 1972), but the original text is *puruṣa*. Where we use the term "intelligence" in the general text, we mean the intellect or *buddhi* actuated by *puruṣa*.

Regarding V. 23, Mainkar notes “This work, it does not in the light of its inherent intelligence, for it has none, as it is the product of matter; but this work it is able to do on account of the proximity of Intelligence, the *Puruṣa*.”

If we take *aviveki* in verse 11 to characterize both manifest and unmanifest as non-discriminative, as implied by the Bhasya to the verse, then there is clearly a conflict with the term *adhyavasāyaḥ* (determinative) used in verse 23 to characterize *buddhi*. If *aviveki* refers rather to the undiscerned or undiscriminated quality of *prakṛti* and its evolutes (including *buddhi*), then these two verses appear to agree with each other. That is, although *buddhi* carries the capacity for discrimination (required for determination), such capacity is not active until *puruṣa* becomes involved: *buddhi* appears intelligent due to its interaction with *puruṣa*, as noted by Mainkar in his comment on verse 23 of SK.

The distinctions between *buddhi* and *puruṣa* may be understood in the context of the metaphor of the farmer in YS IV.3: *buddhi* contains structure, as the plowed irrigation pathways on a farm do, and it selects a particular path to irrigate (*adhyavasāya*), but the selection cannot take place without the light of *puruṣa* illuminating all the pathways. In other words, *buddhi* remains *aviveka* without *puruṣa*. Moreover, not only does *buddhi* select the path to irrigate, it also does the work of irrigating.

As we point out above with regard to YS IV.3, the metaphor of the farmer irrigating a field works just as well in describing observations of quantum events as it does to describe the relationship of *prakṛti* to *puruṣa*. However, in both cases it would be a mistake to assume the farmer and the field are as disconnected as the metaphor implies. Although the experimenter who sets the parameters of a double-slit experiment is clearly separate from the apparatus to an outsider’s perspective, her choices and the neural correlates of those choices are not so easily separated. Yet, without such separation, as Stapp argues in (Stapp 2011), there is no way to avoid either the causal closure of classical mechanics or its determinism. Hence, the “proximity” of *prakṛti* to *puruṣa* Mainkar refers to in his comments on verse 23.

In the following verses Īśvarakṛṣṇa explains why there must be a *puruṣa*; it contains the intelligence that appears to be in the non-intelligent *buddhi*; *prakṛti* contains agency, not *puruṣa*; and he explains the purpose of the association between *puruṣa* and *prakṛti*.

Verse 17 of SK: Spirit as distinct from matter exists, since an assemblage of sensible objects is for another’s use; since this other must be the reverse of everything composed of the three constituents; since there must be superintendence and control; since there must be some one to enjoy and since there is activity for the purpose of liberation.

Although the reasons listed in verse 17 for arguing for the existence of a *puruṣa* differ in some respects from those offered by von Neumann for the existence of an observer in quantum theory, there appears to be agreement on the need for an observer or witness, without which nature maintains a degree of arbitrariness. In quantum theory, this arbitrariness is contained in collection of alternative scenarios that are simultaneously evolved forward in time before an observation is made.

Verse 20 of SK: Therefore, it is from their association that the Liṅga, the non-intelligent body seems intelligent (conscious) and though the agency really belongs to the Guṇas, the constituents, the indifferent one appears as the agent.

Verse 21 of SK: The association of the two, as of the lame man and a blind man, is for contemplation by the Spirit of the Nature and for the release of the Spirit. Creation proceeds from this union.

The latter two verses distinguish between agency and intelligence (consciousness)—the first carried by nature, not the witness, the latter by the witness, not by nature. In the next subsection we define a type of causation that represents the association between subject and object, or between *puruṣa* and *prakṛti*, as these are characterized by the properties of agency, intelligence, and discriminative power.

12.4.3 *Atemporal Causality: Causation Without Temporal Order*

We propose to understand the relationship of subject and object in both quantum theory and Sāṅkhya-Yoga philosophy by defining a type of causality—atemporal causality—that is distinct from the kind of causality specific to events that are governed by definite temporal ordering.¹⁷ In classical physics the cause of acceleration of an object is the net force applied to the object: the cause (net force) must be applied before the effect (acceleration) is observed. In axiomatic quantum mechanics, as described by von Neumann (Von Neumann, 2018), a wave function propagates and evolves in response to interactions (forces) by the same sort of causality as in classical physics when such evolution is determined by the Schrödinger equation. However, process 1 appears to be instantaneous—the collapse of the wave function appears to take place at the instant observation occurs. This is also the case when one member of an entangled pair of particles is observed, no matter how far apart the particles are when one of them is observed (Bell, 1964; Hensen et al., 2015). Moreover, there is some evidence that causal order can sometimes be reversed in quantum mechanics, where the effect precedes the cause (Goswami et al., 2018; Manning et al., 2015).

The distinction we are proposing is between causality as it applies to the realm of classical physics and the evolutes of *prakṛti*, which we regard as comparable, and causality as it applies to the moment an observation takes place in quantum mechanics and the comparable moment unmanifest nature becomes manifest. The role of the observer in physics is described by process 0 and process 1, nature is responsible for process 2 and process 3.

¹⁷ In one of the few competing theories of quantum gravity, that proposed by Carlo Rovelli (Rovelli, 2019), time does not appear, whereas causality remains as the local relationship between the direct antecedents and precedents of individual events. An argument can, therefore, be made that causality in loop quantum gravity is comparable with the type of atemporal causality we describe here.

The interplay of these processes can be summarized as follows: process 0—the experimenter chooses an experimental setup to measure a physical property to which definite values can be attributed (a parallel description can be made in SK)¹⁸; process 2—the interacting elements of the experiment evolve in accordance with the Schrödinger equation, unseen while this is taking place (and in the SK is represented by the interaction among the *gunas* in the unmanifested realm); process 1—the observer looks at and registers the outcome of the experiment, which “atemporally causes” the collapse of the wave function to a single perceivable physical event (*puruṣa* “sees” the subtle constituents of which the particular evolute being observed is composed, thereby imbuing nature with intelligence-like characteristics); process 3—nature herself, as agent, enacts the instantiation of a specific one among many alternatives. In turn, process 3 events link back to process 0 in the following way: each process 3 result of an observation (and its directly corresponding action/experiment) leaves imprints or memory traces (*saṁskāras*, see verse 67 of the SK) that influence future process 0 decisions.

A key point that links this quantum theoretic description to the Sāṁkhya Kārikā is that classical physics and the behaviour and evolution of manifest nature (*vyakta*) both already have the observer embedded within them. As a result, it becomes a conceptual challenge or perhaps an epistemological problem to not attribute intelligence to *buddhi*, for example, which appears to be intelligent, and to not attribute agency to *puruṣa* which appears to be the agent.

An additional distinguishing feature of the two kinds of causation is that classical (temporal) causation requires energy, atemporal causation does not. Observation merely selects from among many alternatives, and *prakṛti* performs the energetic action of instantiating the observable object from the unmanifest to manifest.

Although we use simultaneity here primarily to characterize the relationship between *puruṣa* and *prakṛti* in SK and between unobserved and observed wave function in quantum theory, we can point to simultaneity within *prakṛti* alone and classical mechanics. In the case of *prakṛti*, we have the following two verses:

Verse 30 of SK: In regard to sensible objects [*dṛṣṭe*], the functioning of the four—the three internal organs and an organ of the outer sense [*catustayasya tu*] is said to be [*nirdiṣṭā*] either simultaneous [*yugapat vṛttiḥ*] or successive [*tasya kramaśaśca*]. The functioning of the three internal organs is [*trayasya vṛttiḥ*], in respect of an unseen object [*tathā api adṛṣṭe*], preceded by that of the fourth [*tat pūrvikā*].

Verse 31 of SK: The external and internal organs perform their respective functions [*svāṁ svāṁ vṛttim*], prompted by mutual impulsion, incited by mutual invitation [*paraṣpara ākūta hetukām*]. The purpose of the Spirit is alone the cause [*puruṣārtha eva hetuḥ*]. By nothing else is any organ incited, actuated [*na kenacit karaṇam kāryate*].

Verse 30 clearly states that the three internal senses (mind, ego, intellect) sometimes function simultaneously together with an external sense organ such the eyes to

¹⁸ Here it should be noted that process 0 can be teased apart into two conceptually separate parts, according to SK: *prakṛti* provides the discernment of multiple alternatives, *puruṣa* provides the light that actuates the choice of a single alternative.

apprehend a sense object. In neuroscience this simultaneity, not yet well understood, is one aspect of what is called the binding problem. A related phenomenon in classical physics, mentioned in the Abstract, is self-organization, in which interacting parts of a whole exhibit order (either spatial or temporal) that generally arises as a physical parameter reaches a critical value. The order is usually seen to appear throughout the whole simultaneously—at least on a time scale that is very short compared with other time scales in the system. A striking example of self-organization is the murmuration of starlings. Verse 31 above mentions such self-organization (*paraspara ākūta hetukām*).

Consider now the issue of plurality or non-plurality of *puruṣa* brought up during the Webinar. In quantum theory, as von Neumann explains, any observer that specifies the conditions for selecting a particular alternative among many is necessary and sufficient for an object to become reified. But there is no specification as to number, nor spatial location of the observer, only of the moment of the event of observation. In fact, the act of observation is nonlocal, as evidenced by the nature of quantum entanglement. That is, if two entangled particles are arbitrarily far apart, the wave function collapses if either one of them is observed. Once the wave function is “collapsed” it is collapsed for *all* observers. So, I propose that number as a category that applies to physical nature—observable and distinguishable things—does not apply to *puruṣa*. This is in contradistinction to SK, according to which *puruṣa* is multiple (verse 18 of SK: “The souls are many since birth, death and the instruments of cognition and action are allotted severally; ...” [Mainkar, 1972]). Although this verse clearly states there are many *puruṣas*, the argument for this claim is made in terms of what is observable. But what is observable exists in the classical world of multiplicity. A wave function that represents hundreds of particles is treated and evolved in time as a single whole yet is *observed* as hundreds of separate particles. If the particles are quantum entangled, then the single multi-particle wave function cannot be represented as the sum of individual particle wave functions.

12.5 Discussion

In this article we have argued for a correspondence between the evolutes of *prakṛti* (*vyakta*) and observable aspects of nature as described in classical physics. This includes the self-organizing aspects of nature in both domains of inquiry (classical physics and SK). We also argue that the fundamental constituents that underlie all of nature according to SK—the unmanifested *triguṇas*—correspond to any observable phenomenon whose state and time evolution can be described by quantum wave functions *before* it is observed. This includes states of mind such as feelings, thoughts, and dispositions, all of which we suggest are amenable to some form of non-reductive physicalism as mentioned in Part II. Although such states are subjective, they are “observable” by the subject. The third element, *puruṣa*, corresponds to consciousness as the factor in quantum theory responsible for a particular instantiation of nature to be observed. Consciousness, as synonymous with *puruṣa*, is a missing factor

in physicalist accounts of the mind–body connection (whether reductive or non-reductive). Although consciousness is responsible for the actuation of specific forms in nature, nature herself selects *which* alternative is observed, in accordance with antecedents and constraints (*saṃskāras*, the law of karma).

We have also pointed to correspondence between the SK concept and structure of *prakṛti* with some physicalist philosophies of mind. If such a correspondence holds, then it may be said that the hard problem of consciousness (Chalmers, 2007) is hard because attempts to account for its existence either miss it altogether in physicalism, or they fail to acknowledge the fundamental and irreducible duality of consciousness and all else that is observable. By what is observable we include all the characteristics of the mind that can be understood by neuroscience—even the origin and development of a self (Damasio, 1999).

We mention several implications of the links between Sāṃkhya-Yoga philosophy and quantum theory conjectured in Part III to exist. Foremost among these is that general knowledge of some aspects of the world of the quantum must have existed at least since the time of the Sāṃkhya Kārikā (likely earlier since the portions of this text relevant to our conjecture appear in some form in the Upaniṣads). That is, although the SK aims to infer the existence of *prakṛti* (*avyakta*) and *puruṣa* from what is manifest (*vyakta*), verse 6 mentions valid testimony for knowledge of what is neither inferable, nor perceived through the senses.

Verse 6 of SK: Knowledge of objects that are beyond the reach of the senses are known through the Inference based on analogy. What is not directly perceived, is beyond the senses and is not proved by Inference as well is established through Valid Testimony.

If our conjectured parallel between SK and quantum theory is valid, then key aspects of what modern physics has inferred through experiment and mathematical insights to be an accurate description of nature at the smallest scales may have been discovered centuries before the development of sensitive instruments of the twentieth century. The implication is either that a way of knowing was accessible during the time of the Vedas distinct from sensory perception, and distinct from inference (and may still be accessible today), or that we have so far missed in modern physics macroscopic consequences of quantum mechanics that are accessible with unaided senses.

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Chapter 13

Rethinking Pātañjala Yoga Through the Concepts of Abhyāsa and Vairāgya



Daniel Raveh

Abstract This paper offers a close reading of Patañjali's Yogasūtra through the concepts of abhyāsa and vairāgya, "repetitive practice" and "dispassion," drawing on Patañjali's classical commentators and on Krishnachandra Bhattacharyya's "Studies in Yoga Philosophy," an (almost) forgotten chapter of his corpus. I open with a critical examination of Patañjali's citta-vṛtti scheme, his attempt of "mapping" the contents of consciousness. Thereafter, I discuss the "procedure of yoga," based on the mutual operation of abhyāsa and vairāgya for the sake of nirodha, cessation of the vṛttis, or "movements" of consciousness. A close analysis of Patañjali and his commentators indicates that both abhyāsa and vairāgya are depicted as consisting of a strong reflective dimension. This is to say that the radical meditative act of "emptying" the consciousness of its objective content is in fact a rational conclusion of the mind, as it reflects upon itself. This reflection is both sensitive to the "limitedness" of the objective world and "receptive" to the silent presence of the "unlimited" selfhood beyond, which Patañjali, following the Sāṃkhya tradition, refers to as puruṣa. It is implied here that the yogic act of disengagement from the worldly and objective (conveyed by the notions of pratyāhāra, vairāgya, and kaivalya) is as much an act of will (emphasized and "taken forward" by Krishnachandra Bhattacharyya), as it is an act of self-sacrifice. Finally, the analysis offered here reveals substantial "philosophical threads" in the Yogasūtra, a text which is usually considered as too "practical," or "therapeutic," or "spiritual," to be "really" philosophical.

Keywords Pātañjala Yoga · Abhyāsa · Vairāgya · Krishnachandra Bhattacharyya · Consciousness · Freedom

I cannot think of a more contradictory statement to Descartes' *Cogito Ergo Sum* than Patañjali's *Yogaś Citta-Vṛtti-Nirodhaḥ*. The former statement is from Descartes' *Principles of Philosophy* (1644); the latter from Patañjali's second or third century

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Yogasūtra (YS).¹ Descartes, along the same lines with Aristotle's vision of man as a "rational animal," perceives the thinking faculty, the cogito, as the essence of the human person. Patañjali's position is altogether different. For him, the citta-vṛttis, or "movements of consciousness," are not merely an external layer of one's self and identity but in fact an obstacle on the way to realizing one's svarūpa or "real essence."² Contrary to the implications of Descartes' mahāvākya,³ according to the author of the *Yogasūtra*, the "I am-ness" of each and every one of us can only be revealed when the mental faculty is "switched off." But, Descartes works not just as a pūrvapakṣa to Pātañjala Yoga. There is a deep common denominator between the French philosopher and the *Yogasūtra*-kāra. "I shall now close my eyes," Descartes writes in his *Meditations on First Philosophy* (1641),

I shall stop my ears, I shall call away all my senses, I shall efface even from my thoughts all the images of corporeal things, or at least (for that is hardly possible) I shall esteem them as vain and false; and thus holding converse only with myself and considering my own nature, I shall try little by little to reach a better knowledge of and a more familiar acquaintanceship with myself.⁴

This is to say that Descartes does not merely raise the question of self-identity (who am I?) but searches for an answer, just like Patañjali of the *Yogasūtra*, "within" ("I shall stop, call away, efface" every instance of "externality"). As far as their initial question, and their direction of investigation, namely introversive investigation of the mind by the mind itself, Descartes and Patañjali share a similar path, or method, even if each of them reaches an entirely different conclusion about the (dis)connection between the "I think" and the "I am."

Patañjali opens his treatise, with a detailed citta-vṛtti, or mental activity "map," consisting of pramāṇa, viparyaya, vikalpa, nidrā, and smṛti (valid knowledge, invalid knowledge, verbal construction, sleep, and memory). The blurred line between pramāṇa and viparyaya, in Patañjali's scheme, is intriguing. Both notions refer to phenomenal knowledge, valid and invalid respectively, and implied is a sense of reversibility between the two: what is considered as "valid knowledge" today can become "invalid" tomorrow, and vice-versa. Since both pramāṇa and viparyaya refer

¹ I work with the *Yogasūtra* text as it occurs in Sri Narayana Mishra (1998) and Swami Hariharananda Aranya (2012).

² YS 1.3: Hence (when mental activity ceases), the seer is established in his "real essence" (tadā draṣṭuḥ svarūpe 'vasthānam). [Unless stated otherwise, the translations from Sanskrit are mine].

³ Mahāvākya—By referring to Descartes' famous statement as mahāvākya, "great sentence," a phrase which "belongs" to Śaṅkara's "tat tvam asi," my intention is not just to argue that both sentences are culturally significant, each in its own context, but also that Descartes' maxim, like Śaṅkara's, has a transformative quality. Śaṅkara's sentence, extracted from the sixth chapter of the *Chāndogya-Upaniṣad* is supposed to enable the listener to cut through the veil of avidyā and to transcend the "phenomenal I." Descartes' sentence has had enormous impact on Western formulations of self-identity, emphasizing the importance of, and encouraging the identification with the thinking faculty, with the "I think." It is not about transcendence of one's phenomenal existence as in Śaṅkara, but about the definition of one's phenomenal existence primarily in terms of thinking, marginalizing every other aspect.

⁴ Descartes (1911) Third Meditation, p. 12.

merely to the phenomenal realm, for a metaphysician like Patañjali, there is no essential difference between the two. Another interesting feature of the scheme is the independent status of vikalpa. Swami Hariharananda Aranya (in P.N. Mukerji's translation) explains that,

Vikalpa is a kind of useful knowledge arising out of the meaning of a word, but having no corresponding reality.⁵

This is to say that vikalpa, or verbal construction, refers to that which “exists” only in language. As against śabda (or āgama, as Patañjali puts it in YS1.7), i.e., reliable testimony, which is one of the constituents of pramāṇa (together with pratyakṣa and anumāna, i.e., sense perception and inference), vikalpa is vastu-śūnya, namely objectless or referenceless. “You can call it pure abstraction,” Mukund Lath told me.⁶ On vikalpa as a category of its own in Patañjali's scheme, Krishnachandra Bhattacharyya (henceforth KCB) writes that,

Vikalpa is the presentation of an unreal not as real (which would be viparyaya), nor as unreal (which would be pramāṇa), but as though it were real, i.e., as appearing as real. The appearance of a content is itself a content, and the vṛtti referring to this secondary content is vikalpa.⁷

Patañjali's subtle analysis of the cognitive terrain is revealed here, as he notices language uses which fall out of the inverted categories of pramāṇa and viparyaya and creates the separate category of vikalpa for them.⁸

The last two categories in Patañjali's citta-vṛtti scheme are nidrā and smṛti, sleep and memory. Memory is the basis of the “phenomenal I.” Self-identity, in the worldly sense, is based on continuity which is maintained by memory. Nevertheless, paradoxically, memory cannot “remember” the essence, the svarūpa, that which Patañjali—following the Sāṃkhya tradition—refers to tentatively (since language for him is always, necessarily, tentative) aspuruṣa.⁹ To “remember” puruṣa, or more precisely oneself as puruṣa, memory (in the conventional sense of the word) has to be suspended. Patañjali defines memory as,

conservation [or non-destruction, asaṃpramoṣa] of an object experienced in the past (YS 1.11)¹⁰

And, B.K. Matilal explains that,

⁵ Aranya (2012) p. 28.

⁶ Personal communication, September 2015.

⁷ Bhattacharyya (2008) p. 263.

⁸ It would be an interesting exercise to read closely the different examples given by Patañjali's commentators to the language uses which belong to the category of vikalpa. The first example given by Vyāsa is “Caitanya (consciousness) is the nature of puruṣa” (caitanyaṃ puruṣasya svarūpamiti). For him, this sentence is a tautology. Thus tautology can be listed as the first instance of vikalpa, at least according to the Bhāṣya-kāra.

⁹ YS 1.16, 1.24, 3.36, 3.50, 3.56, 4.18, 4.34.

¹⁰ YS 1.11: anubhūta-viśaya-asaṃpramoṣaḥ smṛtiḥ.

Memory is nothing but a reproduction of some previous experience [... but] the causal conditions which produced the previous experience are not necessary for this reproduction.¹¹

The fact that it is “nothing but a reproduction,” or the “pastness” inherent in memory, as G.J. Larson puts it,¹² is the reason that except for the Jainas (and their position, as Matilal shows, is hard to defend), no other Indian school of philosophy accepts memory as a *pramāṇa*, which explains why memory too is given an independent rubric by the *Sūtra-kāra*. Vyāsa, Patañjali’s *bhāṣya-kāra*,¹³ distinguishes (in *Yogasūtra-bhāṣya* [YSb] 1.11) between two types of memory: *bhāvita* and *abhāvita*, imagined and actual. The former category, in his formulation, refers to dreaming, the latter to the waking state. Since dreaming is included in *smṛti*, or memory, *nidrā* stands for dreamless sleep.

In YS 1.10, Patañjali writes that,

Sleep is mental activity based on the experience of something that does not exist (*abhāva-pratyaya-ālambanā vṛttiḥ nidrā*).

Aranya and T.S. Rukmani¹⁴ explain that the notion *abhāva* (which I translated as “something that does not exist”) projects *nidrā* as negation (*abhāva*) of both waking and dreaming, or in other words, as dreamless sleep. Vyāsa writes that upon waking up even from *nidrā*, i.e., dreamless sleep, one reports “I slept well, my mind is calm, my awareness is clear,” or “I slept poorly, my mind is dull, being unsteady it wanders,” or “I slept in deep stupor, my limbs are heavy, my mind is tired and lazy as if it was stolen.”¹⁵ What Patañjali’s foremost commentator tries to tell us is that even though it seems that “nothing happens” in dreamless sleep, the fact is that “something” does happen. If one reports that he slept well, or slept poorly, it is an indication that subterranean cognitive processes, psychological, or *saṃskāric* (from *saṃskāra*), continue to buzz underneath the mute surface. It is therefore not yet the yogic silence (*nirodha*) aspired for, which covers both *vṛtti* and *saṃskāra*, mental content and psychological undercurrents. Another feature, which prevents dreamless sleep from being considered “ultimate destination,” is the fact that it is not volitional. Dreamless sleep “happens to you.” One goes to sleep without knowing

¹¹ As quoted in Larson (1993) p. 375.

¹² Larson (1993) p. 376.

¹³ Vyāsa is the author of the *Yogasūtra-bhāṣya*, or at least, this important commentary is ascribed to a scholar by this name, about whom, just like Patañjali, we know literally nothing. Most scholars believe that he was Patañjali’s contemporary or lived shortly after him. Philipp Maas, the praise-worthy compiler of a critical edition of the first chapter of what he refers to as *Pātañjala Yogasāstra*, namely Patañjali’s *Yogasūtra* and Vyāsa’s commentary together, argues that Patañjali and Vyāsa are two names of a single author, who assembled sūtras from different sources (Buddhist, Sāṃkhyan, bhakti sūtras on Īśvara, etc.) and commented upon them. See Maas (2010).

¹⁴ Aranya (2012) p. 30; Rukmani (1981) p. 80.

¹⁵ *Sukham aham asvāpsam prasannaṃ me manaḥ prajñāṃ me viśāradīkaroti duḥkham aham asvāpsam styānaṃ me mano bhramaty anavasthitam gādhaṃ mūḍho ‘ham asvāpsam gurūṇi me gātrāṇi klāntaṃ me cittam alasaṃ muṣitaṃ iva tiṣṭhatīti* (YSb 1.10). Text and translation are Rukmani’s (ibid.).

if and when he will “fall into” dreamless sleep. “Like the dream state,” KCB brings the point home,

dreamless sleep is a state in which the self has no control over itself, not a state to which the self rises by a continuous effort.¹⁶

Based on the short synopsis of the citta-vṛtti scheme provided here, I want to argue that Patañjali’s consciousness map is knowledge-oriented. Each of the rubrics expounded by him and discussed here provides a certain type of knowledge, whether valid, invalid, merely lingual, or reproduced by memory. The karmic-saṃskāric residue which gurgles under the surface in dreamless sleep amounts to depth memory, consisting of “primordial” consciousness materials and transgressing the otherwise knowledge centrality of the vṛtti scheme. Patañjali’s “grand project,” in my reading, is about going beyond the scope of knowledge, which is the scope of the “I think”; the very I think, that for him excludes any sense of I am-ness. Patañjali’s “going beyond knowledge” project culminates in YS 4.29. It is implied here that in the last few yards before kaivalya as his “finishing line,” the yogin needs to renounce (or to become uninterested, *akusīdaḥ*, in) *prasaṃkhyāna* or—as Aranya explains—omniscience. This is “the last temptation of the yogin.” The yogin is required to sacrifice his knowledge or in a treatise which opens with a phrase such as *yogaś citta-vṛttinirodhaḥ*, knowledge as such. Knowledge is a powerful temptation, as the biblical myth about “the tree of knowledge” (*ets hada’at*, in *Genesis*, chapter 2) also indicates.

Patañjali’s prescribed remedy for a consciousness afflicted with “thinking” and “knowledge” is made of two ingredients: *abhyāsa* and *vairāgya*, “repetitive practice” and “dispassion.”¹⁷ In the remaining of this chapter, I will look into this remedy and attempt to unpack the concepts of *abhyāsa* and *vairāgya*, the cornerstones of Pātañjala-yoga as a therapeutic procedure.

Abhyāsa—literally: repetition, repetitive practice or exercise, discipline, use, habit, custom—is the mechanism which creates the phenomenal aspects of human existence, or the “day in, day out.” Like the *citta-vṛttis*, or “movements of consciousness,” *abhyāsa* can be *kliṣṭa* or *akliṣṭa*: outgoing, object-centred, worldly, or on the other hand ingoing, objectless, trans-phenomenal, meditative. Patañjali focuses on the latter, i.e., on introversive *abhyāsa*. According to him,

abhyāsa is the effort to achieve stability [of “empty,” motionless mind]. (YS 1.13)¹⁸

He further writes that,

it is firmly grounded if performed attentively and ceaselessly for a long period of time. (YS 1.14)¹⁹

¹⁶ Bhattacharyya (2008) p. 26.

¹⁷ YS 1.12: The cessation of these (*vṛttis*) is accomplished through repetitive practice and dispassion (*abhyāsa-vairāgyābhyāṃ tan-nirodhaḥ*).

¹⁸ YS 1.13: *tatra sthitaṃ yatno’bhyāsaḥ*.

¹⁹ YS 1.14: *sa tu dīrgha-kāla-nairantarya-satkāra-āsevito dṛḍha-bhūmiḥ*.

In YSb 2.15, Vyāsa speaks of bhogābhyāsa, or “worldly abhyāsa,” as the (fatal from a yogic point of view) procedure which “grounds” the human person in the phenomenal realm through avidyā, which he originally defines as viṣaya-sukham, or “enjoyment of objects.” That which seems in the short, “phenomenal-run,” as enjoyment, Vyāsa identifies as a long, “yoga-run,” duḥkha, or suffering. If worldly repetitiveness, through which the saṃsāra-web is constantly weaved and re-weaved, is referred to by the famous commentator as bhogābhyāsa; then the yogic alternative, repetitive as much as its worldly counterpart is, but directed inwards, can be referred to as yogābhyāsa. This is to say that as far as his abhyāsa, or the effort that he puts into his practice is concerned, the yogin walks on familiar grounds. He is a “doer,” devoted to his “doing” as much as any other doer is, even if the purpose of his repetitive practice is trans-phenomenal, or more than worldly. Through abhyāsa, the yogin endeavours to uproot inveterate patterns, by repeatedly practising their opposite. His challenge is to “change direction,” to introvert the outgoing movement of the mind, to overcome the solid habit of turning towards objects. The problem that Patañjali seems to be dealing with is that the human person is totally unacquainted with an objectless mode of consciousness. One “meets” and “creates” his world through repeated acts of objectification. De-objectification is Patañjali’s prescription for the “duḥkha patient,” and the challenge he sets up for the yogin. The question is how to metamorphose a “consciousness-default,” which one is not just thoroughly used to, but which enables him “to participate” in the world. Patañjali suggests practising “the opposite” of that which has become the default. Yogābhyāsa as “the opposite” of bhogābhyāsa loosens the “hermetic grasp” of the latter. It is a counter-force, so to say, intended to “neutralize” the power of the extroversive force. In YS 2.33, Patañjali gives us a glimpse of his method of “cultivating the opposite” (pratipakṣa-bhāvana):

To stop thoughts which contradict the yamas, one should cultivate their opposite.²⁰

The immediate context of the present sūtra is Patañjali’s discussion of the yamas, his list of primary ethical precepts, from ahiṃsā (non-violence) to aparigraha (non-possessiveness). When a thought contradicting any of these precepts arises, the yogin is advised to cultivate its opposite. But cultivating the opposite of a thought such as “I want to kill him,” does not mean to produce a counter-thought in the form of “I do not want to kill him” or “I want to befriend him.” Instead, “the opposite” according to Patañjali, is to reflect upon the consequences of “contrary thoughts,” namely thoughts about violation of the ethical precepts. Or in Patañjali’s own words (in YS 2.34),

To cultivate the opposite is [to reflect upon the fact] that thoughts which contradict the yamas, such as violent thoughts etc., whether executed, planned to be executed or even approved, whether driven by greed, anger or delusion, whether mild, moderate or intense, result in endless suffering (duḥkha) and ignorance (ajñāna).²¹

When a “contrary thought” (as the paradigm of every klišṭa-vṛtti, i.e., intentional, or outward-facing “consciousness movement,” which for Patañjali is inherently “afflictive”) arises in him, the yogin should “confront it” with sober reflection upon

²⁰ YS 2.33: vitarka-bādhane pratipakṣa-bhāvanam.

²¹ YS 2.34: vitarkā hiṃsā-ādayaḥ kṛta-kārita-anumoditā lobha-krodha-moha-pūrvakā mṛdu-madhya-adhimātrā duḥkha-ajñāna-ananta-phalā iti pratipakṣa-bhāvanam.

its inevitable consequences. Vyāsa comments (in YSb 2.33) that the human tendency to reproduce “contrary thoughts,” even after reflecting upon their painful implications, is like the dog’s impulse to lick his own vomit. His stunning remark means that yogic reflection has to be repeatedly “produced” against “contrary thoughts” as long as they arise. But it is also a pessimistic observation about the deeply rooted human obsession with “externality,” and the inclination to always return to the familiar, to replicate the default, “disgusting” and infected with *duḥkha* as it may be.

At this point, I am reminded of Ramana Maharshi, the famous mystic, or for our sake yogin, who in one of his numerous question–answer sessions clarifies the concept of *abhyāsa* or more precisely *yogābhyāsa*. Ramana suggests that,

The passage from *pravṛtti* to *nivṛtti* [from object-centricity to objectlessness at the level of consciousness] is possible through *abhyāsa* and *vairāgya*, and it works, but takes time.²²

Using the yogic notions of *abhyāsa* and *vairāgya*, the renowned Advaitin, famous for his *sādhana*-less teaching, seems to encourage his present interlocutor to follow a prescribed yoga path (“it works,” he says), of which he speaks in terms of a process (“it takes time”). Patañjali too emphasizes the processual dimension of *abhyāsa*, measuring it (in YS 1. 13–14) in terms of time and effort (*kāla* and *yatna*).

Maharshi further tells his interlocutor that,

The mind so used to turning outwards cannot be introverted so easily. It is difficult to restrict a cow used to feed on grass in open meadows to its own cowshed. Even if the owner seduces the cow with delicious grass and fabulous fodder, she will first refuse, then eat a little, but her tendency to look for food elsewhere will not be uprooted so easily. If the owner repeatedly seduces the cow, she will slowly become habitual to the cowshed. Thereafter, even when unleashed, she will no longer wander. Such is also the case with the human mind.²³

The “owner of the cow,” if I may read Ramana Maharshi’s illustration through the *Yogasūtra*, is *puruṣa*. Patañjali himself refers to *puruṣa*, the “selfhood beyond,” as the “owner” (*svāmīn* in YS 2.23, *prabhu* in YS 4.18) of *prakṛti* in the first instance, of the *citta-vṛttis* in the second. However *puruṣa* is inactive by definition.²⁴ Therefore “he” cannot “seduce the cow,” or introvert the mind. The mind itself, through its own

²² I found this question-answer session in Hebrew translation in the book *Awareness and Deathlessness: Questions and Answers with Ramana Maharshi* (1935–1939), Gal Publishers, Tel Aviv, 1994. I translate Maharshi’s words from Hebrew into English. Despite the “long distance” (Tamil to English, English to Hebrew, Hebrew back into English), I feel that Ramana’s point is not (totally) “lost in translation,” especially since he uses a simple (but profound) illustration to elucidate the notion of *abhyāsa*. It should be noted that the context of Ramana Maharshi’s discussion is not necessarily Patañjali’s *Yogasūtra*. The notions of *abhyāsa* and *vairāgya* also occur in *Bhagavadgītā* 6.35.

²³ Ramana Maharshi, *Ibid*.

²⁴ *Sāṃkhya-Kārikā* (SK) 19: *tasmāc ca viparyāsāt siddham sākṣitvam asya puruṣasya kaivalyaṃ mādhyasthyaṃ draṣṭṛtvam akartṛbhāvaś ca* (Therefore, since [puruṣa is] the opposite [of the unmanifest], it is established that *puruṣa* is a witness, possessed of isolation or freedom, indifferent, a spectator and inactive). Larson (1979, pp. 261–262). The translation (including the square brackets) is his.

effort, needs to become free (i.e., empty) of any outer, objective content, in order to “isolate” *puruṣa*.²⁵

What would motivate a cow to stay in the cowshed if her owner is absolutely passive? The answer is that something in the superficiality of phenomenal existence is supposed to hint at the possibility of transcending it. This superficiality resonates in the notion of *duḥkha*, or “suffering,” which pervades, according to “*mokṣa* thinkers” such as Patañjali, every aspect of phenomenal existence. The physical (or biological), mental, psychological, social, and cultural aspects are all prone to suffering. The world and the worldly are inherently mixed with suffering. But if *duḥkha* is identified as such, i.e., as a dance (I draw on Īśvarakṛṣṇa’s simile in *Sāṃkhyakārikā* 59),²⁶ repeating itself again and again, birth after birth, limited, monotonous, incapable of touching “the essence”; then, the mind—rooted as it is in *duḥkha*—can and should develop the urge “to switch itself off,” as to allow something else, unknown, unknowable (at least through the mind) to be de-concealed; de-concealed rather than revealed, since it is always there, unnoticeable as long as the mind constantly “moves.” The movement (*vṛtti*) of the mind excludes the stillness of *puruṣa* or the stillness which is *puruṣa*.

It is therefore up to the mind itself “to stop.” This is the “stoppage” (*nirodha*) of which Patañjali speaks at the very beginning of his treatise.

In his pedagogic handbook *Upadeśa-Sāhasrī* (“A Thousand Teachings,” Up-Sā), Śāṅkara writes an imaginary dialogue between guru and śiṣya, teacher and student. Here, the teacher is the ātman, or for our sake *puruṣa*,²⁷ and the student who aspires “to reach” the ātman, the “selfhood beyond,” is the *manas*, the mind, equivalent for the sake of our discussion to Patañjali’s *citta*. In the course of this fictional (and full of humour) dialogue, the ātman tells the *manas*:

O mind, it is appropriate for you to be silent (calm, tranquil)! (Up-Sā 19.2)²⁸

The idea is that the “noisy mind” rules out the silence of the ātman or, again, the silence which is the ātman. Only when the mind ceases, the ātman can shine forth. Indeed, the word *śama* (in Śāṅkara’s formulation), pertaining to “silence,” “calmness,” and “tranquility,” also means “cessation.” At this junction, Śāṅkara and Patañjali meet.

In *Yogasūtra-bhāṣya* 1.14, Vyāsa suggests that if performed attentively (*sat-kāra*), *abhyāsa* has the capacity of restraining *vyutthāna-saṃskāras*, namely karmic

²⁵ I am writing “to isolate *puruṣa*,” having in mind the term *kaivalya* (literally “isolation”), depicted in SK 19 as one of *puruṣa*’s “inherent traits.”

²⁶ SK 59: *raṅgasya darśayitvā nivartate nartakī yathā nṛtyāt, puruṣasya tathātmānam prakāśya vinivartate prakṛtiḥ* (As a dancer ceases from the dance after having been seen by the audience; so also *prakṛti* ceases after having manifested herself to *puruṣa*). Larson, *ibid.* p. 273; the translation is his.

²⁷ I am not delving into the differences between the Upaniṣadic-Advaitic notion of the ātman and the Sāṃkhya-Yoga notion of *puruṣa*. Despite the obvious differences, such as the oneness of the ātman, as against the manyness of *puruṣa* (*puruṣa-bahutva*), both notions refer to a metaphysic essence or selfhood, transcending the phenomenal, worldly self.

²⁸ Up-Sā 19.2: *tataḥ ca yuktaḥ śama eva te manaḥ* (Swami Jagadananda, 2001, pp. 288–289).

impressions, or psychological dispositions, which activate the consciousness in an external, object-centred mode. The phrase *sat-kāra*, Vyāsa explains, refers to *abhyāsa* performed through *tapas*, *brahmacarya*, *vidyā*, and *śraddhā* (heating practices, celibacy, knowledge, and certainty that *citta-vṛtti-nirodha* is attainable). Of these four components, *tapas*, *brahmacarya*, and *śraddhā* are mentioned by Patañjali²⁹; the notion of *vidyā* (knowledge) does not occur in the *Yogasūtra* text. I stick to my position that Patañjali aims at an “act of will” in which the consciousness “turns itself off,” knowledge of whatever kind included. However, this act of will is based on a certain understanding. It is a logical conclusion of a rational analysis. In this respect, the knowledge that will be finally “burned” in “the great fire of yoga” (and terms such as *tapas* and *brahmacarya* evoke a sense of cleansing by fire, or “inner fire”) is employed in the process of yoga, like a piece of wood used to push every other wooden piece into the fire, that is also thrown at the very end into the flames. Vijñānabhikṣu, in tune with YS 1.20, suggests that *śraddhā*, *vīrya*, *smṛti*, *saṁādhi*, and *prajñā*—namely certainty, power, mindfulness,³⁰ (*saṁprajñāta* or “cognitive”) *saṁādhi* and “yogic insight” (born of meditation)—are the preconditions of *sat-kāra*, or attentive yoga practice. *Prajñā*, or “yogic insight,” can be seen as replacing and as conveying Vijñānabhikṣu’s understanding of Vyāsa’s *vidyā* or “knowledge.” *Prajñā* stands in sheer contrast to *avidyā*, namely to “phenomenal knowledge” that cannot distinguish between the altogether different from one another *puruṣa* and *prakṛti*.³¹ The author of the *Yogasūtra-bhāṣya-vivaraṇa* (the *Vivaraṇa*) writes that,

abhyāsa is the practice of means of yoga such as *yama* and *niyama* [primary and secondary ethical precepts], etc.³²

All three commentators—Vyāsa, Vijñānabhikṣu, and the author of the *Vivaraṇa*—focus on preparative procedures, which are intended to support and maintain *saṁādhi*, i.e., yogic meditation. These procedures include initial meditative practices (such as *smṛti* in the sense of *dhyāna*, and *saṁprajñāta saṁādhi*) and prerequisite ethical conduct. The latter category includes the “cleansing procedures” of *tapas* and *brahmacarya*. For the author of the *Vivaraṇa*, *abhyāsa* is *yama-niyamādi* (“ethical precepts etc.”). The phrase “etc.” implies that for him, *abhyāsa* refers to Patañjali’s *aṣṭāṅga-yoga*, of which *yama* and *niyama* are the first two *aṅgas*, or limbs. In my reading, the

²⁹ *Tapas* is listed both as a component of *kriyā-yoga* in YS 2.1 and as one of the *niyamas* in YS 2.32 and YS 2.43; *brahmacarya* is listed as one of the *yamas* in YS 2.30 and YS 2.38; *śraddhā* is mentioned as one of the means of attaining *asaṁprajñāta saṁādhi* (“trans-cognitive” *saṁādhi*) in YS 1.20; regarding *śraddhā*, Vyāsa beautifully writes (in YSb 1.20) that it protects the yogin “like a good mother” (*jananīva kalyāṇī*).

³⁰ *Smṛti* is initially memory. However in YS 1.6 Patañjali lists memory among the *vṛttis* or mental activities which the process of yoga aims at stopping. Vācaspatimiśra therefore suggests (Mishra, 1998, p. 62) that in the present case, the term *smṛti* is synonymous with *dhyāna*, a preliminary state of meditation which paves the way to *saṁādhi*. I translate *dhyāna* (and *smṛti* in the sense of *dhyāna*) as “mindfulness.”

³¹ See YS 2.5: *anitya-aśuci-duḥkha-anātmasu nitya-śuci-sukha-ātma-khyātir avidyā* (*avidyā* is misidentification of the impermanent as permanent, the impure as pure, the painful as joyous, and non-selfhood as selfhood).

³² *yama-niyamādi-yoga-Sādhana-anuṣṭhānam-abhyāsa-iti* (Rukmani, 2001, p. 77).

precepts listed here, from *ahiṃsā* (non-violence, the first particle of the *yama* list) to *īśvara-praṇidhāna* (“surrender to *īśvara*,” or “to god,” the last particle of the *niyama* list), are aides of meditative introversion, intended to unravel the yogin’s involvement in the world. In this context, non-violence, for example, is not practised for the sake of creating a better society but to facilitate an uninvolved, monadic, “yogic isolation.”

Vyāsa suggested (as we saw above) that attentive performance of *abhyāsa*, or “yogic practice,” has the capacity of subduing *vyutthāna-saṃskāras*. We examined (at least some of) the implications of this prescribed attentiveness (comprised in the phrase *satkāra*). Now, I want to focus on *abhyāsa* as signifying “yogic work” at the level of the *saṃskāras*. In YS 3.9, Patañjali writes that,

When *vyutthāna-saṃskāras* [that activate the consciousness in external, objectcentered mode] are overpowered, and *nirodha-saṃskāras* [enabling the consciousness to turn inwards and to abandon “externality” of any kind] emerge, this is *nirodha-pariṇāma* [*nirodha*-transformation], characterized by [increasing] moments of cessation [i.e., of “no-mind”].³³

The notion of *nirodha*, “yogic cessation,” which refers in YS 1.2 to the *cittavṛtti*, is extended here as to apply to the sub-*vṛtti* *saṃskāra* level. The term *pariṇāma* pertains to the transformative process (described in YS 3.9–12), which takes place at this subterranean consciousness level in the course of meditation. It is implied that in the meditative state called *nirodha-pariṇāma*, *vyutthāna-saṃskāras* are “overpowered” (*abhibhava*), to the extent that *nirodha-saṃskāras* can emerge. The task of the yogin is to “weed” the “seeds of externality” and to “nourish” the “seeds of introversion.” Following Vyāsa’s hint in YSb 1.14, I want to read the “inner yogic work” at the *saṃskāra*-level as *abhyāsa*, even if none of the commentators (Vyāsa, Vācaspatimīśra, the author of the *Vivaraṇa*, Bhojarāja,³⁴ and Vijñānabhikṣu) use this term explicitly. Among these, Vijñānabhikṣu suggests that the overpowering and nourishment of *vyutthāna* and *nirodha saṃskāras*, respectively, take place gradually (*kramaṇa*). I see resemblance between Vijñānabhikṣu’s “*kramaṇa*” and Patañjali’s “*dirgha-kāla-nairantarya*” or “persistency for a long period of time,” the phrase which he uses to convey the meaning of *abhyāsa* (in YS 1.14).

Having touched on *abhyāsa*, and having introduced the method of “cultivating the opposite” as the crux of *yogābhyāsa*, yogic *abhyāsa*, I want to move on and unpack the complementary notion of *vairāgya*. Patañjali works with *vairāgya* as concept and ideal in two stages. First he writes (in YS 1.15) that,

Vairāgya is thirstlessness with regard to objects seen and heard, arising from *vaśikāra-saṃjñā* [conscious control of one’s inclination to objects].³⁵

And second, he adds (in YS 1.16) that, Ultimate *vairāgya* is thirstlessness toward the *guṇas*, arising from the vision of *puruṣa* [*puruṣa-khyāti*, or in fact from the vision of oneself as *puruṣa*].³⁶

³³ YS 3.9: *vyutthāna-nirodha-saṃskārayor abhibhava-prādur-bhāvau nirodha-kṣaṇa-citta-anvayo nirodha-pariṇāmaḥ*.

³⁴ Pātañjalayogadarśana with the Rājamārtanda of Bhojarāja et al. (1930).

³⁵ YS 1.15: *dṛṣṭa-ānuśravika-viśaya-vitr̥ṣṇasya vaśikāra-saṃjñā vairāgyam*.

³⁶ YS 1.16: *tat-param puruṣa-khyāter-guṇa-vaitr̥ṣṇyam*.

In the first stage, with reference to “lower vairāgya” (apara-vairāgya, as against paravairāgya or “ultimate dispassion”),³⁷ the key term is saṃjñā. This is to say that the notion of vairāgya conveys a sense of reflection about one’s inclination to the objective world, reflection which enables the yogin (as in the case of “contrary thoughts”) to move in the “opposite direction,” in this case, away from objects and objectification. In this respect, the commentators from Vyāsa onwards speak of worldly (“seen,” namely grasped by the senses) and other worldly (“heard,” namely explicated in the scriptures) objective temptations. In the latter category, Vyāsa mentions svarga (“heaven”), as well as yogic states such as “bodilessness” (videha) and “merging into prakṛti” (prakṛti-laya).³⁸ KCB reads the notion of vaśīkāra (in his “Studies in Yoga Philosophy”³⁹) as implying “free conquest of desire.” He is thus in one mind with the classic commentators that “vairāgya is not mere desirelessness.”⁴⁰ The freedom of disengagement, for him, is the heart of the matter. It is an act of will, a conscious resolution. Yoga, according to him, is all about “willing,” as he puts it. It is about freedom in the realm of action (action and will are two sides of the same coin), parallel to freedom in the complementary realms of knowledge and emotion.⁴¹ In (the non-Euclidean) geometry of freedom, parallels do meet.

In YSb 1.15, Vyāsa explains that “lower vairāgya,” rooted in vaśīkāra-saṃjñā, is anābhogātmika (of the nature of absence of phenomenal, or objective experience) and heyopādeya-sūnyā (free of attitude of abandoning or obtaining). Vairāgya is thus projected as an existential position of sheer detachment. Vācaspatimiśra suggests that the phrase anābhogātmika pertains to absence of experience even while in contact with objects.⁴² This is to say that vairāgya, in his reading, is inner detachment “indifferent” to whatever takes place externally. It is hinted here that genuine detachment can only be “measured” or “tested” in contact with objects. Along the same lines, the author of the *Vivaraṇa* resembles consciousness in a state of vairāgya to a transparent crystal (sphaṭika), which is no longer “coloured” by the objects around it.⁴³ The commentators further suggest that vairāgya as detachment is the natural result

³⁷ The commentators distinguish between “apara” and “para,” “lower” and “ultimate” vairāgya. See for instance Vācaspatimiśra (TV 1.16 in Mishra, 1998, p. 52) and the author of the *Vivaraṇa* (Rukmani, 2001, p. 80).

³⁸ See YS 1.19: bhava-pratyayo videha-prakṛti-layānām ([In the case of] “bodiless” and “merged into prakṛti” yogins, [saṃādhi] occurs from birth [hence the “path” depicted by Patañjali becomes redundant]).

³⁹ KCB’S “Studies in Yoga Philosophy” (unpublished in his lifetime) is included in his collected essays *Studies in Philosophy* (1958, 2008) edited by his son Gopinath Bhattacharyya. It is the text of one of his last lecture series and is hardly referred to by those who write on KCB’s philosophical work. They usually focus on his earlier writings on Emmanuel Kant and Advaita Vedānta, as well as on his acclaimed essay “The Subject as Freedom.” The important place of “Studies in Yoga Philosophy” in KCB’s corpus is yet to be highlighted.

⁴⁰ Bhattacharyya (2008) p. 303.

⁴¹ KCB works with freedom in the realm of knowledge through Advaita-Vedānta and Sāṃkhya. He thinks of freedom in the emotive realm through Rasa aesthetics. And through Pātañjala-yoga and Kant’s philosophy, he conceptualizes freedom in the realm of action.

⁴² *Tattvavaiśārādī* 1.15 (Mishra, 1998, p. 62).

⁴³ Rukmani (2001) p. 79.

of the capacity of seeing the defects (doṣas) of an object. A sensitive yogic gaze cuts through appearances and weakens one's attraction to objects.⁴⁴ KCB, synoptic as ever, therefore writes that if abhyāsa is the "positive exercise of freedom," then vairāgya is the "negative annulment of unfreedom."⁴⁵

The abhyāsa-vairāgya twosome occurs not just in the *Yogasūtra* but also in the *Bhagavadgītā*. In BG 6.35, Kṛṣṇa says to Arjuna (referred to here as Kaunteya, Kuntī's son):

The mind is undoubtedly hard to control and restless, but it can be controlled by abhyāsa and vairāgya.⁴⁶

Śāṅkara, the famous commentator of the text, explains that vairāgya is thirstlessness (vairiṣṇya) to enjoyment (bhoga) of desirable objects, seen or unseen, which is a result of repetitive practice of seeing their faults (doṣa-darśanābhyāsāt). His analysis is in tune with Patañjali's commentators. Śāṅkara adds that a "thread of pleasure" binds the human person to objects. Vairāgya he sees as signifying the termination of the human pattern of involvement in the world through so-called pleasant experiences. These experiences are "so-called" rather than "really" pleasant, since they create bondage. For Śāṅkara, just like Vyāsa (in YSb 2.15), pleasure (sukha, bhoga) belongs to and in fact determines the phenomenal human existence as duḥkha. To seek pleasure (in the worldly sense of the word), Vyāsa suggests (still in YSb 2.15), is like running away from the sting of a scorpion just to be bitten by a snake. Vairāgya, for him, is the antidote for the poisonous inclination to the objective world.

With regard to para-vairāgya, Vyāsa explains (in YSb 1.16) that "ultimate dispassion" is not born of "seeing" the doṣas, the defects of an object, but rather puruṣa-darśanābhyāsāt, i.e., through the repetitive effort (abhyāsa) to "see" puruṣa, or oneself as puruṣa. In "lower vairāgya," detachment is the "logical conclusion" of the superficiality or the "on-the-surfaceness" of the objective realm. It is therefore "negative" in essence. "Ultimate vairāgya," on the other hand, is "positive" in the sense that—if I may use Isaiah Berlin's famous distinction⁴⁷—it is "freedom to" (puruṣa), rather than "freedom from" (the doṣas and the objects which "carry them"). Moreover, para-vairāgya is "deeper" than its "lower" counterpart in the sense that detachment, at this stage, is not towards objects but towards the guṇas or the "forces behind" each and every object. In this respect, the author of the *Vivaraṇa* reads the guṇas as the "cause" (kāraṇa) of the object. Vyāsa further speaks of "ultimate dispassion" in terms of "knowledge" or reflection, referring to it as jñānaprasāda-mātram ("entirely purified awareness"). Vācaspatimiśra reads the term prasāda as referring to sattvic consciousness devoid of rajas and tamas, enabling the yogin to discriminate between

⁴⁴ See for example Vijñānabhikṣu (Rukmani, 1981, p. 98), who suggests that doṣa-darśanena vairiṣṇyam bhavati (it is the observation of a flaw, or a defect, which leads to thirstlessness).

⁴⁵ Bhattacharyya (2008) p. 306.

⁴⁶ BG 6.35: asaṁśayaṁ mahābāho mano durnigrahaṁ calaṁ labhyāsena tu kaunteya vairāgyeṇa ca gṛhyate || (see Śrīmadbhagavadgītā Śāṅkara-bhāṣya, 1976).

⁴⁷ Berlin (1969).

the guṇas (as the core of prakṛti) and puruṣa.⁴⁸ The next level, he continues to suggest, is detachment towards knowledge itself, which is the prime characteristic of dharmamegha-samādhi, the final meditative stage before kaivalya.

If the concept of saṃjñā in Patañjali's definition of "lower vairāgya" transforms in "ultimate vairāgya" into jñāna, then according to the commentators, even this "discerning knowledge" has to finally be abandoned. KCB summarizes the long commentarial tradition, and writes that,

[Ultimate-vairāgya is] detachment not only from the object of the mind, but also from the mind itself as object, from the mind even in its final actual state of viveka [...] There is no knowledge except through vṛtti, and freedom though achieved through knowledge, is freedom from knowledge itself; freedom as the super-conscious activity of the mind to stand like the self, to be and not to know.⁴⁹

Patañjali sets up a strategy intended to "stop" or "suspend" mental activity. It includes, we saw above, an ethical base which supports meditation as the heart of yoga, meditation in which consciousness gradually becomes "empty" or "purified" of objective content. Yogābhyāsa, or yogic abhyāsa, pertains to a conscious, volitional inverted-operation at the consciousness level, which "opposes" its conventional-intentional modus. For Patañjali, "emptiness" is the "natural" state of consciousness.

In YS 2.54, which touches on pratyāhāra, "withdrawal of the senses" (the fifth limb of yoga in the aṣṭāṅga scheme), Patañjali writes that,

Pratyāhāra is a state in which the sense organs as if follow the "real nature" (svarūpa) of the mind by disconnecting themselves from their objects.⁵⁰

And in the consecutive sūtra (YS 2.55), he adds that,

(Pratyāhāra) results in absolute control over the senses.⁵¹

The notions of pratyāhāra and vairāgya are interrelated. The former refers to disengagement at the level of the senses, the latter at the level of the mind. In both cases, Patañjali speaks of a sense of control (vaśyatā, vaśīkāra). Vairāgya, we have seen, is about development of aversion to the worldly and objective and allowing the "vision of puruṣa" (puruṣa-khyāti, in para-vairāgya) to shine forth. Abhyāsa and vairāgya alike are depicted by Patañjali as consisting of a reflective dimension ("cultivating the opposite" by way of reflection in yogābhyāsa, saṃjñā in Patañjali's formulation of "lower vairāgya" and jñāna in Vyāsa's gloss of "ultimate vairāgya"). This is to say that the act of "emptying" the consciousness of its objective content is in fact a rational choice of the mind as it reflects upon itself. The "twist," as I tried to show through Ramana Maharshi, is that the consciousness has to empty itself. It is as much an act of will (as emphasized by KCB) as it is an act of self-sacrifice.

⁴⁸ Mishra (1998), p. 52; the three guṇas or "forces", which "activate" prakṛti, namely sattva, rajas, and tamas, are referred to by Patañjali (in YS 2.18) as prakāśa (brightness), kriyā (action), and sthiti (inertia).

⁴⁹ Bhattacharyya (2008) pp. 303–304.

⁵⁰ YS 2.54: sva-viśaya-asamprayoge cittasya sva-rūpa-anukāra iva-indriyāṇāṃ pratyāhārah.

⁵¹ YS 2.55: tataḥ paramā vaśyatā-indriyāṇāṃ.

Verse 62 of the *Sāṃkhya-Kārikā*, the root-text of the Sāṃkhya tradition, the “sister tradition” of Pātañjala-yoga, suggests that,

No one is bound, no one released. Likewise, no one transmigrates [or “belongs” to the saṃsāric, worldly cycle]. Only prakṛti, in its various forms, transmigrates, is bound and is released.⁵²

This is to say that the whole process of yoga takes place in the realm of prakṛti, or more precisely, if we take our discussion of the *Yogasūtra* into account, in the consciousness. Bondage and release, malady and cure, are all “here” and do not affect puruṣa’s silence-within-silence realm beyond. Therefore, Vijñānabhikṣu (in his commentary of YS 4.34, the final verse of the *Yogasūtra*) speaks of two parallel kaivalyas, namely prakṛti’s and puruṣa’s. Prakṛti’s kaivalya, or “disengagement as freedom,” is a matter of accomplishment. It is the outcome of the procedure of yoga, discussed above through the correlating notions of abhyāsa and vairāgya. The other kaivalya, puruṣa’s kaivalya, is not a matter of accomplishment. It is always there, primordially there. It is not an end (in both senses of the word) like the kaivalya of prakṛti, of the consciousness, but more of a “source,” or an “origin,” finally unclouded.

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⁵² SK 62: tasmān na badhyate ‘addhā na mucyate nā ‘pi saṃsarati kaścit, saṃsarati badhyate mucyate ca nānāśrayā prakṛtiḥ (Larson, 1979, p. 274; the translation is his, the square brackets are mine).

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Chapter 14

Discriminative Knowledge: A Way Forward to Higher Consciousness



Ranjan Kumar Panda

Abstract In this chapter, I would like to discuss the notion of *discriminative knowledge* in Sāṃkhya-Yoga and illustrate its philosophical significance concerning the ontology of higher order consciousness. Following the fundamentals of Sāṃkhya-Yoga philosophy, of course, consciousness is deemed real and functions as an independent metaphysical principle—the *Puruṣa*. The concept of *Puruṣa* is theorized from the soteriological and cosmological points of view in Sāṃkhya-Yoga. How does the *Puruṣa*—the pure consciousness become the source of *discriminative knowledge/discriminative wisdom*—*vivekajñāna*? This question could also be raised differently. That is, how does discriminative knowledge arise in the case of an individual mind/consciousness? To me, a reasonable response to any one of these questions could be a reasonable response to the first question, as they both deal with the nature and development of *vivekajñāna*.

Keywords Consciousness · Higher order consciousness · Discriminative knowledge · Self-knowledge · Self-consciousness · Evolution and Emergence

14.1 Introduction

The notion of *discriminative knowledge* in Sāṃkhya-Yoga has the power of illustrating the philosophical significance of the ontology of higher order consciousness. Consciousness is considered real in both the realms, at the realm of the manifestation of Prakṛti, the *mahat*, *ahaṅkāra*, and *manas* constitute the *antaḥkaraṇa*—that is *thinking*. In the realm of the existence of *Puruṣa*, consciousness is treated as higher order ontological category. How does one comprehend the existence of the *Puruṣa*—the higher consciousness? Consciousness in the realm of *thinking*, particularly with reference to *antaḥkaraṇa*, represents the psychological notion of consciousness. In the realm of human psychology, one not only deals with the

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issues related to the mundane world but also aspires to know the higher form of reality. This individual aspiration is something unique about human thinking. The nature of thinking transcends the experiences concerning the world and contemplates knowing its own nature, that is, about its ontology and function that makes experiences conscious. Hence, we need to discuss the nature of the psychological function of individual consciousness. The psychological function refers to the nature of thinking, imagining, doubting, and judging which are no doubt conscious manifestations of an individual self. The self is conscious, but this consciousness does not always reflect its true nature. Rather, it shows the expression of intellect, ego, pride, etc. The individual consciousness or the ego and intellect are the evolutes of *Prakṛti*. When the individual consciousness is in proximity to *Puruṣa*—the pure consciousness realizes its nature—the *cetanā* of *discriminative knowledge* arises. *Prakṛti* is *acetanā*—unconsciousness.

Consciousness appears to be operating on two levels in the philosophical systems of Sāṃkhya-Yoga. At one level, the *Puruṣa* represents pure consciousness, whereas, at another level, awareness is expressed by the *antaḥkaraṇa* consisting of *mahat*, *ahaṅkāra*, and *manas*. Since *Antaḥkaraṇa* is a manifestation of *Prakṛti*, it's being *unconscious* projects a different kind of awareness. *Is this projection real? Or, is this awareness unreal?* Hence, we need to study the distinction between consciousness and unconsciousness. More importantly, how does *discriminative knowledge* arise by demarcating the psychological function of the mind of an individual from pure consciousness? The individual mind represents *antaḥkaraṇa*, which includes the intellect (*mahat* or *buddhi*), ego (*ahaṅkāra*), and the mind (*manas*), showing its entanglement with the world. So, the psychological function of the individual is part of individual consciousness which is conditioned by the intentional engagement with the world.

Suffering or *duḥkha* is an instance of the psychological function of consciousness where the individual experiences pain. *Sāṃkhyakārikā*, in its philosophical discourse, refers to various kinds of pains *duḥkhatrayam* that are indicative of painful experiences in life. Discriminative wisdom—*vivekajñāna* is necessary to overcome pain or attain *freedom* from suffering. In this paper, I would like to focus on the nature and function of *vivekajñāna*, drawing some philosophical insights from moral psychology. Mere analysis of the psychological function of consciousness does not ease the development of *vivekajñāna*. Hence, as an intersection of the philosophy of mind and ethics, moral psychology might lessen the difficulty of explaining that question, that is how does *vivekajñāna* emerge?

14.2 Evolution, Emergence, and Antaḥkaraṇa: A Contemporary Exposition

Sāṃkhya-Yoga believes in the theory of emergence. The constituents of *Antaḥkaraṇa* are the emerging features of *Prakṛti*. This emergence begins with *Prakṛti*'s proximity with *Puruṣa*—it is a *saṃyoga* that brings forth many evolves into reality, making a case for emergence. Emergentism, as a theoretical position, dominates the study of consciousness; it maintains that consciousness is a property that emerges from the complex function of the neurophysiology of the brain. Consciousness is construed as an emerging phenomenon and something new that comes out from certain neurophysiological conditions of the brain. Hence, the function of the brain is causally efficacious in explaining the function of consciousness (Kim, 2006). Thus, the notion of emergence explains the mind–body relationship. It tries to show how the phenomenon of the mind has casually evolved by certain neurophysiological conditions of the body. Thereby, it maintains a bottom-up causal relation so far as the mind–body relationship is concerned.

The notion of emergence treats the relationship between the brain and the mind as that of cause and effect, advocated on an implicit background of evolution. The evolutionary process demonstrates various levels of this relationship, starting from the material existence of atoms and molecules to the emergence of the organic body and then to the emergence of the mind. In other words, the human mind is treated as an emerged property of the neurophysiological system causally related to the body. Furthermore, the emergence of the body and the mind refers to the functional relationship that explains their interaction. However, some philosophers of the emergence theory of mind argue that the causal relation between the mental and the physical is a one-way process only (Kim, 2006), whereas others believe that the relation is a two-way process (Searle, 1983). While strengthening the theory of emergence, Jaegwon Kim argues consistently that the mind or consciousness is not only an emergent property but also supervenes the brain processes. Moreover, for Kim, the mental is causally inefficacious; hence, its functional explanation depends on the causal power of the brain processes. John Searle, on the other hand, believes that the mind is an emerging phenomenon, but this emergence is not entirely explainable in terms of supervenience. Rather, Searle accepts that the mental is intentional and has the power to bring out some action. In this regard, the mental and physical are causally efficacious though their nature of causal power qualitatively differs from each other. Nevertheless, the emergentists conceive the mental or the psychological function of consciousness as a whole. It represents in the form of a unified self. Both Kim and Searle agree that the self has functional significance rather than having a separate ontology.

However, the emergence theory signifies a continual process of development in terms of the production of features and properties. In this connection, emergentists have referred to the basic structure and its succeeding effect in terms of the development of superstructures. Since the process of development is continuous, one builds up on the other. So, there are layers of relationship and each newly emerged level

is connected to its preceding level. The hierarchy of levels gives a complex picture in which the entire universe is related from a micro level to a macro level. The micro and the macro levels broadly refer to the level of the brain and the level of the mind, respectively. The brain functions at the micro level cause the mental level functions, such as the formation of representations, beliefs desires, intentions, etc. The complexity involved in each level of function shows a sort of leap from one level of emergence to another. These leaps indicate *transformation* undergone in the emergent properties at different phases of the process of emergence (Ablowitz, 1939: 4).

The notion of emergence is part of the grand theory of evolution. Modern physical science has tried to corroborate the biological development happening in the universe. The human body is conceptualized as a complex biological organism which has evolved following the principles of evolutionary biology. The mind or consciousness has emerged as one of the basic features of the neurophysiology of the human body. As an emerging phenomenon, thus, consciousness is causally dependent on the biological function of the human organism. This causal dependency has often been questioned by non-reductivists who argue that the human mind, even if it has emerged from the biological processes, still cannot be causally reducible to those biological processes. While critiquing the materialistic or naturalistic reductionism, following Henry Bergson's notion of evolution, R.C. Pradhan argues that "Life is not the mechanical process of change because life evolves non-mechanically as a certain pattern which evolves the life force. The mechanical process of change is predetermined; and therefore, its progress from the past to the future can be calculated *apriori*" (Pradhan, 2020: 97). Emergentism, no doubt, follows the mechanistic model, hence there is a scope of prediction as it operates in the theoretical framework of determinism. But the principle of life is not bound by the law of mechanics. The theory of emergence, as it is maintained by Kim, adheres to a mechanistic functional framework in which mental phenomena are treated as an epiphenomenon. That is to say, the mind or consciousness is causally inefficacious to bring any change in the world. In this regard, the mental supervening on the brain process is having a nominal presence, rather than being ontologically real.

Sāṃkhya-Yoga considers consciousness is real and the manifestations of *Antaḥkaraṇa vṛtti* also is real. The ontology of consciousness in Sāṃkhya refers to the *Puruṣa*, whereas the manifestation of *antaḥkaraṇa* and its *vṛtti* (function) is real because that has emerged from the evolutionary process from the primordial materiality of *Prakṛti*. That is to say, in evolution, *Prakṛti* manifests with its evolutes. Sāṃkhya has categorically expressed the sequence in which these evolutes emerge. *Buddhi* (intellect), *ahankāra* (ego), and *manas* (mind), which constitute the *antaḥkaraṇa*, are the first three evolutes mentioned in the sequence successively bringing out *tanmātras*, and then the *jñānendriya* and *karmendriya* develop. Critics like Jayanta Bhatta question the sequential form of evolution. How does *ahankāra* come out of *buddhi* and evolve into *manas*? As Shiv Kumar summarizes Jayanta Bhatta, "The *Buddhi* is the cognition of the objects, and the *Ahaṅkāra* is also a variety of the *Buddhi*, a special form of cognition, viz, I-notion. It is absurd to hold that the objects come out of such a cognition" (Kumar, 1989: 160). There is no

sequence followed here. The *ahaṅkāra* and *buddhi* are cognitions, and they are not separate as far as the I-notion is concerned. Their occurrence is part of the function of cognition as a whole. Hence, which one will occur first and which one will occur next cannot be explicitly stated.

However, in the case of cognition, there are internal cognitive functions and also the external cognitive function. The cognitive function of the individual is part of the emergence of *buddhi*, *ahaṅkāra*, and the *manas*. They all have emerged from the *Prakṛti* which is in a *saṃyoga* with the *Puruṣa*. The existence of *Prakṛti* and *Puruṣa* has a cosmological dimension, apart from having a cognitive aspect which is part of the psychological function of the body. Jayantabhatta emphasizes that *tanmātras* are *qualities* which can be well explained concerning the knowledge aspects (Kumar, 1989: 165). But, for the Sāṃkhya, *tanmātras* are not qualities, rather they are *guṇas*. *Guṇas* in Sāṃkhya are not qualities but rather attributes. The *guṇas* as *tattvas* of *Prakṛti* have a cosmological existence. Jayantabhatta overlooks the cosmological dimension of the *guṇas*. Hence, this kind of confusion arises when we undermine the *tādātmya*—the relation of entity in difference. Shiva Kumar (1989) tries to show that Vijñānabhikṣu, in his exposition, has made it clear that *tanmātras* are subtle substances—*bhūta sūkṣma*. Nevertheless, the subtle elements are not discrete phenomena; rather, these are grounded in *Prakṛti* which is a primordial material substance but has a cosmic presence.

The cosmic manifestation of *Prakṛti* is the beginning of evaluation. It is about the beginning of the transformation. The first essence that emerges in *Prakṛti* shows its self-transformation in the cosmos as the *mahat*—the *buddhi*. The emergence of *buddhi* is a cosmic creation. This emergence is not a biological evolution. The evolution that Sāṃkhya advocates is not the same as it has been projected by Darwinian evolutionary biology. The Darwinian theory of evolution projects a mechanical process of different stages of biological development. Sāṃkhya's approach to creation is a teleological explanation, which is one of the central points that corroborates with the other classical philosophical systems. The creation is about the transformation of basic elements which is about the flow of cosmic energy in the process of creation: "Cosmic energy is eternal and imperishable and goes on creating new forms in its ever-flowing process of evolution" (Pradhan, 2020: 101). The teleological explanation specifies the metaphysics and its relevance in proposing the necessity of understanding the life force. The metaphysics of Sāṃkhya does not undermine the divine presence of *Prakṛti*. Just saying that is a primordial material substance does not imply that it has lost its divinity. Its cosmological presence brings into the discourse that *Prakṛti* is a living organic system that continues to evolve and that the most creative aspect of its dynamism is real and cannot be denied by mechanism. Moreover, its divinity is explained by metaphysics which transcends the realm of scientific explanation (Pradhan, 2020: 98).

The metaphysics of Sāṃkhya appeals to reflect on the dynamic force of life which runs through the mechanism. In this regard, Pradhan while meditating on the nature of evolution in the Indian philosophy, following Sir Aurobindo, argues that life force is "consciousness which liberates the matter from its inertia" (Pradhan, 2020: 100). The matter itself is inert and living. "Matter and life are two faces of the

same reality that came into existence in the process of evaluation of the universe.... Modern science has discovered the fundamental substance of matter as energy such that every form of material existence is a form of energy. This material energy is expressed differently” (Pradhan, 2020: 97). The energy is inherently present in the *Prakṛti* which is manifested in the dynamism of the *guṇas* and their preponderance in the whole process which defines the entire nature of emergence. In the process of emergence, the volitional knowing represents intellect and self-awareness. In the realm of knowledge, it also specifies some of the psychological functions. In other words, the psychic function of *buddhi* or intellect brings in its attachment to ego and other mental phenomena.

The internal psychological function of the mind refers to the function of *Antaḥkaraṇa*. Among the three constituting parts of *Antaḥkaraṇa*, *buddhi* represents dual aspects: the psychological aspect and the cosmological aspect. The psychological aspect includes (*ahankāra*) ego and its manifestation in asserting the sense of self and sometimes showing a sense of denial in *abhimāna*. The cosmological aspect shows the *reflection* of *Puruṣa*. As *Puruṣa* exists independently of *Prakṛti*, its *saṃyoga* shows a *reflection* in the form of *attention* on *Prakṛti* by making a case for the emergence of evolutes (Conger, 1953: 237). This *attention*, however, is the disinterested *attention* of an onlooking *Puruṣa* that *witnesses* the emerging activities of the *Prakṛti* (Bhattacharya, 2004: 70–71).

14.3 A Note of Sāṃkhya’s Discriminative Knowledge or Wisdom—*Vivekajñāna*

Antaḥkaraṇa, as a field of the emerging activities of *Prakṛti*, unfolds the complex psychological process that is experienced and involves many mental phenomena, such as *mati* (thought), *pratyaya* (idea), *upalabdhi* (ascertainment), *jñāna* (wisdom), *khyāti* (discrimination), *prajña* (insight), *saṃvṛtti* (understanding), *citti* (mentality), and *smṛta* (recollection) (Parrott, 1985: 245/cf. SK 23, 2019). The experience, reasoning, understanding, imagination ascertainment, etc., are conditioned by the process of the function of *buddhi* which represents the most sophisticated cognitive faculty. Since *buddhi* is also the locus of reflection of the cosmic *Puruṣa*, it gives an impression that “*Puruṣa* becomes the agent of activity” (Parrott, 1985: 246). That is the activity or the process of emergence. But *buddhi* as intellect operates through ego and the mind as well. That represents the psychological functions of the individual self. In the social world, the individual self performs activities and interacts with the other. While interacting with the other, it is known whether the action is egoistic or altruistic. The intent of action, therefore, must be well thought out because the intent of action must aim at removing pain. Therefore, the knowledge of *tattvas* is important and can be grasped while constantly seeking knowledge by following *śruti* and *smṛta*. Sāṃkhya’s epistemic concern is also nurtured by the normative attitude of perseverance in attaining the right knowledge, which would

refrain from committing sins and inviting pain to life. In this regard, Sāṃkhya is committed to seeking the right knowledge as well as the practice of truth. The practice of truth is produced by absorbing the right knowledge into oneself, with earnest and uninterpreted contemplation (Virupakshananda, 2019, SK, p. 9).

It is hard to articulate and contemplate the right knowledge because our thoughts are often oriented by *ahaṅkāra*. Every individual who self-performs actions motivated by *ahaṅkāra* makes a case of “erroneous self–projection” (Buitenen, 1957: 19). Action-projecting ego demands the fulfilment of the desires and feelings of the individual. *Ahaṅkāra* expresses a sense of pride that emerges from the occasional coincidence of *rajas* with the *buddhi*—that is, *rajayukta cetasā* where *buddhi* is influenced by the *rajas*. Hence, its expression exhibits emotional feelings—the *bhāvas* of possession. For instance, the feeling of asserting that “I have wealth, wife, children, houses, etc.” The sense of possession is higher than it felt in the normal case of life. “The ego is rather empowered with the *bhāvas* where the *guṇas* cease to influence, rather the psychological *bhāvas* appear.” That is to say, ‘The members of the triad (i.e., the *triṅguṇas* - sattva, rajas and tamas) are here static conditioning factors of the *buddhi*’s emotional life” (Buitenen, 1957: 22). There is no significant change that emerges in terms of the progressive evolutionary influence of the *guṇas*. On the other hand, the psychological condition of the *bhāvas* shows the emergence of passionate activity due to the predominance of *rajas* on the *buddhi*. From this, the senses emerge and disclose their nature of clinging to the world. The emergence of senses is not due to the *buddhi*, rather the important variation here is that “the *buddhi* does not evolve the senses directly but out of *ahaṅkāra*” (Buitenen, 1957: 23).

In this condition, the individuals display attitudes of being engrossed with the world and passionately acquire and accumulate things to satisfy their ego. Anger and dissatisfaction emerge if the ego is hurt or there is a loss of pride. The loss of self-importance sometimes leads to violence. The psychological functions of the ego are such that it does not give up its belongingness to the world. Rather, it tries to possess by exercising power and having control over things. Excessive possession of material wealth along with the possession of ego makes an individual greedy. The materialistic concerns entangle the individual ego with the desire for pleasure and possession; as a result, it fails genuinely to differentiate between good and bad—what is worth possessing in life. *Ahaṅkāra*, thus, displays certain obscurities. This psychological condition of the individual shows *ahaṅkāra* as the *vikṛti* of *buddhi*. The individual is rather falsely driven into the deeper chamber of darkness. The darkness here signifies what Surendranath Dasgupta mentions about “the lack of transparency.” There is a lack of self-knowledge “to differentiate *Puruṣa* from *buddhi* and that is due to avidya in Sāṃkhya and is the root of all experience of misery” (Larson, 1998: 249–250).

These modes of existence not only engage the self but also differentiate it from its other. This self is an individual who exhibits various psychological modes of expression in which it represents the world. Often, it is noticed in our expressions and actions that the self is engrossed in the world, which gives a sense of attachment and belongingness to the world. This belongingness predominately is the bearer of *ego*, which gives a sense of *I* or self that affects the world and gets affected by it. Nevertheless, the world being the manifestation of *Prakṛti*, the self’s experience of

the world remains within the realm of an epistemic relationship, whereas the ontology of this experience is embedded in the *Prakṛti*. The self is derived from this epistemic relationship of knowing about the world. And, that is about being aware of the world. The *awareness* is always an *awareness* of something that unfolds intentionality or directedness of the mind.

However, when do *I* experience this *ahankāra* or the ego? I do experience it while being motivated to achieve something or while being engaged in performing voluntary action. The successful realization of desire or intention brings satisfaction and pleasure in performing what a person assumes or thinks of as desirable. Dissatisfaction and anger emerge when the self encounters obstacles in the course of its realization of desires or expectations. The experience remains central to the *buddhi* in both situations because it takes decisions or forms the judgement. Intellectually, the experiential content may be accessible to the *reason* for forming the judgement. Normatively, when we evaluate its reason, it might take us to different kinds of experiences. For example, it is easy to say that we are all intelligent and equally worthy, but actually, to experience the worth of another person from a different caste or race is indeed challenging. While citing this example, David Bastow mentions that intellectual knowledge concerning experience is different from *yogic* experience (Bastow, 1978: 200). For him, *yogic* experiences are actual and direct, whereas intellectual knowledge is indirect and mediated. Moreover, this distinction of experiential knowledge is based on discerning intentionality that forms discriminative knowledge—*vivekajñāna*.

Discriminative knowledge or wisdom—*vivekajñāna*—is achieved when a person has self-control. One must overcome mental weakness, that is, the *akratic* attitude towards the attractions of worldly pleasures. Till the world of objects fascinates the individual and has an influence over the senses, then one is not free from the bounds of *Prakṛti*. Larson writes, “For Sāṃkhya, the human condition generates itself and is finally the only agency of generating its awareness of itself either as bound or free” (Larson, 1969: 234). The sense of agency or the awareness of *I* is developed by the *ahankāra*—*I am*, and *I do*, or *this is mine*—which are the binding factors that project the individual self in a particular way. Ego, weakness, and the fear of loss project the self as *indiscriminating consciousness* (*ajñāna/avidya*) that forms experience and knowledge about the world (Parrott, 1985: 248). Indiscriminative consciousness, without dismissing the overwhelming predominance of the *rajasic* and the *tamasic* attitude, makes a case for the strong presence of *ahankāra* and *abhimāna* in our everyday engagement with the world. While expressing these attitudes, one might exhibit successful and intellectually reasonable or psychologically robust actions, which causes *misidentification* (Bruke, 1988). At this phase, knowing is confined to the act of *antahkaraṇa* that delivers a false identity.

However, will these attitudes of the self ever have the power to discern good from bad, right from wrong? Can it resolve intellectually generating a sense of humility without resorting to the certain presupposed normative condition for its epistemic exercises? An attempt to answer these questions might help us meditate through the intentionality of seeking *self-knowledge*, safeguarding us from misidentification. No doubt, Sāṃkhya is concerned with, i.e., the ability to have a kind of perfection that

would unfold the necessity of *vivekajñāna*. The discerning intentionality conceives its function beyond the over-imposition of *ahañkāra* and *abhimāna*. Freedom from the false identity emerges spontaneously from the human condition, but as Larson puts it, “Freedom is not a positive realization of what the human condition is. Freedom itself is precisely the realization of what the human condition is not – namely that it is not contentless consciousness” (Larson, 1969: 234). Having content is to be *aware* of something which gets disclosed in the expressions *I am...*, *I have...*, and *I know...* The content of my experience thus presupposes the existence of *I* as the subject of experience. But, does this *awareness* disclose real self-consciousness or self-knowledge? Or, does it only express one’s individuality? In the case of self-consciousness or self-knowledge, one strives to know the real self—the very source of consciousness. Since *buddhi* along with *ahañkāra* can only impress us with the egoistic attitude of individualism, it does not take us deeper into the realm of *awareness* and provide the knowledge of pure consciousness or the *Puruṣa*.

In this regard, Larson suggests that this *awareness* does not refer to the realization of the cosmic or the existence of a metaphysical self—*Puruṣa*. Rather, in his description, the awareness is a realization that can be described negatively stating *na asmi* (I am not), *na me* (Consciousness does not apply to me), *na aham iti* (I am not this consciousness) (Larson, 1969: 235). That is to say, the psychological expression of individual awareness does not reveal the real nature of the self. Indirectly, Larson possibly suggests the notion of transcendence as *na aham iti* discloses the limit of the individual’s awareness. But what he mentions firmly is that “Ordinary ‘awareness’ (*Antaḥkaraṇa vṛtti*) appears to be ‘consciousness’ (*Puruṣa*), the failure to discriminate (*aviveka*) the difference between ‘awareness’ and ‘consciousness’ brings about the experience of suffering and bondage” (Larson, 1969: 227). The suffering is associated with life and the psychological condition in which the individual grounds his/her knowledge based on awareness only. So long as this *awareness* prevails, one fails to discriminate one’s relationship with the world—being engrossed in the world of materialism or confined to *Prakṛti* only without reflecting on the real nature of *tattvas*. This sort of awareness obstructs self-knowledge, as it fails to discriminate the relationship of the intellect or *buddhi* with ego and thereby fails to disown egocentricity that invokes self-assertions.

Following this, one might suggest that if the *Antaḥkaraṇa vṛtti* does not free *buddhi* from its engaged relationship with *ahañkāra*, then with this “strong dependence relation,” the *Prakṛti* as a whole, for Karl Potter, appears to be “consistent with reductive materialism.” As Larson summarizes Potter, “All through intellect or *buddhi* is the primary factor within the causal system, thus separating *Sāṃkhya* on this level from a form of crude materialism nevertheless the system assigns only an epiphenomenal status to the *buddhi* making it as much as product or effect of *prakṛti* as is jar or clod of the earth” (Larson, 1969: 229). Certainly, *buddhi* or intellect is not an epiphenomenon as it is the first evolute called the *mahat*. Although, with evolution, the *mahat* comes into existence, and with dissolution, it returns to the triguṇas of *Prakṛti*, still, the functional dynamism of *Prakṛti* does not take away the ontological significance of intellect in *Sāṃkhya* philosophy. The intellect is powerful and efficacious as it brings necessary changes in the very process of emergence including its

horizontal functional relationship with other *jñānendriya* and *karmendriya*. Hence, it is necessary to reflect on the very reason for evolution as it presupposes the presence of *Puruṣa*—the *pure consciousness*. What is the relationship between *pure consciousness* and the *awareness* of intellect—*buddhi*?

To describe, the pure consciousness of *Puruṣa* being a witness (*sākṣin*), being isolated (*kaivalya*), and being uninvolved (*madhyastha*) (Larson, 1969: 230), Sāṃkhya, in my reading, opens up a discourse of higher consciousness. Pure consciousness is transcendental and contentless, whereas the psychic function of the *awareness* caused by the *antaḥkaraṇa vṛtti* is intentional and involves content. The contentless consciousness can be grasped, if the *buddhi* tries to reflect upon its nature of intentionality. The reflection is conceived in the form of discrimination, that is, the *buddhi* discriminates against the other with an intention that *what it is not*. This is a spontaneous outcome of the *bhāvas* which are not in relation with *ahaṅkāra*. The *bhāvas* manifest themselves with an aspiration to understand their *svabhāva*. That is why, this epistemic endeavour is known as *viveka-khyāti* which aims at attaining *viveka-jñāna* (Larson, 1969: 228). The attainment of this knowledge transcends the realm of egocentric intentional awareness. The transcendence unfolds the reason for projecting the cosmic existence of *Puruṣa* and *Prakṛti* having a metaphysical significance. As I have already discussed in the previous section, in the case of creative evolution, the presence of “divine reality explained by metaphysics transcends the realm of scientific explanation” (Pradhan, 2020: 100). Sāṃkhya presupposes the *Puruṣa* as the pure consciousness in the form of *sākṣin*, *kaivalya*, and *madhyastha* that show the significance of divinity present in the *Puruṣa*. Thus, the ontology of *Puruṣa* presents a higher order consciousness. Nevertheless, to put the function of evaluation in a causal closure of the function of *Prakṛti* will nullify the grand metaphysics that Sāṃkhya proposes while narrating the normative order of evaluation that unfolds ways to gasp the divine nature of consciousness.

14.4 Vivekajñāna as Higher Order Consciousness

Human existence cannot just discard the normative significance of witness (*sākṣin*), uninvolved (*madhyastha*), and liberation (*kaivalya*). They are not just symbolic but unfold the possibility of freedom inherent in human consciousness to reflect and mediate the purpose of creation. Such an aspiration helps in understanding the deepest nature of selfhood. The individual’s deepest selfhood does not lie in the empirical ego only, but rather from the very fact of consciousness that frees an individual from all the bondage of life and helps in realizing absolute knowledge (Larson, 1969: 13). The self that is confined to the world alone is *bandha*—living in bondage. Suffering is inevitable in this mode of engagement with the world. Yoga, which is an ally of the Sāṃkhya philosophical system, fulfils this necessary vacuum providing a solid normative framework for seeking an answer to this primitive philosophical question concerning one’s identity—that is, *who am I?* Am I only *this*? Furthermore, what can free *me* from the clutches of suffering? The self-constituted function of

antaḥkaraṇa does not release itself from the boredom of dissatisfaction, anxiety, and stress produced by the struggle for power and wealth that affects a person's psyche and becomes constraints for driving the self towards higher consciousness.

The Pātañjala Yoga provides a normative framework for living and experiencing a different world from the world of an *ahmakari* and *abhimānin* person. An *ahamkari* lives in a self-centric world where he/she knows the world as it *appears* to be. The locus of experiencing such a self-centric world is not beyond the realm of ego and the intellect; rather, one reflects on its nature and tries to act in such a way that he/she does not become egoistic. Because an *ahamkari* lives in its false paradigm and fails to see reality as it is. Rather, one understands own thoughts and reason as they appear valid. One must act in transforming oneself by properly implementing the normative principle of *yama* and *niyama* into one's life. A yogic life must be laid by the virtue of truthfulness, non-violence, nonpossession, etc.

With its sound metaphysics and epistemology, Sāṃkhya emphasizes the view of cosmic existence and the necessity of rational knowledge. If the cosmic metaphysical viewpoint is undermined, then one might fail to understand the relevance of *Puruṣa* and *Prakṛti* and their harmonious co-existence. However, the failure to understand this metaphysical viewpoint of the *tattvas* of *Prakṛti* is due to a lack of *self-knowledge* necessary for appreciation of the true nature of *Puruṣa*. As Gasper Koelman illustrates,

The process of ordinary cognition, as well as the process of discriminating knowledge, (*vivekajñāna*), belongs to *Prakṛti*, in particular to the *sattvam* (buddhi), for the illumination by the lights of consciousness. But that reality, which has the awareness of this ordinary cognition or discerning cognition, is the Spirit. The Spiritual self is, therefore, the ecstatic and inactive 'discerner' (*viveki*), not the agent of the cognitive process. (cf. Parrott, 1985: 245)

The cognitive processes in the *buddhi* of *Prakṛti* are insufficient to fully comprehend the nature of *tattvas* because it assumes the empirical experiences are real, and as a result, it fails to distinguish between the knowing and the knower.

The spiritual dimension of the self can be well construed concerning the ideas of values of life and liberation from suffering. Sāṃkhya is an atheistic philosophical system. It does not project the existence of God but rather argues from the presupposition of a higher consciousness about the existence of *Puruṣa*. It not only unfolds the notion of cosmic existence but also shows the means to elevate one's consciousness to a higher realm of thinking that is life-enriching and life-enhancing. While analysing the idea of perfection in human life, N.K. Devaraja points out that "Man seeks awareness of whatever is life-enriching and life-enhancing; further, he seeks to adjust his affective or emotional attitudes in the light of his total awareness" (Devaraja, 1979: 429). The realization of the existence of pure consciousness does not eliminate the psychic function of *buddhi-ahankāra* or intellect-ego which exhibits the affective emotional attitudes of an individual. It is rather to develop an attitude of gradually withdrawing from this engagement and contemplate on higher values laden existence. This transcendental epistemic approach tries not only to comprehend the consciousness as a whole but also unfolds some direction towards reality considering human existence has a cosmological viewpoint. This total awareness, therefore, may

point to a transformed self that freely engages with the world in a more enlightened way.

The question that arises here is “Is this failure only an epistemic failure?” Sāṃkhya’s metaphysics speaks of *Puruṣārtha* and is optimistic about the possibility of freedom from suffering. Hence, it conceptualizes the possibility of cognitive separation, which would liberate him from the experience of suffering. In this connection, the evaluative reasoning of the world’s experience stresses the function of a discerning attitude that points to a reality beyond discontentment, suffering, attachment to pleasure and bondage: “The real mode of freedom from the misery of existence lies in the knowledge of principles (essences) of Sāṃkhya; the evolved, the unevolved and the knower” (Parrott, 1985: 236).

Yuktiṭīpikā suggests the function of *vivekajñāna*—*vijñāna* as a direct experience—*sākṣātkāra*, which means seeing through one’s mind’s eye. The term “mind’s eye” refers to intuition rather than intellect. *Sāṃkhyakārikā* mentions “intuitive nondiscursive realization.” While elucidating this, Dmitry Shevchenko mentions that discerning power refers to *reflection*—understanding the intended object only through thinking power without perception, inference, and verbal testimony. In this state of consciousness, one understands *that—the ūhā*, I would like to emphasize that *not this* which belongs to a kind of knowledge called *Apūrva* (unprecedented) (Shevchenko, 2017: 872–873).

Reference to the notion of attention and reflection further needs elaboration. The attention of *Puruṣa* is a reason for disturbing the equilibrium of the *guṇas* of *Prakṛti*. Since it is the cause of making the *jaḍa* into *cañcala*, how can it fail to witness the changes occurring in the realm of *Prakṛti*? How to estimate the cognition of the witnessing consciousness—*Sākṣin*. It is undoubtedly a non-interfering state of consciousness; hence, its intentionality of witnessing is neutral—which has the power of *discerning* itself to make a perspicuous representation of what is being witnessed. Normatively speaking, being a witness, one is only being guided by the *dharma* and not by any other enforcing intentional agential power than its agency. This agency cannot disown the moral space conceived by the normative power of *dharma*. The agency of *Puruṣa* is thus autonomous and independent of being selectively attending as a neutral observer to the occurrences in the realm of *Prakṛti*. Hence, its disengagement and recovery from attention are due to its own presence not being causally bound by the function of the *antaḥkaraṇa*.

Moreover, the *reflection* makes *buddhi* act consciously. This conscious experience must have the experience that forms self-knowledge. The actual knowledge is not intellectual. The knowledge delivered through intellect seeks justification and proof. The *discriminative knowledge* is beyond the realm of justification. A *viveki* is a seeker who keeps *shraddha* in *seeking* knowledge about the self till it perfects itself in practising the attitude of discerning, which helps to overcome not only one’s ego but also all mental weaknesses. Thus, *vivekajñāna* needs supreme detachment and *ekāgratā* in yogic practices in which one obtains *self-knowledge* in which the experience enters into an uninterrupted flow of *knowing* as the idea of *Puruṣa* itself. It speaks about absolute consciousness devoid of any objectivity. It is the highest knowledge of *pure consciousness*—a non-conceptual knowledge.

To conclude, discriminative knowledge—*vivekajñāna*—needs to be understood from the perspective of normative epistemology that must enable comprehension that *wisdom is good*. Wisdom arises in *buddhi* as a case of self-knowledge where the experience transcends the psychological realm of duality and enters into the realm of cosmic knowing. The epistemic concern must be nurtured by the normative attitude of seeking truth and practising it. Thus, it helps us realize how to overcome differences concerning the knowledge of the world and the cause of suffering. *Vivekajñāna* is essential for overcoming suffering.

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Chapter 15

Self-Knowledge and Self-Transformation: A Way Towards the Ethics of Life



Barada Laxmi Panda

Abstract Yoga philosophy talks about the realization of the ultimate truth about the self and the world. Yoga refers to the union of the individual and the supreme selves. To achieve this goal, yoga promotes *nirodha*, cessation or control of the mind. Yoga is the science of controlling the mind, as the mind is considered the root cause of bondage and the cause of liberation. Yoga teaches non-attachment to the self with the world. Attachment creates an imbalance between body and mind. It makes difficult for the self to choose between the reality of eternal bliss and sensual pleasures received from the world. Non-attachment, for *Patañjali*, is to detach the mind from the fascinating worldly pleasures and be united with the infinite, where the self attains super-consciousness. The cessation of the cycle of life is possible with the practice of yoga, where the limited mundane self gets the scope of realizing its unlimited power of true knowledge and enters the level of pure consciousness. The self starts realizing the power of self-transformation present within it. Yoga promotes the self to break the cycle and move forward in the direction of eternal bliss by achieving self-knowledge and self-transformation recognized as *pure consciousness*. The limited self transforms as the limitless self with the help of *sādhana* is defined as yoga, that is, the ultimate point of “unitness.”

Keywords Yoga · Self · Self-knowledge · Self-transformation · Pure consciousness

15.1 Introduction

Yoga means union. Yoga speaks of *cittavṛtti nirodha*, that is, cessation of the modification of *citta* (Abhedananda, 1967). There are several reasons for the modification of *citta*. But a yogi’s *citta* at the state of *samādhi* is not affected by the *vṛttis*; rather, the yogi has gradually obtained control of the *vṛttis* at various stages and transcends them

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to realize *kaivalya*. A yogi's *citta* represents a case of an individual *citta Puruṣa*—that is, an individual self-consciousness which aspires to realize *kaivalya*. The realized state is a state where the individual self-consciousness merges into the universal self-consciousness. That is the union between *jīvātman* and *paramātman*. Yoga explains the mechanism of this unification or the individual self merging in the realm of the universal self. In other words, the individual self is unified with the higher universal self. Yoga's methodology focuses on the explanation of the nature of *citta vṛtti* and its way towards the cessation of *vṛttis*—*samādhi*. The process enlightens a yogi about the transcendental nature of *ātmān* as a source of knowledge, intelligence, and bliss. The theory states the union of the mundane individual self with the higher universal self. Yoga talks about the ultimate form of transformation and union of the individual self with the divine self. In other words, yoga philosophy aims to signify the science of unification of the lower self with the higher one, the union of *jīvātman* with *paramātman*. It promotes the mind to catch a glimpse and realize the glory of the absolute, the true nature of the transcendental *ātmān*, which is the fountainhead of knowledge, intelligence, and bliss and the true nature of *vṛttis* or the distracted modifications of the mind.

Patañjali, the chief exponent of the yoga system, maintains that yoga is *cittavṛtti nirodha*. There is absolutely no modification of *citta* at the yogic state. The *vṛttis* come to an end while attaining *samādhi* (Dvivedi, 1890). Patañjali's yoga *sūtras* or aphorisms, in this context, are truly relevant as they not only enunciate the laws and principles of purification of the body and the mind. The process of purification is technically brought into action to maintain a perfect balance between body, mind, and spirit. The yoga system teaches to reduce the mind's substance into its simplest form following the method of cessation (*nirodha*), which ultimately helps the mind to shine in its beauty and majesty. However, the challenge is how to obtain cessation with the fluctuating attitude of the mind. As a solution, yoga psychology states that coming out of the changing approach of mind and moving it in one direction will be possible with the help of constant practice. Practice helps the self to maintain steadiness, and steadiness helps the distracted mind to transform into a conscious mind and attain self-knowledge (Abhedananda, 1967: vi and vii).

15.2 Self and Self-Knowledge

The notion of self-knowledge is very much part of the discourse of liberation or enlightenment right from Upaniṣadic philosophy. The state of liberation represents the most sublime state of union that not only speaks about an awakening self but also unfolds self-transformation. Following the Upaniṣadic understanding, it is believed that the individual self unites with or merges with the absolute self through yoga. On the other hand, the *Patañjali Yogasūtra* does not support the acknowledgement of such a self. It promotes the detachment or separation of the self from *Prakṛti*. Thus, yoga, which means “union” in the Upaniṣad, means disunion (*viyoga*) in *Patañjali Yogasūtra* (Hiriyana, 1967: 122). Liberation means the isolation of *Puruṣa*

from *prakṛti* following the understanding of yoga philosophy. While Sāṃkhya holds knowledge as the source of attaining liberation, yoga admits the steps of concentration and active striving as the true path to liberation (*kaivalya*). While Sāṃkhya refers to knowledge, yoga advocates the attainment of self-knowledge and self-realization.

According to yoga philosophy, self-knowledge can be attained by following a dutiful action and holding on to a spirit of detachment. On the one hand, while Sāṃkhya *darśana* is logical, yoga *darśana* guides the self to be devotional following mental and bodily disciplines. As Radhakrishnan pointed out, “The aim of yoga is to free the individual from the clutches of matter. The highest form of matter is Citta, and yoga lays down the course by which a man can free himself from the fetters of natural functions, we overcome the pain of the world and escape from *saṃsāra*” (Radhakrishnan, 1992: 344). When the *citta* or mind acts actively, the self appears to experience various conditions and with the calmness of mind following the path of meditation, the self abides in its own true form (Radhakrishnan, 1992: 347). Yoga teaches us how to control our mind by becoming the master of the mind. “I” or soul is considered as the subject and the mind is considered as the object in understanding. In principle, the subject controls the object. But, many times, it has been noted that with the constant flux of the individual nature and world, the object seems superior to the subject. That means, many times, for example, human actions are guided by the *indriyas* or the knowledge derived from them known as *indriyanubhuti jñāna* or sense experiential knowledge.

The mind is one of the *indriyas*. As an individual, if one is often guided by his mind and does not have any control over it, then that creates obstacles in terms of acquiring self-knowledge. It is because the *indriyanubhuti jñāna* overrules any other forms of knowledge, and one becomes blinded by the content of experiential knowledge and, more importantly, by considering them only true and nothing beyond them. Thus, lack of self-control in a person’s life becomes the reason for not gaining self-knowledge. To avoid this, yoga has maintained the eightfold steps as a guide to deal with the problem. Yoga, in this context, teaches us the method to control the *indriyas*. This refers to the idea of disciplining the mind by following those steps as one becomes the master of our mind. This technique, according to Patañjali, helps us achieve ultimate happiness. Thus, freedom of the soul is an essential requirement in yoga philosophy.

Yoga philosophy emphasizes the notion of freedom as a valid source of attaining liberation. It promotes the self to remove the superficial layers of knowledge or ignorance and enter the inner spirit of attaining self-knowledge. Concentration on understanding the true nature of self, in this regard, is an essential and helpful aspect of attaining self-knowledge. Concentration is a quality of the *citta* in all its five stages (Yogasūtra, i). The *citta* is called *kṣipta* or restless when it has an excess of *rajas* and is tossed about by objects. We might focus our attention on objects due to our passions and interests, but this kind of concentration does not help us to our real freedom. It is *mūḍha* or blinded when it has an excess of *tamas* and is possessed by the modification of sleep. It is *vikṣipta* when one is more often distracted and unstable on account of natural defects or accidental troubles. The ordinary mind is in this condition perusing the pleasant and avoiding the unpleasant. These three are

said to be imperfect since they are associated with the three *guṇas*. The mind is said to be *ekāgra* or single-pointed when it is devoted to one object of meditation and is filled with *sattva*. This prepares the mind for its greatest efforts. It is *nirūḍha* or restricted when its developments are checked. The yoga psychologists admit that concentration is a general characteristic of all states of mind, though it is found in its interest form in the state of *samādhi*.

Every mental modification (*vṛtti*) leaves behind a *saṃskāra*, or latent tendency, which may manifest itself as a conscious state when the occasion arises. Similarly, *vṛttis* strengthen similar dispositions.

The *yogi* should not only arrest the modifications but also destroy the dispositions; otherwise they may shoot forth again. When the mind is rid of its modifications, it is said to be in a balanced state (*samāpatti*) and to assume the form of whatever object is presented to it, the knower, the known or the act of knowledge. It assumes the nature of the object as it is in itself. (Radhakrishnan, 1992: 348)

The human mind holds conflicting and self-developing dispositions with irrational desires and is influenced by the empirical conditions of the world. The mind pleases with such remembrances. These states are refusable states to be controlled because of the influential nature of the *indriyas*. This remembrance nature of the mind does not allow the self to realize the reality of its own. As a result, the self holds misconceptions because of the dispositional state of nature. To be a *yogi*, it is important to make the memory and get rid of accepting the biases of the *indriyānubhūti jñāna* and stand firmly accepting the *ātmā jñāna*. It is important to see the rope as a rope and not as a snake with the adoption of the power of knowledge and self-reflectivity.

Yoga philosophy adopts the Sāṃkhya ontology with slight variations. It agrees with Sāṃkhya in holding that bondage is due to non-discrimination between the self and *Prakṛti*, and liberation is possible by discriminating between the two. At the same time, yoga is considered the best means of realizing this discrimination. Yoga helps to understand the difference between the self, which does not realize the essential reality present within it, and the world which is always represented in the form of the illusory state known as *Prakṛti*. Yoga helps to distinguish between “I” and the world or between self-knowledge and knowledge about the world. Knowledge about the true nature of the self can be defined as self-knowledge. Why, then, does acquiring self-knowledge seem like a difficult task? This happens when the self passes through different modes of worldly changes which restrict the self from realizing its inner potentiality of carrying the self-proven attitude. As the earth has the potential to transform into a jar, similarly, the self has the potential to realize its self-existence. As J. N. Sinha elucidates with an example, saffron grows in Kashmir and not in Panchal as its seeds germinate in a particular environment. This shows the limitations of the place. Different crops grow at different times. This is the limitation of time. A female deer cannot give birth to a human being. This is the limitation of the form. Similarly, the soul has limitations when it crosses different modes of time and place. It is shaped into a different form. *Sattva*, *rajas*, and *tamas* are the material causes for which the soul shapes into different forms and stays away from self-realization. To be self-awarded and self-transformed, the self needs to adopt the ten unique qualities of

knowledge, detachment, lordship, austerity, veracity, forgiveness, patience, creative power, self-knowledge, and superintendence (Sinha, 1998: 296–297). Adaptation of these steps certainly will help the soul to find out and move towards the highest life, that is, the ethics of life.

15.3 Self-Transformation: Ethics of Life for a Limitless Journey

One of the most common obstructions to attaining eternal bliss is the self's willingness to live or cling to life. Patañjali states that as *swarasavahi*. This means flowing with the nature of desire is the clinging of life which we find in every human and other animal. This clingingness is very powerful as it binds us with the world. This binding thus is full of worldly desires that one is always after them. In this regard, clinging signifies the attachment to life creating the fear of death in all animals including humans. With death, life ends and so the unfulfilled desires remain. More importantly, the fear of death creates a strong illusory bondage and obstacle for the soul to acquire self-knowledge. The self loses its power of self-governance in this stage and becomes the slave of passion and attachment. There is a strong influence of the external world which remains a binding factor. The object controls the subject as discussed earlier. To get back the mastership, the self needs to be self-governed. Self-governed would be possible if, and only if, the self is committed to the *self* in terms of realizing its capacity of influencing by its own power of self-guidance. But how is it possible? This would be possible by gaining the right knowledge as obtaining the right knowledge is the true nature of the self. The self needs not to be confused between understanding the difference between the right knowledge and instinctive knowledge or sense experiential knowledge. The experience that remains latent and stays in the form of an impression in the subconscious mind is known as instinctive knowledge, such as fear of death (Abhedananda, 1967) and desire to live in the form of continuation. On the other hand, the right knowledge can be defined as the understanding of the eternal existence of the soul instead of the perishable nature of the material body.

Yoga enjoins the suppression of all the five stages of the mind such as *kṣipta*, *mūḍha*, *vikṣipta*, *ekāgra*, and *nirūḍha* mentioned by Vyāsa. *Kṣipta* is considered the lowest form of mind where the mind lacks the necessary power and ability to make proper decisions reflecting the situation. This state of mind is dominated by *rajas guṇas*. The second state of mind known as *mūḍha* is dominated by *tamas guṇas*. In this state of mind, the self is incapable of hearing the inner voice of it for which the self fails to communicate with the true nature of it (self). The third state of mind is *vikṣipta* where the mind becomes confused between clarity and darkness. In this state, the self becomes diverted by many external factors and ignores the limitless power of achieving self-knowledge. The self does not realize the capacity to control the distracted mind. Yoga suggests, in this context, that the regular practice

of meditation will be helpful for the self to build a sense of clarity and focus in nature. In the yogic sense, whatever the self perceives through the five senses is impure and incomplete. In the state of *ekāgra*, without being affected by external factors, the self turns into a one-pointed focus following the practice of meditation. The self finds absolute control in thoughts and actions in the *ekāgra* state of mind. In the state of *nirūḍha*, no impressions and factors can distract the mind as the mind comes under the control of the subject or self. The self does not react to any changing situation and stays stable and calm to make itself prepare to start the journey towards attaining *kaivalya*. The *nirūḍha* state of mind is the ultimate aim of the yoga state by *Patañjali*. In this state, the self becomes detached from the fascinating external world expiring through sense organs and starts obtaining self-knowledge through self-transformation. The first three states of mind are restless, less energetic, and unfocused whereas the last two states of mind, that is, *ekāgra* and *nirūḍha*, help the self to build self-awareness and concentration. To be concentrated and pure conscious, yoga suggests the eradication of all mental dispositions with the help of following the rigid discipline of the body which refers to the vital force and the mind which refers to the moral or ethical practices (Abhedananda, 1967: 304). *Patañjali*, in this context, defines yoga as a complete suppression of all mental modes. Vyāsa defines yoga as absorptive concentration and regards it as a universal attribute of the mind. A person can attain yoga by repeated practice (*abhyāsa*) and detachment (*nivṛtti*). The distracted, infatuated, and occasionally steady minds are not fit for yoga. It can only be attained by the one-pointed and restrained mind. The person who holds this kind of mind is called a *yogin* who holds the qualifications for moving towards the highest ethical life.

The yogin enjoins the ethical life following the *aṣṭāṅgamārga*. The first *mārga* or stage is *yama* (restraints) which guides the self to stop thinking of all negative factors and work on the positive thoughts of truthfulness, non-violence, etc. The second stage is *niyama* (observance) which promotes the self to maintain cleanliness in both the bodily and mental levels. The third stage *āsana* (bodily posture) helps the self to calm the mind by maintaining certain smooth and pleasurable bodily postures. The fourth stage known as *prāṇāyāma* (breath control) helps the self to bring control over the breathing functions of the body as it helps the mind to think in one direction. The fifth stage of discipline is *pratyāhāra* (withdrawal of the sense organs) which focuses on withdrawing the external sensible object as these create obstacles to maintain steadiness of mind. The sixth discipline *dhāraṇā* (fixation of attention) helps the mind to fix itself on one particular object, either an intra-organic object such as the navel or an extra-organic object image or idol. The seventh stage is *dhyāna* (meditation). This stage of discipline helps the mind to pay attention to an intra-organic or extra-organic object continuously or for a longer period where the mind finds a way of not being distracted by other sources. The last stage known as *samādhi* (absorptive concentration) helps the mind to be purely concentrated and helps the self to be transcendent (Yogasūtra, iii, 1–3; Sinha, 1998: 304–310). This is the stage where the self enjoys pure consciousness and the “I” attains the state of “pure self.” This self is far away from *avidya* or ignorance. This self attains *ātmajñāna* or self-knowledge, which is different from discriminative or false knowledge. The self

becomes super-conscious and attains the stage of realizing *Isvara* or God. With the help of this state, the self acquires the intuitive knowledge that apprehends the truth (*rta*). This knowledge is known as *ṛtambhara prajñā*. This self becomes unique and stays away from generalities (Sinha, 1998: 312).

To be one with the infinite by avoiding *avidya* or limitations of the finite being, knowledge of the right knowledge is the key. Knowledge of the right knowledge is possible with the constant practice of meditation as proposed in yoga philosophy. Meditation helps us develop the limitless power present within us. Regular practice of meditation creates the power of concentration within the self which helps the self to be focused in terms of realizing eternal infinity. *Patañjali* states meditation is the self-effulgent or spiritual light. In other words, meditation brings perfection to the self. “Concentration leads to meditation, and when meditation is deep, it is called *samādhi* or super-conscious state. When the mind becomes quiet, the Spirit reigns Supreme in its own glory” (Abhedananda, 1967: 336). This state of super-consciousness is the state where the self knows about its own knowing. This state is the state of self-knowledge.

Self-knowledge is the pure, true, and certain form of knowledge here. True knowledge is a subject of self-experience. By using consciousness, if the self understands something, that is called true knowledge. To know the divine, we must search or enquire who we are. That means self-knowledge is an essential criterion for knowing the divine. The divine truth is the absolute truth. The more we come to know Him, the more we become attached to Him. Once the soul attains this knowledge, the soul stays undisturbed from the atomic to the infinite. The self becomes free from all attachments and becomes the eternal spiritual being.

The super-conscious mind enjoys complete freedom. This makes the self realize heavenly bliss. The self becomes a *yogin* with complete freedom and bliss. Freedom, in this sense, brings *kaivalya* for the self with the power of absolute independence. It is the eternal life of the *Puruṣa* as it is freed from the fetters of *Prakṛti*. The self realizes the “Self” with the light of self-knowledge, and all the darkness of ignorance disappears. The self is introduced as the “Purified Self” and remains untouched by the conditions of *citta*—*yoga citta vṛtti nirodha* (Patanjali Yoga, Sūtra 1.2). Yoga is the cessation of the movements of the mind. With the purifications of body, mind, and soul the self enters the beautiful kingdom of God with a beatific vision where the concentration of the soul is so deep that it will not be disturbed by the strong vibration of the air or ether. The real significance of the meaning of life is understood. The meaning cannot be grasped until the self becomes one with the meaning. This is the stage of self-realization along with acquiring self-knowledge. Realization means to be one with the object. Knowing is being here. *Brahmavid Brahmaiva Bhabati* (Abhedananda, 1967, 138).

Concentration, meditation, and super-consciousness are the three principal stages of self-realization. Concentration leads to meditation and meditation leads to a super-conscious state. But the most faced obstacle for self-realization is our *ego* which is guided by many worldly forces. The ego comes in the form of “me,” “I,” and “mine.” In other words, the ego may be defined as the self-conscious entity, the thinker, the doer, and the performer of actions. But because of passing through different worldly

modes, the “I” loses the potential of realizing the inner unlimited power of its own consciousness. When we eat, we are eating consciously and we are conscious of the sensation of eating. The body takes the food but the sensation of eating is felt, not by the body but by the ego. The enjoyment is not by the body but by the ego. After the food goes into the stomach, the stomach does not feel, but there is someone outside of all these things who has the power of feelings. And this someone presents within all of us who feels is the “I” who says “I feel,” “I am happy,” “I am sorry,” “I am suffering,” etc. Those who hold these different kinds of feelings are our selves. It is like a witness (*sākṣi*). It stands beyond and yet is connected.

What is the goal of this self then? The goal is God-consciousness where the mortal ego transfers into a super-conscious state and gains the power of realizing eternal Truth (Abhedananda, 1967: 191). This is the state of the ultimate union of the self with All-Being where the self is not aware of anything except Itself. This is a stage where the individual consciousness unites with universal consciousness, maintaining the self-transformation. This helps the self to adopt the knowledge of its own uninfluential knowing. The goal of the self, at this stage, is to be united with the *Puruṣa*—the universal consciousness. To reach that goal, the self needs control over the senses. The real meaning of mortification is holding the sense wheels firmly while guiding the body and mind. It is not torture but controlling desires so that our intellect will take steps with proper understanding and knowledge. This helps the self to make sensible discrimination. Discrimination and separation are the most desired virtues in this context. This, of course, helps the self to attain self-knowledge. So the power of the mind needs to be strengthened. Through the power of the mind, it is possible to get control over the body. “Mind must be the ruler of the body, not *vice-versa*. Constant practice using the body helps the mind to become the ruler. The mind must be the ruler, intellect is the charioteer, the mind is the reins which the intellect is holding tight, and our soul is the rider above all” (Abhedananda, 1967: 138). Following this process, we may notice that we are progressing each time, and we are being rewarded with stronger willpower. Ultimately, the sense of more discrimination will arise within us. Our understanding, knowledge, and realization will be clearer like a cloudless sky. Our inner visions can see the real “I” and the perfect and endless “Self” within us. To transcend ignorance, the self has to be one with pure divine knowledge. The self has to attain *pure consciousness*. For the knower of the self, there will be no ignorance, and the self will shine with the light of its power following the path of meditation. By meditation, all kinds of modifications of the mind are to be conquered. Thus, meditation is a necessary aspect of self-knowledge and self-realization. Swami Vivekananda also mentions in his way of discussing Raja Yoga that meditation or absolute concentration of the mind is one of the greatest means of controlling the rising waves of desires. Raja Yoga is the psycho-physiological method and par excellence for Vivekananda (Rolland, 2010: 221). Vivekananda calls it Psychological Yoga as it promotes the self to have absolute mastery of the mind—the first condition of all knowledge. “The powers of the mind are like rays of dissipated light; when they are concentrated they illumine. This is our only means of knowledge” (Vivekananda, 1896).

This would be a great blessing. By practising meditation, we can win the different forms of waves that arise in our mind. Vivekananda prescribes that we can meditate upon any ideal we like. Patañjali also mentions that we can meditate on anything that appeals to us as good. There can be different objects of meditation. But we should hold on to one particular object for the time, and meditate upon it for gaining a certain result. If this happens in regular form, then the yogi's mind becomes undisturbed from the atomic level (*aṇu*) to the infinite sphere (*mahat*). Nothing in the universe will be able to disturb our minds. A good vibration will be created within us with a tremendous force and no worldly power will be sufficient to interfere and restrict the vibrating power of the self to attain *mokṣa* or *kaivalya*. As a result, the self will enjoy living like a master with a perfect mind and pure heart using supreme freedom. In this state, the self awakens and transforms from external authority to internal authority or *guru* of its own. External authority, in this context, is the fluctuating self who has the power to control the body but not the mind. For example, following a diet routine to keep the body looking attractive, the self is controlling the body but not getting happiness or satisfaction as it cannot control the mind which is craving delicious spicy food. On the other hand, the internal authority is the experiential authority who first tries to calm worldly thoughts and gets control over both body and mind by realizing the health benefits of taking a proper diet and enjoying the process. Yoga refers to the state of acquiring knowledge of self-controlling following maintaining a balance between body, mind, and spirit which guides the self to walk in the lane of moral progress.

Emotional feeling, in a real metaphysical sense, promotes the self not to be diluted with worldly pleasure but rather to be self-awakening by realizing the essential nature. This is considered a new form of consciousness achieved through self-knowledge. The achievement of knowing about one's knowledge may be defined as a proper form of emotion here. In this context, human consciousness, understood in an ordinary sense, is not the ideal form of consciousness. The consciousness achieved by the internal authority is the *consciousness purse* or pure consciousness which comes out in terms of maintaining the differentiation between the cosmic self and the metaphysical self following the *aṣṭāṅgamārga* proposed by Patañjali. "I" or the self bears the capacity of infinity which extends to the metaphysical level. The aim of this self with infinite power is to create a healthy individual. "The healthy individual is one whose emotional life is tightly linked to primal feeling" (Asher, 2011). The primal feeling is the realization of attaining the state of pure consciousness. It is the feeling of the soul about the non-differential aspect of his *yogic self*. As *Puruṣa* is pure consciousness and eternal, it gets the scope to guide *Prakṛti*. But there is a scope that the *Prakṛti*, which holds the nature of changeability, once out of the ignorant state and enlightened with self-knowledge, can be merged and tied with *Puruṣa* where the absolute liberation (*kaivalya*) becomes a possible state. For attaining *kaivalya*, the main root of the self requires to be watered perfectly by awakening the spirit and making it realize its own importance. With this, a healthy life tree will grow and serve the whole of mankind with the sweetest fruits.

15.4 Conclusion

Yoga is defined as *nirodha* or the science of controlling the mind. If the mind is controlled, everything is controlled. Mind is the cause of bondage and mind is the cause of *moksa* or *kaivalya*. Controlling the mind is the most difficult task for the self, and yoga teaches and guides the self to overcome this difficulty by following certain methods and ultimately with *sadhana*. *Nirodha* does not negate the relative states of consciousness nor take away the social, historical, and embodied identity of the self; rather, it refers to broadening the understanding and perceiving every dimension of reality considering its true identity of pure consciousness (Whicher, 1998: 293). This is the way the self can be the master as well as be the witness of the mental activities.

Yoga talks about non-attachment. Attachment creates an imbalance between body and mind. It makes the self confused to choose between the reality of eternal bliss and sensual pleasures received from the world. Non-attachment, for Patanjali, is to detach the mind from the fascinating worldly pleasure and to be united with the infinite where the self attains super-consciousness. Yoga promotes the self to break the cycle of life. Cycle means meeting the same point again and again. This life cycle makes the vision of the self-limited where the self accepts the finite world as real and forgets its limitless power of obtaining true knowledge and enters into the level of pure consciousness. The self starts ignoring the power of self-transformation present within it. Yoga promotes the self to break the cycle and move forward in the direction of eternal bliss by achieving self-knowledge and self-transformation and being recognized as pure consciousness. Yoga helps the self to be non-attached to the world and be attached to the eternal divine god. Patanjali refers to this as the ultimate union of the soul with the all-being eternal entity. This ultimate union is the final stage known as *sampatti*, where the self becomes the *Self* adopting the technique of self-help. It is the connectedness, self-awareness, (Griera, 2017: 87) and flow of the self experiencing releasing from constraint and being flowing towards the realm of supreme reality.

The existence of the self or “I” is recognized as the all-pervasive eternal *Self*. The existence of “I” ends like a river after mixing with the ocean. As the river flows and merges with the ocean, it is recognized as an ocean, not a river. At this point, it is impossible to separate the river water from the ocean water. Similarly, after attaining eternal bliss, it is not possible to recognize the narrow limited self. The perfect union takes place where the limited self transforms into the limitless *Self* with the help of *sādhana*. Thus, “an authentic and fruitful coherence of self-identity” can emerge (Whicher, 1998: 291). The transformation of the self to the level of oneness is yoga for Patanjali. In this stage, the self comes in the form of God-experiencing (Whicher, 2000). Self-consciousness turns into pure consciousness. The self becomes aware of *itself*. The self obtains the knowledge about its knowing. The self owns *sampatti*, the true metaphysical significance of selfhood where the self enters the kingdom of happiness by enjoying inner peace. The self-awakening *yogic self* becomes the

moral self. Yoga becomes the journey of the self, through the self, to the self. It is the practice of uncovering the wisdom of self as mentioned in *Bhagavad Gita*.

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Chapter 16

The Yoga of Nonseparation



Ian Whicher

Abstract Yoga, as classically formulated in Patañjali's *Yoga-Sūtra*, has far too often been conceived as leading to a freedom from the world, emphasizing renunciation, asceticism, disengagement, and transcendence of the body, mind, and world. Yet, from another perspective, freedom or spiritual liberation can be understood more inclusively as being in and for the world, thus supporting a life-affirming approach, both transcendent and immanent, that challenges us to an enriched, relational humanity whereby the world is made a better place. Yoga, it is suggested, can culminate in a balanced, embodied integration of life as a whole that incorporates a clarity of awareness with the integrity of being and action.

Keywords Patañjali · Yoga-Sūtra · Kaivalya · Nirodha · Yoga · Liberation

Abbreviations

BG	Bhagavad-Gītā
RM	Rāja-Mārtaṇḍa of Bhoja Rāja (ca eleventh century CE)
SK	Sāṃkhya-Kārikā of Īśvarakṛṣṇa (ca fourth-fifth century CE)
TV	Tattva-Vaiśārādī of Vācaspati Miśra (ca ninth century CE)
YB	Yoga-Bhāṣya of Vyāsa (ca fifth-sixth century CE)
YS	Yoga-Sūtra of Patañjali (ca second-third century CE)
YSS	Yoga-Sāra-Saṃgraha of Vijñāna Bhikṣu (ca sixteenth century CE)
YV	Yoga-Vārttika of Vijñāna Bhikṣu

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16.1 Introduction

This paper centres on the thought of Patañjali (ca second-third century CE), the great exponent of the authoritative classical Yoga school (*darśana*) of Hinduism and the reputed author of the *Yoga-Sūtra*. I will argue that Patañjali's philosophical perspective has, far too often, been looked upon as excessively "spiritual" or isolationistic to the point of being a world-denying philosophy, indifferent to moral endeavour, neglecting the world of nature and culture, and overlooking the highest potentials for human reality, vitality, creativity, and service. Contrary to the arguments presented by many scholars, which associate Patañjali's Yoga exclusively with extreme asceticism, mortification, denial, and the renunciation and abandonment of "material existence" (*prakṛti*) in favour of an elevated and isolated "spiritual state" (*puruṣa*) or disembodied state of spiritual liberation, I suggest that Patañjali's Yoga can be seen as a responsible engagement, in various ways, of "spirit" (*puruṣa* = intrinsic identity as Self, the "seer," pure consciousness, the masculine component of reality) and "matter" (*prakṛti* = the unmanifest source of psychophysical being as well as manifest life which includes mind, body, all of nature, the feminine component of reality) resulting in a highly developed, transformed, and participatory human nature and identity, an integrated and embodied state of liberated, yet engaged selfhood (*jīvanmukti*).

The interpretation of Patañjali's Yoga *Darśana* presented here—which walks the fine line between a historical and a hermeneutic-praxis (some might say theological or "systematic") orientation—counters the radically dualistic, isolationistic, and ontologically oriented interpretations of Yoga¹ presented by many scholars and suggests an open-ended, epistemologically and morally oriented hermeneutics which, I maintain, is more appropriate for arriving at a genuine assessment of Patañjali's system.

The classical Yoga system is often reduced to or fitted into a classical Sāṃkhyan scheme—the interpretations of which generally follow radically dualistic lines. Metaphysically, classical Sāṃkhya and Yoga are closely akin. However, both systems hold divergent views on important areas of doctrinal structure, such as epistemology, ontology, ethics, and psychology, as well as differences pertaining to terminology. These differences derive in part from the distinct methodologies adopted by the two schools: Sāṃkhya, it has been argued, emphasizes a theoretical or intellectual analysis through inference and reasoning in order to bring out the nature of final emancipation, while Yoga stresses yogic perception and multiple forms of practice that culminate in *samādhi*. Additionally, there is clear evidence throughout all four *pādas* of the *Yoga-Sūtra* of an extensive network of terminology that parallels Buddhist and Jain teachings, which are notably absent in classical Sāṃkhya literature. For instance, Patañjali includes several *sūtras* on the "restraints" or *yamas* (namely, non-violence [*ahimsā*], truthfulness [*satya*], non-stealing [*asteya*], chastity [*brahmacarya*], and nonpossession/greedlessness [*aparigraha*]), which comprise the "eight-limbed" path

¹ An earlier version of this article has appeared as "Reflections on Liberated Consciousness" in *Thinking with the Yoga-Sūtras: Translation, Interpretation*, eds. Christopher Key Chapple and Ana Fumes, Lexington Books: Idaho Falls (2019: 3–15). See also Whicher (1998).

of Yoga as listed in the *Acārāṅga-Sūtra* of Jainism (the earliest sections of which may date from the third or fourth century B.C.E.), thereby suggesting possible Jaina influences on the Yoga tradition.

I argue that many scholars have fallen prey to reading the *Yoga-Sūtra* from the most abstract level of the dualism of *puruṣa* and *prakṛti* down to understanding the practices advocated. In other words, they have engaged in a top-down reading, which elicits the concrete (action/experience) from the abstract (metaphysics/theory). Then they proceed to impute an experiential foundation to the whole scheme informed not from mystical insight or yogic experience but from the effort to form a consistent worldview—which rests in a presumption of a disjunctive duality—that culminates in a radical dualistic finality² or closure. Moreover, Yoga scholarship has not clarified what “dualistic” means or why Yoga had to be “dualistic.” Even in avowedly non-dualistic systems of thought such as Advaita Vedānta, we can find numerous examples of basically dualistic modes of description and explanation.³

Patañjali’s philosophy is not based upon mere theoretical or speculative knowledge. It is founded on and therefore elicits a practical, pragmatic, experiential/perceptual (not merely inferential/theoretical) approach that Patañjali deems essential in order to deal effectively with our total human situation and provide real freedom, not just a theory of liberation or a metaphysical explanation of life. Yoga is not content with knowledge (*jñāna*), perceived as a state that abstracts away from the world, removing us from our human embodiment and activity. Rather, Yoga emphasizes knowledge in the integrity of *being and action* and as serving the integration of the “person” as a “whole.” In a study dedicated to the meaning of Yoga, Edgerton concluded that: “...Yoga is not a ‘system’ of belief or metaphysics. It is always a way of getting something, usually salvation...”⁴ However, this does not say enough. It does not fully consider what might be called the integral nature of Patañjali’s Yoga. Yoga derives its real strength and value through integrating theory and practice.⁵

² See in particular: Feuerstein (1980: 14, 56, 108); Eliade (1969: 94–95, 99–100); Koelman (1970: 224, 251); and G. Larson (1987: 13) who classifies Patañjali’s Yoga as a form of Sāṃkhya.

³ See, for example, Śaṅkara’s (ca eighth-ninth century CE) use of *vyāvahārika* (the conventional empirical perspective) in contrast to *paramārthika* (the ultimate or absolute standpoint).

⁴ F. Edgerton (1924), “The Meaning of Sāṃkhya and Yoga,” AJP 45, pp. 1–46.

⁵ As argued in Whicher (1998, 2019).

16.2 Cessation (*Nirodha*) and the “Return to the Source” (*Pratiprasava*): Transformation or Elimination/Negation of the Mind?

In Patañjali’s central definition of Yoga, Yoga is defined as “the cessation (*nirodha*) of [the misidentification with] the functioning/transformations/fluctuations (*vr̥tti*) of the mind/ordinary awareness (*citta*).”⁶ We must then ask: What *kind* of “cessation” is Patañjali actually referring to in his classical definition of Yoga? What does the process of cessation entail for the yogī: ethically, epistemologically, ontologically, psychologically, and so on? I have elsewhere suggested⁷ that *nirodha* denotes an epistemological emphasis and refers to the transformation of self-understanding brought about through the purification and illumination of consciousness; *nirodha* is not (for the yogī) the ontological cessation of *prakṛti* (in this case, the mind and *vr̥ttis*). Thus, *nirodha* is not, as is often explained, an inward movement that annihilates or suppresses *vr̥ttis*, thoughts, intentions, or ideas (*pratyaya*), nor is it the non-existence or absence of *vr̥tti*; rather, *nirodha* involves a progressive unfoldment of perception (*yogi-pratyakṣa*) that eventually reveals our authentic identity as being rooted in *puruṣa*. It is the state of affliction (*kleśa*) evidenced in the mind and not the mind *itself* that is at issue. To be clear, *cittavr̥tti* does not stand for all modifications or mental processes (cognitive, affective, emotive) but is the very seed (*bīja*) mechanism of afflicted identity, the misidentification of consciousness with *prakṛti* from which all other *vr̥ttis* and thoughts arise and are (mis)appropriated or self-referenced in the state of ignorance (*avidyā*), that is, the unenlightened state of mind. Spiritual ignorance gives rise to a profound dysfunction or misalignment of *vr̥tti*

⁶ YS I.2 (p. 4): *yogaś cittavr̥ttinirodhaḥ*. The Sanskrit text of the *Yoga-Sūtra* of Patañjali and the *Yoga-Bhāṣya* of Vyāsa is from *The Yoga-Sūtras of Patañjali* (1904), K. S. Āgāṣe ed. (Poona: Ānandāśrama) Sanskrit Ser. no. 47. The modifications or functions (*vr̥tti*) of the mind (*citta*) are said to be fivefold (YS I.6), namely, ‘valid cognition’ (*pramāṇa*, which includes perception [*pratyakṣa*], inference [*anumāna*] and valid testimony [*āgama*]), ‘error’/‘misconception’ (*viparyaya*), ‘conceptualization’ (*vikalpa*), ‘sleep’ (*nidrā*) and ‘memory’ (*smṛti*), and are described as being ‘afflicted’ (*kliṣṭa*) or ‘nonafflicted’ (*akliṣṭa*) (YS I.5). *Citta* is an umbrella term that incorporates ‘intellect’ (*buddhi*), ‘sense of self’ (*ahaṁkāra*) and ‘mind-organ’ (*manas*), and can be viewed as the aggregate of the cognitive, conative and affective processes and functions of phenomenal consciousness, i.e., it consists of a grasping, intentional and volitional consciousness. For an in-depth look at the meaning of the terms *citta* and *vr̥tti* see I. Whicher (1998). In the first four *sūtras* of the first chapter (*Samādhi-Pāda*) the subject matter of the *Yoga-Sūtra* is mentioned, defined and characterized. The *sūtras* run as follows: YS I.1: “Now [begins] the discipline of Yoga.” YS I.2: “Yoga is the cessation of [the misidentification with] the functioning/transformations of the mind.” YS I.3: “Then [when that cessation has taken place] there is abiding in the seer’s own form (i.e., *puruṣa* or intrinsic identity).” YS I.4: “Otherwise [there is] conformity to (i.e., misidentification with) the functioning [of the mind].” YS I.1-4 (pp. 1, 4, 7, and 7 respectively): *atha yogānuśāsanam; yogaś cittavr̥ttinirodhaḥ; tadā draṣṭṛṇuḥ svarūpe’vasthanam; vr̥ttisārūpyam itaratra*. For a more comprehensive study of classical Yoga including issues dealt with in this paper see Whicher (1998).

⁷ See Whicher (1998, 2019).

with consciousness, which Yoga can remedy, thereby allowing for a proper alignment or “right” functioning of *vr̥tti*.⁸ It is the *cittav̥rtti* as our confused and mistaken identity, not the *vr̥ttis* themselves—thoughts and experiences in total—that must be brought to a state of definitive cessation. Yoga thus purifies and liberates the *cittav̥rtti* dynamic from ignorance and enables one, I suggest, to get beyond afflicted identity (as ordinary awareness masquerading as consciousness).

To be sure, there is a suspension and transcendence of all the mental processes as well as any identification with an object (i.e., in *aśaṃprajñāta-samādhi*, this being for the final purification of the mind⁹), but it would be misleading to conclude that higher *samādhi* results in permanent or definitive cessation of the *vr̥ttis* in total, thereby predisposing the yogin who has attained purity of mind to exist in an incapacitated, isolated, or mindless state and therefore of being incapable of living a balanced, useful, and productive life in various ways.

The three *guṇas* of *prakṛti* are purity/light/virtue, dynamic activity, dullness/inertia/delusion, or *sattva*, *rajas*, and *tamas*, respectively. The purpose of the *guṇas* is outlined in YS II. 18 and 21 are to provide experience (*bhoga*) and liberation (*apavarga*) for the unliberated practitioner; that is, they ultimately have a soteriological role. From the perspective of the discerning yogin (*vivekin*), human identity contained within the domain of the three *guṇas* amounts to nothing more than sorrow and dissatisfaction (*duḥkha*).¹⁰ The declared goal of classical Yoga, as with Sāṃkhya and Buddhism, is to overcome all dissatisfaction (*duḥkha*, YS II.16) by bringing about an inverse movement or counter-flow (*pratiprasava*)¹¹—variously referred to as “return to the origin,”¹² “process-of-involution,”¹³ “dissolution into the source,”¹⁴ or “withdrawal from manifestation”—a kind of reabsorption into the transcendent purity of being itself.

Does a “return to the origin,” *pratiprasava*, culminate in a state of freedom in which one is stripped of all human identity and void of any association with the world including one’s practical livelihood? I argue that Patañjali leaves much room for understanding “dissolution” or “return to the source” with an epistemological emphasis, thereby allowing the whole system of the Yoga *Darśana* to be interpreted along more open-ended lines. In other words, what actually “dissolves” or terminates in Yoga is the yogi’s misidentification with *prakṛti*, a mistaken identity of self that—contrary to authentic identity, namely *puruṣa*—can be nothing more than a product of the three *guṇas* under the influence of spiritual ignorance. Understood as

⁸ See Whicher (1998).

⁹ See Chap. 6 in Whicher (1998).

¹⁰ YS II.15 (p. 74): *pariṇāmatāpasamṣkāraduḥkhaṃ guṇav̥rttivirodhāc ca duḥkham eva sarvaṃ vivekināḥ*. “Because of the dissatisfaction and sufferings due to change and anxieties and the latent impressions, and from the conflict of the transformations of the *guṇas*, for the discerning one, all is sorrow alone.”

¹¹ Patañjali uses the term *pratiprasava* twice, in YS II.10 and IV.34.

¹² See Chapple and Kelly (1990: 60).

¹³ Feuerstein (1979a: 65).

¹⁴ Cf. U. Arya (1986: 146, 471).

such, *pratiprasava* need not denote the definitive ontological dissolution of manifest *prakṛti* for the yogī but rather refers to the process of “subtilization” or sanctification of consciousness so necessary for the uprooting of misidentification—the incorrect worldview born of *avidyā*—or incapacity of the yogin to “see” from the yogic perspective of the seer (*draṣṭṛ*), our authentic identity as *puruṣa*.

16.3 “Aloneness” (*Kaivalya*): Implications for an Embodied Freedom

In the classical traditions of Sāṃkhya and Yoga, *kaivalya*, meaning “aloneness,”¹⁵ is generally understood to be the state of the unconditional existence of *puruṣa*; however, this “aloneness” is often misconstrued as a disconnection from others and severance from world engagement. On the contrary, in the Yoga Sūtra, *kaivalya* can refer more precisely to the “aloneness of seeing” (*drśeḥ kaivalyam*) or “oneness of life” which, as Patañjali states, follows from the disappearance of ignorance (*avidyā*) and its creation of *saṃyoga*¹⁶—the conjunction or apparent conflation of the seer (*puruṣa*) and the seeable (i.e., *citta*, *guṇas*)—explained by Vyāsa as a mental superimposition (*adhyāropa*, YB II.18). “Aloneness” thus can be construed as *puruṣa*’s innate capacity for pure, unbroken, non-attached seeing/perceiving, observing, or “knowing” of the content of the mind (*citta*).¹⁷

According to yet another *sūtra* (YS III.55), we are told that *kaivalya* is established when the *sattva* of consciousness has reached a state of purity analogous to that of the *puruṣa*.¹⁸ Through the process of subtilization or “return to the origin” (*pratiprasava*) in the *sattva*, the transformation (*pariṇāma*) of the mind (*citta*) takes place at the deepest level, bringing about a radical change in perspective: the former impure, fabricated states constituting a fractured identity of self are dissolved resulting in the complete purification of mind. Through knowledge (in *saṃprajñāta-samādhi*)

¹⁵ The term *kaivalya* comes from *kevala*, meaning “alone.” Feuerstein (1979a: 75) also translates *kaivalya* as “aloneness” but with a metaphysical or ontological emphasis that implies the absolute separation of *puruṣa* and *prakṛti*.

¹⁶ YS II.25 (p. 96): *tadabhāvāt saṃyogābhāvo hānam taddrśeḥ kaivalyam*.

¹⁷ YS II.20 and IV.18.

¹⁸ YS III.55 (p. 174): *sattvapuruṣayoḥ śuddhisāmye kaivalyam iti*. One must be careful not to characterize the state of *sattva* itself as liberation or *kaivalya*, for without the presence of *puruṣa* the mind (as reflected consciousness) could not function in its most transparent aspect as *sattva*. It is not accurate, according to Yoga philosophy, to say that the *sattva* is equivalent to liberation itself. The question of the nature of the *guṇas* from the enlightened perspective is an interesting one. In the *Bhagavadgītā* (II.45) Kṛṣṇa advises Arjuna to become free from the three *guṇas* and then gives further instructions to be established in eternal *sattva* (beingness, light, goodness, clarity, knowledge), free of dualities, free of acquisition-and-possession, Self-possessed (*nīrvandvo nityasattvastho nīryogakṣema ātmavān*). It would appear from the above instructions that the nature of the *sattva* being referred to here transcends the limitations of the nature of *sattva-guṇa* which can still have a binding effect in the form of attachment to joy and knowledge. It is, however, only by first overcoming *rajas* and *tamas* that liberation is possible.

and its transcendence (in *asaṃprajñāta-samādhi*), self-identity overcomes its lack of intrinsic grounding, a lack sustained and exacerbated by the web of afflictions in the form of attachment (*rāga*), aversion (*dveṣa*), and the compulsive clinging to life based on the fear of extinction (*abhiniveśa*). The yogī is no longer dependent on liberating knowledge (mind-*sattva*)¹⁹ and is no longer attached to the constant fluctuations of the mind and its thought processes (*vṛtti*) as a basis for self-identity. As expressed earlier, cessation does not mark a definitive disappearance of the *guṇas* from *puruṣa*'s view and the yogi's experience.²⁰ For the liberated yogī, the *guṇas* cease to exist in the form of *avidyā* and its mental impressions (*saṃskāras*), *vṛttis*, and false or fixed ideas (*pratyaya*) of selfhood that formerly veiled true identity. Without the veil of *avidyā*, the changing *guṇic* modes cannot alter the yogī's now purified and firmly established consciousness. The mind has been liberated from the egocentric world of attachment to things that function under the purview of *prakṛti*.

Thus, *kaivalya*, I suggest, in no way destroys or negates the personality of the yogin, but is an *unconditional state in which all the obstacles or distractions preventing an immanent and purified relationship or engagement of person with nature (prakṛti) and spirit (puruṣa) have been removed*. The crucial (ontological) point to be made here is that in the "aloneness" of *kaivalya*, *prakṛti* ceases to perform an obstructing role. In effect, *prakṛti* herself has become purified, illuminated, and liberated²¹ from *avidyā*'s grip, including the misconceptions, misappropriations, and misguided relations implicit within a world of afflicted identity.

The reason for challenging an isolationistic understanding of Patanjali's highly nuanced system is as follows: Not being content with mere theoretical knowledge, Yoga is committed to a practical way of life. To this end, Patañjali included in his presentation of Yoga an outline of the "eight-limbed" path (*aṣṭāṅga-yoga*)²² dealing with the physical, moral, psychological, and spiritual dimensions of the yogin. This integral path emphasizes organic continuity, balance, and integration in contrast to the discontinuity, imbalance, and disintegration inherent in *saṃyoga*. The idea of cosmic balance and the mutual support and upholding of the various parts of nature and society is not foreign to Yoga thought. Vyāsa deals with the theory of "nine causes" (*nava kāraṇāṇi*) or types of causation according to tradition.²³ The ninth type of cause is termed *dhṛti*—meaning "support" or "sustenance." Based on Vyāsa's explanation of *dhṛti*, we can see how mutuality and sustenance are understood as

¹⁹ YB III.55 (p. 175): *nahi dagdhakleśabījasya jñāne punar apekṣā kācid asti*. "When the seeds of afflictions have been scorched there is no longer any dependence at all on further knowledge."

²⁰ H. Āraṇya writes (1963: 123) that in the state of *nirodha* the *guṇas* "do not die out but their unbalanced activity due to non-equilibrium that was taking place ... only ceases on account of the cessation of the cause (*avidyā* or nescience) which brought about their contact."

²¹ Vijñāna Bhikṣu insists (YV IV.34: 141) that *kaivalya* is a state of liberation for both *puruṣa* and *prakṛti* each reaching its respective natural or intrinsic state. He then cites the *Sāṃkhya-Kārikā* (62) where it is stated that no *puruṣa* is bound, liberated, or transmigrates. It is only *prakṛti* abiding in her various forms that transmigrates, is bound, and becomes liberated. For references to Vijñāna Bhikṣu's YV I have consulted T. S. Rukmani (1981, 1983, 1987, 1989).

²² YS II.29; see the discussion on *aṣṭāṅga-yoga* in Chap. 4 of Whicher (1998).

²³ YB II.28 (pp. 99–101).

essential conditions for maintaining the natural and social world. There is an organic interdependence of all living entities wherein all (i.e., the elements, animals, humans, and divine bodies) work together for the “good” of the whole and each other. Far from renouncing the world, liberated yogīs have transformed themselves, gaining new access to the world, and are thereby enabled to engage and transform the world.

In the last chapter of the *Yoga-Sūtra* (*Kaivalya-Pāda*), “aloneness” (*kaivalya*) is said to ensue upon the attainment of *dharmamegha-samādhi*, the “cloud of dharma” *samādhi*. At this point, the mind and actions are freed from misidentification and affliction, and one is no longer deluded/confused with regard to one’s true form (*svarūpa*) or intrinsic identity. This clarity about identity is highly significant to selfless action in the world. This is because, at this stage of practice, the yogī is disconnected (*viyoga*) from all patterns of action motivated by *egoity*, even the attachment to reward or “profit” from his or her meditational practice. According to both Vyāsa²⁴ and the sixteenth-century commentator Vijnāna Bhikṣu,²⁵ one to whom this high state of purification takes place is designated as a *jīvanmukta*: one who is liberated while still alive (i.e., embodied or living liberation). Engagement with the world at large by such individuals occurs without selfishness, greed, insecurity, narcissism, false perception, delusion, or wrong motivation. This is highly significant to beneficial worldly engagement because when one engages the world through the lens of an afflicted and deluded identity, the resulting actions and reactions will be similarly afflicted and disordered.

By transcending the normative conventions and obligations of karmic behaviour, the yogī acts morally not as an extrinsic response out of obedience to an external moral code of conduct but as an intrinsic response and a matter of natural, purified inclination. The stainless luminosity of pure consciousness is revealed as one’s fundamental nature. The yogī does not act as others who are bound by the spiritual ignorance inherent in normal existence in *saṃsāra* and ceases to act from the perspective of a delusive sense of self confined within *prakṛti*’s domain. Relinquishing all obsessive or selfish concerns with the results of activity, the yogī remains wholly detached from the egoic fruits of action.²⁶ This does not imply that the yogī loses all orientation for action. It is important to remember that only attachment (and compulsive, inordinate desire or craving), not the action itself, sets in motion the law of moral causation (karma) by which a person is implicated in *saṃsāra*. The yogī is said to be non-attached to virtue or non-virtue and is no longer oriented within

²⁴ See YB IV.30 (pp. 202–203): *kleśakarmanivṛttau jīvanneva vidvānvimukto bhavati*. On cessation of afflicted action, the knower is released while yet living.”

²⁵ YV IV.30 (pp. 123–124). Elsewhere in his *Yoga-Sāra-Saṃgraha* (p. 17) Vijnāna Bhikṣu tells us that the yogin who is “established in the state of *dharmamegha-samādhi* is called a *jīvanmukta*” (... *dharmameghaḥ samādhiḥ ... asyāmavasthāyāṃ jīvanmukta ityucyate*). Vijnāna Bhikṣu is critical of Vedāntins (i.e., Śaṅkara’s Advaita Vedānta school) that, he says, associate the *jīvanmukta* with ignorance (*avidyā-kleśa*)—probably because of the liberated being’s continued link with the body—despite Yoga’s insistence on the complete overcoming of the afflictions.

²⁶ This is the essence of Kṛṣṇa’s teaching in the *Bhagavadgītā* on *karmayoga*; see, for example, BG IV.20.

the ego-logical patterns of thought as in the epistemically distorted and confused condition of *saṃyoga*.

As some scholars have misleadingly concluded, this does not mean that the spiritual adept or yogī is free to commit immoral acts²⁷ or that the yogī is motivated by selfish concerns.²⁸ Actions must not only be executed in the spirit of unselfishness (i.e., sacrifice) or detachment; they must also be ethically sound, reasonable, and justifiable. Moreover, the yogī's spiritual journey—far from being an “a-moral process”²⁹—is a *highly moral process*! The yogī's commitment to the sattvification of consciousness, including the cultivation of moral virtues such as compassion (*karuṇā*)³⁰ and non-violence (*ahiṃsā*),³¹ is not an “a-moral” enterprise, nor is it an expression of indifference, aloofness, or an uncaring attitude to others. Moral disciplines are engaged as a natural outgrowth of intelligent (*sattvic*) self-understanding. This insight arises out of highly advanced consciousness and commitment to self-transcendence that takes consciousness out of (ec-stasis) its identification with the rigid structure of the monadic ego, thereby reversing the inveterate tendency of this ego to inflate itself at the expense of its responsibility in relation to others.

Having defined the goal of Yoga as aloneness (*kaivalya*), the question must now be asked: What kind of aloneness was Patañjali talking about? Aloneness is not the isolation of the seer (*draṣṭr*, *puruṣa*) separate from the seeable (*dṛśya*, *prakṛti*), as is often maintained as the goal of Yoga. Rather, it refers to the aloneness of the power of seeing (YS II.20, 25) in its innate purity and clarity without any epistemological distortion and moral defilement. Aloneness refers to the nonseparation of life, which reveals itself through the power of seeing, a full vision which includes both consciousness and activity and manifest and unmanifest existence. The cultivation of *nirodha* uproots the compulsive tendency to reify the world and oneself with an awareness that reveals the transcendent yet immanent seer (*puruṣa*). Through clear seeing, the purpose of Yoga is fulfilled, and the yogī, free from all misidentification and impure karmic residue, gains full, immediate access to the world. By accessing the world in such an open and direct manner, in effect uniting epistemologically with the world, the yogī ceases to be encumbered by egoism, which, enmeshed in confusion, misappropriates the world. The sacrifice of the “self as Seen” or afflicted identity as I-am-ness (*asmitā*) to identify as the seer-*puruṣa* is precisely what renders *prakṛti* sacred and ultimately reveals her intrinsic significance and value. Yoga can be recognized as a highly developed and integrated state that extends and enhances our self-identity. The yogī can dwell in a state of balance and fulfillment serving others while feeling at home in the world because the yogī truly abides or is at home in the

²⁷ See Zaehner (1974: 97–98).

²⁸ See Scharfstein (1974: 131–132).

²⁹ See Feuerstein (1979a: 81).

³⁰ YS I.33 (p. 38): *maitrīkaruṇāmuditopekṣāṇāṃ sukhaduḥkhaḥpunyāpunyaviṣayāṇāṃ bhāvanātaś cittaḥprasādanam*. “The mind is made pure and clear from the cultivation of friendliness, compassion, happiness and equanimity in conditions or toward objects of joy, sorrow, merit or demerit respectively.”

³¹ YS II.35.

true nature and form of the seer (YS 1.3); the yogī's way of being is embodied within the lived world itself.

Yoga can be seen to unfold states of epistemic oneness that reveal the non-separation of knower, knowing, and the known (YS I.41). *Kaivalya* implies a power of seeing in which the dualisms rooted in our egocentric patterns of attachment, aversion, fear, and so forth have been transformed into unselfish ways of being with others (YS I.33).

The psychological, ethical, and social implications of this identity transformation are immense. Yoga does not anaesthetize our feelings, thereby encouraging indifference towards others. On the contrary, the cessation process (*nirodha*) steadies one for a life of compassion, discernment, and service informed by a seeing who can understand and is in touch with the needs of others.

I wish to suggest, therefore, that through the necessary transformation of consciousness brought about through yogic discipline, an authentic and fruitful coherence of self-identity, perception, and activity emerges out of the former fragmented consciousness in *saṃyoga*. If Patañjali's perception of the world of forms and differences had been destroyed or discarded, how could he have had such insight into Yoga and the intricacies and subtle nuances of the unenlightened state?³² If through *nirodha*, the individual form and the whole world had been cancelled for Patañjali; he would more likely have spent the rest of his days in the inactivity and isolation of transcendent oblivion rather than undertake the effort to systematize and present Yoga philosophy to others! Rather than being handicapped by the exclusion of thinking, perceiving, experiencing, or activity, the liberated yogī actualizes the potential to live a fully integrated life in the world. I conclude here that there is no reason why the liberated yogī cannot be portrayed as a vital, creative, thoughtful, empathetic, balanced, happy, and wise person.

Yoga presupposes the integration of contemplation and activity; there can be no scission between *theoria* and *praxis*. The *Yoga-Sūtra* is a philosophical text where *praxis* is deemed to be essential. The theory that informs Yoga would have no authentic meaning without actual practice. However, without examination and reflection, there would be no meaningful striving for liberation, no "goal," as it were, to set one's sight on. In an original, inspiring, and penetrating style, Patañjali bridges metaphysics and ethics, transcendence and immanence, and contributes to the Indic and global fold, a form of philosophical investigation that, to borrow J. Taber's descriptive phrase for another context, can properly be called a "transformative philosophy." That is to say, it is a philosophical perspective that "does not stand as an edifice isolated from experience; it exists only insofar as it is realized in experience."³³

³² Although the historical identity of Patañjali the Yoga master is not known, we are assuming that Patañjali was, as the tradition would have it, an enlightened Yoga adept.

³³ Taber (1983: 26).

16.4 Conclusion

To conclude, it can be said that *puruṣa* indeed has some precedence over *prakṛti* in Patañjali's system, for *puruṣa* is what is ordinarily "missing" or concealed in human life and is ultimately the state of consciousness one must awaken to in Yoga. The liberated state of "aloneness" (*kaivalya*) need not denote an ontological superiority of *puruṣa* or an exclusion of *prakṛti*. *Kaivalya* can be positively construed as an integration of both principles—an integration or "absolute oneness of life" that, I have argued, is what is most important for Yoga. I have proposed that the *Yoga-Sūtra* does not uphold a "path" of liberation that ultimately renders *puruṣa* and *prakṛti* incapable of "cooperating" together. Rather, the *Yoga-Sūtra* seeks to "unite" these two principles without the presence of any defiled understanding, to bring them "together," properly aligning them in a state of balance, harmony, and clarity of knowledge in the integrity of being and action. Isolationism may not be and does not seem to be the experience of those who have undertaken these practices at a deeper and more mature level.

The purified mind, one that has been transformed through yogic discipline, is certainly no ordinary worldly awareness, nor is it eliminated for the sake of pure consciousness. To confuse (as many interpretations of Yoga have unfortunately done) the underlining purificatory processes involved in the cessation of ignorance/afflicted identity as being the same thing as (or as necessitating the need for) a radical elimination of our psychophysical being—the vehicle under the realm of *prakṛti* through which consciousness discloses itself—is, I suggest, to misunderstand the intent of the *Yoga Sūtra* itself. There are strong grounds for arguing (as I have attempted to show) that through "cessation," *prakṛti* herself (in the form of the *guṇas* that constitute the makeup of the yogi's body-mind) is liberated from the grip of ignorance rooted in lower levels of consciousness or afflicted identity. Vyāsa explicitly states (YB II.18) that emancipation happens in the mind and does not literally apply to *puruṣa*—which is, by definition, already free and, therefore, has no intrinsic need to be released from the fetters of *saṃsāric* existence. The liberated one "realizes" and thereby experiences this freedom.

Both morality and perception (cognition) are essential channels through which human consciousness, far from being negated or suppressed, is transformed and illuminated. The enhanced perception gained through Yoga must be interwoven with Yoga's rich affective and moral dimensions to form a spirituality that does not become entangled in a web of antinomianism but retains the integrity and vitality to transform our lives and the lives of others effectively. In Yoga proper, there is no support, ethically or pedagogically, for the misappropriation or abuse of *prakṛti* for freedom or *puruṣa*-realization. By upholding an *integration of the moral and the mystical*, Yoga supports a reconciliation of the prevalent tension within Hinduism between (1) spiritual engagement and self-identity within the world (*pravṛtti*) and (2) spiritual disengagement from worldliness and self-identity that transcends the world (*nivṛtti*). Yoga discerns and teaches a balance between these two apparently conflicting orientations. While Patañjali can be understood as having adopted (as a concession to the

aspiring aspirant) a provisional, practical, dualistic metaphysics, there is no proof that his system either ends in duality or eliminates the possibility for an ongoing co-operative duality. Yoga is not simply about “*puruṣa*-realization” but implies “getting it right with *prakṛti*.”

To be sure, the yogic path in all of its knowledge, power, and glory must be transcended. One must, as it were, step outside of the vehicle of *prakṛti* and dwell as the consciousness of *puruṣa* in true form (*svarūpa*). However, I want to suggest that transcendence need not be taken to mean a “static finality”: abiding in nonafflicted, disengaged, formless, transcendent bliss severed from manifestation. Rather, more elliptically, Patañjali may well have set the stage for an inclusive awakening, allowing for convergence and further engagement, a “growing up” in life or maturation with integrity and fullness that perhaps knows no bounds. Now that, I would like to suggest a matured Yoga, the possibility of which we must not overlook or close the door on.

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